

Many Loves

and other plays by

*William
Carlos
Williams*

Many Loves and Other Plays

By William Carlos Williams (in print)

The Autobiography
The Build-up
Collected Earlier Poems
Collected Later Poems
The Farmers' Daughters
I Wanted to Write a Poem*
In the American Grain
Kora in Hell: Improvisations†
Many Loves and Other Plays
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The Selected Letters§
Selected Poems
Yes, Mrs. Williams§

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MANY LOVES AND OTHER PLAYS

THE COLLECTED PLAYS OF

WILLIAM CARLOS WILLIAMS

A NEW DIRECTIONS BOOK

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To Harriet and Bill Gratwick

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Many Loves

Trial Horse No. 1

***“Let me not to the marriage of true minds
Admit impediments . . .”***

CHARACTERS

PETER, a man of considerable wealth. In his middle 50's.

HUBERT, a poet—and dramatist in the making. In his late 20's.

ALISE, a young actress. The leading lady for Hubert's play.

In the first Playlet

SERAFINA, the wife of a factory worker.

A MAN, Serafina's husband.

LADDIE, a young factory worker.

THE BOYFRIEND

A WAITER

A WOMAN

A GIRL

In the second Playlet

PETE THOMPSON, a farmer.

MATTIE, his wife.

ANN, their teen-age daughter.

FRED, their son. A year older than Ann.

GEORGE, Pete's uncle. Owner of the farm.

AUNT KATE, George's sister.

HORACE, Ann's boyfriend.

LIL, a friend of Ann. A fat girl.

MIN, another friend.

A REAL ESTATE AGENT

AGNES BREEN, a young business woman.

In the third Playlet

DOC, a physician. Not so young any more.

CLARA, a young suburban housewife.

A CHILD, Clara's daughter. About 5 years old.

KELLY, a stagehand.

A MINISTER, Episcopalian. A Groton graduate.

Stagehands. Electricians. Friends of the actors.

The roles of Alise, Serafina, Agnes Breen and Clara are to be played by the same actress. Other roles in the playlets may be doubled at the discretion of the director.

SYNOPSIS

The play is made up of three completely unrelated sequences, written in prose—one forming the substance of each act—and a counter-plot, in modern verse, which binds them together. The theme of each “playlet,” and of the counter-play, is love—of a sort.

In the first sequence, a young man loves an older, married woman. In the second, a young man and young woman of high school age—comparable to the lovers of Romance—are assailed by the girl’s father. In the third of these prose playlets, an older man and a younger woman engage in a mild intrigue.

In the counter-play, the love is between two men, an elder and another, younger one. Here the dramatic action hinges on the necessity for the younger, who is the author of the three short pieces, to get the older man, his presumptive backer, to finance the production of his play—but without concessions. For the poet-playwright is in love with and about to marry his leading lady, a fact which he tries to keep secret from his enamored backer. The discovery of this love by the backer supplies the climax and catastrophe of the play.

ACT 1

Scene 1

The curtain is already raised and the stage lighted when the audience enters the theater. The scene is the stage-set for a play which is being prepared for production. Actors and actresses, stagehands and electricians are going about their preparations as they would at any early rehearsal in an empty theater.

It is as if the spectator had come into the theater as might a friend of some member of the company, and what confronts him is an illusion of the theater more profound than an audience is ever allowed to see. Mysterious figures engaged in the practical matters of arranging props, memorizing lines, painting out a hole in a flat, putting a light to its proper angle, hammering a stretcher solid, move like officers and seamen over the deck and into the rigging of a ship being fitted for a voyage of highest adventure—of inevitable disaster unless each smallest detail is readied for the strain that will be brought to bear on each significant flimsiness.

As the audience is consistently ignored by the people busy on stage—and begins to feel that it may be asked to leave by a side door if it doesn't keep quiet—it finds itself in a darkening, menaced space, included in what is going on up there on the stage. The stage manager is organizing the disposal of flats, actors and props for the three separate one-act plays which are to be presented, while Hubert, the author-director, is working with an electrician to get the lighting he wants in one of his scenes—Alise, his leading lady, is running through her role as Clara in the third playlet: she is ironing clothes at an ironing board set up in her kitchen. Hubert is trying for a special effect of some sort

which has to do with factors not present in the flesh. He calls appropriate technical directions to the man on the lights, but this does not interrupt the monologue of the woman at the ironing board who is running lines—out of context, but belonging to the ironing board episode of Act III. Her voice rises and falls, stumbles, repeats itself, tries for a different inflection—completely absorbed in its own sound, while she maintains a fixed pose for the lights to play upon.

On other parts of the stage—quite oblivious to the general confusion—other members of the company are practicing their lines. The girl who plays Ann in the second act, but dressed now in rehearsal get-up of sweater and blue-jeans, is running through her climactic speech, flaming out terrifyingly with: "I'll do it! I'll do it!"—then tapering softly into the tone she will use for more quiet interludes.

There is another oral focus at the center of the stage where the young man who is Laddie in the first act is being cued by the fat girl who plays Lil in Act II. She sits on the stage, reading the cues from a script, while Laddie stands above her, going through his gestures with the lines. He is having a good deal of trouble with them and they keep running it over and over like a ground base, sometimes high and shocking—when the voices of Alise and Ann are lowered—sometimes almost unheard, when one of the others is raised. The director must control these shifts of oral focus so that the whole effect is natural—an atmosphere of confusion and excitement, yet not so confused that the audience cannot register on the different elements in turn.

As the lighting is brought under control and the stage begins to come together, Laddie and Ann become silent, though they do not leave the scene, and attention focuses on the woman ironing, who suddenly takes over in full projection with the lines: "Listen, I didn't finish telling you about the swimming instructor . . ." Her sexual intensity seems to draw a new figure to the stage—Peter, who comes down the center aisle through the audience, climbs to the

stage by steps at the left and stands watching Hubert, who, in turn, is watching Alise at the ironing board.

Peter, who is in the middle fifties, is the obvious well-to-do socialite. But there is something unusual about him that gives the eye rather a jog: his clothes seem too big for him—just slightly too big, as if he wanted to appear bulkier than should be the case. Otherwise he is extremely well-dressed. Close silver-gray curls cover his well-shaped cranium, clustering about his temples attractively. His nose is aristocratic and his hands long and well-disciplined. His look is straightforward, completely unabashed. Speaking with a cultured voice, as might be expected, his tones assume on occasion, especially when directed toward Hubert, a genuine tenderness. But when crossed, the man is transformed as by a fever. Then his voice coarsens and he thrashes his shoulders about as if they alone must express the intensity of his feeling. At such moments his insolence is likely to be flagrant.

Hubert is, of course, much younger than his friend, and though somewhat on the stout side, by no means an indifferent figure. The stabbing glances of his dark eyes are seldom directed long toward anyone except Alise, resting even there only for a moment, as if not wishing the glance to be observed. He wears his clothes indifferently and makes a good many nervous gestures of the hands without purpose, but can, when pressed, assume control of himself and speak positively—though seeming, as he does so, to be afraid of his own voice, which is emotional and deep. Restless and nervous, lacking composure, he will always be a man out of place even in his own world.

Hubert does not at first see Peter when he comes onto the stage. He is talking to Kelly, one of the stagehands.

HUBERT:

Have you got this for the book, Kelly? Be sure you don't leave . . . [As he turns to call to Kelly, he catches sight of

Peter. *He is completely surprised, almost dumbstruck.*] Peter . . . Peter!

PETER:

In the flesh—what I might refer to on a stage as the too, too solid . . .

[Hubert glances quickly toward Alise, then comes to Peter, holding out his hand.]

HUBERT:

But Peter—you're in the Virgin Islands.

[Instead of taking the offered hand, Peter puts his own hand on Hubert's shoulder, leaning there easily as he stares into his face.]

PETER:

The rumor is exaggerated—the islands are no longer virgin.

HUBERT:

But I thought . . .

PETER:

Oh, Hubert! You thought . . . you always think, Hubert . . . when you should feel—*[With a slight tilt of his head he indicates Alise.]*—though I must say that sounded rather nice. Or if not nice . . . *[Their eyes lock for a moment.]* What is it? What are you up to here? *[He turns away, surveying the stage and everyone on it; then, good humoredly.]* Is this really a production—something you seriously intend to open in a week? . . . Tell me about it, Hubert.

HUBERT:

I'd rather you saw it when it's all prepared—all polished. That's when it's for you, Peter. You've come into the garage—the hood's up . . . these are the odd parts lying around, the mechanics, the grease . . .

PETER:

Why don't you want to talk about it, Hubert? You've never been the least reluctant to *talk* about anything.

HUBERT:

Of course, and it's wonderful you're back, but . . . [*impatiently*] Be practical, Peter. Be patient. This is rehearsal. Right now there's no time . . .

PETER:

—and time is money. Delicacy might forbid reference to my drab connection with the arts. Nevertheless, with the delicacy of a West Side madam may I ask just what the customers are going to get for their money?

HUBERT:

You have no! . . .

PETER:

Oh yes I have! The backer, too, has rights—and I'm asking point-blank what I'm getting for *my* money.

[*Hubert stops abruptly and pulls himself together, trying to think clearly and deeply.*]

HUBERT:

Where do I begin with it? What do I say first? [*He looks around the stage as if hunting for an idea.*] It's a complex thing, Peter, like a ship going to sea—like a woman with child—like . . .

PETER [*cutting in sharply*]:

Must it be so very complex? . . . to be so very fine?

HUBERT:

Yes. If it's to be new, it must be complex. If it's to be novel—virginal . . .

PETER:

—and with child . . . complex virgins, virgin complexes . . . must it be all *that*, too? Can it be?

HUBERT:

Yes, it can—believe me! And it *must* be all that, to come alive at all! There's nothing virginal, nothing completely novel left for us other than in complexities.

But some one
must first have seen the complex
simple, simple as water flowing . . .
that was ice, and made it flow, so
that it appears an easy matter: to
give the word a metaphorical twist by
the position it assumes, the elevation
it induces—without pictorial effects—
by the force of its meaning; a similarity
to daily speech, the miracle being it
sounds so, but by the awakening experienced
is proven otherwise, charged to raise the
spirit to a full enjoyment.

ALISE:

My dear, how beautiful!

PETER:

Who is this woman? No introductions,
please. One of your actresses. Thank
you very much. The trouble with you, Hubert?
You're too much a student of the play
and not, I'm afraid, of romance—that's all.
You've always been that way. So you talk
and think up problems. My boy, once for
all, you've got to put your hind legs into
it. You've got to let yourself
go.

HUBERT:

Right, of
course. Only a man may, I would object,
reserve for himself the choice of when
he shall let himself go, as you say, and
for whom and for what purpose. He may
maneuver a lifetime for that moment . . .

PETER:

Don't
talk such rot! You haven't got a lifetime
to maneuver in.

ALISE:

He's quite right,
I'm a woman and I know what he means.

PETER:

And I'm a man and I say, rot!
This is the professional stage. When the
faucet is turned on, the water must run hot
or cold as they want it.

HUBERT:

No doubt. But when I
shall write the play I have in mind . . .
Then . . .

PETER:

What's that? Am I to understand this
is not the play?

HUBERT:

Alise,
will you explain? I have to leave you
for a moment.

[Hubert leaves the stage.]

ALISE:

I hope
you'll be patient with him. He needs
us all so much. He says he's written
these for me to speak. He says I have an
ear. These, of course, are just pre-
liminary to the major work. He says that
when he's finished with what now he has in
mind he'll revolutionize the theater . . .

PETER:

May I tell you something, my
dear young lady, whoever you are? Anything
you have to say is not of the slightest
interest to me.

[Hubert returns.]

ALISE:

Hubert,
who is this person?

[Peter puts his finger to his lips.]

HUBERT:

A friend . . .
I met him in the subway.

[He motions for her to go.]

ALISE:

Very well, Hubert.

[She goes to the actor who is still reading his paper.]

PETER:

Explain yourself. I understand this is not
the play you gave me to believe it was.

HUBERT:

Not yet.

PETER:

Hubert, this is very
disappointing.

HUBERT:

Three short sketches on
a general theme, of which each is a facet
casting its own aspect of the light.

PETER:

Oh my God!

HUBERT [*calling*]:

Alise!

PETER:

Hubert, I've asked you never to do a thing like this to me. Are they written in this new verse of yours?

HUBERT:

Not these.

PETER:

Not these!

HUBERT:

Alise, please come here.

[*Alise approaches deliberately.*]

PETER:

Hubert, are you in love?
You don't love her, do you, Hubert?

HUBERT:

I am passionate
about her voice. A marvelous
facility for modern meters, completely
unspoiled by English. Alise, please
come here for me a moment, will
you?

[*He rushes off.*]

ALISE:

What does he say?

PETER:

The man's in love with you.

ALISE:

I doubt it very much.

PETER:

Oh, but he is! And
you with him. Poor thing. I'm so
sorry for you when he finds you out.
"This is she," he said. What a mind!
What a body! What legs! What a
voice! What discretion! Her youth!
What abandon! What perfection!
Except, I might have said, her morals.
Phew! Get out!

ALISE:

You silly bitch!

[*Hubert returns.*]

HUBERT:

Have you explained our plans to him?

ALISE:

Oh yes, we
understand each other perfectly.

PETER:

She's much too mild. Not the one
for you, Hubert. There'd be no
contrast in your lives.

HUBERT:

She's a very clever actress.
I wanted someone to do the complicated
innocent. I don't know anyone to
equal her, to give the signature, the
peculiar emphasis which, after all, is
I—and what I want to do.

PETER:

Ah yes,
what you want to do. That's it.
What we all want to do. That's it,

isn't it, my dear? What we all want
to do.

ALISE:

I understand.

PETER:

So glad you do. You like
these . . . things we're going to see tonight?

ALISE:

Oh yes, of course.

PETER:

Well, that's not too
reassuring. But what is your plan? What?
You haven't given me your plan.
What are you trying to do?

HUBERT:

I have
one objective and only one in this.

PETER:

A bad start, Hubert, because when
you begin that way I know it's going
to cost me money. As angel, it's *my*
privilege to be above all that—
not yours.

HUBERT:

My purpose is
to write for the stage such verse as never
has been written heretofore.

PETER:

I thought so.
Better than the Bard of Avon?

HUBERT:

No, not better. Not at least the
same—diluted down. A new con-

ception, more suited to ourselves,
our times—which wants to use
its brains.

PETER:

What a charming
and extravagant idea. You haven't
aged a day, Hubert, since last I
saw you. Who wants to use his brains?

HUBERT:

—those who would think rather in
their own terms than borrowed ones . . .

PETER:

No one.

HUBERT:

—and in the same terms
celebrate our achievements—but
elevated to a distinction which, with
genius, may be invented to astonish
them.

PETER:

By you, the genius.

HUBERT:

Yes, of course. After all, no one
believed the crazy rack would fly.

PETER:

You mean the airplane?

HUBERT:

Yes.

PETER:

Why don't
you say so then?

HUBERT:

And newspapers
are printed now on paper made
of wood. Because we have accepted
complex associations simply does not
make them simple. So that we
should not be dismayed by a difficult
approach. Complex derivations are,
for all that, fully possible—
once the taboo is lifted. We don't
like verse in plays.

PETER:

No, we don't.

HUBERT:

I know that. But I know more.
There is no verse, no new verse
to write a play in. That's why. Invent it.

PETER:

And you'll invent it.
This is the usual avant-garde décor,
isn't it, Hubert? So far in front
it's dragging at tomorrow's tail.

HUBERT:

No. You'll see.

ALISE [*to Hubert*]:

I could spit in his face.

PETER:

I wish you all success, my dear.

ALISE:

I hope you like it.

[*They go down into the theater, leaving Alise and one
of the young actors on the stage.*]

Scene 2

SERAFINA

A street in the poorer section of an Eastern mill town. A blond young man of Polish or Russian descent, bareheaded, with his topcoat collar turned up and wearing heavy glasses, is leaning against the wall near the door of a small apartment house. He is reading a folded newspaper. He is dressed as any poor college student might be. His name is Ladislav but the name he goes by is Laddie. There are several childish scrawls in colored chalk along the apartment wall, among them "Annie loves Joe" prominently figured. From time to time Laddie looks down the street, first one way, then the other. A factory worker returning from his job comes along, a man of forty or so.

MAN:

Hello, Laddie. You still hanging around?

LADDIE:

That's right.

MAN:

Thought you were going down to camp this week.

LADDIE:

Thought so too.

MAN:

What's the matter—holes in your lungs?

LADDIE:

Sure.

MAN:

You look it. Seen that God-damned woman hanging around anywhere this afternoon?

LADDIE:

Who?

MAN:

My wife, Serafina.

LADDIE:

No.

MAN:

Maybe she's upstairs for a change. I'm gonna knock her block off one of these days if she don't get back here evenings before I do. Take care of yourself.

[A woman comes out the door of the apartment and almost falls over Laddie's foot as he leans there.]

WOMAN:

Excuse me. *[She goes on.]*

[A pretty young girl comes in, from the left, and stops to talk to Laddie.]

GIRL:

I thought you . . .

LADDIE:

You thought! How?

GIRL:

Oh. *[She gives him a quick grin and goes into the house. Laddie remains leaning against the wall, reading his paper.]*

Detail 2

A barroom waiter, in vest, shirtsleeves and short apron, shifts a screen at the left, moving it forward to shut off a space where he places a small iron table and two chairs. He dusts them off with his towel as Serafina and her Boyfriend come in and sit down. He waits for their order.

BOYFRIEND:

Serafina! A hell of a name.

SERAFINA:

You know where you can put it.

BOYFRIEND:

What are you having?

SERAFINA:

The same.

BOYFRIEND [*to the waiter*]:

Box cars. Make it two.

[*The waiter goes out.*]

SERAFINA:

Let's have a tune.

[*The Boyfriend goes out a moment. As he returns, a jukebox offstage begins to play: "Let me call you sweetheart, I'm in love with you!"*]

SERAFINA:

Oh boy!

BOYFRIEND:

Geezus, I'd have to pick that one.

SERAFINA:

What'd you find out?

BOYFRIEND:

What'd yuh mean, what did I find out?

SERAFINA:

Did you get me pregnant?

BOYFRIEND:

Hey listen, take it easy. Don't pick on me.

SERAFINA:

No?

BOYFRIEND:

No.

[*The waiter returns with their drinks and a bowl of pretzels, then goes out again.*]

SERAFINA:

You probably never even gave it to the doc after me damn near standing on my head to get the stuff for you.

BOYFRIEND:

I gave it to him. Five bucks it cost me.

SERAFINA:

Did you want *me* to pay for it?

BOYFRIEND:

How 'bout the rest of the gang?

SERAFINA:

What'd he say?

BOYFRIEND:

The test was a flop.

SERAFINA:

What do you mean, a flop? He took the five bucks, didn't he?

BOYFRIEND:

Sure, he took it all right.

SERAFINA:

So what?

BOYFRIEND:

No good. [*She merely looks at him.*] He says it didn't work out on account of the God-damned rabbit was a queer.

SERAFINA:

Huh?

BOYFRIEND:

Sure, the doc says it was a hermaphrodite.

SERAFINA:

A what?

BOYFRIEND:

He says he thought it was a she when he shot the stuff into its ear, but when he come to open it up and examine it to see if you was pregnant it turned out to be her boyfriend—that hadn't come of age yet.

SERAFINA:

Jesus God! Is that what he said? What was that again?

BOYFRIEND:

He says we got to send him another specimen. To hell with it. I'm in the army.

SERAFINA:

What'd he say? Tell me again.

BOYFRIEND:

He said it's one case in ten thousand. Picked the wrong rabbit outa the hat. Said the girl that does the work in the laboratory was scared as hell, didn't know what the hell she'd found. A lousy hermaphrodite. Wouldn't that get you?

SERAFINA:

So that's what they did to me.

BOYFRIEND:

Yeah.

SERAFINA:

I don't get it. You gotta tell me again.

BOYFRIEND:

You see, what happens, the doc says, is you take a young female rabbit that's never come around yet and you shoot the stuff out of you into a vein in its ear.

SERAFINA:

Is that right? Into a vein.

BOYFRIEND:

So they pick the rabbit. It's got to be a young she—you know, a virgin—and that's what they thought they had, and they shoot the stuff outa the bottle into it.

SERAFINA:

In the ear.

BOYFRIEND:

Then they wait two days and kill it and examine it. And if the stuff brings it around then you're caught.

SERAFINA:

Is that right?

BOYFRIEND:

So when they did it to this one they found it had come around all right because you couldn't tell what the hell it was but it wasn't a she.

SERAFINA:

Can you believe it?

BOYFRIEND:

You gotta believe it.

SERAFINA:

And he kept the five bucks?

BOYFRIEND:

Sure, he's a professional man. Said to send him up another specimen and he'd do it for nothin'.

SERAFINA:

Are you gonna do it?

BOYFRIEND:

Aw, tell your old man. I'm leavin' for Georgia tomorrow. To hell with it. [*She begins to laugh hysterically.*] What the hell you laughing at?

SERAFINA:

The way that poor rabbit got showed up. Thought she was a lady and by God they ripped her open after me giving it to her in the ear and they found out she was a man. [*She laughs foolishly.*]

BOYFRIEND:

You're nuts. Hey, waiter! Here. [*The waiter comes and the Boyfriend gives him a bill. The waiter makes change.*] Keep it. So long, kid. [*She pays no attention to him.*] You'll be all right. [*He waits a moment.*] So long. I'll send you a post card. [*He goes out.*]

[*After the Boyfriend has left, Serafina gradually stops laughing. She fusses in her bag for a coin, goes out a moment and returns immediately. As she sits making herself up the jukebox plays again: "Let me call you sweetheart."* She finishes her makeup, gathers up various small bundles she has placed on a free chair—maybe takes another drink—and leaves. The waiter clears everything away—chairs, table and screen.]

Detail 3

Laddie is alone at the door, still reading his paper. The woman who came out of the house a short time earlier returns now and again falls over his foot.

WOMAN:

Excuse me. [*She goes into the house.*]

[*Someone begins playing a violin, rather well, somewhere in the street—fairly complicated runs and fast passages, but all incomplete, broken off and started again irregularly. Serafina comes in from the left, carrying her parcels. She stops short on seeing Laddie. He does not*

appear to have noticed her. She is about to pass him and go into the house but then stops.]

SERAFINA:

What are you doing here?

LADDIE:

Oh. Just . . . waiting.

SERAFINA:

Waiting? I thought you'd left.

LADDIE:

No.

SERAFINA:

Who are you waiting for?

LADDIE:

A drunk. [*He just looks at her.*]

SERAFINA:

You're nuts. When are you leaving for camp?

LADDIE:

They turned me down.

SERAFINA:

What do you know! Got a match?

[He looks at her, takes a pack of matches out of his pocket and prepares to light one. To find her cigarettes she has put her packages down at the door. She takes out a cigarette.]

LADDIE:

Your old man went upstairs about twenty minutes ago.

SERAFINA:

To hell with him. [*Laddie lights her cigarette for her.*]
You don't smoke, do you?

LADDIE:

No.

SERAFINA:

You don't do anything, do you?

LADDIE [*after a pause*]:

I've been waiting to see *you*—the last half hour.

SERAFINA [*gasping*]:

Me! [*Tobacco smoke comes out of her eyes and nose—she coughs.*]

LADDIE:

Yes, you. I want to talk to you, Serafina.

SERAFINA:

You got a nerve calling me by my first name.

LADDIE:

Look! You think I'm a silly kid, don't you? Imagine! I was born on this block. Can you imagine it? I grew up here. I went to high school four blocks over. I've been sticking around here long enough. But what am I goin' to do with my mother?

SERAFINA:

You asking me? And what am I going to do with that son of a bitch upstairs? [*She makes a face.*]

LADDIE:

You've been drinking this afternoon?

SERAFINA:

What's it to you?

LADDIE:

That's what I wanted to tell you.

SERAFINA:

What?

LADDIE:

I want you to stop drinking.

SERAFINA:

You what? I'll slap your face, you damn kid. [*He rubs his hand over his hair.*] What do you mean saying a thing like that to me?

LADDIE:

I don't know what I mean. I'm telling you. You're the only one around here, next to my mother, that I think anything about.

SERAFINA:

You know too much.

LADDIE:

Not half what I want to know. But I'm going where it is and I'm going to get it.

SERAFINA:

Tough luck. [*She looks down at her feet.*]

LADDIE:

And I just wanted to tell you before I left, that you and I have got something in common.

SERAFINA:

We have, huh. What?

LADDIE:

I don't know. Just something . . . and I wanted to tell you about it. I don't get much chance.

SERAFINA:

What's the matter with you?

LADDIE:

Nothing. God damn it—nothing! For once in my life I'm going to say what I have on my mind to say. [*Suddenly changing.*] Nuts.

SERAFINA:

Yeah, you poor kid. What do you know?

[A woman comes up with a baby carriage and takes out an infant, carrying it into the house.]

LADDIE:

Look—maybe I'm crazy but I know this much. I know if I'm ever going to get anywhere I got to get out of this place. I thought I was going to be drafted. Well, they turned me down. That gave me the idea. I got work to do.

SERAFINA:

Yeah, that's right.

LADDIE:

I can raise a couple of hundred bucks. I don't know how I'm going to do it . . . but I'm going to do it.

SERAFINA:

Do what?

LADDIE:

I'm going to be a writer.

SERAFINA:

Laddie, honest—are you? That's marvelous. Write books—you mean like Hemingway and all that?

[An auto horn plays la-do-dee-da.]

LADDIE:

Yes, but I've got to work. I'll get a job on a newspaper. I've got to do it mostly at night. I don't know where—but somewhere. And do you know why?

SERAFINA:

No.

LADDIE:

Because I'm so damn sick crazy in love with you that . . .

[He loses his nerve.]

SERAFINA:

What? [*She is drunkenly serious.*]

LADDIE:

I don't know whether it's love. Maybe I'm just sorry for you.

SERAFINA:

You've got a crust.

LADDIE:

Don't talk to me that way, Serafina. You're drunk.

SERAFINA:

What do you mean, I'm drunk? I had a couple of drinks but I'm not drunk.

LADDIE:

I don't know what I mean. Good-bye.

SERAFINA:

Wait. Darling, wait! [*He stops, amazed.*] Why haven't you told me about this before?

LADDIE:

I guess I didn't . . . think of it. I don't know what difference it would have made anyway. I don't mean that.

SERAFINA:

You poor kid. Why do you suppose I took a drink today?

LADDIE [*looking at her*]:

How should I know?

SERAFINA:

You!

LADDIE:

Liar!

SERAFINA:

No. I'm not a liar . . . funny, ain't it? I didn't know what

it was. I'll tell you the truth. But just now I know. It was because you're going away. That's why. I just found it out.

LADDIE:

You can't pull a rabbit out of the hat on me that way.

SERAFINA:

What? [*She laughs wildly.*] A rabbit?

LADDIE [*going to her*]:

What's the matter?

SERAFINA:

Get out. Go on. Keep away from me, you damned kid.

[*A man's voice calls from above.*]

MALE VOICE:

For Christ's sake, what the hell you two doing down there? Come on up here! I been wondering where the hell you were with my supper.

[*Serafina picks up her bundles.*]

SERAFINA:

Good-bye, sucker! [*She goes in.*]

[*Someone throws a bunch of stale flowers down at Laddie's feet. Before the curtain can descend Hubert steps forward with his hand raised.*]

HUBERT:

Hold it! We'll cut out the business of the flowers. Just "Good-bye, sucker!" and a slow curtain. Pick it up from "For Christ's sake . . ."

[*Serafina comes back to the stage. She and Laddie get into their positions for the repeat.*]

MALE VOICE:

For Christ's sake, what the hell you two doing down there? Come on up here! I been wondering where the hell you were with my supper.

[*Serafina picks up her bundles.*]

SERAFINA:

Good-bye, sucker! [*She goes in.*]

[*Peter comes up from behind. The curtain slowly closes leaving Hubert and Peter, continuing their dialogue, before it. Hubert stands at the break in the curtain, on the left; Peter stands to the right of the break.*]

PETER:

Um! Really, Hubert! Rather, ah . . . isn't it?

HUBERT:

Well? Do you like it?

PETER:

Ummm . . . I don't know. Probably not.

HUBERT:

Why not?

PETER:

I can't see the point. Is it related to something I should know about?

HUBERT:

You mean, for yourself?

PETER:

Yes.

HUBERT:

No.

[*Hubert draws the curtain back for Peter to step through. Peter does not move.*]

PETER:

There's more been going on here than meets the eye, my friend. Let it pass. [*He pushes back the other edge of the curtain for Hubert to precede him.*] Go on.

[*Hubert yields and goes through the curtain, as Peter watches him and then abruptly follows, letting the curtain fall back into place as the house lights come up.*]

ACT II

Scene 1

To follow after the last without too great delay, the previous set having merely to be lifted to show this one standing behind it: the front porch of a small white wooden farmhouse. There is no railing. Two or three steps lead down in the center from the front door. It is a Sunday afternoon in midsummer. When the curtain rises the setting is complete—except that a mechanism to move the whole porch forward five or six feet is being tried out. The stagehands move it back and forth once or twice while the introductory scene is in progress. Hubert and Peter are standing on one side. As they talk, the actors come on stage and prepare for the action as they would if the curtain were still lowered—gestures and silent conversation, arranging the porch furniture, looking at the newspaper, etc.

PETER:

Get rid of that woman, will you?

HUBERT:

I can't do it.

PETER:

Why not?

HUBERT:

I've told you.

I'm schooling her gradually to
speak as I wish her to—a verse
form that'll be modern and expressive.
I must myself first learn how. It's difficult.
She is most important to me . . .

PETER:

Then get rid of the verse. Why
must you write in verse?
What in God's name do you want to
write in verse for?

HUBERT:

Because that is the basis of everything
I want to do. That is what says
what I am saying beyond the words.
There can never be
a play worth listening to except in verse.
But look, in this next act I'm trying out
a device which has certain possibilities—
various scenes on the same scene simultaneously . . .

PETER:

Let's first agree that there'll be no
more verse. And that she'll go . . .

HUBERT:

If she goes, I go.

PETER:

Are you serious?

HUBERT:

What do you mean, am I serious? I
have already told you, now I repeat
it. There is only one thing that I
intend to do—it is to learn to write
a play in verse. There's nothing else
that in the least concerns me, neither
to eat, nor drink, nor sleep—either alone
or with a woman—or anything. I'm
going to put this over . . .

PETER:

You need to, my boy.

HUBERT:

The words must carry a special meaning,
a special dramatic structure of their
own. What is the dramatic structure
as it occurs in words? Verse. That
is the drama of words—words in love,
hot words, copulating, drinking, running,
bleeding!

PETER:

There's still this woman.

HUBERT:

You see, no one knows what it is.
They've never heard invention on
the stage. No one knows what poetry
should be today. It should be the
audience itself, come out of itself
and standing in its own eyes, leaning
within the opening of its own ears,
hearing itself breathe, seeing itself
in the action—lifted by poetry to
a world it never knew, a world it has
always longed for and may enter for a
few precious moments never to be known
in prose. The audience is the play.
And it is pure poetry—unless one
fails to imagine it and lift it beyond the
dirty boards into the empyrean. Can prose
do that?

PETER:

Can you do that?

HUBERT:

Have I done it—to you? A little?

PETER:

It's dazzling, I acknowledge, but I'm
a special case. You're impractical,

Hubert. Do you know, really, what an audience is? An audience is made up of boredom—those that have money enough to pay for tickets in the commercial theater—a belly full of supper. Poetry? To them? Something like—a handkerchief, to blow your nose on. They smell. They talk during the pauses. During key speeches they cough. They're not people. They're not even representative. You can't imagine an audience. They don't exist. They merely have tickets. That's all they are. And you'd better entertain them. They don't come here to be elevated—by the imagination or otherwise. They're tired—you've heard it. This isn't an affair of state—or taste. This is the modern commercial theater. If the play isn't interesting, they leave.

HUBERT:

That's the challenge. But if their curiosity can be excited, you can insult them, cheat them, make them pay for what they never get, and generally show them up as idiots to their complete satisfaction. Excite their curiosity and you can do anything you please with them.

PETER:

That's a fine attitude for a young playwright to take. So, by God, you're going to make them swallow poetry—for your amusement. You won't get away with it, Hubert. Besides I don't believe you.

HUBERT:

How do you mean?

PETER:

Is this another one
in prose?

HUBERT:

Yes. A picture
I saw one day last summer
driving up through Jersey. A
Sunday afternoon. Just some farm
people sitting on a porch. It
seemed full of malignant tension—and
I conceived the play. I had already
passed and had to stop and back up
a distance to make my notes on it.
Something suggestive of the Greek theater.

PETER:

Well, I'll listen through this one
but if my suspicions are confirmed,
good-bye, Hubert.

HUBERT:

Don't say that.

[Hubert glances quickly at Peter, hesitates, then turns to the players.]

If you're ready, begin.

[He goes to the left side of the stage, followed by Peter, and gets two chairs from the wings. He places them far forward, out of the way, sits down and motions for Peter to join him. They remain there throughout the scene, watching the action—and occasionally commenting on it in asides.]

Scene 2

THE FUNNIES

The actors are now in position. On the right side of the porch, stretched out full length on an old horsehair couch—from which the stuffing is coming out—lies George, a heavy-set, bald-headed man of about seventy. He is reading the funny sheet of the paper. He is wearing suspenders over a white shirt, open at the collar. Next to him toward the center sits Pete, his nephew, who runs the farm. Pete is a rather lean, tough-looking individual with a sour face. He is lame and wears a corrective shoe. He wears a hat on the back of his head, no tie and a colored sport shirt. Pete's wife, Mattie, sits next to him, with a part of the paper in her hand. Farthest to the left sits their daughter Ann, a pretty dark-haired girl of seventeen, neatly though simply dressed in her good clothes.

Aunt Kate, a stout old woman who is patiently fanning herself with a cardboard advertising fan, sits in a rocking chair in the foreground as if—if the size of the stage permits—she were under a tree on the lawn below the porch. Mattie and she are dressed in loose cotton print dresses, making no pretense of style.

Pete and his daughter Ann are looking straight out in front of them. Pete lights a cigarette, takes a couple of draws, rubs it on the porch, grinding it under his foot, gets up and stretches. He looks as though he were going to say something to George, then changes his mind and goes to sit on the edge of the steps.

MATTIE [*looking up from her paper*]:

Why don't you go out and take a walk around, Pete?

PETE:

Why don't you mind your own business?

MATTIE:

You get yourself all stirred up this way so none of us can't have any rest.

PETE:

Yeah, I heard you. [*He turns toward George without getting up.*] Looka here, George.

[*George has not heard him. He is reading the funnies, chuckling to himself.*]

GEORGE:

By guy! She wants to duck the baby in a tub of icewater to cure the hiccoughs. Then she starts hiccoughing herself! So what does Popeye do—he grabs her around the neck with one fist and . . . oh boy.

ANN:

Mother!

GEORGE:

Huh?

MATTIE [*shouting*]:

How much longer you going to be with that funny sheet, George?

ANN:

He doesn't even hear you.

MATTIE:

Well, just be patient. [*She goes on reading.*]

ANN:

Oh, mother!

[*Pete gets up and goes into the house.*]

KATE [*from her chair*]:

What's the matter, Annie?

ANN:

Nothing! Absolutely nothing.

[There is a pause. Pete comes out of the house, carrying a wooden sign about a foot and a half square. He leans against the doorjamb looking at the sign.]

MATTIE:

Why don't you quit it, Pete?

PETE:

Because I don't intend to. *[shouting]* Hey, George!

GEORGE:

What do you want?

PETE:

I want to put up a sign.

GEORGE:

Let's see it.

[Pete, without moving, carelessly turns the sign around so George can see it.]

GEORGE:

No! *[He goes on reading.]*

[Pete takes George by the shoulder and pulls him up until he is sitting on the edge of the couch. He shouts in his ear.]

PETE:

What do you mean, no? *[shaking him violently]* I say, yes!

GEORGE:

You take your hands off me, Pete Thompson. You ain't a gonna put no sign on this house.

PETE *[shoving George back on the couch]*:

You damned old fool.

GEORGE *[struggling to sit up]*:

Who's a damned old fool?

PETE:

You are! [*George subsides on his back.*] And for two cents I'd knock your teeth down your dirty throat.

MATTIE:

You're like to do him an injury, Pete, shoving a man of his age around thata way. Stop it! You'll be driving him into a stroke if you ain't careful.

PETE [*still beside himself*]:

No luck. I wish I knew what'd do it. [*He brandishes the sign in his hand.*]

KATE:

You don't wish nothing of the sort, Pete. Now go on, put that piece of wood down before you do something you're sorry for.

[*George has finally gotten himself up into a sitting position.*]

GEORGE:

Looka here, Pete Thompson, you don't own this place.

PETE:

Agh! [*He threatens George with the wooden sign in his hand. George cowers down on the couch again.*]

MATTIE:

Now remember what I said, Pete. You ain't got no right to treat George that way. He's much too old for that. [*to George, handing him the funnies which he has dropped*] Here, George, look at your paper and don't pay no attention to him. Go on, lie down and read your paper. Pete don't mean half of what he says.

KATE [*from her chair*]:

Let's see the sign, Pete.

[*Pete shows it, sullenly. The sign reads:*]

FOR SALE
INQUIRE WITHIN

MATTIE:

It ain't very big, Kate. It won't show much from the road.

KATE:

It ain't how big it is, it's what it says on it makes George mad.

PETE:

Well, as far as I'm concerned he can go to hell. I'm through.

KATE:

You ain't through, Pete. You got a living here, ain't you?

PETE:

You call it a living?

KATE:

And you and Mattie'll get the whole place after we're gone. You and Annie here.

PETE:

That slut.

KATE:

Now, Pete, that's no way to talk.

PETE:

By Christ, Kate, I'm sick of working for nothing and waiting the rest of my life for an old cripple like him to croak and leave me the farm. What the hell, he'll probably live longer than I do anyway. Then where'll I be?

GEORGE [*suddenly coming to life*]:

Somebody want to buy the place, Pete?

PETE:

No!

GEORGE:

's what I thought. [*He yawns, holding the paper in one hand.*]

PETE [*continuing, to the others*]:

I tell you I'm pulling out tomorrow, and to hell with the whole pack of you. [*He takes the sign into the house. There is a pause.*]

ANN:

And I have to sit here all afternoon listening to a lot of disgusting people quarrelling over an old house. You won't even let me see the funny paper.

MATTIE:

Be careful, Annie, don't anger your father no more than he's angered right now. Lower your voice, child, lower your voice.

ANN:

Him!

PETE [*to his daughter, from the house door*]:

Yeah? And you're another.

MATTIE:

Didn't I tell you?

PETE:

If you don't like it here you know what you can do. Nobody's keeping you.

MATTIE:

Leave her alone, Pete. It's Sunday and you said enough to her already.

PETE:

I'll leave her alone when she learns to shut her yap when I talk to her.

ANN:

Who's saying anything to you?

KATE:

Don't pay no attention to her, Pete. [*to Ann*] Your father's got a right to tell you what to do.

ANN:

Yes, if he treats me like a lady he has, but not the way he talks.

[*Kate makes a gesture of despair and buries herself in her paper.*]

PETE:

What's the matter with the way I talk? Not good enough for you, huh? Well, I'm the only one around here that tells you what you are, to your face. Damn fool kids—sneaking around at night like a lot of rats.

ANN:

Where do you want me to go? You let them take the car.

PETE:

So that's what's eating you? You got legs—walk. Yeah, you got legs, plenty!

ANN:

I resent that!

PETE:

Go ahead, you ought to. There's lots of things you ought to resent—only you don't pick the right guy to resent them from. You don't like that, do you?

MATTIE:

Don't raise your voice, Pete. People'll hear you.

PETE:

To hell with them.

KATE:

Now Annie, don't answer him back . . . takes two to make a quarrel. You just listen to Aunt Kate. Just don't answer him back.

ANN [*sarcastically*]:

We're not quarreling. We're just talking pleasantly together.

PETE:

You got too much lip, that's what's the matter with you.

[There is a pause. George rolls over on his side and puts the paper over his head to keep off the flies.]

MATTIE:

Listen to this. [*reading*] "Would-be Runaways Please Read This Item." That's the headline. Then it says: "Harold Gramlich, 11, Jersey City, ran away from his home with a 15-year-old companion to find adventure. His father, John Gramlich, 57, died of a heart attack while coming here on a bus to get him."

PETE:

What put you up to reading that?

MATTIE:

I don't know. It just struck me, that's all.

PETE:

Well, for God's sake.

[There is silence for a moment.]

MATTIE [*putting down her paper*]:

Anybody want a glass of lemonade?

[No one replies. Mattie gets up and goes into the house.]

ANN:

I wish you'd turn on the radio when you're in there, Ma.

PETE:

Leave it alone. *[He picks up part of the paper from the porch floor and puts it down again. Then he takes out a cigarette . . . and puts it back in the pack. He hangs his*

head low between his knees and looks down at the ground. The radio in the house begins playing a dance number, not too loud.] You would.

KATE:

Go on in the house, Annie, and turn off that music. [*Ann doesn't stir.*] Now, Ann, you go do what I tell you. We was all worried about you last night. You shouldn't a done it. You know that. Keeping us up till all hours worrying about you, thinking you'd been in an accident maybe. You can't blame your Pa for getting mad coming in at five o'clock in the morning that way. Now go in and turn off that radio, like a good girl. [*There is no answer.*]

PETE:

No use, Kate—no use talking to the little bitch.

KATE:

Now Peter, you're a grown man and what's more, you're her father. You oughtn't to carry on like that.

ANN:

No more than I expect of him.

PETE [*really angry*]:

I'll warn you good one of these days, young lady, big as you are. I'll take 'em down for you in a way you ain't used to.

MATTIE [*in the door*]:

Pete!

PETE [*continuing*]:

Right here where they can see from the road. I'll show 'em what you are. Just keep it up a little while and see what happens to you.

PETER [*from the side*]:

Well! After all, Hubert!

HUBERT:

Sh! Please!

[Pete gets up, goes into the house and turns off the music. Mattie comes out with a tray and glasses of lemonade. She puts it down on the floor of the porch and takes a glass to Kate. She looks at George, but sees he is sleeping and passes him by.]

Detail 2

Independently of the family group on the porch, and without any interval or change of the set, a second group of actors enter and go into action at one side of the stage. They are four picnickers—two young men and two girls, one of them rather chubby. They come in from the right and put their things down on a crude table and bench which the boys drag in. Hot from walking, they spread themselves around on the grass.

They are Fred, Ann's brother; Min, a sharp-faced girl; Lil, the stout one; and Horace, the one who had kept Ann out the night before and because of whom she was punished. The boys are about nineteen or twenty, the girls a little younger.

The two groups ignore each other. Peter and Hubert are still seated at the left side of the stage.

PETER:

What's this?

HUBERT:

Picnickers at a public park in
the neighborhood.

PETER:

What! On the same scene?

HUBERT:

The mind's the scene.

PETER:

Whose mind?

HUBERT:

Let them continue.

LIL:

Whoof! Am I hot. I thought we'd never get here over that path. [*looking off to the right*] Ain't the view grand?

FRED:

What'll you have, girls?

MIN:

Just a glass of water.

FRED:

Come on. Come on. How about it? Ginger ale. Coke. What'll it be?

HORACE:

Don't ask 'em. Just get something. Go on. Beat it.

MIN:

I'll have a glass of water.

FRED:

Three cokes and a glass of water. Right?

LIL:

I'd rather have an ice-cream soda.

FRED:

O.K., Kate Smith.

LIL:

Strawberry.

FRED:

Oh boy!

LIL:

You said it.

PETER [*to Hubert*]:

I'm sure you're trying to insult me.

[*Fred goes out. The other boy is sullen, moody.*]

LIL:

Come on, Horace . . . smile! Come on, smile. Show your dimples. Look who's here. Little me. I can't help it because your girl wouldn't come with you.

PETER:

And take my cash at the same time.

HORACE:

She'd have come all right if she could have got away.

PETER:

And yet . . .

MIN:

Don't pay any attention to him, Lil.

PETER:

I rather admire you for it . . .

HORACE:

That thick-head of an old man she has. I'd like to wipe his nose for him.

PETER:

Against my will.

MIN:

You're disgusting. What do you want him to do? You bring his little girl home at five in the morning—with the reputation you got. And you want him to meet you with a brass band, I suppose, and a bunch of flowers.

HORACE:

He can't do this to me. I'll lay him low.

MIN [*laughing scornfully*]:

I can just see you. He'll knock your block off if he catches you within a mile of the place.

HORACE:

Like hell he will. I'll let him have it.

FRED [*bringing the drinks*]:

Let who have what?

MIN:

He's going to clip your Dad, Fred. Him—Sir Lancelot! And rescue little Annie from her irate parent.

LIL:

Isn't he wonderful? My hero!

PETER:

I'm still the best friend you have.

FRED:

Yeah, he's dumb enough to try it. Come out of it, you dope. Where do you think you'll land? In the hoosegow.

PETER:

You need me more than you realize.

HORACE:

You think so. Well, wait and see.

LIL:

Are you really, Horace? Come on, cutie, forget it—just for this afternoon. You asked me to come and I came with you. Now you can't say I wasn't generous—knowing what I know.

HORACE:

What do you know?

LIL:

Well, anyway we ain't having any fun at all, just because of you. I'm going home.

HORACE:

Go on, walk off some of that fat.

LIL [*laughing*]:

Ain't he cute? I just love him.

MIN:

Maybe you think so. After all, mister, I didn't come here this afternoon just to have a fresh guy like you show off his bad temper. I'm through with you.

PETER:

I wonder how you can draw them as
you do, your women—vulgar to a degree.

[Someone in the wings whispers to Hubert, who then tries to induce Peter to retire offstage with him. Instead, Peter walks straight across to the right side of the stage, his chair in hand, and seats himself there, smiling. Hubert follows him and remains standing beside him.]

LIL:

Say, where's my ice-cream soda?

FRED:

You'll have to take a coke, Lil, they didn't have any.

[They open their cokes and put straws into them.]

Detail 3

ANN [*pointing to George*]:

Look at him! He's gone to sleep with it over his head now.

MATTIE:

Well, leave it alone. You can look at it later after he's had his nap.

ANN:

Oh, I wish I was dead.

Detail 4

Lil has been making up to Horace, leaning against him.

HORACE:

Lean off me, will you. Ain't it hot enough here without you making it worse? Go on. [*shoving her*] Pull up your socks.

PETER:

Very pretty.

Detail 5

A Real Estate Agent, a middle-aged man, comes in with Agnes Breen, a young business woman. She is well but rather severely dressed in a tailored suit. The Agent brings over two chairs from the left, one of them with an arm rest on which he may write. He places the chairs as if they were in his office. A stagehand puts a telephone on the floor beside his chair. This action takes place at the other side of the stage from where the young people are having their picnic and in front of the family group on the farmhouse porch.

AGENT:

Won't you come over here, Mrs. . . . uh . . .

MISS BREEN:

Thank you. Breen is the name. Agnes Breen.

PETER:

She looks like a man!

AGENT:

Oh. Mrs. . . . or . . .

PETER:

Hubert! What is this?

MISS BREEN:

Miss. I'm a business woman. I have no family. You might as well know it. I'm alone. And I want a small place in the country for my personal use. The usual things, and I don't want to pay too much for it. I'm told you can help me.

AGENT:

Oh, yes, yes, yes, yes!

[She sits down and they talk. He takes notes and shows her various papers and photographs.]

PETER:

But you *are* trying to insult me,
Hubert.

HUBERT:

I can't talk to you, Peter, when
you act this way.

PETER:

I'll be quiet.

Detail 6

ANN:

I'll do it! I'll do it! No matter what anybody says. [*There is a pause.*] Poor thing, he didn't mean it. I know he didn't mean it. But if he was lying, if he was lying! . . . I'll never show my face again around here. I don't believe it. I've got to see him tonight. I don't care what they say, I'll get out of here tonight—and I mean it. Nobody's going to stop me. I will get out . . . and he'd better be waiting.

PETER:

Oh Hubert, Hubert, Hubert!
You poor baby.

Detail 7

HORACE [*to Lil*]:

I told you to lean off me.

LIL:

Aw, come on, be a sport. The whole afternoon's almost gone and we haven't done anything but sit here.

HORACE:

Aw, go feed the squirrels.

LIL:

There ain't any around here.

MIN:

I wouldn't stand for it.

HORACE:

How much money you got on you, Fred?

FRED:

What's the idea?

HORACE:

How much?

FRED:

A couple of bucks. But I need it—for gasoline.

HORACE [*to Lil*]:

How much you got, Fatty?

LIL:

What's it to you?

HORACE:

I got to have it. Come on, open up. How much? I'll give it back to you.

LIL:

I'll say you will. How much do you want?

HORACE:

Ten bucks. Are you game?

LIL:

Ten dollars! What do you think I am?

HORACE:

Listen, Lil. If you ever wanted to be my friend, this is your chance. It's up to you.

LIL:

Oh, is that so?

PETER:

I find I have very little power
over you any longer, Hubert.

MIN:

Come on, Lil, don't listen to him.

HORACE:

You keep out of this. Come on, Lil, what do you say?

HUBERT:

I can't go on with you, Peter.
You confuse me and I don't want
to be confused. I want to think
straight . . . straight. Without consideration.

LIL:

What do you want it for?

HORACE:

I can't tell you now, Lil, but I got to have it right away.

PETER:

I've been away much too long.

MIN:

He's going to elope, darling. Think of what you're missing.
Come on, Fred, I won't listen to such stuff any more.

HORACE:

What do you say? I'll give it back to you next Saturday.

LIL:

You promise?

MIN:

Oh my God, she's going to let him have it!

[Lil opens up her handbag and takes out several small bills.]

LIL *[holding the bills]*:

Well. But just try and find anybody else would do a thing like this for you.

PETER:

The little idiot!

[Lil gives Horace the money which he counts quickly and puts in his pocket. He looks at his wrist watch and then up at the sky.]

[Peter yawns and goes off into the wings, followed by Hubert.]

HORACE:

Thanks, Lil, you're tops. I'll never forget this.

LIL:

I'll say you won't. What I can't understand is . . .

FRED *[interrupting]*:

Come on, let's go down to the pool.

HORACE:

Not me.

MIN:

Come on, Lil. Let's go down and see them feed the bears. We don't need him.

LIL:

He's nothing but a big bear himself.

MIN:

A teddy bear.

HORACE:

Oh yeah? I'll show you.

[Lil, Min and Fred go off. Horace remains and during what follows takes out his pocket knife and carves into the picnic table before him.]

Detail 8

George is still sleeping with the paper over his head. The other members of the family are lolling about as before.

KATE *[to Ann]*:

So they went away and left you. Where were they going, baby?

[The girl does not hear her, so intense is her reverie.]

MATTIE *[answering for Ann]*:

Over to Mountainside Park, Kate. Her brother had it all arranged, so he had to go.

PETE:

Can't she answer for herself when Kate talks to her?

MATTIE:

Now, Pete.

ANN:

Did somebody say something to me?

PETE *[continuing]*:

And let me tell you this, you. Don't you try to pull a fast one around here tonight. Because by Jesus Christ I'll break your back for you, if you try it. I know what's going

through your head. You can't kid me. But you're not getting away with it. Remember.

MATTIE:

She ain't thinking nothing, Pete.

PETE:

No, that's right, she ain't thinking nothing. O.K. That makes everything perfectly all right. She ain't thinking nothing.

KATE:

Takes after her father, Pete. You'll never get nowhere that a way. Just make her more stubborn.

ANN [*to her father*]:

I hate you.

PETE:

That's all right with me, sweetheart. I only hope it ain't too late.

Detail 9

Miss Breen stands up. The Agent gets up more slowly. Peter, followed by Hubert, reappears at the right. They stand there, watching and listening.

MISS BREEN:

Thank you very much. You've been quite helpful.

AGENT:

It's only about a mile and a half from here, down the old Blauvelt Road. Take us two minutes in the car.

MISS BREEN:

No, not today. I'm afraid I'll have to get back to the city.

AGENT:

I think you ought to see it. A colonial house, not too big. Beautiful location. Possibilities for a nice garden. You can do anything you want with it.

MISS BREEN [*laughing*]:

Very poetic. And a wonderful buy! I suppose at, shall we say, twenty thousand dollars?

AGENT:

Oh no, I wouldn't say that.

MISS BREEN:

How much?

AGENT:

Well, it's never been listed.

MISS BREEN:

I see. Is it vacant?

AGENT:

No, the same family is living there that's owned it for the past hundred and fifty years. The Thompsons.

MISS BREEN:

Any young people?

AGENT:

A boy and a young girl just out of high school last year. But they aren't interested.

MISS BREEN:

Oh!

PETER:

This from you! Since when have you become so courageous, my little sparrow? You amaze me! You used to eat out of my hand . . .

[Peter confronts Hubert, who is confused and turns away, leaving the stage. Peter seats himself again, defiantly.]

MISS BREEN:

Why do they want to sell?

AGENT:

That's the catch. They don't. But I think I can get it for you. Shall we go down and take a look?

MISS BREEN:

Well, I'll look at it.

AGENT:

Good. I'll see if I can get them. *[He picks up the phone.]* 154 ring 3 *[He waits.]* Busy signal. I think I ought to try to get him first. Pete's anxious to sell but he don't own the place. The old people own it. We got to play this right.

MISS BREEN:

Do you think this girl you were speaking of might be interested in secretarial work?

AGENT:

Why not? *[He tries the phone again.]* Still busy.

PETER:

Huh!

[He looks around and not seeing Hubert, gets up and goes out.]

Detail 10

ANN:

For God's sake, mother. I know what it's all about. I know I'm a poor girl. I know what my chances are. *[Pete comes to the door of the house and leans, unobserved by his daughter, in the doorway, listening.]* What is there in the

world for me? I've got to get out of this place. I know. I've been to high school. So what? I don't want to teach. I don't want to be a nurse. I don't want to work in an office.

PETE:

Then for God's sake what *do* you want to do, be a night club hostess?

ANN:

I wish I were clever enough, or good-looking enough to be worthy of such a job.

PETE:

Well, you picked the right way to start out after it.

ANN:

What do you mean by that?

PETE:

You know damn well what I mean.

ANN:

Well, you're wrong.

PETE:

Look me in the eye and say that again. Tell me what you were doing in that car last night. Or do you want me to tell you? Go ahead—how far did he get with you?

ANN:

None of your business.

PETE:

That far, huh? You haven't got the guts to come out clean with it.

ANN [*bitterly*]:

All right then. I'm probably going to have a baby!

[*There are various exclamations of amazement from the members of the family.*]

ANN:

It's what you've all been saying. It's what you've been trying to pin on me right along all day—all day long with your dirty minds. Wouldn't you like to believe it? [*She sobs hysterically.*]

[*The telephone rings in the house. Pete hesitates, then gets up slowly and goes to answer it.*]

Detail 11

AGENT [*holding the telephone*]:

Hello, Pete.

PETE [*from inside the house*]:

Hi, Elmer, what's on your mind?

AGENT:

Going to be around the place a little while? Got a client here wants to talk to you about buying the farm.

PETE:

Who is it?

AGENT:

A professional woman from New York.

PETE:

Not interested. Like hell I'm not! Sure I'll sell it. I'll give it away. How much is she offering?

AGENT:

We'll talk about that later, Pete. Coming right over.

PETE:

How much is she willing to pay?

AGENT:

Don't know yet, Pete. How much you asking?

PETE:

Ten thousand dollars—for the whole business. Twenty acres, house, barn, garage—the works.

AGENT:

Too much, Pete. Wait a minute. [*He puts his hand over the mouthpiece.* To Miss Breen:] Ten thousand.

MISS BREEN [*shaking her head*]:

No!

AGENT:

Offer you five. See you in a few minutes. Think it over. Cash down—five thousand dollars.

PETE:

Wasting your time, Elmer. George won't let you have it anyhow, so save yourself the trouble.

AGENT:

See you in a few minutes. [*He hangs up.*] Let's go.

[*They go off to the left.*]

Detail 12

PETE [*coming out onto the porch*]:

Somebody wants to buy the house. Now how'd that happen?

MATTIE:

It ain't yours to sell, Pete. You know that.

PETE:

By God I'll sell it. George!

MATTIE:

Don't wake him now. They coming over?

KATE:

But what are you going to do with *us*, Pete?

PETE:

We can get an apartment somewhere. All right, let him sleep. It's a woman. Hey, Mattie, go on in the house and fix things up so we won't have to be ashamed of the place. Maybe when we get somebody here with real jack we can talk to the old bastard.

[Pete and Mattie go into the house.]

Detail 13

LIL *[from offstage]*:

Hor-ace!

[Peter appears on the right side of the stage.]

PETER:

What's she bellowing about?

LIL:

Hor-ace! *[She comes in from the left.]* Why don't you answer me? Come on. You just wanted to make me climb up all those steps. We're going home.

HORACE:

O.K. *[He gathers up the picnic things and goes off with Lil to the right.]*

[Hubert joins Peter and they stand looking curiously about.]

HUBERT:

I believed that you would look beyond
self-interest.

PETER:

Oh you did, did you?

HUBERT:

And not for merely personal reasons
obstruct me.

PETER:

He, ho! So that's
the tune! When you heard that I
had come back you thought to take
advantage of me. Deliberately!
And yet you have the crust to say . . .

HUBERT:

It was an opportunity
I couldn't afford to pass up. I . . .

PETER:

You counted on my continued affection.

HUBERT:

I counted on your help and understanding.

Detail 14

Ann and Aunt Kate are alone now on the porch except for the still-sleeping George. Ann goes over to George and tries to take the funnies. He has hold of the paper and won't let go. Ann looks at him closely and turns to Kate.

ANN:

Kate! There's something funny about George. He don't seem to be breathing right.

PETER:

Why don't they stick a pin in him?

KATE:

Oh, leave him alone. Been that way when he's asleep for the last forty years. Come on. Sit down here on the step by your old auntie and lemme talk to you. You need it bad.

ANN:

Kate, do you think we're going to sell the house? Didn't Pete say it was a woman? What kind of a woman do you

suppose she is, Kate? Do you suppose it's someone like Helen Hayes—some woman like that? Because if she is, Kate, you never can tell what might happen. Do you think it is, Kate? Oh, that would be marvelous. You believe in me, don't you, Kate? You know I wouldn't do anything wrong.

KATE:

Well, I guess we don't need to worry too much about that. Don't do no good anyhow.

ANN:

Look, they're coming.

[The Agent and Agnes Breen enter from the left and stand for a moment looking at the house.]

AGENT:

Hello, Annie! This is the young lady I told you about, Miss Breen. Annie, this is Miss Agnes Breen. We've come to look at the farm.

MISS BREEN:

Really charming. How are you, Ann?

ANN [*eagerly*]:

Oh, I'm all right.

AGENT [*to Kate*]:

I'm sorry—this is a young woman from New York who's interested in looking at the farm.

[Kate struggles to get out of her chair.]

MISS BREEN [*going to her*]:

Please don't get up. So sorry we had to disturb you.

KATE:

Not at all. Very nice of Elmer here to bring you around.

MISS BREEN [*to the Agent*]:

Yes, I like this!

ANN:

Do you!

MISS BREEN:

Yes, dear, I do. I wish I owned it. Really a charming place.

[Mattie comes out of the house, followed by Pete.]

AGENT:

Oh, there you are, Pete.

PETE:

How do you do?

AGENT:

Miss Breen, this is Mr. Thompson. Excuse me, and Mrs. Thompson, Miss Breen. Miss Breen is interested in looking the place over, Pete. Do you mind if we look around?

MATTIE:

No, not at all. Come right in.

AGENT:

George taking a little snooze over there?

PETE:

Yeah, he's been asleep most of the afternoon.

MISS BREEN:

Don't bother him. Poor man, he's probably tired.

PETE:

Yeah. Shall I show you around? Maybe you'd like to go inside first. Nothing's fixed up much but you're welcome to see what we got.

MISS BREEN:

Yes, of course.

[She goes in through the front door, followed by Mattie, Pete and the Agent. Ann, Kate and Uncle George, still asleep, remain on the porch.]

ANN:

Oh, Kate, do you think I could ever get to be like that, so lovely, so thoughtful—and so clever. She must be clever. I feel different just to be near her. Oh, if you only knew what this means to me.

[Horace comes in resolutely from the right. Ann retreats instinctively to the porch before him.]

HORACE:

Ann!

ANN:

What do you want? Go away from here before my father sees you. I'll meet you tonight.

HORACE:

Ann, I got to talk to you. Now!

ANN:

No!

HORACE:

What? You know what you said last night. Come on—I got a car waiting down the road.

ANN:

I won't do it. Not now. You got to wait.

HORACE:

Say, what's going on here? What's that big car out there on the road?

ANN:

Somebody wants to buy the house.

HORACE:

To hell with that. Here's our chance.

ANN:

No. I'm not sneaking off with anybody. Not now or any time. I'm fed up with you. Right up to here. *[She puts her hand to her neck.]* I was crazy last night. I don't know what I said. I don't remember. All I know is I'm not leav-

ing now. Go on, get out of here before my father comes back and you make it all the worse for me.

HORACE:

O.K. Is that all you got to say, Ann?

ANN:

Darling, I don't mean it that way. I'll meet you tonight, the way I said. I'll promise you.

HORACE:

I don't know, kid. Maybe you will. But maybe I'll just wait here and see what happens. I ain't kidding about this. Not this time.

ANN:

Oh!

[Miss Breen, Pete, Mattie and the Agent come out of the door.]

MATTIE:

She has a brother, in California, that's rich. He promised to send her to college after she finished high school—but we ain't never heard from him since.

ANN:

Oh, mother.

[They all stop and look at her. Pete sees Horace for the first time.]

PETE *[to Horace]*:

What are you doing here?

AGENT *[to his client]*:

Well, how do you like it?

MISS BREEN:

It's exactly what I want. If we can agree on a price, I'll buy it.

[There is an awkward pause. The family all turn and look at George where he is sleeping without a move.]

PETE:

Well, let's wake him up. Go on, Ann. Take the paper off his head.

[Ann refuses and instead goes over and stands behind Miss Breen.]

MISS BREEN:

Why, what's the matter, dear?

PETE *[to Kate]*:

Anything the matter with George, Kate?

KATE:

No, I don't think so.

[Pete goes over and slowly takes the paper off George's head.]

PETE:

Hey, George. *[He puts his hand on George's shoulder and shakes him.]* George! *[Pete turns around and looks at the others a moment, not knowing what to do next. Finally his eye lights on Horace.]* Horace!

HORACE:

Yes, sir.

PETE:

Go get Doc Smith.

[Horace runs out.]

KATE:

I told you you shouldn't ought to have fought him that a way, Pete. He must be dead!

MISS BREEN *[taking Ann in her arms]*:

It's all right, darling. I'll take care of you.

[Ann clings to her.]

CURTAIN

ACT III

Scene 1

TALK

The scene is the kitchen of a small, modern house in the suburbs. It is two days after Christmas.

Clara, a well-built, athletic-looking young woman, is furiously ironing a pile of pink and white table napkins. Her dress is open at the neck—she hasn't much on. By her movements she shows herself to be of a tense, nervous disposition. Occasionally she stops to drink from a tumbler containing an amber-colored liquid.

The doorbell chimes sound. Clara stops ironing, tilts her electric iron up on the board and disappears through the door which leads to the front of the house. The action takes place at high speed throughout.

CLARA [*from the other room*]:

Come on in. Put your things anywhere. Everything's upset here. What do you know? She's asleep.

DOC [*from the other room*]:

Well, let her sleep then.

CLARA [*appearing at the door*]:

Come in here. Want a glass of wine?

[*The Doctor comes in. He is a man of fifty or more. He is rubbing his hands and blowing on them.*]

DOC:

A glass of wine? No, thanks. I've got to get home for lunch.

CLARA:

Come on.

DOC [*changing his mind*]:

Oh well, all right.

CLARA [*intensely*]:

Fine!

[*From under the kitchen table she drags out a gallon jug, half gone, opens it and pours the wine into two large glasses. She nearly fills Doc's glass.*]

DOC:

Hey! Take it easy. What is this?

CLARA:

Nothing good. One dollar eighty-nine cents at the A & P. California Tokay. It won't hurt you. [*She picks up her glass and drinks it lustily. Everything she does and says is jerky and overemphasized.*]

DOC [*tasting and shivering*]:

Terrible! How can you down such stuff?

CLARA:

It's cheap.

DOC:

It'll ruin your stomach.

CLARA:

I don't think so. [*She begins to iron again furiously.*] Don't mind if I finish these. We only have one decent cloth and these napkins go with it. This holiday business, having the family and guests in, dinner, cards . . . I go crazy! And of course, today . . . [*She makes a despairing gesture toward the ceiling.*]

[*Doc jams himself into a chair in the space between the kitchen table and the wall.*]

DOC:

What's going on upstairs?

CLARA:

Oh, that child of mine! She's coughing again. Have a cigarette? [*She offers him her pack.*]

DOC:

No, thanks. [*He gets up and strikes a light for her.*]

CLARA [*smoking furiously*]:

She drives me to the verge of insanity. Whenever we want to go out—of course that's the very moment she picks to throw a fit. But this time I'm really worried. You ought to hear her. [*imitating*] A-shoop! A-whoop! I've been listening to that for three days now. It scares me nearly to death.

DOC:

Three days. Any difficult breathing?

CLARA:

No, only when she coughs. It's been going on for a week, really. But I've been putting it off from day to day, hoping she'd be better—and I thought she was. But an hour ago I took her temperature and it was over a hundred.

DOC:

Mouth?

CLARA [*rapidly*]:

Yes. So I decided I'd waited long enough. Besides I want to go out this afternoon—it's my club and we have six people for supper—but I don't know whether to leave her or not. I've got a little girl that comes in, but she's no good and if the child's going to be sick, I want to know it. Will it do her any harm if I bundle her up and take her over to my mother's? I don't want to give her pneumonia. [*She drinks from her glass.*] Don't you like it?

DOC:

Not much.

CLARA:

What do you think?

DOC:

I'll have to see her first. Shall we go up?

CLARA:

Do you want to wake her? She hasn't had a decent sleep for three nights.

DOC:

It's up to you.

CLARA:

I just want to feel that I'm doing the right thing.

DOC:

Oh, I see. [*He laughs, then picks up his satchel and rises.*]
Come on, let's go up.

CLARA [*ironing furiously*]:

I'll be through in a minute. [*She burns herself.*] Ouch!

DOC:

Did you burn yourself?

CLARA:

That's nothing. I'm always doing that.

DOC:

I'm sorry. [*He sits down again and takes up his glass.*]

CLARA:

I think if we let her sleep, when she wakes a little later maybe she won't have any fever. I don't think we'd better wake her. I'm sure she'll be all right now. I was just nervous.

DOC:

That's fine. [*He gets up to go.*]

CLARA:

No, I think we ought to wake her. Stick around a while, won't you?

DOC:

For the love of Pete, woman, make up your mind and *don't* wait until tonight to call me again. I'm here now but I'll be damned if I'm going to come out again after office hours tonight to please anybody.

CLARA:

Look, Doc . . . I've been taking some iron medicine from my own doctor. You're just for children, aren't you?

DOC:

Practically, yes.

CLARA:

I don't want to have to go to his office this afternoon. Would you give it to me? I've got the stuff.

DOC:

Where?

CLARA:

Right here, in the hip. Do you mind? I've just had a bath.

DOC [*laughing heartily*]:

All right, get it.

CLARA:

Let me finish these things. [*She goes on ironing.*] Help yourself to a cigarette. Oh no, you don't smoke. Haven't you any bad habits?

DOC:

Sure. I eat too much and waste too much time talking to too many silly women. But I seem to like it. So what?

CLARA:

Have some more wine.

DOC:

I shouldn't. It makes me amorous and low. [*He picks up his glass and eyes it a while.*]

CLARA:

Not this stuff.

DOC [*still eying his glass*]:

What do you get out of it?

CLARA:

Me? I love it. Keeps me going. I can work twice as fast when I have a little drink in me. I never take too much.

DOC:

Smart woman. Well. [*He drinks half his glass down and makes a face.*] How do you do it?

CLARA:

I know. Just like my mother—you think I'm weak in the head.

DOC:

I shouldn't say so.

CLARA:

Oh yes, you would. Everybody says the same thing, even my husband. Sometimes my head does bother me, as if the brains were too big for my skull. But if I keep moving, I feel all right.

DOC:

With this assistance.

CLARA:

Just so long as I keep going. It's natural to me. I've been like this all my life, I guess. Never stop. Can't be happy any other way. Oh, I don't mean that I'm really happy, if you know what I want to say. And if I'm not doing something, I'm talking my fool head off. Everybody says I never stop talking. I know it. They probably get sick and

tired of listening to me—hearing me, I mean—because they never listen. I can't—that's why I talk. I just go on and on. Half the time I don't know what I'm saying. Why do people do that?

DOC:

Oh, there are lots of things worse than talking too much. I enjoy talk. A good talker can be delightful.

CLARA:

I don't talk that way. I just talk.

DOC:

Don't we all.

CLARA:

Whew! [*She sits on the edge of the table to rest, smoking, and then takes her glass up to drink.*] Anything to quiet the nerves when I get this way. Shhh! [*listening*] I thought I heard her. [*She drinks deeply.*]

DOC:

Will you do me one favor? Please stop swallowing that vile stuff the way you're doing—it makes me nervous.

CLARA:

It's good. I need it.

DOC:

You don't need it. There are a lot of things you may need but you don't need that.

CLARA:

I don't, eh? You'd be surprised. Say, you were born in this town, weren't you?

DOC:

Yes, in the dim past.

CLARA:

Then how come you don't know about me, or do you?

DOC:

It's not important. I came here to see your child.

CLARA:

It is important. It's the most important thing in the world. You're a doctor—tell me what's the matter with me. Nobody else seems to help me. Maybe you got some ideas.

DOC:

I don't want to know about your case.

CLARA:

Oh, but you must. I'm in a bad way. [*He is still holding his glass.*] Would you rather have a little Scotch?

DOC:

No, I'll just finish this.

CLARA:

You know what?

DOC:

No.

CLARA:

I'm going to tell you something. Believe it or not! I haven't got an ounce of mother love in my whole carcass. What do you suppose is the matter with me? I just haven't got it. You know what kind of a reputation I have in this town. I'm the original black sheep. I don't care. [*emphasizing each word*] I don't love children. Shocked?

DOC:

Shocked? I'm practically in love with you already.

CLARA:

Wouldn't do you any good. I mean it. I'm not shy and I'm not timid. I'm no blushing violet. I tell you just as I'd tell anybody else—I'm trying to do my job as a sweet mother and it's killing me. I'm telling you—killing me. If I quit the whole mess of this having children and sent it to hell and

gone out of my sight, I'd be a better woman—and that's the truth.

DOC:

Amazing!

CLARA:

What is? And that's why I've been married twice, I suppose, to find that out.

[Clara gets up, takes the jug from under the table and fills both their glasses again. Doc does not protest.]

DOC:

So what?

CLARA:

Why don't somebody tell us how to bring up our children right? I don't think anybody knows. Everything they ever did to me was stupid, as far as I remember. The food they gave me even must have been tainted. I think I must have been allergic to cow's milk. Do you know the first thing I remember? My father was cutting down a tree and I laughed like a fool. I must have been about a year old.

DOC:

Oh, come, come! That's a bit strong. You don't remember that.

CLARA:

Anyhow, maybe someone told me. But what I do remember is my father drunk and perfectly marvelous. He let me stand with my feet right on top of his head, with my regular shoes on. Maybe he'd just been to the circus. And I fell off. He tried to catch me, the poor fool, but I landed on the dog, really. You wouldn't believe the impossible things that have happened to me in my life. The poor mutt. Probably saved me from an injury, or maybe he didn't. My brains have been curdled ever since, Mac says. I fell down a well once but they dragged me out. I fell out of a tree

once, too, trying to get horse chestnuts. I don't know what for. My brother was way up in the top of it shaking the branches, so I had to follow him. Stupid.

DOC:

And you remember all these things.

CLARA:

I hated school. Why should I learn all that stuff? Nobody ever took me and talked to me as if I had any intelligence. Maybe I didn't. I never could see any sense to it. Do you know what I wanted to do? Play with the boys. There was a patch of woods—you know where we lived. Do you remember Martha Van Cleve? Well, I was just a little kid but I knew all about it, too. Only I was too small, I guess. All those things. I used to watch the boys behind the back fence. I didn't care. I wasn't even interested but I used to like to follow them around—sometimes the bushes were way over my head. I can still remember it. I wasn't afraid. I ran away once . . . I didn't run away . . . I just started to walk and pretty soon I came to the river. There were those catkins that fall off the poplar trees in the Spring lying all over the path and I thought they were worms. I must have been barefoot. I was terrified. I didn't want to step on them—so I turned around and went home again.

DOC:

I was just going to remind you . . .

CLARA:

Oh, let me talk! I'm just getting to what I wanted to say. Do you remember me when I was a little girl? No, you wouldn't. You were one of the older boys. I used to hear about you, how wonderful you were.

DOC:

I knew your brother.

CLARA:

It doesn't matter. Just a lot of kids. What did we want? Did you ever know? What were we all so excited about? I used to wonder about others. I still do. I remember how I wanted a bicycle. I don't think I ever wanted anything in my entire life as much as that. But I didn't get it. The only reason I wanted it, I guess, was because somebody else had one. Anything we hadn't seen before . . . Isn't that what it was? School! So stupid. I used to vomit my breakfast so I wouldn't have to go. [*She reaches under the table for the jug.*] Have a little more of this?

DOC:

Sure. Why not?

CLARA:

Like it now?

DOC:

Not too bad, after you get by the taste of it.

CLARA:

Imagine me a student. Honestly, what good is knowledge? If it doesn't make you happier or better it's a drug on the market. The happiest people I know are those that simply don't know nothin'. Some of these girls that went to college. Phoof! Of all the God-damndest people! Honestly, don't you hate some people? So I got married—to the first man that proposed to me. Poor Ed. I knew him ever since we were kids. I wasn't excited about him, but he was a nice boy—I used to think. And I still think so. But I couldn't see why I should have a baby right away. This isn't a hundred and fifty years ago. These are modern times—people don't have babies like that any more. Isn't that what causes wars, too many babies?

DOC:

Go on! [*He drinks.*]

CLARA:

Anyhow, that wasn't what I got married for. We fought every minute. Boy, what battles! You could have heard us a mile, especially when we were drunk. I often had to laugh at what the neighbors must have thought of us—right here in this town. To hell with them. What do I care? Do I have to be a God-damned fool just to please the neighbors? Not me. Let 'em move away if they don't like it. Do you know the best time I can remember? It was when we were breaking up. I thought I was in love with a swimming instructor . . .

DOC:

Let me tell you some of my own little weaknesses. Women! They fascinate me. All kinds of women. I'm an absolute fool for them.

CLARA:

Sex, huh?

DOC:

I admire them profoundly. What a marvelous job they do with the equipment they have. Mentally concave, physically inferior . . . I always think of women in terms of the old Roman gladiatorial contests—as the *retiarii*—the netmen. Remember?

CLARA:

Who, me?

DOC:

There were the fellows with the short swords and the broad-brimmed bronze helmets and a fish for a crest, the *mirmillones*. Shin guards, a girdle of some sort—and that, I think, was all. The others, unprotected, completely nude in fact, if I'm not mistaken, carried a trident in one hand and a small fishnet in the other. It must have been a fairly light net at that so it could be handled. These two fought together. [*He sips his drink. She does not interrupt him.*]

It must have been pretty much of a stand-off since those duels seem to have been a regular fixture on the old programs. The net against the short sword. The swordsmen attacked and the *retiarii* tricked them with their nets—as a matador does a bull with his red cape. More or less, that's the way a woman has to play it. Odd, it never occurred to me before that the matador plays the part of a woman!

CLARA:

Say, what is this? I thought I was talking.

DOC:

You were. We get slapped alongside the face, we become salesmen, walking up and down, tossing in our beds—at the wrong time. Even turn on the gas—and worse. Purely a matter of the uniqueness of experience—the old sow has only the one milk to offer them no matter which tit they take it from . . .

CLARA:

Listen! I didn't finish telling you about the swimming instructor I thought I was in love with, in one of these club pools. I guess it was just the relief I felt at getting unmarried again. But I thought it was love. I never did like to wear clothes. I'd never put on a dress if I didn't have to. Too lazy, I suppose. I got a pretty good build—too much down here maybe, but not so bad. I guess he thought I was a hot chicken, getting divorced and all that. Poor guy. But I liked it—while it lasted. I'd lie out in the sun on the hot boards. Gee! But sometimes they're too hot. And put my head on his knees and he'd fool around with my hair, comb it out and massage my scalp by the hour. Right there in the open. I suppose some of the club members didn't like it. Do you know the thing I enjoy better than anything else in the world?

DOC:

No.

CLARA:

To have my back scratched.

DOC:

Now look here, young woman.

CLARA:

We had some good times together—he had an old jalopy. But I didn't want to marry him. We went out a few nights and he fooled around. That was enough. So finally I got married again, to a real guy. Poor Mac, he didn't get much. I'm funny. If he doesn't come home on time for supper sometimes, I'm heartbroken. I cry like a fool. Then when he does come finally, I'm completely satisfied. That's the trouble. Isn't that nuts?

DOC:

Completely.

CLARA:

But he says he can't sleep if I don't sleep with him. Well, I can't sleep that way and I've got to get my sleep. So . . .

DOC:

He sleeps alone. Look here . . .

CLARA:

The first time I was married I refused to have a baby and let the whole town know about it. I didn't want one. All right, now I'm married again and I have one. Poor kid, I was right the first time.

DOC:

I remember when I was a youngster . . .

CLARA:

I want to do the right thing—but you have to be such a liar.

DOC:

Good.

CLARA:

I don't think I'm capable of love. What is love anyway? I don't know. Like the cats, do they mean? Not me. Never. Do you know what I think of myself? Cigarettes, drinks, cards. That's me. If it weren't for them I'd go crazy. [*She drinks.*] What makes me that way?

DOC:

Lack of iron, apparently, according to your doctor. Did anybody ever try to rape you?

CLARA:

No, why?

DOC:

When I was a kid once, I planned to seduce a little girl of the neighborhood. I wonder if it was you?

CLARA:

How could it be? I wasn't even born then.

DOC:

Unimportant. I plotted the assault with great care, I assure you. She was considerably younger than myself and used to pass our house regularly every weekday toward sundown. I can't have been very young, after all, since my objective was rape. She was a somewhat plump but alluring little animal, always alone, always on time—I wonder if she didn't have a music roll in her hand—always coming up the street at that strange hour when no one else was about. With great secrecy and almost devilish ingenuity I arranged every detail of the plan, to the last stroke, in my fevered brain.

CLARA:

Is this true?

DOC:

Of course it's true. It took me a week or more to lay the thing out. The abduction was to take place in front of the

Episcopal Church, just across the street from where we lived. Behind the church, between its rear wall and a shrub-hidden iron fence, was a narrow space—as well known to me as my own bed—where the passionate deed was to be completed, on the bare ground. Lest she struggle and cry out I had prepared pegs and cords to which her arms and feet were to be bound and a gag for her mouth. Under pretense that we were playing a game of cops and robbers I had my father show me just how he thought a proper gag should be made. Mother stitched it up for me out of an old piece of sheeting. I cut and notched the stakes myself and several times made trips back of the church to pick the exact spot. Yes, I figured the proper distances and drove the wooden stakes into the ground securely against the time of my arrival with the victim.

CLARA:

Huh?

DOC:

My plan was, of course, to try first to induce her to come willingly for after all I had no desire to harm the child but merely to enjoy her and to endow upon her those things which I had so abundantly to give. But if she would not yield, then I would carry her off, come what may.

CLARA:

What are you talking about?

DOC:

Women! With their small heads and big lustrous eyes. All my life I have never been able to escape them.

CLARA:

But what happened?

DOC:

What do you mean?

CLARA:

To the little girl.

DOC:

Oh, that. Nothing. Just talk. She probably had been waiting weeks for me to speak to her. We were both excited. When she smiled and said hello as I stopped her—that ended it for me, completely. I remember, a week later, coming on the stakes I had driven into the ground and looking at them in amazement—that I ever could have even thought of such a thing.

CLARA:

Is that all? [*She has had the glass of wine in her hand all this time. She puts it down.*]

DOC:

Aren't you drinking?

CLARA:

No. Go on, you're doing things to me. Go on, talk some more.

DOC:

Talk, talk, talk! Everything runs out finally into talk.

CLARA:

Doesn't it though—and isn't it restful.

DOC:

And pretty soon we'll all be dead forever and never have opened our eyes wide once—wide, that is, to see what actually . . . starved as we live, because we never, never, never, never took a chance among the five or six thousand or million people of our small personal world to know them actually and individually . . . what actually the creature in the next bin is doing or feeling. And all the shyness and all the prudery and all the moral carpings are no more than so much heartburn from our chronic emptiness. Shall we go upstairs now?

CLARA:

No. Talk some more. I love it.

DOC:

No. Let's get out of this.

CLARA:

God! I haven't felt so relaxed in months. It's marvelous to find someone you can say anything to—anything at all, and he'll understand it. I can't open my mouth except to a couple of girls—and I can't tell them everything. I can't tell my mother, I can't tell my husband . . .

DOC:

And I'm not interested.

[Peter starts to come impetuously out onto the stage at the right, but is drawn back, persuasively, by Hubert. As this happens Peter cries out, "Mama!" in a childish, falsetto voice, imitating a child. Doc picks up his satchel and starts to go. Clara grabs his arm as he passes her.]

CLARA:

Hey, come here. *[He turns.]* Do you love me?

DOC:

How ridiculous. No.

CLARA:

Don't you want to kiss me?

[She puts her arms about his neck and plants a long kiss on his mouth as, at first, he struggles to avoid her. Without relinquishing her hold, she lays her head on his shoulder, relaxed. Just at this moment, Clara's child, a little girl of about five, comes in. She is wearing a sleeping suit and carries a white rabbit doll with pink ears—almost as big as herself.]

THE CHILD:

Daddy!

[Doc has seen the child before Clara and, breaking loose, goes to the little girl, picks her up and sits her on the ironing board. Clara puts her hand up to her mouth, aghast. There is no curtain as this scene runs, without break, into the next.]

Scene 2

The sound of Peter's voice simulating the crying of the child has been heard a moment earlier. Now there is a commotion at the side of the stage and Peter comes forward, laughing derisively, followed by Hubert, who hangs his head. Clara and Doc stand back, disapproving and disturbed.

PETER *[laughing]*:

No, no, no, no, no, no!

I told you at the beginning—no.

HUBERT:

Well done, Alise! And you, George.

I wish only that I had written
something worthier of you.

[Following the interruption by Peter and Hubert, others also come on the stage from various directions—well-wishers, friends of the actors, members of the stage crew and theater staff, both men and women. They gather around Alise and Doc, talking to them, or wait to say a word to Hubert, whom Peter is monopolizing—ignoring everyone else.]

PETER:

Yes,

you did very well, both of you.

But, Hubert, you're the one at fault.

Can't you see it? It's unresolved,

floating, too silly. The old goat
gets nowhere.

HUBERT:

Does it matter?

PETER:

Does
it matter! What's wrong with you?

[Alise now abandons her role as Clara and comes forward—as herself.]

ALISE:

Can't you understand? Hubert
has told you twenty times.

[She thinks better of her impetuosity.]

I beg your pardon. I'm sorry.

PETER:

You should be. Hubert!
With your ability! What is there here?
No heat, no lifting of the scene,
no tension—no romance! Here, in
the third act, when the business should be
primed and waiting, you leave both
these miserable characters
flapping their wings like wounded birds.
It's stylized, well-worked and I like
it—in a sense. But what's that?
It won't stand up. Stand up, you understand.
Kick and yell and drive in as
it should—as any proper scene
nearing the catastrophe must do.
I say this, Hubert, for you. You
yourself, I mean. Have you ever
been in love? I doubt it. That anguish,
that insistence, that mad fatalistic

plunge! The arrow! That's it.
Where in all this will you find
that likeness of an arrow, insistent,
unrelenting, an arrow
that seeks its mark through all
obstructions?

ALISE:

Darling, shall I laugh or cry?

HUBERT:

Please!

PETER:

Cry, you'd do it so
extremely well.

HUBERT:

But you *are* angry?

PETER:

Hurt rather,
that you should think me so obtuse.

HUBERT:

And there's nothing here? I thought you
at least . . .

PETER:

Oh well, if you say, nothing!
But for you, Hubert! What I want
for you is something different,
something that
grips a man in his sinful heart
and tortures him, unrolled like
a red carpet at a Polish wedding—
down to the footlights! And over them,
until he sees it as if it were blood
creeping to his feet. I've imagined
many things for you, young man,

but you seem to have a knack
to avoid coming face to face,
whether with yourself—or me.

HUBERT:

Come, come, Peter.

PETER:

You're slick as a dance floor, my friend.
You know, sometimes I despise
the shoes you walk in. Have I
hurt you, Hubert?

HUBERT:

Not at all.

ALISE [*to Hubert*]:

Darling, what's the matter?

HUBERT:

I wanted
to write a play . . .

PETER:

It won't do. Let some idiot—in
the usual arty fashion—make
a book of it. But don't seek to produce it.

HUBERT:

It can be done successfully—
trial and error.

PETER:

No, my boy.
Trial, yes. The theater is a trial,
truly. It's not a plaything. But
in the theater to kill you've got
to kill! With a hammer if need be . . .
Or they'll walk out on you. I don't
know but that I should walk out
myself at this point and call it quits.

HUBERT:

Don't do that, Peter.

PETER:

If you weren't
so able, I'd do it without a thought.

ALISE:

I'm sure we don't need you.

HUBERT [*to Alise*]:

Go in and get dressed, won't you, Alise?
We'll be leaving in a moment—when
we can continue this discussion
elsewhere. Shall we, Peter?

PETER:

This
is no discussion.

[The stagehands have been standing around anxious to clean up, waiting for an opportunity to take down the set. Hubert motions for them to go ahead with it—which they proceed to do. Alise does not leave. Peter watches her. Seeing that both are determined to stick it out, Hubert resigns himself to the circumstances.]

HUBERT:

Let's understand each other, Peter.

PETER:

Well, out with it.

HUBERT:

No, I've nothing more to say.

ALISE:

Of course you have.

PETER:

Come on.

HUBERT:

I have a play, mature
enough to suit you, which has been sketched
scene for scene, act for act.
But lacking experience, as you know,
I have adopted this method
of a trial-horse to approach it.
And were it not for the bitterness
which . . .

ALISE:

Go on, Hubert.

HUBERT:

I say: when we see,
on the stage, what we expect to see—
I'm not speaking of circuses
but something to turn our minds a little
to the light—it should project
above the coarseness of the materials . . .
something else, in the words themselves,
tragic without vulgarity. Seen—
in the mind! The mind itself . . . today,
without firearms and other claptrap,
in its own tragic situation. We can't
do this at once but must restudy
the means. If I wish to present love,
dramatically, today . . .

PETER:

Yes.

ALISE:

Yes.

HUBERT:

I might do it—with a coalscuttle.

PETER:

How?

HUBERT:

By spitting in it.

ALISE:

Darling!
You mustn't talk that way.

PETER:

Puh!

ALISE:

Don't let that beast dishearten you.

PETER:

Young woman, let me ask you a
direct question.

HUBERT:

Please, Peter!

PETER:

Speak to *her*.

HUBERT:

I hope you're not
going to make a scene, Peter.

PETER:

Don't be grotesque. You never have
known what you're talking about and I'm
afraid you never will. [*to Alise*] We understand
each other. Do you love this person?

ALISE:

Hubert!

HUBERT:

What can I do?

PETER:

Splendid!
Then let me tell you this:
when I first knew Hubert he was
a very beautiful young man . . .

ALISE:

Oh!

[Up to this point the others on the stage have been moving about somewhat embarrassed, interested, amused at the completely brazen indifference shown to them by Peter. Now they become more attentive, trying to hear as much as possible of what he is saying. Hubert, seeing that both Alise and Peter are determined to fight it to a finish, turns to one of the stagehands.]

HUBERT:

What do you think of it, Kelly?
Has it got a chance?

KELLY:

Beyond
me, sir.

PETER:

Don't be a sentimental
jackass, Hubert.

ALISE:

Leave him alone!

HUBERT:

Please, my dear. Let's get out
of this.

PETER:

Not on your life!

ALISE:

You're worse
than a dog in heat.

HUBERT:

Don't
be vulgar, Alise.

PETER:

She's a woman.

[At this point one of the scene-shifters who has been trying, carefully, to remove part of the set and listen at the same time to what is being said, allows the flat he has been moving to fall to the boards.]

HUBERT:

Peter!

PETER:

What is it?

HUBERT:

That's enough.

I might as well tell you, first
as last—Alise and I are to be married.

[Some have heard, others have not. Hubert goes toward Alise, or attempts to, but Peter takes his hand, detaining him. A profound change in attitude is simulated by Peter toward Hubert and Alise.]

HUBERT *[to Alise]*:

Let's go now.

PETER *[gaily]*:

Do you hear that, people?
We're going to have a wedding amongst us.
Alise, why didn't you tell me? Of course,
this alters everything.

ALISE *[to Hubert]*:

Take me home.

PETER:

Don't let
her go. But Hubert, are you all set?
Have you had the blood tests? And
the license? Everything?

HUBERT:

In my pocket.

PETER:

Kelly!

Where are you?

HUBERT:

What are you doing, Peter?

[Kelly has come up to Peter, who gives him a fistful of bills.]

PETER:

Have a couple of the boys go out
and buy some decorations—you understand.
Some flowers too.

KELLY:

It's rather late, sir.

PETER:

The best there is and plenty. You have
the money.

HUBERT:

What is this?

[Peter takes a small notebook from his pocket.]

PETER:

And Kelly!

KELLY:

Yes, sir.

PETER:

Have one of the girls ring
this number for me, quickly! And call me
when she gets it.

[He pats Alise on the shoulder.]

This, Hubert,
is too precious to be wasted.
We haven't got much time, we must
improvise. Why didn't one of you
come out with it?

HUBERT:

What are you up to?

PETER:

The wedding! We'll have it here! Tonight!

HUBERT:

You can't do that, Peter.

PETER:

Who says
I can't? I can do anything—
except one! Alise, what do you say?
Come on. You're a woman. Tell him
what it's all about. This play
shall be my wedding present to you babies.
What a fool I've been.

[*A young woman comes in to Peter.*]

GIRL:

I've got
your number for you, sir.

PETER:

It's the "archbishop."
He's just around the corner.

[*Peter goes out. Hubert goes to Alise, who is standing somewhat aside. The others respect their desire to talk privately. Peter's voice is heard loudly from outside.*]

ALISE:

Let's get away from here, Hubert. Quickly.

HUBERT:

What for?

ALISE:

Oh, don't ask me. Come!

HUBERT:

Your clothes.

ALISE:

We'll take a taxi.

HUBERT:

Run away?

ALISE:

Oh, I'm afraid. Come on.

HUBERT:

We can't

do that, my darling.

ALISE:

Can't you see?

HUBERT:

My dear baby!

Let him have his way. We'll
be married and . . .

ALISE:

No, Hubert!

He's too strong for you.

HUBERT:

What do

you mean?

ALISE:

Don't ask me. Only . . .

Come . . . *now!*

HUBERT:

But the play.

ALISE:

Oh, damn the play! I know what I'm
talking about. Now. At once.
If you love me, Hubert.

HUBERT:

Very well.

ALISE [*seeing his face*]:

No. You poor boy.

[*Peter returns, triumphantly.*]

PETER:

He was a tough one, but I threw him.
And he'll be here, as the leopard flies!

[*He sees them.*]

Oh, there you are.

[*Alise starts away.*]

HUBERT [*to Alise*]:

What is it, my dear?

ALISE:

I'm cold.

HUBERT:

Can't I fetch you a wrap?

ALISE:

I'm going to my dressing room. •

PETER:

Let her go, Hubert. She'll
be back. There must be a piano
somewhere. One of you girls look
about. We should have confetti
and white doves to release! Someone
tear up a telephone directory . . .
Don't sulk, Hubert. Look—this is my
last evening. I claim it. After

the ceremony is over we'll take Alise
and pack her into her little bed—
so she can get her beauty rest
against tomorrow evening.

[*Alise returns at this point, wearing a loose wrap.*]

She'll
agree, and you and I shall steal
away . . . It is my privilege!
Le Droit du Seigneur! For just this one
night! We two, together.
Marvelous. Don't you think so,
Alise?

ALISE:

I didn't hear you.

PETER:

That's the spirit.
[*shouting*] Bring us some champagne, Kelly!
Where is that man?

Then it's agreed!
Come on, everybody. Let's fix things up
a little before the Church in all
its fury bursts in upon us.

[*Much of the scenery has been taken down. The whole place is more or less a shambles. Everybody turns to and an altar-like platform is set up in the center of the stage.*]

HUBERT [*to Alise*]:
Is everything all right?

ALISE:

Quite perfect,
darling.

[*Alise is clinging to Hubert's side, looking at him with great concern in her eyes. Peter takes the center of the stage.*]

PETER:

Before this wedding takes place, kind people,
let me tell you the bitter truth of it.

[There is some laughter.]

As a husband, this man isn't worth
a woman's hairpin—completely
wasted. I'd like to break his neck
rather than see him do it.

ALISE *[to Hubert]*:

I'm going
to shoot him.

[Her right hand is hidden under her wrap.]

HUBERT:

Alise!

[She moves away from him, but he follows her.]

PETER:

So I have warned her: He may say,
I love you. Don't believe him. There is
something in this man—as in
any man—not to be benefited by a marriage.
And he knows it thoroughly.
This thing that you see here, that you,
Alise, imagine is your lover,
this complexity about whom you
will never in your entire life
learn anything to the purpose, this man,
as you are a woman, will remain . . .

*[The company is amused and laughing at Peter's mock
heroics.]*

as cold as ice in his heart—toward you,
as toward every other feeling
thing about him, completely cold . . .

except—as interpretable to him through his writing! Do you think he loves you? Don't make me laugh. He doesn't even love himself. He is as specialized as a foxhound. He waits only to be loosed by his writing. That aside, he is a prisoner, dim-witted, furious, raging at his prison no matter how smooth the waters may seem to ripple under your shining sun. He has only one ambition—to get out! Out from within himself, where he is freezing. There is only one door. Writing! Stop him and he'll destroy you—or himself, with as much indifference as he'd eat a potato. Marry him and become his jailor—you'll find him thoroughly contemptible, not even human. This is the way it is—and you shall have, tomorrow, no part whatever in his life.

HUBERT:

Heroic nonsense, Peter. Just the relief I needed. Very funny.

PETER:

Oh, but I'm serious! And I warn all women. Leave men like this alone. Dear Alise! She should have taken my warning. I say, whatever he does you may be sure when you flatter yourself that he's deceiving you, or slighting you, running here and there, it's nothing of the sort. You'd be fortunate if he had that much feeling in him for you.

He has none. It is only
the machine grinding toward its end.
To break the walls and let him out.
To escape, to write, to realize,
to come through the obscurity
of his surroundings to the flame—
of himself, not you—a light
he, poor fellow, thinks he sees.
Keep out of his way in such moments,
if you wish to hold him . . .

A VOICE [*from outside*]:
Here's the minister.

PETER:
Hurrah! [*singing*]
Strike up the band!
Here comes the sailor!

[*As they all turn to look for the Minister, Hubert, who has been watching Alise, rushes over to her.*]

HUBERT:
Alise!

[*She evades him and goes over to Peter.*]

ALISE:
Peter, take this—I don't want
Hubert to have it.

PETER:
What is it?

ALISE:
A pistol. I was going to shoot you.

PETER:
Oh. It's loaded!

[*Peter takes the pistol and puts it in his pocket. As he does so the Minister enters. He is a man of Peter's age, his*

classmate at Groton where he was known as "The Archbishop." He is wearing a dark suit with clerical collar.]

MINISTER:

This is preposterous.

PETER:

Oh, shut up, Tommy, we're not at Groton.
Of course it's preposterous.
These young people want you to marry them.
Come on, gather round, everybody!

MINISTER:

But who are they? At this hour!

ALISE:

And I'm going to have a baby.

MINISTER:

Yes, yes,
of course, my dear, what else is marriage for?

[Kelly comes in with champagne and glasses, and two assistants carrying flowers.]

SEVERAL VOICES:

Kelly, Kelly! Here he is!

[Someone begins to play the piano. There is general excitement. Peter shows the pistol to the Minister. The women are talking gaily, congratulating Hubert and Alise.]

CURTAIN

A Dream of Love

CHARACTERS

DR. DANIEL THURBER, a physician. He is in his middle 40's, of medium height, dark complexion, emotional in temperament.

MYRA THURBER, Dr. Thurber's wife. She is a slim, attractive blond in her late 30's.

CLIFF RANDALL, a young business executive. He is in his early 30's, heavily built and blond.

DOTTY RANDALL, Cliff's wife. A dark-haired woman in her late 20's—tall, well-built—rather beautiful, if you admire the type. Able to take care of herself.

JOSEPHINE, Mrs. Thurber's part-time maid. She is a short, rotund and slow-moving but intelligent colored woman, about 50—devoted to her mistress.

THE BUTCHER BOY, a "fat boy" in his teens. He plays the harmonica.

THE MILKMAN, the proprietor of a milk route. He is a capable-looking man, heavy set, approaching 40. He wears steel-rimmed glasses. He is very self-confident in manner—on the make.

MRS. HARDING, an elderly colored woman, a friend of Josephine.

"She, leaving to her fellow-citizens the din of shielded hosts, and armings of the fleet with spears, bringing to Ilion destruction for a dower, went lightly through the doors, dishonorably brave; and many a sigh was uttered by the bards of the palace, while they sang—O house! O house, and rulers! O marriage-bed, and pressure on the pillows of her head who loved her lord! He stands by in silence, dishonored, but without reproaches, noting with anguish of soul that she is fled. Yes, in his longing after her who is beyond the sea, a phantom will seem to rule his house. The grace of goodly statues hath grown irksome to his gaze, and in his widowhood of weary eyes all beauty fades away. But dreams that glide in sleep with sorrow visit him, conveying a vain joy; for vain it is, when one hath seemed to see good things, and lo, escaping through his hands, the vision flies apace on wings that follow on the paths of sleep."

[Menelaus abandoned in his home by Helen]

Aeschylus: *Agamemnon*, Translation of J. A. Symonds
The Greek Poets, Vol. 1, p. 425 of the 1901 edition

ACT I

Scene 1

The living room of the Thurbers' home, a rather old-fashioned house, built probably in the early 1900's, in a suburb near New York. It is evening—just after dark—in the early fall. The time is a few years previous to the Second World War. The fittings of the room are somewhat somber, with an appearance of settled home surroundings. In the middle of the room, at the back, is a large davenport couch with pillows at both ends; on the wall above this couch is a large modernist painting done in bold primary colors and with a white frame—the only object of the sort in the room. The entrance to the room is toward the rear on the right through a pair of double folding glass doors in front of which, forward along the wall, is an antique side-table with some books on it. In the middle of the left wall is a shallow bay window which looks out upon the street; in its embrasure there is a comfortable overstuffed chair. A floor-lamp, which gives off a rather dim light, stands to the left of the couch. The window shades are half drawn, but admitting the beams of a powerful street-lamp. The rattle of bus traffic is occasionally heard outside.

Mrs. Thurber is lying asleep on the couch. She has a blanket over her and the light from the floor-lamp catches her blond hair.

There is the noise of a door closing somewhere outside, followed by footsteps coming through the house. Suddenly the hall lights are snapped on, the light showing through the glass doors.

"Doc" Thurber comes in from the hallway and turns up the light of the floor-lamp. He takes off his overcoat and drops it carelessly on a chair, then stands looking down at his wife who does not immediately awaken.

DOC:

Hi. [*There is no response.*] Myra. Sweetheart. Myra. Wake up.

MYRA [*waking*]:

What?

DOC:

Sleeping? So early?

MYRA [*sitting up, shading her eyes*]:

Oh, turn those lights down—a little. Please. [*He half dims the lights.*] What time is it?

DOC:

About eight-thirty. Any calls?

MYRA:

I didn't hear anything. I was dog tired.

DOC:

You'll spoil your hair-do.

MYRA:

I didn't think you'd notice it. [*She sits up, arranging her hair. Her skirts have caught about her hips as she does so.*] Ooff!

DOC:

A damned good-looking woman. You always did have beautiful legs. That's why I married you.

MYRA:

Yes, I know. [*She straightens her skirts.*] Where have you been?

DOC:

Around. How about a little more light?

MYRA:

Sure, if you want to, go ahead. [*He turns up the light as Myra picks up a book from the floor beside the couch.*]

DOC:

Don't read. Talk to me awhile, I'm restless. What have you been doing?

MYRA:

Reading—what else? Aren't you going into the office to write?

DOC:

Lay off, darling. I don't *always* go out there in the evening.

MYRA:

Pretty nearly always. Don't you—when you can?

DOC:

You know, you look tired. Why don't you take a vacation for yourself? You need it.

MYRA:

Not without you.

DOC:

That's ridiculous.

MYRA:

No. It's not ridiculous. I shouldn't enjoy myself without you. [*There is a pause.*] Perhaps you'd like to get rid of me, darling—for a week or so?

DOC:

That's an idea.

MYRA:

Then you'd be free. Free! To do as you please. Isn't that what you're living for?

DOC:

I'd still have my practice of medicine.

MYRA:

Give it up. You've always resented it.

DOC:

I have.

MYRA:

Because you've always resented me.

DOC:

You're wrong.

MYRA:

I'm right.

DOC:

You're wrong.

MYRA:

I interfere with you.

DOC:

That's right. How is anyone ever going to live with anyone else unless he interferes with him? So what? That has nothing to do with it.

MYRA:

Everything.

DOC:

You have to take it out of me, don't you. Don't I work hard enough for you?

MYRA:

For me?

DOC:

Who else?

MYRA:

Oh my dear husband, what a fool you are—and how lovable and transparent.

DOC:

That's bunk.

MYRA:

I'm not much use to you. I'm not much use to myself—and pretty much disgusted with myself most of the time. I don't know why. What do I do—now that the children are away? Almost nothing.

DOC:

Ain't it the truth.

MYRA:

What's the truth?

DOC:

Anything—that you say.

MYRA:

Walking out on me?

DOC:

Perhaps—when you least expect it.

MYRA:

Things go fast, remember, today.

DOC [*after a pause*]:

As far as medicine is concerned all I work for is your comfort and happiness. That's all I want—as far as I'm able to give it to you.

MYRA:

And I want only one thing—when I want anything.

DOC:

What's that?

MYRA:

You.

DOC:

You've got me—and how.

MYRA:

I've never had you. [*She yawns.*]

DOC:

No, you've never had me—in that way. I guess that's why you've kept on loving me—as I've wanted to be loved—by you.

MYRA [*looking up*]:

What's the matter with you? You certainly are off tonight.

DOC:

I love you!

MYRA:

My God! [*She smiles and shakes her head.*] Sweetheart. You're a nice boy and I'm stupid about you—but I don't want you now. You know you're itching to get away. Please go. Write me a beautiful poem. Go out in your office and work.

DOC:

Yeah—work.

MYRA:

Now look. You know I always like to have you close to me. Almost always. I love you. You don't love me—not in the same way. But that's my affair. I love you and believe in you. I tremendously admire you. But I don't trust you. Now yank up your pants—they're dragging at the back—and go out and enjoy yourself.

DOC:

O.K., puss. [*He leans over to kiss her.*]

MYRA:

You've had a drink.

DOC:

Just a short one.

MYRA [*putting down her book*]:

Say, where were you this evening?

DOC:

You gave me the call. Mrs. Tennant, our milkman's wife. I got a queer hunch about that gal—I don't think she's going to last very long.

MYRA:

Did you go anywhere else?

DOC:

Why?

MYRA:

Nothing. I guess I must have been dreaming. My head's been heavy all afternoon. I wish you'd get out of here.

DOC [*picking up a book from the table*]:

Look at this. The Complete Collected Poems of Daniel T—for Titcomb—Thurber. Complete all right—up to the time of his death. How come?

MYRA [*changing the subject*]:

Would you care for anything as simple as a glass of iced fruit juice? I'm awfully dry.

DOC:

No, thanks. How would you like to have me read some of my poems to you?

MYRA:

I'd love it—if you can wait.

[*He is looking through the book. Myra goes out and he sits down on the couch. Leafing through the book, he comes to something that interests him and after a moment begins to read aloud.*]

DOC:

I lie here thinking of you—
the stain of love
is upon the world!
Yellow, yellow, yellow

it eats into the leaves,
smears with saffron
the . . .

[Myra returns with glasses of juice on a tray.]

MYRA:

It sounds marvelous. Read it to me. Here take this first
[She hands him a glass.]—it'll do you good.

[He sits with the book still in his hand and sips his drink.]

DOC:

You know that was an interesting case I saw this evening.
There doesn't seem to be much the matter with the woman
—a little overweight . . . You know who I mean.

MYRA:

Yes, you told me. She hasn't been ill, has she?

DOC:

No. Just a hunch I have. I shouldn't be surprised they'd
find her dead in bed some morning.

MYRA:

So what? As far as I'm concerned, I'd love it if it happened
to me.

DOC:

That's putting it a little strong, isn't it, darling? *[He looks hard at his wife.]*

MYRA:

No. How about reading?

DOC:

How about putting your head down in my lap?

MYRA:

All right.

[The telephone rings in the hall.]

DOC:

Shall I go?

MYRA:

No. Stay where you are. [*She goes to the phone—out of view—in the hall.*] Hello . . . Who is this calling? . . . No. I'm sorry, you'll have to give me your name . . . No . . . No . . . Is there anything I can do to help you? . . . Hm . . . [*She returns to the room.*] She hung up.

DOC:

Who was it?

MYRA:

I don't know. Some woman with a sick child. I don't pay any attention to them if they don't give me their names.

DOC:

That's a good example of the privacy we enjoy in our idle moments. [*He pauses.*] One thing I know, my dear: we've got to get the hell out of this kind of a life—if you call it that. It isn't good for either of us. Now that the kids are away it's getting terrific. And as far as I'm concerned—as far as money is concerned—as if we had any—they can have it!

MYRA:

It's up to you.

DOC:

You too.

MYRA:

All I want is a little place in the country—a place where flowers will *grow* and not choke to death with the oil and grease there is on the leaves here.

DOC:

And a private bath—your own—where nobody, not even I—especially I—could so much as peek inside the door. And

hot and cold running water and electricity and gas—a modern heating and ventilating system. A simple little place where we should be happy and at peace together.

MYRA:

Happiness and peace!

DOC:

What little peace there is.

MYRA:

Hardly any.

DOC:

A hideout—for our old age. Perhaps in Vermont.

MYRA:

Where you, darling, could do what you've always wanted to do—quit the God-damned thankless practice of medicine and write, write, write to your heart's content.

DOC:

I'll bet I could make more money. I'll bet with a little luck I could make more money—as much as I make here now.

MYRA:

The way you practice medicine—or neglect your bills, I mean—you'd double your present earnings. But what would you do without all your women, darling?

DOC:

I'd find one up a tree somewhere.

MYRA:

You sure would. And drag her down by the hair—if she didn't drop on you first from a low branch. I don't care—so long as I have my garden. Really, Dan. I'm getting awfully fed up with this routine. The same thing, the same thing, over and over and over and over.

DOC:

Me too.

MYRA:

Why don't you really quit then?

DOC:

On what? I haven't got enough money to quit on—at my age.

MYRA:

Just quit.

DOC:

Just quit, huh? I'm going to quit—but I can't afford right now to do it.

MYRA:

Agh, you! Quit now, tonight. This minute.

DOC:

How?

MYRA:

Hang a sign up that you're not practicing medicine any more.

DOC:

You would!

MYRA:

I will!

DOC:

I think you took a swig of something out there in the kitchen.

MYRA:

You coward. You haven't got the nerve. Do you want me to do it? I'll do it. Why don't you give up being a half-time writer if you like to write that much? Why don't you make a decision one way or the other? I'll do it for you.

DOC:

Sure. If that's the way you feel about it, go ahead.

MYRA:

Well! Well! [*She looks at him and laughs.*] You poor baby. Come here and kiss me.

DOC:

Not tonight.

MYRA:

Look at you, pouting like an infant. So you don't want to quit your old practice of medicine? Believe me, if I felt the way you do about it I wouldn't for five minutes let anyone make me go on with it. And that's the way I feel about you. I wish I could quit this minute and leave you here—to go to hell any way you want to—you and your women. I wish I could do it.

DOC:

Why not?

MYRA:

Sure. Easy for you. Twenty women are just waiting to fling themselves at your feet. That's where a man has it easy—a man with an income. But what chance have I got? Who wants a woman like me?

DOC:

Don't kid yourself, you'd have some money.

MYRA:

You bet I'll have some money. I'll sell this house.

DOC [*startled*]:

This house?

MYRA:

Yes.

DOC:

Would you do that?

MYRA:

Would I do it? Huh!

DOC [*after a short pause*]:

At that, you'd be right. Maybe it's the writing that's at fault.

MYRA:

Deeper than that.

DOC:

I don't think so. It's the writing. Why do I write? Just about what you were saying a little while ago—I want to pass out. And I do pass out when I'm writing—forget everything except that. The works. Out the window.

MYRA:

Certainly it's not interesting to talk about.

DOC:

You got something there.

MYRA:

If only I could sleep better. You're asleep as soon as your head hits the pillow. But I stay awake half the night—listening to you snore. I really think we should have separate rooms.

DOC [*arranging himself on the couch*]:

Stretch out here and let me read to you for half an hour—that always puts you to sleep. Huh?

MYRA:

That isn't fair.

DOC:

Some of my own stuff. I haven't done it for years. Something about us, just us.

MYRA:

Read the one you were reading when I was in the kitchen—it sounded marvelous.

DOC:

Don't you want to put your head in my lap? I'll fix a pillow.

MYRA [*making herself comfortable on the couch*]:

Now read. This is heaven. What a marvelous way to spend my anniversary.

DOC:

Anniversary of what?

MYRA:

You wouldn't know . . . of the day you proposed to me.

DOC:

Is that right?

MYRA:

Do you remember what you said?

DOC:

Do *you*?

MYRA:

—when I asked you if you loved me?

DOC:

No. What did I say?

MYRA:

You said, "Love you? Hell no. I want to marry you."

DOC:

I don't believe I said that.

MYRA:

Then I asked you, "Why do you want to marry me?" And you said, "To love you, I suppose."

DOC:

Was I that intelligent—in those days? It must have been real passion.

MYRA:

I suppose I have never got over that first dazzlement.

DOC:

"When faith stood clear in your eyes." It was about all we had.

MYRA:

I had you—then.

DOC [*opening the book and reading*]:

—a dream
we dreamed
each
separately
we two
of love
and of
desire—
that fused
in the night—

A dream
a little false
toward which
now
we stand
and stare
transfixed—

All at once
in the east
rising!

All white!

a locust cluster
a shad bush
blossoming

And so
 we live
 looking—
a dream
 toward which
we love—
at night
 more
than a little
 false—

We have bred
we have dug
we have figured up
our costs
we have bought
an old rug—

We batter at our
unsatisfactory
 brilliance—

There is no end
 to desire—

[He pauses.]

MYRA:

You loved me, I think. But it's never been wholeheartedly me. It's always been something else—someone else where I was concerned.

DOC:

Give me time. I'm still young.

MYRA:

It's always been as though you were trying to escape.

DOC:

It can't be done. I've tested it.

MYRA:

You've succeeded pretty well in your day.

DOC:

You got to relax sometime.

MYRA:

I can't beat you at talking.

DOC:

Women usually do.

MYRA:

Not you. If only I were sure of your love.

DOC:

What for? There's no sense to it. Love is a matter of the will, pure and simple. I love you.

MYRA:

You force yourself to love. That's not it.

DOC:

You think it's something else? You *fall* in love, huh?

MYRA:

You do or you do not.

DOC:

Laughable. I love you, I tell you. But you drive me off.

MYRA:

Of course I drive you off—what do you think I am?

DOC:

I think you're an amazing woman whom I sometimes greatly admire, frequently count on in emergencies and always love—and protect.

MYRA:

You're a liar.

DOC:

You're a romanticist. What do you think a man is, a papaya?
To digest your dinner? In pill form?

MYRA [*laughing*]:

You ass. But it's wonderful to be noticed—and talked to.

DOC:

Noticed! I make love to you day and night, year in, year out, and most of the time never even get a tumble.

MYRA:

Is this what you call making love to me? I'll bet there's a reason back of it and not a pretty one either—if I know you.

DOC:

After all, you can't walk if you don't move your legs.

MYRA:

You see. You're not coming clean.

DOC:

Listen, darling. I'm not a stone or a Diesel engine. I don't live on air.

MYRA:

Uh huh! Something's up. I knew it. Hurry and read to me, won't you? The one I asked you to read: "Yellow, yellow, yellow!"

DOC:

My dear wife, you make it almost impossible for me. [*He opens the book and begins to read.*] "Love Song." I wrote this when we were first married. You were away and I was thinking of you. It was just at sunset and I was looking toward the horizon where I knew you to be.

I lie here thinking of you—

the stain of love
is upon the world!

Yellow, yellow, yellow
it eats into the leaves,
smears with saffron
the horned branches that lean
heavily
against a smooth purple sky!
There is no light
only a honey-thick stain
that drips from leaf to leaf
and limb to limb
spoiling the colors
of the whole world—

you, far off there under
the wine-red selvage of the west!

Have you ever seen the sky that way in the west just after sunset? [*He looks at her.*] Myra darling? Christ! You're not . . . crying, are you? God damn it, you mustn't do that.

MYRA [*with tears in her eyes*]:

It's so beautiful, my dear. I'm not sad, really. Happy. Really happy. You're so lovely. I adore you.

DOC [*closing the book*]:

No more of that.

MYRA:

Go on, please. You don't understand. You can't. With all your interests—how can you? I don't expect it. Really, I don't expect it. I get angry at you. I feel lonely, neglected. But I don't blame you. Ever. I love you. And that's my life. That's all. I suppose you think it's stupid . . . I do, myself, at times.

DOC:

No, I don't think it's stupid. But knowing myself—and the way I live—doesn't it get awfully dull for you at times?

MYRA:

Never. I'm perfectly happy—though you may not think so. Perfectly happy—for me. I'm not an accomplished person, I'm sorry. I think perhaps we should never have married. [*She pauses.*] But you're marvelous. You're a wonderful person. And a great poet. When you die—I don't know . . .

DOC:

What don't you know?

MYRA:

I just don't know . . . that will be the end—as far as I'm concerned.

DOC [*after another pause*]:

One marriage! [*He kisses her hair.*]

MYRA:

Almost a miracle.

DOC:

Quite. [*A bus goes by in the street outside, rattling the windows.*] What in Christ's name is a man to do? I don't know. Is all poetry evil? I think so—since John Donne. [*He slings the book across the room.*]

MYRA:

What are you doing with my book? [*She gets up angrily and retrieves the book, straightening the pages.*] You have no right to do that.

DOC:

I'm sorry, dear—I'll get you another if it's torn.

MYRA:

That's not the point.

DOC:

Right here I'm happiest—if that's what we want. Here there is at least the possibility of contentment and peace.

MYRA:

What I don't understand is: you're an excellent physician and a good writer—sometimes I'm amazed how good you are—but what do you want? What do you want a woman to do—you're not subtle—blow her brains out for you? What in God's name is our relationship?

DOC:

Do you expect an answer?

MYRA:

Am I just a trough for you to feed out of?

DOC:

Our relationship? Something horrible, in all probability—if it isn't magnificent. Perverse. Insane—of which we shall never know anything. Murderous perhaps, but inevitable . . . I love you! —the second word being an eternal lie. And you can omit the "eternal" too . . . What does any man know? [*He is silent a moment.*] Suppose I were blocked out of existence—twenty-four hours from now. A plane crash or something like that. Don't you think you'd be happier?

MYRA:

Yes, in some ways.

DOC:

You would? Of course you would. [*He gets up and looks into the street.*]

MYRA:

Oh come on—forget it . . . I'm going up. I'm not angry, only a little surprised, that's all. I shouldn't be. It's been going on all my life, since we've been married. I should be used to it—but it still surprises me for some reason—and yet, what else better in life can I wish for? . . . I love you. I wouldn't give that up for anything else in the world. Good night, my dear. [*She starts out the door.*]

DOC [*near the window*]:

Oh, by the way, I'll be going to the city tomorrow. Want to come along?

MYRA:

No. It's your afternoon off. Go ahead, enjoy yourself—but it was nice of you to ask me. Good night. [*She goes out.*]

[*Doc stands looking out into the street for a moment. Then he puts out the lights in the room, leaving those in the hall burning. Taking up his overcoat, he hesitates, then puts it on and goes into the hall. We hear the front door close as he leaves the house.*]

CURTAIN

Scene 2

The Randalls' front room, in a rented house in another section of the same suburb of New York. It is the same evening, about a quarter of an hour after the preceding scene.

The general tone of the place is youthful, bright—though all done on a modest income. There are a few comfortable pieces of furniture about, floor-lamps, a radio, etc., and a child's tricycle and toys. The pages of a newspaper are scattered about the floor and a book lies opened, face down, on a side-table.

At the right is the street door, opening directly into the room. It is flanked by windows. At the back is a false fireplace with a large frame print over it—a full-rigged ship at sea. The stairs to the second floor are at the left of the fireplace, rising against the wall, from right to left, with a banister and a newel post at the bottom step. The door leading to the dining room and kitchen is in the middle of the left wall.

Cliff Randall, a heavy-set man in his early thirties, is sitting comfortably in his favorite chair, reading a magazine with his back to the door. The lamp beside him is lit. The radio is on—softly. The doorbell rings.

CLIFF [*without interrupting his reading*]:
Come on in.

[Dr. Thurber comes in from the street.]

CLIFF [*without turning*]:
Hi, Doc.

DOC:
Hi, Cliff.

CLIFF:
How yuh doing?

DOC:
O.K. You look comfortable.

CLIFF [*still without turning*]:
I am. She's upstairs taking a bath.

DOC:
Good. I'm glad somebody's keeping clean around here.

CLIFF [*putting his magazine down and turning*]:
Take a seat. She'll be down in a minute as soon as she knows it's you. Maybe we can get her to mix us up a drink.
[*calling out*] Hey, Dorothy!

DOC [*who has remained standing*]:
Don't bother her.

CLIFF:
Why not? Come on, take your coat off and sit down. Offer you a cigarette?

DOC:
No, thanks.

CLIFF:

That's right, you're one of those weaklings. [*He calls again.*] Hey, Dorothy! Somebody here to see you.

DOC:

Listen, Cliff, forget it. I'll call her up in the morning. She's doing some typing for me.

CLIFF:

Yes, I know. I hear you're going in to the city tomorrow.

DOC:

Well, that's the general idea—if it's all right.

CLIFF:

Sure. Go ahead. Now for God's sake sit down. You give me the jitters. I was just waiting for the nine o'clock news.

[*Cliff turns the radio up louder. Doc takes off his overcoat and throws it on a chair but remains standing. He picks up the book that has been turned down on the table and begins to read.*]

DOC [*after a moment*]:

I think she's calling you.

CLIFF:

Huh? What? [*He turns down the radio.*] Did you say something?

[*Doc points upstairs.*]

CLIFF [*raising his voice*]:

Did you say something to me, honey? [*There is no reply.*] I guess she's still in there. What are you writing now, Doc?

DOC:

A play. A modern play. I like that kind of stuff. You know.

CLIFF:

Yeah. She does too. What you going to do with it when you get it written?

DOC:

Put it on Broadway.

CLIFF:

You shoot for the money, Doc, don't you? Every time. Can't say I blame you.

DOC:

Why not?

CLIFF:

Hell. Good luck to you. I hope you make it.

DOC:

Thanks. I'll save you some tickets—on the aisle.

CLIFF:

But I thought you were a poet.

DOC:

Anything there is—so long as it's writing. Fills up the time for me—when I got nothing else to do.

CLIFF:

Yes, I suppose your life gets pretty monotonous at times.

DOC:

At times.

CLIFF [*looking up the stairs*]:

There she is.

[Mrs. Randall comes part way down the stairs and pauses. Just out of the bath, her hair hurriedly gathered up, bare-legged and with obviously little on under her robe, she stands and looks down at the men. Doc turns to face her. Her husband remains seated.]

DOTTY:

Oh, it's you.

DOC:

I'm sorry. I'm . . .

DOTTY [*coming on down into the room*]:

No. I'm just surprised, that's all. How wonderful to see you. Isn't it late?

DOC:

Just past nine.

CLIFF:

Listen, hon, how about mixing us a little drink?

DOTTY:

Why yes. Have we got anything? I don't believe there's a drop in the house.

DOC:

Listen—I was just out on a call and dropped in for a minute. Forget it. I'm going home.

DOTTY:

I haven't touched your work. It's good though. Won't you really stay?

CLIFF:

Just a short one. Come on. [*to his wife*] Don't ask him. Get busy. Oh for God's sake. [*He gets up and goes toward the interior door, still talking to his wife.*] You talk to him. I'll get it. [*He goes on into the kitchen.*]

DOC [*with his arms spread in admiration before Dotty*]:
Marvelous!

[*Doc goes toward her but she motions him off, puts her fingers to her lips and throws him a kiss. He is humorously in despair, pretending to tear his hair. She laughs. Impatient, he questions her feeling for him by gesture and his eyes. Smiling, she signifies, "Yes!" He makes the exaggerated gesture of putting his fingers to his lips and throwing a kiss in the air, then calls to Cliff in a loud voice.*]

DOC:

How are you making out there?

CLIFF [*from the kitchen*]:

I can't find the damn stuff. I'm sure it's here though.

DOTTY:

I'll find it. [*She goes to the kitchen. Doc, left alone, looks at his wrist watch and walks about.*]

DOC [*going to the door*]:

Can I help you two in there?

CLIFF [*from the kitchen*]:

No. Stay where you are.

DOC:

Why should I?

CLIFF:

Because I say so. Coming right up.

[*There is a pause, until Dotty comes back into the room.*]

DOTTY:

You men! It was right there. You can never find anything.

DOC:

Never?

DOTTY:

Don't boast. It doesn't suit you.

[*Cliff returns with the drinks—or rather, a bottle and glasses—which he places on a small table.*]

CLIFF:

Not bad stuff. Help yourself. Water if you want it—we haven't got any soda. [*to his wife*] I told you about that last week.

DOC [*to Dotty*]:

Aren't you joining us?

DOTTY:

No. [*She turns away while the men pour their drinks.*]

CLIFF [*to Doc*]:

The best of luck.

DOC:

Yep, I hope it goes over. [*They drink.*]

DOTTY:

What in the world are you talking about?

DOC:

My next play.

DOTTY:

You haven't had a first one yet.

CLIFF:

Sure. His play. [*to Doc*] Another? Come on. Warm you up.

DOC:

No, thanks. It's pretty late, you know.

CLIFF:

Aw come on. Just a little snifter. It won't hurt you.

DOC:

No, thanks. I hate to run off this way but I really must get home. Thanks, Dotty, for your good intentions—on the typescript, that is. And don't hurry—I don't care how long you take.

DOTTY:

I'll do it when I can. Good night. [*She starts up the stairs but stops to watch Doc go.*]

DOC:

Thanks again. You're a marvelous typist, that's all I can say.

CLIFF:

She ought to be.

DOC [*putting on his overcoat*]:

Well, so long. Thanks, Cliff, for the drink—and the good wishes.

CLIFF:

Come again some time.

[*Doc leaves by the street door.*]

DOTTY [*still pausing on the stairs*]:

What do you mean “she ought to be”?

CLIFF:

I mean what I said. You ought to be a good typist. I never knew a better.

DOTTY:

So that’s what I am to you? Thanks. [*She again starts upstairs.*]

CLIFF:

Hey, come down here. You, I said.

DOTTY:

I’m going to bed.

CLIFF [*in a voice of command*]:

Come down here.

[*Dotty turns, hesitates and comes down.*]

DOTTY:

What’s the idea?

CLIFF:

Sit down a minute. I want to talk to you.

[*She sits on the arm of a chair, gathering her robe about her.*]

DOTTY:

I presume this is about the person who was just here?

CLIFF:

Yeah, what do you think of him?

DOTTY:

I think he's charming. Why? Don't you like him?

CLIFF:

Sure I like him. He comes right out with it, doesn't he?

DOTTY:

What do you mean by that little speech?

CLIFF:

What I said. Why don't you marry the guy? [*His wife looks at him a moment, gets up, rolls the baby's doll carriage into a corner and turns toward the stairs.*] Hey, wait a minute. What about it?

DOTTY:

What about it? If that's all you have to say to me, I'm going to bed. Good night.

CLIFF:

Now listen, hon. Take it easy. You're in love with the doc—what's the use of lying about it? When were you in his office last?

DOTTY [*turning on him furiously*]:
Never!

CLIFF:

What do you mean, never?

DOTTY:

Just what I said. Never!

CLIFF:

Come on. Oh, I see. You mean never without the kid.

DOTTY:

I answered your question—just what you asked me. Never! Now may I go to bed?

CLIFF:

Listen, honey—why don't you ever give me a break? Come on back down here. I got a lot of things I want to say to you.

DOTTY [*coming down*]:

Look, I got a lot of things to say to you too—and the first one is that you bore me to death.

CLIFF [*crushed*]:

As bad as that?

DOTTY [*astonished at her own words*]:

No, darling, but I'm tired and I want to go to bed. I don't feel like fighting tonight. Just let me go and don't bother me.

CLIFF [*half to himself*]:

No. [*He starts to help himself to another drink.*]

DOTTY [*taking the bottle away from him*]:

That's enough of that. [*She goes out to the kitchen with the bottle.*]

CLIFF [*as she returns*]:

Wait a minute. [*He takes hold of her arm to detain her as she goes toward the stairs.*]

DOTTY:

I've done a day's work and I'm tired. Let me go.

CLIFF:

What are you two doing in the city tomorrow?

DOTTY:

Talk, I hope. I'll be home in time for your supper—you needn't worry. He'll have his car.

CLIFF:

Come on, hon. [*He tries to pull her down on his lap.*]

DOTTY:

No! [*She breaks away from him. As she does so her robe falls partly off, revealing her nudity under it.*]

CLIFF:

O.K. I think you better stay home.

DOTTY:

Do you mean it? Because if you do you'll be sorry. You'll be sorry you ever spoke. [*She again starts to leave.*]

CLIFF:

Come here.

DOTTY:

Who do you think you're talking to?

CLIFF:

You—my wife. You are my wife, aren't you? Why don't you take him in bed with you—while you've got the chance?

DOTTY:

You're disgusting. You fool. You idiot.

CLIFF:

Hell, you asked for it.

DOTTY:

And you came up like the clown you are. Haven't you any sense at *all*? Any fineness of feeling? You're crude.

CLIFF:

I love you, that's all.

DOTTY:

Oh, you're impossible. You haven't ever learned what a woman is.

CLIFF:

He knows, huh?

DOTTY:

Of course he knows. He's marvelous. I never knew a man who could talk the way he does—the way he can talk when he gets started.

CLIFF:

I suppose.

DOTTY:

I never get tired listening to him. It does something to me. I make no bones about it.

CLIFF [*mildly*]:

Look, sweetheart—I'm not kicking. You want to meet him in the city? Meet him. Go ahead. And I tell you, if you'd only be a little decent to me . . . [*He hesitates a moment.*] . . . I wouldn't care if he took you to a hotel and you went to bed with him.

DOTTY:

What! Do you know what you're saying?

CLIFF:

I'm telling you. I mean it. I give you everything I've got. If I haven't got what you want and you know how, go get it. That's what I want for you.

DOTTY:

You're taking an awful lot for granted, young man.

CLIFF:

Does his wife know about it?

DOTTY:

That's her business.

CLIFF:

Take it easy, kid—if you don't want trouble—and a hell of a lot of talk. I wonder how good he'd be at that.

DOTTY:

Do you realize that you're insulting? You're as offensive and stupid a man as I ever had to do with. Why don't you learn? [*She is suddenly suspicious.*] Say, listen! What were you two talking about while I was upstairs?

CLIFF:

About his play—that you're typing for him.

DOTTY:

—because if I thought . . . if you said anything to him about me! If you so much as hinted the slightest thing about what you've been saying to me now—the least hint of what was in your mind! [*There is a pause.*] If you did that, you can march right to that phone this minute and tell him or his wife or anyone that answers it—and this goes for you too—the lot of you—that you can go straight to hell, as far as I'm concerned! . . . Did you?

CLIFF:

No. For God's sake. What do you think I am?

DOTTY:

You're sure of that.

CLIFF:

Why wouldn't I be sure if I didn't say it?

DOTTY [*still suspicious*]:

Huh! [*Again she starts upstairs.*]

CLIFF:

Hon! Let me carry you up.

DOTTY:

You mean to bed with you?

CLIFF:

Well, there's nothing wrong with that, is there? Do you realize how long it is since we . . .

DOTTY:

Make it a year and I'll be happiest. Do you realize—*do you* know how long it is? Agh, you wouldn't understand. Don't touch me.

CLIFF:

Well, I'm still a man, by God.

DOTTY:

What are you trying to tell me? You mean other women?

CLIFF:

Draw your own conclusions.

DOTTY:

I hope they enjoyed it.

CLIFF:

What's the matter with me? Why don't you love me? I've done everything in this world a man can do to satisfy you but you treat me like a cur. Come here! [*He tries again to stop her.*]

DOTTY [*struggling to free her robe*]:

Let go of me! [*She frees herself.*] Your idea of love is that every woman wants to be raped—by such as you. For God's sake get over it. You're disgusting. I hate you.

[*She goes angrily upstairs and slams her bedroom door. Cliff goes back to his radio.*]

CURTAIN

ACT II

Scene 1

The kitchen of the Thurbers' house. It is just past noon of the following day.

The kitchen of the old house has been modernized to fit present-day demands—it is roomy and high-ceilinged. At the back, on the left, the swinging door of a butler's pantry leads to the front part of the house—and the living room of Act I. Forward on the left is a practicable sink with drainboards, etc. Above this is a lattice window with flowers in pots on the sill. A telephone can be seen in the pantry beyond the swinging door when it is open.

To the rear, in the center, is a back stairway going up from left to right. The area below the steps has been closed in with a partition to form a storage space. A sliding door in this partition is open, revealing a little alcove where various articles of outdoor male attire—fishing waders, an old hat, etc.—are hanging on hooks. There is a shotgun standing in the far corner of the alcove. Under the stairs, at the right, is the cellar entrance.

In the right wall, toward the front, is a door opening on the backyard. Back of this stands an electric refrigerator and beyond it is the door to the kitchen pot closet. There is a high stool near the sink and a kitchen chair at the back. A round electric clock is fixed to the wall above the refrigerator.

Josephine, a slow-moving, short and rotund colored woman, cheerful and thoroughly at home with the family, stands at the sink, finishing the lunch dishes. There are various cooking utensils on the drainboard near her.

Dr. Thurber, wearing a business suit, soft felt hat and carrying his overcoat, comes in from the main part of the house. In one hand he holds a bulky satchel. He stops sud-

denly, puts down the satchel and feels in the change pocket of his suit coat. Irritated, he goes through his pants and other pockets.

DOC:

God damn it!

[Leaving the satchel and his coat, he re-enters the front of the house. Josephine, having finished the dishes, wipes her hands and taking up a pot and a cloth, goes into the closet at the back of the room. Doc, much perturbed, returns from the front of the house and calls out.]

DOC:

Jo! Hey, Jo! [He goes to the inner door and calls again.] Jo!

JO [from the closet]:

Yes, sir.

DOC [going mistakenly to the stairs and calling up]:

Jo, have you seen my car keys?

JO [still from the closet]:

What?

DOC [calling down into the cellar]:

Have you seen the keys to my car?

[Josephine comes lumbering out of the closet, practically on top of him.]

JO [laughing good-humoredly]:

You don't have to yell like that.

DOC:

I'm late. I got to get out of here. Have you seen my car keys anywhere? On the floor, maybe, somewhere.

JO [going to the wall cabinet near the sink]:

You mean these?

DOC:

No, no. My own keys, the Buick keys. Damn it to hell, what did I do with them?

JO:

I don't know what you do with your keys. Sure you haven't got them in your pocket the same as last time?

DOC [*trying to recall*]:

No, damn it, I looked. It seems to me I had them upstairs before I changed my suit. I had them in my hands but I can't remember where I put them.

JO:

I only know one other place to look.

DOC:

Go—go and look for them. [*He pushes her out into the front of the house.*]

[Working himself into a more and more angry mood, Doc starts to go through all his pockets again. Failing to find the keys, he flings the coat down angrily and is about to follow Josephine into the front of the house when Myra appears and confronts him. She is looking very attractive in a loose, gaily-figured house coat.]

MYRA:

What's the matter, dear? I thought you had left. Why so disturbed?

DOC [*turning away*]:

Those God-damned keys again—I can't find them!

MYRA:

After all, that's no way to talk. Look at you! Where did you have them last?

DOC:

If I knew I'd tell you.

MYRA [*icily*]:

Well!

DOC:

I'm sorry. Upstairs, I think. I've looked everywhere.

MYRA:

Well, calm down a moment and I'll go see if I can find them.

DOC:

Haven't we an emergency key somewhere?

MYRA:

Well, have we? Wait here. And don't excite yourself this way. Sit down and take it easy. It's not good for you to behave like this—you, a doctor, know that perfectly well. Do what I tell you.

[Josephine comes back in.]

DOC:

Did you find them?

JO:

No, sir.

[Josephine goes about her work between the sink and pot closet into which in a moment she disappears. Myra goes back into the house. The doctor sits down, then stands up. He checks his watch against the clock on the wall. Finally he sits again, his hands between his knees, head bent down as if he were in pain.]

JO [*calling from the closet*]:

Maybe you left them in the car when you came in for lunch.

DOC:

That's an idea.

[*He starts to get up but can't make it. He puts his hand to his heart—he is in sudden pain. After a moment Myra returns from the front of the house with a man's suit on her arm. He does not get up.*]

DOC [*with difficulty*]:

Well, what luck?

MYRA [*kidding*]:

The mystery of the keys!

DOC [*his manner greatly changed*]:

Did you find them?

MYRA:

You look like a ghost.

DOC:

Did you *find* them?

MYRA:

Is it serious, darling? You worry me. [*pointing to the satchel*] They must be right in that bag. Look at this. [*She holds out the suit.*]

DOC:

What about it?

MYRA:

You got the suits mixed up. *This* is the one you're supposed to take to the invisible mender. You put the other one—that you just took off—in your bag. The keys must be in the pocket of that one.

[*Doc looks at her incredulously. She opens the satchel, takes out the coat and finds the keys.*]

DOC:

I'll be damned.

MYRA:

You see? You were too crossed by your evil temper to know what was going on. Now say thank you.

DOC:

Thank you. [*He looks at her to see what she will say next.*]

MYRA:

You haven't kissed me this morning. [*He remains seated.*]
Darling, what is it?

DOC:

Nothing. Why?

MYRA:

Don't lie to me. Are you all right?

DOC:

Sure. Look. [*He stretches his arms out and takes a deep breath.*] Nothing to it. [*pointing to the satchel*] Put the stuff back in and give it to me.

MYRA [*repacking the satchel*]:

I don't see why you have to take this big satchel, just for a suit of clothes. Couldn't you just throw them over your arm?

DOC:

I'm taking the satchel.

MYRA:

O.K., fussy. [*holding the satchel in her hands*] I wish you wouldn't go to the city today. You're too tired. Really, you don't look well.

DOC:

Nuts. [*taking hold of the satchel*] Give it to me.

MYRA:

All right. But remember the invisible mender. Have you got the address?

DOC:

I'll find it.

MYRA:

And I'll expect you when you get back. Is that right? Kiss me.

[*While he kisses her, the telephone rings and interrupts them.*]

DOC:

Tell them to go to . . . I'll bet it's that damned maternity case I've been waiting for for the past two weeks. That'll fix it, but good. [*He sits down in despair while Myra answers the phone which she has brought into the room on the cord from the pantry.*]

MYRA:

Yes, this is the doctor's house. [*After listening a moment she motions for her husband to go. He stands hesitant. She throws him a kiss and waves him out.*]

DOC [*throwing her a kiss in return*]:

Goodbye. Goodbye, Jo. [*He leaves by the back door.*]

MYRA [*continuing at the phone*]:

Is there anything I can do for you? . . . Why don't you give it an enema? A pint of water . . . No, just plain tap-water with a few teaspoonfuls of baking soda in it. Warm water, of course. No, not washing soda. Bicarbonate of soda, that's right. Use a regular douche bag. Don't hold it too high. [*A car is heard to start up and draw off.*] If he has fever it usually doesn't do any harm to give a little aspirin. How old is the child? Well, a whole tablet would be all right. Crush it in a spoonful of water and mix it with about an ounce of strained orange juice. Add a little sugar if you want to. The doctor should be back this evening—but not early . . . Not at all. Goodbye. [*She hangs up and turns to Josephine.*] Has he gone?

JO:

Why, yes ma'm. I heard his car pull out while you were telephoning.

MYRA:

Poor man. I hope he knows what he's doing!

JO:

He sure gets excited when he loses his keys.

[Myra goes into the front of the house.]

CURTAIN

Scene 2

The Thurbers' kitchen. A week later. About five in the afternoon.

As the curtain rises a sad figure is discovered sitting at the foot of the back stairs reading from a bit of newsprint which she holds in her hands. It is Myra. Her face and hands are unwashed, her dress is soiled, her hair disheveled.

Josephine stands at the sink, washing her hands. She dries them, then goes to the closet and fetches an old soap box from it which she places on the seat of a chair. Returning to the closet, she brings out an ironing board and rests it near the sink with the other end on the box. Plugging in an electric iron and bringing in a basket of wash from the front of the house, she begins to iron some shirts. A door-bell rings. Myra, startled, gets up to her feet. Turning instinctively toward the house, she gets to the swinging door but recoils from it, unable to go through.

JO:

Why don't you go on in?

[The bell rings again—aggressively. Myra looks apprehensively toward the door to the backyard. She is confused. As the bell rings again she glides quickly into the closet from which Josephine has recently brought her ironing

things. The doorbell continues to ring. Josephine pays no attention to it. It rings persistently. The back door swings open and the Milkman enters with a wire basket full of milk bottles in his hand. He is an impressive-looking person, approaching forty. He has on overalls, a blue sweater and a crimson hunter's cap—the peak turned up in front—which he does not remove during the scene. He wears steel-rimmed glasses and speaks well, striving to use his words correctly—though not always with success.]

MILKMAN [to Josephine]:

Don't try to tell me it's broke because I could hear it ringing. Loud. You were standing here, why'n't you answer it?

JO [ironing]:

Because I'm tired of answering bells around here.

MILKMAN:

What kind of a way to talk is that?

JO:

Don't blame me.

MILKMAN:

Where is she? [*Josephine shrugs her shoulders. A bell of a different tone from the first now starts ringing.*] What bell's that?

JO:

The front door.

MILKMAN:

Well, answer it. Go on. [*He finds a chair and sits down.*] Go on. I'll wait. I want to talk to you.

JO:

It won't do you no good.

MILKMAN:

We'll see about that.

[Josephine goes into the front of the house after reluctantly putting down her iron. The Milkman gives the place a good looking over. He goes to the back stairs and listens, then sees a woman's nightdress hanging on a wall hook. He lifts the lower part of it in his hands and studies it a moment. He looks into the alcove and picks up the shotgun, raises it to his shoulder and sights along the barrel; he opens the breech, examines it, then closes the breech, and puts the gun back where he found it. Josephine returns from the house.]

MILKMAN:

Who was it?

JO:

A man. [She goes back to her work.]

MILKMAN:

O.K. Then tell me what's wrong with the phone. I've been trying to get this house for three days. I knew you were here because my driver told me so. Phone out of order?

JO:

What do you think?

MILKMAN:

Is that so? Where is she?

JO:

She won't see nobody.

MILKMAN:

Well, I'm nobody. Tell her I want to see her. Tell her Mr. Tennant wants to see her—she knows me. And I'm not leaving till I do. Tell her that. [Josephine shrugs her shoulders. There is a noise in the pot closet. They both look.] You got a cat in there?

JO [aggressively]:

What's it to you? You have no right sitting here talking to me. Get out and leave me alone—I got work to do.

MILKMAN:

Whose shirts are those you're ironing?

JO:

The doctor's.

MILKMAN:

Too late now, baby.

JO:

Mind your own business.

MILKMAN [*looking at his wrist watch*]:

What do you know? My watch stopped.

JO:

That's bad luck—for you. [*The Milkman makes a pass at her with the back of his hand, kidding. Josephine threatens him with the hot iron.*] You keep away from me and get out of here.

MILKMAN:

Where's your clock? [*Josephine indicates it with her chin, behind him, over the refrigerator.*] Five o'clock! Geez! [*He sets his watch, goes to the back of the room again, and picks up one of Myra's slippers which is lying there. He holds it in his hands—appreciatively.*] Would you look at that! Ain't that something?

JO:

What?

MILKMAN:

The shape of it! I'll bet it's a triple A. What a foot! That means something. A good-looking woman. Look at it. You wouldn't know what that does to me. [*He lifts the night-dress again, gently, in his fingers.*] What does she do, sleep here?

JO:

Keep your dirty hands off those things. [*She takes them away from him.*]

MILKMAN:

Then what are they doing here?

JO:

They're here because that's where they are. I put 'em here. But she won't even look at them. She won't even take her clothes off any more even to go to bed. And that's not right.

MILKMAN:

As bad as that, huh? That's what I heard.

[Josephine nods her head in silence. She busies herself with her work. The Milkman pulls up a chair and sits.]

MILKMAN:

What do you suppose got into the doc? *[Josephine refuses to talk.]* So you won't talk. But I'm going to get it out of you before I leave.

JO:

You won't get *nothing* out of me.

MILKMAN:

I can't understand it. I mean, it would be different if . . . but she's a good-looking lay. Why the hell couldn't he stay home?

JO:

You shouldn't talk like that.

MILKMAN:

Like what?

JO:

What you said.

MILKMAN:

You mean that she's a good lay? What's wrong with that? You can't say it about everybody.

JO:

It's not respectful.

MILKMAN:

There's something to that. But why not? She's still a good lay—no woman was ever insulted by saying that about her—not unless she heard you say it. I can't understand the doc.

JO:

I think you've said enough. You better go. Now.

MILKMAN:

Why?

JO:

Because I tell you to—for your own good.

MILKMAN:

I've been thinking about her all week. I've been worrying about her. The things I've heard around town. The first night I read it in the papers—and they sure gave it a spread! I stepped out and really tied on a beautiful package—what I mean! Just thinking about her—and the doc. The doc and I were good friends. I wonder how much he left her.

JO:

Nothing you'll ever get your hands onto.

MILKMAN:

I don't want the doc's money—I don't need it. He never had any anyhow—what I mean money. If he had this wouldn't have happened.

JO:

He didn't do right.

MILKMAN:

So what? He's left a good-looking widow for some other guy with more sense than he had to take up with. That's all I can see to it. That's all there is to it, Doc.

JO:

He's *daid*!

MILKMAN:

O.K. He's daid. But he didn't need to be. One sweet guy, as straight as they come. So he takes a woman to a hotel . . .

JO:

It wasn't his wife.

MILKMAN:

Don't talk like that.

JO:

I don't care—that wasn't like the doctor.

MILKMAN:

What do you mean, it wasn't like the doctor? How do you know? It could have been any man, any good man.

JO:

No it couldn't.

MILKMAN:

To take a woman to a hotel that wasn't his wife? Sure, it could be any man at all—those things happen every day. I will admit you don't have to drop dead in bed with her. That was bad—in fact, that ended the doc. But it shouldn't have happened—that's what I'm trying to tell you. And it wouldn't have happened except that he was just an amateur, poor guy. Don't get me wrong. Doc was a good guy, one of the straightest I ever knew and a good friend of mine. That's the tough part of it. [*Josephine is pretending not to listen.*] What you need is money, plenty of it. These things don't happen, not with money to hold you over. I will admit he did pick her pretty close, practically in the next block. But there it is again. The same thing—where could he go? He didn't even own a yacht. [*He gets up and, still talking, takes a couple of bottles of milk from his wire basket and carries them to the refrigerator.*] I can't get it through my head what happened to the guy. He was always kind of excitable but he never had a bad heart. Why

I used to play ball with him not too many years ago. I think he practically scared himself to death. And that don't happen when you've got money. Real money. And, as I say, look what he leaves behind him—just for nothing, you might say. Now *there's* a woman I'd like to hand some real cash to—to spend on herself. [*Opening the refrigerator, he is surprised to find two untouched bottles of milk still there. He takes them out and turns questioningly to Josephine.*] What's the idea?

JO:

She doesn't want any.

MILKMAN:

Who's asking what she wants? I'm putting these in fresh—this is Golden Guernsey. Here. Here's a bottle of cream to go with it.

JO:

She won't use it.

MILKMAN:

Tell her she needs it.

JO:

I told her. I told her a hundred times.

MILKMAN:

Tell her again. Don't tell her nothing—anything. Put it in her hand.

JO:

She won't touch it.

MILKMAN:

If Doc was here he'd tell her. But he ain't here. Somebody's got to take care of her or she's going to ruin herself. Tell her to snap out of it.

JO:

You tell her.

MILKMAN:

I would if I could get to her. That's what I came here for. Look, you—I'm going to marry that woman.

JO [*laughing*]:

You?

MILKMAN:

You don't think much of me, do you? I don't blame you. I don't look like much, I guess, to you. I'm not like the doc, that's sure. I'm a different type. Do you think she'll talk to me?

JO:

That'll be the day!

MILKMAN:

I'll give her a life, too—the best. Anything she wants, just the way she wants it. Tell her. All I ask is for her to use my name.

JO:

Um *um!* Will she be mad.

MILKMAN:

Tell her I said so.

JO:

You! Who are you?

MILKMAN:

Anything she wants me to be. She's got everything I need and I'm the man to make her see it.

JO:

What you going to do with the wife you got?

MILKMAN:

Oh her! I'll put soap in her shoes.

JO:

That won't do you no good.

MILKMAN:

You going to let me see her? [*He picks up Myra's slipper again.*] Sure, I got a lot to learn—you got to build yourself up. But it can be done—in fact, what else is there to anything? And I can do it. It's just beginning to open up for me. Who the hell's anybody in this country, anyway? My people all came from the farm, right around here. Farmer stock, the best in the world. Why, my uncle founded the National Bank in this burg. They took it away from us—but I'm going to get mine—you wait and see. Only I got to have the right start. I got to have the right woman.

JO:

Better not let your wife hear that.

MILKMAN:

Agh. I got enough on her to blow her into the middle of the Pacific Ocean any time I want to spring it. I'll organize the whole region. There's a nice piece of change to be made around here in my line—if I can work it right. Look. What do you suppose makes this country what it is? Is it guys like the doc? And I appreciate the doc. No. They got nothing. Money's what it takes here. I don't mean crooked money. Money and drive. You got to want it, bad. And get it. Those are the big men in this country.

JO:

You haven't got money like that. Go on out of here.

MILKMAN [*refusing to budge*]:

I hear she even refused to see the body.

JO:

She's hurt and sore.

MILKMAN [*taking out some bills and holding one up*]:

How about a fin? [*Josephine refuses.*] You can't afford to turn down money like that. Make it two. [*Josephine still*

refuses.] So you're not going to take a message in to her for me?

JO:

If she wanted to talk to you she'd tell you herself. She knows you're here.

MILKMAN:

O.K. I'll see her. Tell her what I said.

JO:

I'll tell her nothing. Now get out.

[The Milkman ponders a moment, pockets his cash, turns and leaves. Josephine continues to clear away her ironing things. An outside gate is heard to swing back and forth with a sharp click each way. After a moment Myra comes slowly out of the pot closet. She is disheveled, dirty and tired. She stands listening. Hearing nothing more, she comes forward.]

MYRA:

Thank you.

JO:

Yes, ma'm. *[She goes about her business, watching Myra out of the corner of her eye. Then she speaks in a complaining voice.]* I don't see why you want me to wash and iron all these shirts and things of the doctor's now. Some of them have never even been worn.

MYRA:

They're for you.

JO *[surprised and overcome]*:

All these good new shirts and things?

MYRA:

Yes.

[She goes back to the stairs where she sits down on the lowest step, as before, and stares at her hands. There is a vague movement in the unlighted space above and behind where she is sitting—just enough movement to attract attention. The figure of Dr. Thurber may, possibly, be made out. It is in this space—above the lower part of the stairway—that the various apparitions also appear later in the play. Now an offstage voice—Doc's voice—is heard. It may sound as if it were coming down the stairwell from upstairs—distant but clear enough to be understood.]

THE VOICE:

—a dream
we dreamed
a little false
of love
and of
desire
we two.
We have slaved
we have dug
we have bought
an old rug—
We batter at our
unsatisfactory
brilliance—

JO [*who has heard nothing*]:

Do you want me to take that old rug home too?

MYRA:

What was that?

JO:

The one in the attic you said I could have last year. Walter is coming for me tonight in his car.

MYRA:

Which rug? What . . . Which rug do you mean?

JO:

I said I could take that old no-good rug home with me tonight if you want me to.

MYRA:

Did you hear anything?

JO:

No, ma'm.

MYRA:

Then why did you say what you said?

JO:

I don't know, ma'm. I just happened to say it, I suppose. We could use that old rug—if you don't want it. And if you were maybe thinking of going away somewhere, sometime—I just thought I'd mention it first.

MYRA:

Of course, take it. [*She picks up the piece of newsprint that has been lying on the stairs and begins again to read it.*]

JO:

You shouldn't keep reading that old newspaper that way—you're too smart for *that*. Throw it away. Here, let me take it. That'll never bring him back—reading over what the dirty old newspaper said about him last week. [*Myra goes on reading. Finally she puts the paper down. Josephine speaks again, hesitatingly at first.*] I've been wanting to tell you, ma'm, it won't be convenient for me to come back here tomorrow. I got my family to think of—and I'm tired. I'm getting awful tired. Real tired. [*Myra merely looks at her.*] What you going to do? You can't just stay here in this room the rest of your life. What's going to happen to you when I leave you? Because I just can't stay here much longer. They'll just come and take you.

MYRA:

Who?

JO:

Why, the police, I suppose.

MYRA:

Oh.

JO:

Because they'll just think you're crazy. They do now—some of them do.

MYRA:

Go upstairs and get me my handbag.

JO:

Now listen, please Mrs. Thurber. [*pleading*] Why don't you go up and get it yourself? You ought to go. You haven't been out of this room for almost a week. Now, go on.

MYRA:

If you want to get paid, you better do what I tell you.

JO:

Yes, ma'm.

[Josephine goes into the front part of the house. Myra remains seated. She starts as she hears a noise outside—the sound of the gate swinging back and forth. She stands erect as the Butcher Boy dashes in, after a perfunctory knock. He has a very small paper-bag parcel in his hand.]

BUTCHER BOY:

What's the idea? [*He sees Myra.*] Jeeeeeez-us! [*He turns and after putting his parcel down hurriedly flees out the back door.*]

JO [*returning*]:

Who was that here?

MYRA:

The butcher boy.

[Josephine takes the parcel to the sink, removes a head of lettuce and starts to clean it. She speaks in a pleading voice.]

JO:

Why don't you go up and lie down on your own bed? You haven't had a real rest for over a week—ever since those ugly newspaper men were here. You'll wear yourself sick. *[There is no reply.]* You need a bath! You don't smell right. And you shouldn't be using my toilet in the cellar. It isn't decent. That's for me. You should use your own things upstairs. Go on, go on upstairs and wash and rest yourself. *[During this speech the bell of the frontdoor begins to ring persistently. They pay no attention to it at first. Josephine finally turns to Myra.]* What do you want me to do about it? That bell? It's getting almost supper time now—you'd think they'd leave you alone.

MYRA:

Go and look.

[Josephine goes to see who is ringing the bell. Myra remains alone, silent, unmoving.]

JO *[returning]*:

It's that same woman. I think she must be the one. I didn't let her in.

[She continues to busy herself about the sink—preparatory to leaving. The bell at the back door begins to ring. Both Myra and Josephine look in that direction. Someone is at the door. Myra hesitates. Josephine watches her. Myra retreats rapidly into the pot closet. The back door opens. Mrs. Randall enters, looks about, and sees no one there but the colored maid.]

DOTTY:

What's the matter with you, stupid? Didn't you hear the bell?

JO:

Yes, ma'm.

DOTTY:

Then why didn't you answer? Where is she? [*Josephine shrugs, gathers up some things and goes toward the cellar stair.*] Is she in the house?

JO:

She hasn't left the house as far as I know, ma'm.

[*She goes to the cellar entrance, turns on the light and goes down. Dotty stands hesitant awhile as Josephine withdraws. Then she makes up her mind and goes through the swinging door into the house proper. The stage is empty for a moment. Then Myra comes out of the closet and stands facing the inner door. Doc's voice is heard again—as if he were speaking from somewhere up the back stairs.*]

THE VOICE:

As the rain falls
 so does
 your love
 bathe every
 open
 object of the world—

 In houses
 the priceless dry
 rooms
 of illicit love
 where we live
 hear the wash of the
 rain—

There
 paintings
 and fine
 metalware

woven stuffs—
all the whorishness
of our
 delight
sees
from its window
the spring wash
of your love
 the falling
rain—

[After a moment Dotty returns from the house and the two women confront each other.]

DOTTY [*with compassion, seeing the other's prostrate condition*]:

Oh! . . . My dear!

MYRA [*coldly*]:

Did you go upstairs?

DOTTY:

No. [*stretching out her hand*] Oh, my . . .

MYRA:

I'm surprised. What do you want?

DOTTY:

Will you forgive me—please? Please!

MYRA:

For what?

DOTTY:

For—for what happened.

MYRA:

Well, what happened?

DOTTY:

Oh, you're hard. I'm sorry.

MYRA:

Yes, I'm hard. Why don't you get out of here—you're not wanted. There's nobody here wants you any more. Get out!

DOTTY:

Perhaps it would be better. Oh, but my dear!

MYRA:

Then get out—while you can.

DOTTY:

But I wanted to explain.

MYRA:

There is nothing to explain, you dirty whore.

DOTTY:

That's not true, as it happens. That's not true.

MYRA:

Not true that you take money for it? Or is this the first time you ever slept with anyone besides your husband. You lying bitch.

DOTTY:

No . . . No! I loved your husband. He understood me as I have never in my life . . . [*She puts her hands to her face.*]

MYRA:

Sit down.

[*Dotty draws a high stool out from the wall, and sits down. Myra moves about, only occasionally looking at her—for the most part, not. Dotty takes out a pack of cigarettes.*]

MYRA:

He at least had the grace to drop dead. I have no way of knowing with how many women like you he did the same thing. No, I'll never know. And how many times with you in the three years since he's known you. How many times

—tell me! Tell me how many times you've been to bed with my husband.

DOTTY:

I can't speak with you if you're going to carry on like this. What good can it do?

MYRA:

Knowing what liars you are—any of you, all of you—I don't know why I ask you anything. Except there are some things I must know. I must know, I tell you, I must know. What happened?

DOTTY:

You know what happened.

MYRA:

But what did he say?

DOTTY:

What does anyone say?

MYRA:

What did he say to you while you were in bed with him? About me? What did he say?

DOTTY:

I don't know. I don't think he said anything about you. I can't tell you. I don't remember. [*She starts to light a cigarette. Myra stares at her. She starts several times to speak but each time stops, looks at the woman and then turns away.*] Is there an ash tray around here?

MYRA:

Use the sink.

[*Dotty, in looking for something in which to throw her burnt match, glances into the wall cabinet near the sink. Something catches her eye. She takes out a small paper container.*]

DOTTY:

What is this? Fish flakes. That's something I haven't seen. I bet it's good. [*She puts it back on the shelf and finds a saucer.*] Oh, here's something I can use. Do you mind my smoking?

MYRA:

Yes, I do.

DOTTY [*putting out her cigarette*]:

Can't we talk sensibly now, woman to woman? I am so anxious to.

MYRA:

When did you go up to the room?

DOTTY:

In the afternoon—you know that.

MYRA:

Light enough for you to see his face—when he died?

DOTTY:

Oh, can't we forget that terrible thing just for a few moments—until we reach some sort of understanding.

MYRA:

Answer me!

DOTTY [*slightly annoyed*]:

Is this an inquisition? I didn't come here for that.

MYRA:

Answer me!

DOTTY:

I don't know why I came here. It was a mistake.

MYRA:

No, you won't go. Sit down.

[*Dotty sits down and lights another cigarette which she proceeds to smoke—watching Myra closely the while. Myra*

stands silent, staring at her rival until Dotty is forced to talk.]

DOTTY [*putting down her cigarette, unable to smoke*]: It was terrible. I've got to talk to someone. I have no one I can go to who would understand. I never knew a father. He left us when I was a baby. My mother was very simple about such things. I have always wanted something, someone who would listen to me—like a father. I dreaded to be alone. I have always dreaded to be alone—that's why I married. I remember once I was left alone in the house, I was just about sixteen. It was very hot and I was—I didn't want to dress so I was lying on the bed without clothes. I remember I got up for something. Suddenly I saw myself in a long mirror we had. I stared at it a long time and—I was frightened. I ran and got under the covers of my mother's bed and hid myself. I was afraid. Did anything like that ever happen to you? [*There is no answer from Myra.*] I was ashamed of my own body—that it was evil. And I was right. I suppose I never really got over that, never really. That my own body was evil. He tried to teach me better. But *now* I know it.

MYRA:

He thought you beautiful.

DOTTY:

No, I didn't say that.

MYRA:

Yes, you are. You're still young enough for that. Beautiful. At least you had what he wanted.

DOTTY:

Why don't you talk to me sensibly? I'm . . . unhappy. I don't ask you for anything. Just tell me you understand and forgive me. [*She pauses.*] If only we could do things over again—things which when we are young we think are desperate. If only we had dared. I remember one evening,

one hot summer evening before I was married. I had been working in the bank all day and was waiting on the corner for a bus to go home, when a man, a good-looking man, drove up to the curb and began to talk to me. I never cared for boys, of college age I mean—this was an older man. He had a nice car. We talked awhile. I almost went. I don't know why I didn't go. I wanted to. I think all this would have been avoided if I had gone, then, as I really wanted to.

MYRA:

You could see the sort of man my husband was. He would never have stirred unless you made the first move.

DOTTY:

I could talk to him. He understood me.

MYRA:

Yes, he was a doctor. It was his profession to understand women. Did you plan to marry him after you'd got rid of me?

DOTTY:

No. We never talked of that.

MYRA [*laughing hysterically*]:

You picked him, I suppose, because he was a doctor. In case you needed an abortion. Did you get pregnant?

DOTTY:

Are you? [*immediately distressed*] Oh I'm so sorry. I don't want to hurt you. I chose him, if you want to put it that way, because I needed him and because he knew, without me saying more, how much I needed him. Because he was a writer, a writer about things—like that—a poet.

MYRA:

Because he was a poet.

DOTTY:

Perhaps. Because he was a poet.

MYRA:

A poet! [*She smiles ironically.*]

DOTTY:

He spoke to me of those things—I was happy listening to him.

MYRA [*reflectively*]:

And I . . . listened! Always. [*There is a pause.*]

DOTTY:

How long have you lived together in this house?

MYRA:

Nearly fifteen years. [*Another pause.*]

DOTTY:

And I had to end it for you this way. But I did nothing wrong—no matter what they say. I don't know how you stood it here. I'm leaving this dirty-mouthed little suburb tomorrow morning.

MYRA:

No you don't!

DOTTY [*warning Myra*]:

Now look. My husband's waiting outside in the car. I'll call him if you get funny.

MYRA:

You dirty low-down coward. You think that'll help you?

DOTTY:

I'm no coward.

MYRA:

Then stand there and tell me what he said before he died. What did he say about me? Tell me, if there's any good left in you. Then I'm through with you. What did he say?

DOTTY:

Nothing.

MYRA:

You liar! He talked—he always talked.

DOTTY:

Yes, he talked. He can talk. But not about you.

MYRA:

What did he say?

DOTTY:

He loved you.

MYRA [*furious*]:

Shut up!

DOTTY:

What's the use?

MYRA:

He must have said something of what you were planning to do.

DOTTY:

Nothing. Just what we did. Nothing else. He thought we were being followed. He thought he'd seen someone he knew as we were entering the hotel. He spoke of that.

MYRA:

Pitiful!

DOTTY:

He shook like a leaf. I was surprised. Of course, we were both excited.

MYRA:

And when you got to the room he undressed you and you let him worship your glorious body!

DOTTY:

You're talking like a fool.

MYRA:

Perhaps I am a fool, as you'll find out. He told you you were beautiful—the most beautiful thing in the world—with your big legs!

[Myra is near hysteria. Josephine comes up from the cellar, in her street clothes. She stands at the back a moment waiting to tell her mistress she is leaving.]

DOTTY *[ignoring Josephine]*:

I'm dreadfully unhappy at the sorrow I have caused you. I mean it. You won't listen to me. I can't do any more for you. I'm disappointed, bitterly disappointed. I thought more of you. Why can't we both join together and pray for him? You have a minister you can talk to and you need it. It's all that's left, as far as I can see.

JO *[timidly]*:

She's right, ma'm. That's what I've been telling you all week. *[She recoils at the sight of Myra's reaction.]* I beg your pardon.

MYRA *[to Josephine]*:

Keep your mouth shut! Get out of here, you stupid. Go in the living room.

[Josephine obediently crosses between the two women—avoiding Dotty, at whom she looks in disgust—and goes into the front of the house.]

DOTTY:

Let me out of this!

MYRA:

Oh no you don't! *[She interposes herself between Dotty and the back door.]*

DOTTY:

You're a monomaniac, I think.

MYRA:

Go back there! [*Dotty, a little frightened, retreats.*] Now sit down and tell me what he said to you about me.

DOTTY [*sitting on the high stool*]:

I have told you. Nothing. We never talked about you.

MYRA:

So it's happened often.

DOTTY:

I didn't say that.

MYRA:

No, you dirty bitch, you wouldn't. Who are you anyway? Worming your way in here among decent people. Where did you come from? I don't believe you ever had a father.

DOTTY [*on her feet again*]:

One thing sure—I didn't come here to brawl with you.

MYRA:

What did you put in his drink? I'll prosecute you for murder.

DOTTY:

Well, if you're going to be stupid as well as vulgar! Get out of my way. [*She goes toward the back door.*] Move aside. I'm stronger than you.

MYRA [*at the door, blocking her*]:

Try it!

[*Dotty hesitates a moment, then turns to run out the other way, through the front of the house. Myra, caught off her guard, rushes after her and catches hold of her dress, calling, "Jo! Jo!" Dotty breaks away. Myra turns a moment and grabs the shotgun. But by this time Dotty has run through the swinging door and is gone. Myra rushes to the door but stops—unable to proceed. She is defeated and*

backs up in a fury of impotence, throwing the gun to the floor. Then she turns and walks dazedly about the room. Josephine comes back into the kitchen.]

MYRA [*furiously, threatening Josephine*]:
Why didn't you stop her? What good are you?

JO [*also angry*]:
Why didn't you stop her yourself? You know I can't do things like that. You're crazy. You're really crazy. That don't look like you, that kind of talk. And honest now, I'm not coming here tomorrow.

MYRA:
You will come here tomorrow. You'll come here just as long as I tell you to come.

JO [*gathering up the shirts to take home*]:
No I won't. I've been coming here too much to help you. You don't appreciate it. And I'm getting sick, real sick of it. And I mean sick. I've got to stay by my family. They need me. I got things to do for my children.

MYRA:
All right then, get out. And get out now! [*She knocks the shirts out of Josephine's hands and stands facing the stairs.*] Dead! Completely dead. [*She stoops and goes into the alcove under the stairs, crouching down and hiding her face in her hands.*]

JO [*full of pity*]:
I didn't mean to hurt you. Now ma'm, I didn't mean that. You'll do yourself a harm. [*As she talks, she picks up the shirts from the floor and folds them again.*] Come on, come on back out of there. Why, all the good I ever had in my life I owe to your family. I owe you and the doctor and your family all the happiness I ever had in my life—since I was a little girl. But I've got to do *some* things for my own children, you know that. [*Myra does not move.*] I'm

awfully sorry for what happened this afternoon. I thought we were all done with that after last week. Wouldn't you think those women would leave him alone now he's gone. Well, I'll come back tomorrow just the way you want me to. I got to go home for a few things—but let me fix you up a little supper before I leave. Come on.

MYRA:

Dead. Completely dead!

[The room is growing darker.]

JO:

There's that old newspaper again.

MYRA:

What else have I got?

JO:

You've been reading that for six days now. Give it up. Give it to Josephine and let her burn it up.

MYRA:

Take it.

[Josephine takes the piece of newspaper from her and lights a match to it over the sink.]

JO:

There, that's better. *[The backdoor bell rings.]* That must be my husband come for me. *[She steps outside the back door for a moment.]* He'll wait.

MYRA:

Set up the cot.

JO *[rolling out a folding cot from the pantry]*:

If you won't go upstairs to your right bed, why don't you go into the front room and sleep on the lounge? It's so much more comfortable.

[Myra comes out of the alcove and tries to close the sliding door to it.]

MYRA:

I can't close this door.

[Josephine goes to help her. She slips her fingers under the lower edge of the door, coaxes it out a few inches, then grasps it and closes it.]

MYRA *[smiling]*:

Mechanical Jo! You always could fix things.

JO:

Look at his old hat, hanging there. It sure looks like him. *[She wheels the cot directly in front of the alcove door, unfolds it and busies herself making it up.]* Sometimes on a Saturday afternoon when I'd be working here he'd be going in and out of the office. And I remember one day he said, "Let's see if I can sit in one spot for fifteen minutes!" Then the telephone rang and he had to go. I don't see he was so bad you have to hate him. There's lots of men worse than he ever meant to be. *[She finishes her job with the cot.]*

MYRA:

Thank you.

JO:

Shall I fix you up a little something before I go?

MYRA:

No, thanks.

JO:

I know you always like salad. I ordered a fresh head of lettuce for you. I got it here.

MYRA:

Very sweet of you, Jo. But I don't want anything to eat. Thank you very much.

JO:

Won't you even take a glass of milk?

MYRA:

I can get that myself if I want it.

JO:

You're going to be sick, I know it.

MYRA:

I'm sick now.

JO:

Nobody can stand not eating the way you're doing. That's what's the matter with you now—your head don't work right. Look at you. That isn't you.

MYRA:

Then please don't look at me. Just come once more, tomorrow morning. Maybe I won't need you after that.

JO:

What do you mean, you won't need me?

MYRA:

Just come in the morning.

JO [*gathering up her bundle of shirts and other things*]:
I'll try—but I got a lot of things to do for my family. You call me if you need me. Maybe Walter could help you if you want to move any heavy things.

MYRA:

I can't call you—the phone's disconnected.

JO:

There you are. You did that. You took the receiver off till they just stopped ringing it. You cut yourself off from everybody. That's what I mean. If you'll put the receiver back on the hook I'll call up the telephone office when I get home and tell them to connect you again. Do you want me to hang up the receiver now?

MYRA:

Good night, Josephine. Have you got the shirts?

JO:

Yes, ma'm.

MYRA:

Tell Walter he can pick up the rug tomorrow.

JO:

Yes, ma'm. Good night.

MYRA:

Good night, Jo.

[Josephine goes out with her various bundles. Myra stands listening, then mechanically hangs the telephone receiver back on the hook.]

CURTAIN

ACT III

Scene 1

A few hours later, the same evening. The front room of a two-room apartment in a small house in the colored section of the same suburb. The apartment is in the attic, with the ceiling sloping in on both sides. At the right is the top of a stairway, protected by a balustrade. An open doorway in the rear wall shows the kitchen beyond.

Everything is neat, clean, and well arranged, though the furnishings are old-fashioned and ill-assorted—but pleasant in appearance: a couch with a tattered leopard skin draped over it, a small bookcase, a sheaf of pampas-grass in a large urn, and some chairs. There is a small tea table by the stair well and to the right of the kitchen door a very old harmonium with carpet-covered pedals. On the wall above the harmonium is a large oil painting in a heavy frame—a ship under full sail coming into harbor.

Mrs. Harding, a tall austere colored woman with white hair, stands looking down the stairs. She is plainly dressed in a grey semi-uniform which outlines her spare figure and emphasizes the dignity of her movements.

MRS. HARDING:

Who's that?

[The voice of Josephine is heard offstage, as if from below.]

JO:

Just me.

MRS. HARDING:

Who's "just me?" *[She looks down over the balustrade.]*
That you, Josephine? It sounds like your voice.

[Josephine's head appears above the level of the stage as she laboriously mounts the stairs.]

JO:

Sure it's me. *[She comes fully into view.]*

MRS. HARDING:

What do you want here this time of night? Why ain't you home with your family?

JO:

Whoof! Let me sit down.

MRS. HARDING:

I was just finishing supper. Can I offer you a cup of tea?

JO:

No, thanks. They're waiting for me home.

MRS. HARDING:

You want to lay off your things?

JO:

No. Just let me breathe.

MRS. HARDING *[studying her]*:

You come alone?

JO:

Yes. I came alone. Let me get my breath. I came to ask you for your help.

MRS. HARDING:

You mean the committee—about the church supper? I told you I couldn't spare the money this month. But I'll do some baking for you. I'd like to give you the dollar but . . .

JO:

No, it's not that. I'm in real trouble.

MRS. HARDING:

Come on, child, tell me. You got me all mixed up coming here this time of night and acting so mysterious. What you up to?

JO:

It's my madam.

MRS. HARDING:

Mrs. Dan, the doctor's wife?

JO:

You heard what happened.

MRS. HARDING:

I heard something about it. What's the matter?

JO [*looking back toward the kitchen*]:

Anybody else back there?

MRS. HARDING:

No, just us here.

JO:

She's gone off her head and I don't know how to help her.

MRS. HARDING:

Hungh! That's bad. Tell me about it.

JO:

She stays in the one room all day and all night and I can't get her to leave it.

MRS. HARDING:

Which room is that?

JO:

The kitchen.

MRS. HARDING:

What's she stay there for?

JO:

That's the last place she saw him alive. Maybe she thinks he'll be coming back and she'll meet him there.

MRS. HARDING:

Did she say that?

JO:

No, she didn't say that, but that's the way she acts.

MRS. HARDING:

She just stays in that one room?

JO:

That's what she does.

MRS. HARDING:

Day and night.

JO:

She was all right at first. It was those newspaper people did it to her. I never saw anything like it. They were like a lot of dirty cats. They walked right past me. I couldn't keep them out. Took his picture out of her own bedroom. Women worse than the men. They just pushed you right out of the way. First she fought them—locked the front door. Then she hid in the cellar. She wouldn't see anybody. Not her friends, not even the minister. Nobody. I got her to the kitchen but there she sits. For a whole week. And it's getting worse. Her mind's touched and I've got to have some help.

MRS. HARDING:

That's why you came to me. [*She picks up a pack of cards and begins to lay them out on the tea table.*]

JO:

If I could get her past that swinging door and up into her bed for just one night I think she'd come to herself, but I can't. She won't listen. I've never seen anything like that. Have you?

MRS. HARDING:

Well, not exactly. But we had a small dog once we used to keep alongside the front stairs by putting a little strip of wood across the passageway. She could have stepped over it any time but she never dared to do it. Till one day there came a thunderstorm and she jumped out and ran upstairs and got under the bed. [*She continues to lay out the cards.*]

JO:

I've tried every way to break her spell.

MRS. HARDING [*looking at the cards*]:

Hungh!

JO:

What?

MRS. HARDING [*shaking her head*]:

No. This just don't work out. You know any other man mixed up in this case?

JO:

No, no one else but the doctor. You think you can do anything to help me?

MRS. HARDING:

Have you tried praying to the Lord?

JO:

I've prayed every night, on my knees, to save her.

MRS. HARDING:

You can't do more than that.

JO:

But I'm beginning to be discouraged. I wish I knew something else I could do. Can't you help me?

MRS. HARDING:

Give me time. Give me time. Maybe I can, maybe I can't. But you got to give me a little more time. You been there with her yourself every day?

JO:

Yes, and I'm getting tired of it.

MRS. HARDING:

Nobody else?

JO:

Just the tradespeople. Except today that woman had the nerve to show up and talk to her. And there was a scene.

MRS. HARDING:

Um um! I'll bet you. You saw it?

JO:

Mostly I heard it—they like to kill each other.

MRS. HARDING:

They did, huh?

JO:

That's what made me come here. I got nobody else to talk to. I thought you might see it my way.

MRS. HARDING:

You came to the right person, but you got to believe. And you got to pray, you got to pray hard—and maybe you need some help. I'm going to give it to you . . . You got to have the help of the Lord—or you can't win. You know me. I've been a church woman all of my life, ever since I was born, you might say, in the Blue Mountains of Virginia. I never took much stock in charms and spells. But if you got faith you can remove mountains, I believe that implicitly. But you got to have faith, and how you going to get it?

[Josephine says no more. Seeing she has got the older woman stirred, she watches her in hope and no little awe as Mrs. Harding continues.]

MRS. HARDING:

How you gonna do it? How you gonna do it? You come to me for help and I can't help you. But I got to help you.

How we gonna do it? All we have to do is to get her out of that room. She don't want to leave that room because that's where she last saw her beloved husband. That's why she stays in that room—and because they all tormented her every other place all over the house. That's why she wants to stay in that room, because she can't live without some thought of the man she loved. But he won't come back to her—that's what you got to say. He won't come back to you no matter how you rant and rave. He won't come back to you so you better stop your mourning and go on into the house and forget your troubles in the Lord!

JO:

She won't listen. Why, even when that woman asked her to go back to pray she only got worse. What I'm afraid of is that they're going to have to come take her away if I can't do something quick.

MRS. HARDING:

She hasn't done anything wrong.

JO:

I mean to the insane asylum. Or else to the hospital if she don't kill herself first.

MRS. HARDING:

Hrrrugh!

JO:

I really love that woman and I don't want any harm to come to her. Well, I guess I better go.

MRS. HARDING:

Now you wait a minute, sister. Sit down. I'm going to help you out of this trouble because I see you've made up your mind. Josephine, you're a good woman and your prayers will be answered if you do what I say.

JO:

What do you want me to do?

MRS. HARDING:

You wait here a minute. [*She goes back into the kitchen. After a moment, she returns.*] Now I tell you what you do. When you go home tonight you go into your room by yourself where your family can't see you and you pray. You say to the Lord: Lord, I want that woman to be free because she's a good woman and I love her. And I ask you, Lord, not to forsake her in her troubles. You hear me?

JO:

Yes, I hear you.

MRS. HARDING:

And while you're praying you hold this close up in your hand. [*She shows her closed fist.*]

JO:

What's that?

MRS. HARDING:

Never you mind what it is. You just take it and do what I say. It's something—a piece of something that was give to me by my mother and she never told me where she got it. There ain't much left of it now but I'm going to let you have a little piece. I'm going to let you have it because your need is great. You do what I say, and, *if you believe*, when you go there tomorrow morning the woman will be cured!

JO:

How much is this?

MRS. HARDING:

One dollar. But you take it up with the committee of the church. Now I want you to sing a little hymn with me before you go home—so you'll be in a good mood. [*She goes to the harmonium, takes up the hymnal there, puts it on the rack and adjusts her glasses.*] You know this, Josephine. Come on, sing with me. [*She begins to pump the pedals.*]

JO:
Which is that?

MRS. HARDING:
"Now the Day is Over." Come on, sing! [*She plays and they sing together.*]

Now the day is over,
Night is drawing nigh.
Shadows of the evening
Steal across the sky.

Comfort every sufferer,
Watching late in pain,
Those who plan some evil
From their sins restrain.

When the morning wakens
Then may I arise,
Pure and fresh and sinless
In Thy holy eyes.

[*The curtain falls slowly while they are singing.*]

CURTAIN

Scene 2

The Thurbers' kitchen. Later the same night.

The setting is the same as in Act II, but by means of lighting the scene has been subtly transformed to take on the feeling of a dream. There are shadowy recesses in the background, and the ceiling, which before gave a shut-in appearance, has been raised so that everything above is darkness. [Toward the close of the act the lighting changes and the normal appearance of the room is restored.]

Myra is seen asleep on her cot in front of the closed alcove under the stairs. A moonbeam, projected from the front, rests upon her face.

The click of a garden gate, opening and closing, is heard outside, then the sound of footsteps on a stone walk and coming up wooden stairs. We hear a latchkey turning and the back door is opened. A man wearing a soft felt hat, a light overcoat and carrying a doctor's satchel enters. It is Dr. Thurber. He gropes to the refrigerator door and opens it. The automatic light inside the refrigerator allows him to find the string to the switch operating the electric bulb which is overhead in the center of the room. He turns on the light. He gives his satchel a shove along the floor and it slides against the wall. He does not pay any attention to his wife but throws his hat and coat on the foot of her cot. His manner is casual and abrupt.

MYRA [waking]:

Dan!

DOC:

Hello. [He goes on about his business of getting himself something to eat and drink.]

MYRA:

You're dead! So you're not dead. But we burned you up.

DOC:

Come on, come on, come on. I'm hungry. Get up and do your stuff.

[Myra, amazed, obeys, looking at him with the greatest bewilderment and delight.]

MYRA:

What happened?

DOC [casually]:

Come on, get on the job here. I'm worn out.

[Myra gets up—she has been sleeping in her slip—and goes about preparing something for her husband to eat. The Milkman enters—irrationally, from nowhere. He takes some things from the refrigerator, fills it with fresh bottles and disappears into the shadows—to reappear now and then, as if he were Myra's protector, throughout the act. As Myra works preparing food for him Doc speaks.]

DOC:

—a dream
we dreamed
each
separately
we two
of love
and of
desire—
that fused
in the night—

A dream
a little false
toward which
now
we stand
and stare
transfixed—

[He grows excited.]

All at once
in the east
rising!

All white
a northern flower!

[During this speech the sliding door of the alcove has unobtrusively opened, revealing, in the darkened recess, the

nude figure of a woman—which quickly disappears. Doc turns and speaks to Myra.]

DOC:

How you been?

MYRA [*who has seen nothing*]:

Oh, I'm all right. Really.

DOC:

Did you see it? There!

MYRA:

No.

DOC:

All white! That's the last I remember. There! All white and the rain coming down over her—in the shower, you know—encasing her in long translucencies. Standing there! You would have liked that.

MYRA:

Here's your sandwich, dear. Are you sure you're all right?

DOC [*offering her some of his food*]:

How about you?

MYRA:

No. I'll just sit and look at you. You don't know. You don't know!

DOC [*eating*]:

What don't I know? I know everything.

MYRA [*irrationally, but to the point*]:

Take me or leave me—my life is yours forever.

DOC [*paying no attention*]:

Geez! Am I tired!

[There is a pause. Myra goes toward the back and puts on her housecoat and slippers.]

MYRA [*returning*]:
Tell me what happened.

DOC:
What do you mean, what happened? You know what happened.

MYRA [*angrily, following his lead*]:

 All white!
 a locust cluster
 a shad bush
 blossoming
 a wild
 magnolia bud—
 At night
 it wakes
 on the black
 sky—

DOC [*stopping her*]:
No, no.

MYRA:
I'm sorry.

DOC:
Listen:

 a dream
 toward which
 we love—
 at night
 more
 than a little
 false—

More than a little false . . . a hell of a lot more!
 at night
 on the black
 sky—

MYRA:

What happened? Nobody will tell me.

DOC:

I'll tell you. Think I won't?

MYRA:

I know you'll tell me.

DOC [*going to the refrigerator*]:

What, no milk? You're slipping, kid . . . This'll do. [*He holds a glass of blood-red fluid up to the light.*]

MYRA:

No milk? Why, I saw him, with my own eyes. No milk?

[*The Milkman again replenishes the refrigerator, after which he places himself inconspicuously at the back and watches silently. Myra serves her husband.*]

MYRA:

How marvelous to be able to see and talk with you again! Have I been cold? Have I been stiff? Have I ever refused you anything?

DOC:

No, my dear. You have never refused me. No. Never.

MYRA:

I wondered. I wondered. I know I can't keep up with you—in some ways. But you know yourself—in some ways you're no giant. Mind you, dear, I don't mean a thing more than I say.

DOC:

I know.

MYRA:

I've tried to protect you, not to let you—waste yourself. I know you've hated this life, wanted to write. I had every sympathy for the way you've gone about getting what you

wanted. That's you and I respect it. Do you believe me? I wanted to tell you this.

DOC:

Yes. I know.

MYRA:

You've had to work. Hard. Without much praise.

DOC:

Oh well, it's too late now.

MYRA:

No, no, no. Listen to me.

DOC:

Why?

MYRA:

There's so much I want to say. Please listen. We've both had many things take up our time and strength—and we've been plenty kicked around by all kinds of people—your literary friends and the shits of this town—I don't know which is worse. They were all out for themselves, every one of them—and to use you, if they could. But you can't say that of me.

DOC:

That I'll agree to.

MYRA:

They say such cruel things of me—and you seem, sometimes, to encourage them.

DOC:

Who said anything against you?

MYRA:

We'll come to that, darling. I don't want to lose this opportunity. I've taken a lot from you. Because I loved you. I've wanted to have you near me, always. I've wanted you to love me.

DOC:

I love you, darling. You know that. In ways sometimes I'm sure you scarcely suspect.

MYRA [*smiling*]:

No, I don't know that you love me—or that you ever did. I guess I'm not always so bright in those things. Sometimes I'm sure you do but—sometimes I stand in your way. I have to! And you come pretty close to hating me. I can see it. Don't lie. We don't need to lie to each other, do we? And yet, as much as I love you, I'd let you go in a moment if you so much as said: Will you? I wouldn't put a finger in your way. You know that, don't you?

DOC:

I have never regretted our marriage. I have never wanted to leave you.

MYRA:

Let that go. You haven't answered me—but never mind that now. That's not the point. I've been mortally afraid I'd lose you. That's the truth. It's so wonderful to see you again. Often. But that isn't what I want to say, either. What is it I want to say, dear, do you know?

DOC:

No, I don't know.

MYRA [*recollecting*]:

What I want to say is that I will not let you waste yourself. That's it. Or part of it. That's what hurts me most, to see you throw yourself away—like something without value—yourself—on some worthless woman, or one of your famous literary friends that seem to amuse you so much. Oh, but it's anybody, anybody.

DOC [*looking at her, amazed*]:

Myra!

MYRA:

I'm talking now—and I don't express myself well. But I've been so afraid to lose you when . . . [*She is bewildered but recollects herself quickly.*] I'm sure I've offended you sometimes by the things I say and my refusals sometimes to do all the things you ask of me and which are beyond my power. But I can't tell you that. I, rather, let you alone.

DOC:

I don't like to be alone. Where are we?

MYRA:

But I'm not cold, am I? That's not true, is it? That isn't true. It hurts me to think that you would believe that and let others believe it without raising a word in my defense. You do, sometimes, don't you? It hurts me, darling, that you are sometimes so cheap. Yes, I mean it. You. You don't see how women take advantage of you. They are sly and scheming, they smile at you and you love it. They use you.

DOC:

I, too, am a scheming person.

[*The Milkman reappears and comes toward Myra. He is followed by the Butcher Boy, who holds a mouth organ.*]

MYRA:

Yes, you are. But that's not what I admire and serve in you. Why don't you speak to me? I half wonder if you are real. I am uncertain.

[*Doc gets up and approaches Myra. But the Milkman cuts in, bowing to him courteously, and takes her about the waist. To the music of the Butcher Boy's mouth organ, Myra dances with the Milkman—with many stops, speaking to her husband over her shoulder as she does so.*]

MILKMAN [*to Myra*]:

Myra! It isn't credible, I know, coming from me. You think I'm a kind of rough guy, not the sort of person you'd care to have much around you. But I'll tell you one thing, if you was married to me—if . . . if I ever was lucky enough to have you for my dear wife, there's nothing I could lay my hands on I wouldn't get for you.

MYRA [*to Doc*]:

I don't think you've ever taken a mean advantage of a woman in your life—except me. That I can't understand, when you say you love me. [*She stops dancing for a moment.*] But look at their faces, the best of them, this new one along with the others—for there must be many others. Look at their faces . . .

DOC:

Aren't we all more or less alike in those things, my dear?

MYRA:

—the best of them. If you could see them as they are. [*She dances again.*]

MILKMAN [*to Myra*]:

Doc is a good guy. I always liked Doc—but he's dead. Look at it any way you like, he's dead. I got nothing against him but one thing—you. That's all I got against him. You. Forget him. Come on, dance and forget him.

MYRA [*to Doc*]:

And the men, the great figures, the artistic paragons. Not a kind face among them. I often wonder that you, who see so much, do not see them as they are—small, scheming little souls. More like mice than humans. They're watching you to see what you'll do for them. Look at the faces in the background of some of the snapshots you have of them—vermin startled when the light goes on, those who think they're not being observed. You must have noticed it.

DOC:

You, I am sure, my dear, are not scheming.

MYRA [*who has stopped dancing to listen*]:

Toward you? Never.

DOC:

I could have told you many things—had I dared.

MILKMAN:

I'm going to marry you, Myra, and I'm going to make you happy, happier than you have ever been in all your life. And you're not going to be ashamed of me either. You'll see what I can do. I can do anything. What are nine-tenths of the successful men in this country that I can't be like them? What have they got that I ain't got. You. That's all. You. I need you. With you back of me I'm going to clean up. I know what those guys are thinking and I'm one up on them every time. Something tells me I can do it. I'm making money, I'm making it fast and I'm going to make it so fast pretty soon they won't be able to catch me. It's for you, Myra, for you. Just for the pleasure it'll be for me to give it to you. And it'll be honest money and clean money and I don't want none of it—any more than the business demands. What am I good for but business—I know it. But ain't that what it's all about? I don't ask you to love me the way you loved the doc. I could never compete with the doc. But I want to give you things, Myra, the doc could never give you—he never had any interest in them. We're not too old. I can make you happy. And you can make me what I never had a chance to be—proud of you. So proud of you I'd think I was king of the world.

MYRA [*to Doc*]:

I ask only one thing. [*to the Milkman*] You'll have to pardon me. I'm tired, my dear, very tired. I think I'll rest awhile. [*She goes to the cot, sits a moment, then lies down, her head raised on the pillow. She beckons to the Milkman.*]

Come here. [*He leans over her. She takes his head between her hands and kisses him.*] Some other time. Please go now. [*The Milkman goes out, followed by the Butcher Boy. Myra turns to Doc.*] What could you tell me that I do not know? Tell me, tell me, dear. We have so little time.

DOC [*going to the foot of her bed*]:

Well, I'll tell you. A man must protect his price, his integrity as a man, as best he is able, by whatever invention he can cook up out of his brains or his belly, as the case may be. He must create a woman of some sort out of his imagination to prove himself. Oh, it doesn't have to be a woman, but she's the generic type. It's a woman—even if it's a mathematical formula for relativity. Even more so in that case—but a woman. A woman out of his imagination to match the best. All right, a poem. I mean a woman, bringing her up to the light, building her up and not merely of stone or colors or silly words—unless he's supremely able—but in the flesh, warm, agreeable, made of pure consents. That means they're not married, of course—unless he unmaries them by hard work for a moment now and then. Something—to that time unconceived by him or anyone in the world. Do you follow me?

MYRA:

Is that all?

DOC:

When a man, of his own powers, small as they are, once possesses his imagination, concretely, grabs it with both hands—he is made! Or lost, I've forgotten which . . . [*He looks at her closely.*] And just as a woman must produce out of her female belly to complete herself—a son—so a man must produce a woman, in full beauty out of the shell of his imagination and possess her, to complete himself also . . .

MYRA [*yawning*]:

The rape of the imagination.

DOC:

Good. It is a kind of rape. You often surprise me by your felicitous phrasing.

MYRA:

Your voice is so soothing. What did you say, dear?

DOC:

I was trying to tell you.

MYRA:

Darling, I love you so. I love you so much. I am desperate.

DOC:

I was trying to tell you.

MYRA:

I remember—and possess her. That was it, was it not?

DOC [*speaking now as if to an audience*]:

This is purely personal—ad interim: He interests his wife in this—she follows his vision—or she does not. She joins him—or she doesn't—in the search for that divine beauty which is not theirs, to be sure, but moves them both, together—or it does not. It is supremely detached from their acts, from all infidelities. It stands in the full light, APART. It is *his* perishable genius, such as it is, which he has hardly won and which she . . . [*He leans over her, studying her intently for a moment.*] She is asleep! [*He lights a cigarette and walks about.*] I died when I walked upon the grass. I died in everything. I died when I was born. [*He leans over her.*] From which you once rescued me—hence my devotion. [*He sits down on a chair, at some distance from her, and buries his head in his hands.*]

MYRA [*half waking*]:

Where did you go before you took her to the room, my poor boy?

DOC:

Where did I go? It all depends, I suppose, on how you look at it. Shall I tell you the whole story?

MYRA:

Yes, tell me. I want to hear it. Oh, it is so marvelous to *feel* again. I thought that was ended for me forever. [*She nestles down comfortably into her covers on the cot as her husband begins to talk. The Milkman enters at the back. He takes his place beside Myra, giving her his entire attention.*]

DOC:

It begins when I was hardly old enough for anyone to think that it could be possible. There is never a time, when young, that we are not tormented by our minds, those magnificent Stradivarii, presented to us intact by our beloved parents—tormented brats that we are and have not yet learned to play them. It traps us, we can't find a way out. We haven't the skills, we haven't the data. Yet the thing, the thing itself, is there and all our games, in consequence, are psychic assaults upon our masters, who suppress us. Sex comes in here. It did with me. How I ever got through the sixth grade for what the girl in the seat back of me used to say to me over my shoulder soon after breakfast every morning is more than I can understand. That was the second check. There I was, right up against it. I wasn't scared. Or was I? I was scared all right, but scared to lose something I instinctively wanted—if there was anything I wanted more than to bust out and forget myself in anything, which seldom happened.

MYRA:

Your voice, again!

DOC:

It was something else I wanted—wanted terribly—though I couldn't have named it to save my very life. I think that's

where the fake of sex took its heaviest toll. I did nothing. As a consequence I never recovered! And this something else in my mind grew and grew, mushroomed up in me until I was a smalltime Emerson of ideas and determinations gone sour. Thus I conceived sex, the monster! Something somebody was trying to put over on me. Poor St. Lizzie saying, This is *it*, boy! Don't be a damned fool. Grab it. But I knew it wasn't it. I knew it interminably, day and night, and I knew it so well that I almost went nuts over the thing—so intimately did I know it—in its wrappings of cellophane. Bah! I couldn't take *this* because I wanted *that*. And what was that? Damned if I knew what it was. How could I—it was right in front of me? I looked at the sky and the sky looked back with its blue eyes into my brown ones and—winked. I was too dumb. Maybe I should have taken up astronomy, huh? Don't you think so?

MYRA [*sleepily*]:

Yes, darling. Anything you say—just so that you keep talking so beautifully.

DOC:

And nobody told me—except my bald-headed Sunday School teacher, poor guy—who used to read from Plato's Dialogues to us. If I could only have known what his poor dried-up life found there in those days! He couldn't put it over—not the way I wanted it put over. But he tried—bless him in hell, out of which I don't think he ever got anyway—or wherever he is today.

Meanwhile, there sat Lizzie—she married a doctor in Brooklyn later, so her old mother told me, and lived an exemplary life—there sat Lizzie—virginal as a water lily in a cow pond for all I ever did about it—there sat Lizzie every morning—smelling like something out of a department store basement. Yeah, them wuz the days—to forget. We were powerless. And we are powerless unless we have the luck to slip into the mud early—but that usually finishes us any-

how. And what kind of power do we get, even at that? Nothing we want, in the long run. We end up at the bottom of the stairs only, instead of entirely missing them. That's the only difference. Remember your dreams, darling? How you used to run downstairs—down, down, down, down, endlessly? You used to tell me of them. Floating off like a feather in the wind. Remember?

MYRA [*almost asleep*]:

I remember. It was beautiful.

DOC:

Poor kids. I was a mighty unhappy pup. And Delia. God, how I remember Delia! I almost pulled the breeches off her in the kitchen one night after supper—and we ask them why they don't want to eat their meals! But she was a peasant and knew how to take care of herself. At least she wasn't a damn fool—or mercenary—and fought me off. Poor kids, what they go through.

Gaudeamus igitur! Yeah. Corn if there ever was corn in this man's world. Struggle, struggle, struggle. To keep what? That inherited great gleam of—light! That's what it is, it's light! So, while I held my arm over my eyes, I went around hunting the light. I must have been tough to withstand that treatment. I kept right on going.

MYRA:

You poor boy.

DOC:

I wouldn't drink. Not that I hadn't. I wouldn't smoke. I wanted that mind in there, that bombulus, and refused to slow its denoting instancy by so much as the drag of a needless breath taken. And no women! No women! I didn't want women. Not much. I must have had a guardian angel watching over me among the back streets of Philadelphia. Maybe I frightened them—or looked too poor. Frightened them because I looked too poor. That must

have been it. I didn't realize how safe I was. There was nothing but the tormented thought of females. And if I did meet one who seemed to offer something, she was of no more body to me than the scent of a rose in the wind. It's better going nowadays—but it was hell then, I can tell you. I was like two guys in the ring, twins, slugging it out. And I wasn't even getting paid for it. First I'd sock myself in the ear, then in the kisser, then in the slats. Oh well.

MYRA:

Yes, darling. I know.

DOC:

Maybe I was foolish, huh? Agh! Why doesn't one of these prize bitches squatting their fat fannies on inherited billions of our national wealth, widows of industrialists who died of cerebral hemorrhage rooking the everlasting daylights out of us, year in, year out—why doesn't one of those wrinkled bags get religion and donate a million dollars to me right now—to throw away for her? I'd change the complexion of the world! Overnight! A lousy million, something she'd trip over on her way to the can any morning and never notice it. And I'd give her a buildup for it to sink the Pyramids.

MYRA [*waking finally*]:

Oh, I've had such a sleep! Such a restful sleep. Why did you stop talking? I had dreamed that you were dead, that you returned and that you were talking, telling me something I wanted desperately to hear, something of vast importance to both of us. But your voice was so soothing—and I, tired and disturbed in my mind, I fell asleep and never heard you. I had been so very unhappy and was so relieved at the sound of your voice again. What were you saying? Oh my dear, in spite of it all I've never enjoyed so sweet a sleep. What were you telling me?

DOC:

What the hell? You always fall asleep when I'm telling you anything of importance to me—or reading to you.

MYRA [*starting up*]:

What happened?

DOC:

What happened? You fell asleep.

MYRA [*on her feet*]:

No, no, no, no! Dan, you went to a hotel with that woman.

DOC:

Sure. Anything you can do you must do. I'm not proud. If it comes my way I do it.

MYRA:

My husband! My poor husband.

DOC:

That's one thing about sex—you're never so happy as when you're rid of it.

MYRA:

Do you love her?

DOC:

Sure I love her—what do you want me to say?

MYRA:

Why didn't you tell me?

DOC:

I didn't want to hurt you.

MYRA:

Are you dead, really?

DOC:

Me? Why? I love you.

MYRA:

On the very day when your love for me should have been most alert, if any day is sacred to love, you walk out without a thought of me in your mind.

DOC:

Exactly—if you put it that way. Because on such a day love is uppermost. To . . .

MYRA:

You are perverted and disgusting.

DOC:

—to renew our love, burn the old nest and emerge transcendent, aflame—for you! Do you know any other way?

MYRA:

How can you talk like that?

DOC:

Because I will not lie. Cost what it may, I will not lie.

MYRA:

And you think that excuses you? I want to know all that took place that day, not just what happened—I already know that. No one will tell me. I want to know, I suppose, just how far in a lie a man can go, to the last bitter word. I must have something to cling to—even if it is the worst. Something definite. I do not want to lose myself to emptiness. We had been so happy together recently. I thought our lives were just beginning to be reconciled each to the other.

DOC:

I felt restless just for that reason. Something had to be done, I tell you. We couldn't let ourselves drift into that.

MYRA:

Happy for the first time in years.

DOC:

I was getting bored. I was afraid to be alone with you.

MYRA:

Oh.

DOC:

And don't think you can't be a bitch. And that it wasn't a relief to be rid of you sometimes. I never wanted to go far. Darling, don't let that bother you. I knew that if we were to keep on loving each other something had to be done about it. This opportunity offered itself and I took it.

MYRA:

Oh, no!

DOC:

Oh, yes. Here's a beautiful woman who really needs me. I tell you she needed me—for private reasons I don't want to talk about. After all, it's none of your business. I needed her, too.

MYRA:

Oh, Dan.

DOC:

Everybody has to be true! She was good-looking, hot as a hound and practically asking me to love her. I'd be mad to pass up a chance like that. Naturally, I took her up. Naturally, I did what had to be done.

MYRA:

Had to be done!

DOC:

To keep love alive.

MYRA:

To keep our love alive.

DOC:

It went all right. I loved you, as a consequence, more than I ever loved you in my life up to that time. It worked. I couldn't tell you—you couldn't have understood what I felt. It's impossible that you should have understood what I felt.

MYRA:

I don't know what to think of you. Suppose you had found me in such a position.

DOC:

You couldn't be in such a position. You've got *me*! Other women are not so fortunate. [*Myra slaps his face.*] That proves it. I don't mind you slapping my face. I love it. I love you more when you slap my face. If I didn't love you, I'd . . .

MYRA [*laughing and kissing him*]:

You adorable idiot. You look nice. You look sweet when you talk that way. [*She kisses him again. He tries to put her off.*] I wonder if there's another man in the world like you—there's no other I could so love!

DOC:

Don't be profane. Every man is like me. Don't try to hand me that bunk. I know too much. I'm just the run of the farm, dull average. I'm not neurotic. That's just what I'm *not*. I'm just like everybody else. That's my pride. I'm proud. Hellishly proud that I'm just the core of the onion—nothing at all. That's just what makes me so right. And I *know* I'm right.

MYRA:

Did you talk to *her* this way?

DOC:

No. I didn't know her that well. And I had my troubles with her, getting her where I wanted her. She's no genius,

in love or anything else, and had to be led to it, so she'd know what she was up to.

MYRA:

So you did talk to her that way. I can see it.

DOC:

I had work to do.

MYRA:

With her?

DOC:

With her.

MYRA:

Just as you do with me. Tell me what you talked about. Wait a minute. Before we get down to business go look at your face in the mirror.

DOC:

What for? I don't want to.

MYRA [*laughing*]:

I didn't think you would. I just wanted to see something.

DOC:

What?

MYRA:

I don't know, my dear, it was merely a thought. A woman's curiosity. [*There is the sound of thunder.*] Thunder! Isn't it late in the year for thunder?

[*Doc goes to the sink for a drink of water, lets the water run a moment to freshen and takes a glass. It slips; he tries to catch it as it falls and it breaks, cutting his finger.*]

DOC:

I've cut my hand.

MYRA [*going to him*]:

You're too rough with everything. Take it a little easy. [*As she tears a piece from a dish towel to bandage his finger she goes on talking to him.*] Darling, how long had this been going on?

DOC:

I met her in New York and we went to a hotel.

MYRA:

Brilliant. You registered her as your wife?

DOC:

Why be so literal?

MYRA:

Could anything be more literal than what you did there? Or is that putting it too crudely?

DOC [*looking at his finger*]:

You think it's bad?

MYRA:

Hold still. You're like a coiled spring, waiting only for the release. I have always been made to feel that if I turned my back on you you'd be away with some woman.

DOC:

You should be complimented.

MYRA:

Why?

DOC:

On your imagination.

MYRA:

I despise you.

DOC:

Who has a better right to do so? Or ever will?

MYRA:

There, your finger is bandaged. Grant me this one final wish. What did you talk about when you were alone together?

DOC:

My dear, I don't know.

MYRA:

As you love me, and for the last time, tell me what you said to her.

DOC:

I will not.

MYRA [*viciously*]:

Oh, come out of it, you dirty, lying, cheap guy! If you don't want me why don't you say so and let me get out? Go with this woman or that woman—or man or boy or little girl or anyone your mind will lead you to. I don't care what you do but I demand that you tell me, in so many words, what you promised this woman before you dropped dead in bed with her.

DOC:

What did I do?

MYRA:

I don't know. Don't ask me. I only ask you to speak to me honestly, once, that I may forgive you if I can and, if I cannot, let you go out of my mind and out of my life forever and be done with you.

DOC [*looking hard at her*]:

You want that? [*Sound of thunder, louder than before.*] You remind me of the woman who dragged out a long life on crutches to the end, to prove a point. What point? That God is good and man vile—in his two eyes, his chemical brain and two hands. [*defiantly*] I did it. The details are of no interest.

MYRA [*grieved*]:

Oh, my dear.

DOC:

So what? I live with you. I live from you. I am you. We are married. I do what I please.

MYRA:

Oh! Oh!

DOC [*passionately, with great conviction*]:

All my life I've been saying hello, my darling, and good-bye to you—the anodic opening and the cathodic schluss, the best moments of a lifetime—all yours! The most intense in the current of our lives.

MYRA:

Oh, my dear, why do you talk this way? It's paralyzing to everything I begin to feel again for you. Do it if you can't help it but—better keep silent.

DOC:

The thrill of a perpetual recovery from an illness.

MYRA:

Is that what you're after, a thrill? Isn't there anything to stop you if what you call your love for me can't do it? The seriousness and the very nature of your profession as a doctor should at least—should prove at least a hint for you—of what we are to believe.

DOC:

Life and death. That's the burden of my profession. What's there to learn in that? I am a *man*!

MYRA:

God damn you!

[*There is a blinding flash of lightning, followed by thunder and wind. The lights on the stage go off and other,*

bluer lights color the scene—as when there is a short-circuit in the subway and the cars switch onto the batteries. When the light returns the scene has been altered—a new scene has been imposed upon the old one, but the curtain is not lowered. The transformation is accomplished by lighting and the placement of a few properties.]

Scene 3

A hotel room. The swinging door to the pantry has become the frosted glass door of a shower. The cot has become a hotel bed and there is a small table beside it. Dotty is sitting on the edge of the bed. Doc stands near her.

To the right, but in half-darkness, is a bench on which Josephine, the Butcher Boy and the Milkman sit watching. On the left side, facing the front, Myra is seated alone on a chair. She is barefooted and paring her toenails—apparently indifferent to what is taking place.

Doc goes to Dotty and tries to take her in his arms but she gently pushes him away.

DOC:

Well?

DOTTY:

No, wait a while.

DOC:

Let me undress you.

DOTTY:

Don't rush me. Order some drinks. Come on.

[Josephine rises from the bench, is handed a tray of drinks from offstage and brings them to the table beside the bed. Doc pays her and she returns to her place on the bench.]

DOC:

Why this slow torture? You are gloriously beautiful.

DOTTY:

Yes, I know. But give me time. So far I'm doing all right, for me. Don't you think so, pal?

DOC [*handing her a glass*]:

Drink up.

[*They both drink.*]

DOTTY:

And maybe we could have just a few dainty sandwiches, huh? See my game? [*She laughs.*]

[*The Butcher Boy approaches and mimes the taking of an order.*]

DOTTY:

Isn't it hot in here? Open the window. [*She feels the bed with her hand.*] Sure you really love me?

DOC [*sitting on the bed beside her*]:

Darling!

DOTTY:

Praise me! Flatter me!

DOC:

You've been a marvelous sport.

DOTTY:

Tell me I'm doing just what I ought to be doing.

DOC [*smiling*]:

I suppose you'd like me to rape you.

DOTTY:

What good would that do either of us, big boy? [*They drink.*] I feel a little better. What does one really want?

I often wonder, doctor. You are my doctor, aren't you?
I'm in your hands, doctor. Say something nice.

DOC:

When I think of the steel-ribbed, mush-bellied bitches I've known about these parts in a lifetime . . . you've been like an angel to me—at times.

DOTTY:

Only at times?

DOC:

At times more illuminating than others.

DOTTY:

No good. I don't like that kind of talk.

DOC:

You're a breath out of the stratosphere to me.

DOTTY:

Chilly? [*patting him*] Never mind, you'll feel better after a little while, darling.

DOC:

I hope so. When a man reaches such a climax as this in his life . . .

DOTTY:

You exaggerate, my dear. You know perfectly well, bless you, that for my part any little girl in the rumble seat of a Ford would have done as well.

DOC:

Not interested.

DOTTY:

We're not at least two little innocents, no more than we're adventurers. We've got responsibilities, haven't we?

DOC:

Divorce? Is that what you mean?

DOTTY:

Don't be silly. That's the last thing in your mind. I want to look out of the window. [*She gets up and mimes the action of looking out a window on the left.*] Heavens, look how high up we are!

DOC:

You certainly aren't very much interested.

DOTTY:

You don't know a thing about it. Besides, I need a bath. I'm really all sweaty.

DOC:

Good. Let's both.

[*She goes to the glass door, opens it and turns on a light behind it.*]

DOTTY:

Look what a pretty shower! Did you see it? Look. All pink tiles and a light inside and everything. [*She turns away and begins to undress.*]

DOC:

Let me help you.

DOTTY:

Don't do that. And don't pout. I want to see what's across the street.

DOC:

You'll be seen. Come on, let me have the pleasure.

DOTTY:

No. [*She holds her dress about her obstinately.*]

DOC:

What did you come here for then? Why else did you come here?

DOTTY:

To hear you talk, mostly. Talk to me, my dear.

DOC:

We had a choice, I suppose, either to be very excited or very calm.

DOTTY:

Let's be excited.

DOC:

All right.

DOTTY:

Then go on talking—and don't look at me.

DOC [*patiently*]:

Talking? Of what? The Greeks!

DOTTY:

Oh wonderful! Yes, of course—the Greeks.

[*While Doc talks, getting up and walking about as he does so, Dotty stops undressing and sits on the bed—in her slip—following his words with fascination.*]

DOC:

—bastardized by our bemused scholars who speak through a hole in a Nebraska dollar as those old boys used to project their voice from the hollow of the sacred rock. Obscenity in the open. But imagine! We can't translate them—in our day! It ain't allowed! There's something in our day, common to them, that we can't even talk about. Imagine! We can't speak of it—it is too . . . too beyond our thoughts. Infra-ideational! Christ! We won't even mention it. So we have murders. Do you know why? Because we can't let it out—until we bust. Until one takes a woman, not one's wife, into a strange room—a public room and . . .

DOTTY:

You and me, huh?

DOC:

There is something in our day, common to them, that we can't talk about. "Figure it," as poor old mother used to say. We can't speak of it. We are too pure! Christ!

DOTTY:

Please.

DOC:

Instead, we have something they call "the university." And we present the *Lysistrata* so befouled by omissions, so dirtied by reticences that even to have smelt of it Aristophanes would have thought himself a whoremaster.

DOTTY:

Sweetie, how you talk!

DOC:

Do you think these things do not have repercussions in the mind? Drunkards who chew sonnets like tobacco and spit them into every corner . . . [*He stops talking suddenly and looks at her silently for a moment. He comes over to her and puts his hand gently on her shoulder.*] Come on—let's go home.

DOTTY:

No, no, no, no, no, no, no! I'm just beginning to get excited. Go on! [*She gets up and begins to undress again.*]

DOC [*disgustedly*]:

Go on, where?

DOTTY:

Talk!

MYRA [*rising from her chair and breaking in*]:

How can you be so thoughtlessly indifferent? So cruel?

DOC [*to Myra*]:

You asked for it. I'll stop if you'll let me.

MYRA:

No. Go on, go on.

[*Doc turns his attention back to Dotty, who has not seen or heard Myra.*]

DOC:

As they say in Washington, a private life and a quick death—what else better is there to wish for? This is too public.

DOTTY [*caressing him as he sits dejected*]:

Ooooh, sweetheart. I thought we were doing beautifully. Talk nice again the way only you can. Come on. Please. It'll come.

DOC [*putting his arm about her*]:

Short fare. Our dreams! And a long deathwatch, seeing who will breathe the last first. Listen, do you know what their damned language sounds like?

DOTTY:

Whose language?

DOC [*growing more and more excited*]:

The Greeks. Here's one of the most famous lines from their most famous poem:

*Káy seh gayrón táw preén men acoúomen
ólbion áynay . . .*

Sounds like a horse coughing, doesn't it? Achilles said that to Priam. Or does it just remind you of Hiawatha?

DOTTY [*bewildered*]:

What does it mean?

DOC:

"What does it mean?" she asks me. What does it mean? To hell with what it means! That's what it *sounds* like, out of which they made—MADE, God damn it—the finest poems ever written by man. But we are bound by rule of procedure. Our imbecility cannot follow them—because of

the ART of poetry. No less! A verse—multiplex, efflorescent, varied as the day in its forms—within the limits of their world, to be sure. But we, who inherit the ages, crawl from the light! Good God, what they would have done with what *we* have to do with! But we crawl off, night things—Joyce was right—monotonous in our voices as katydids . . .

DOTTY:

Go on! Go on!

DOC:

—monotonous in our voices as two men staggering up the street, a drunken brawl after moonset. Good God! What a business! Some business! So we come to talk about death as if it were the dividend on a share of common stock—in profound silence, in spite of *their* gorgeous noise . . . “They say, old man, that you too were a tough guy in the old days . . .” Me, also, full of fish-tailed gnats named Flaherty. I disgust myself.

DOTTY [*with complete conviction*]:

All right, darling.

DOC:

All right what?

DOTTY:

I love you.

DOC:

You mean you know what I’m talking about?

DOTTY:

Yes.

DOC:

You mean you understand what I’m after?

DOTTY:

Yes.

DOC:

And it doesn't make you wanna puke?

DOTTY [*shaking her head violently*]:

No. It makes me want to love you, my darling, until I'm deaf and blind and . . .

DOC:

You angel out of heaven, it can't be.

DOTTY:

Yes. Now! Yes, yes, yes, yes!

[He takes her in his arms. Her slip falls from her shoulder. There is a sudden darkness pierced by flashes of light. At the same moment the other figures on the scene break into a unison chant of: Yes, yes, yes, yes, yes, yes, yes, yes! which suddenly changes into the sound of machine-gun fire, running from right to left, low at first, but with increasing intensity. The figures from the bench rush to the center of the stage as if joining in an attack. The Butcher Boy leads the way, bearing an American flag. The Milkman has a shotgun and Josephine is beating a drum. Offstage, a fife is playing Dixie. There are pistol shots, and flashes of light through a general darkness. The attack succeeds, with cheers! Then a final explosion—not too near—followed by silence and darkness lit by a flickering light, as of a conflagration.]

There is no curtain as the scene ends. When the lights come up again, all evidence of the hotel room has vanished.]

Scene 4

It is about dawn of the next morning, in the Thurbers' kitchen—as it was in the earlier scenes, with the ceiling in place and normal lighting.

Myra, asleep on her cot, is awakened by the persistent ringing of the telephone. She gets up, pulls on the ceiling light by its hanging string, and goes into the pantry to answer the phone. She brings the instrument on its extension cord to the doorway.

MYRA:

Hello. Yes. I'm sorry—the doctor died a week ago. I'm sorry you haven't heard about it, but it's true. No. I'm afraid you'll have to get someone else. [*She hangs up almost immediately. The phone rings again. Myra ignores it. She has been running around in her night clothes. Now she puts on slippers, goes to the sink and washes her face. The daylight has been increasing. The phone rings again and she answers it.*] The doctor isn't here. No! [*She hangs up. There is the sound of the outside gate opening. Then heavy footsteps approaching, followed by the click and clatter of empty milk bottles being removed and others being placed at the back door. Myra listens. She reaches above her head for the hanging string and, with a scarcely perceptible movement of her hand, turns off the light. Dawn is well advanced—a ray of sunlight enters the room. Myra turns and casually walks through the swinging door into the front of the house.*]

CURTAIN

Tituba's Children

CHARACTERS

Salem, Massachusetts: 1692

REV. SAMUEL PARRIS, minister of the church of Salem Village.

About 35 years old.

MRS. PARRIS, his wife.

BETTY PARRIS, their daughter, aged 9.

ABIGAIL WILLIAMS, Betty's cousin, aged 11.

TITUBA, the Parrises' half-Carib, half-Negro slave.

JOHN INDIAN, Tituba's husband, also a slave.

ANN PUTNAM, a Salem girl, aged 12.

MERCY LEWIS, maidservant in the Putnam household, aged 19.

MARY WALCOTT, a Salem girl, aged 16.

ELIZABETH HUBBARD, a Salem maidservant, aged 17.

SARAH CHURCHILL, another maidservant, aged 20.

JOHN PROCTER, a farmer living near Salem Village.

ELIZABETH PROCTER, his wife.

MARY WARREN, maidservant in the Procters' home, aged 20.

SARAH GOOD, an old woman, a vagrant crone.

SARAH CLOYCE, another old woman.

GILES CORY, an old man, aged 80.

WILLIAM STOUGHTON, Deputy Governor of Massachusetts
Bay Colony.

JOHN HATHORNE, a magistrate.

JONATHAN CORWIN, another magistrate.

REV. NICHOLAS NOYES, a minister from Salem Town.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON, a Salem citizen.

BENJAMIN HUTCHINSON, another townsman.

A Physician. Constables. Townspeople. Judges. Demons.

Washington, D. C.: 1950

STELLA RAJAPUTSKY, hostess in the restaurant of the National Club. About 25.

"MAC" MC DEE, a young official in the State Department. About 30.

TONY PROPOSITO, headwaiter at the National Club, who doubles as master of ceremonies for its floorshows.

SENATOR PIPELINE

SENATOR YOKELL

SENATOR GASSER

SENATOR WISE

FRED, AN F.B.I. AGENT

A NEWSPAPER COLUMNIST

A group of waitresses, young colored girls, who double as dancers in the floorshow.

Club members and their guests, some of whom are government officials. Reporters. Senate hearing attendants.

NOTE

Many of the parts in the Salem and Washington scenes are played by the same actors—with change of costume, but intended to be recognizable as the same persons. Salem magistrates become Washington senators, Stella plays Sarah Good in one sequence, etc.

ACT I

Scene 1

The kitchen of the rectory in Salem Village, Massachusetts. It is the afternoon of a windy March day in 1692. There is a large open fireplace, shown somewhat at an angle. In the style of old New England houses, this fireplace is a good ten feet wide, tall enough for a child to stand upright in it and deeply recessed. The andirons and flue are in the center, with ovens inset in the brick of the back wall and swinging iron arms to hold pots over the flame. There is a leaded window in one wall near the door; a bench before the fireplace; a few chairs, etc.

Two small girls, Betty Parris, aged 9, and her cousin, Abigail Williams, 11, are busily sewing by candlelight near a low fire in the fireplace.

The musical background for the opening of the play is high-pitched, childishly imaginative and "frightening."

BETTY:

Abigail Williams. [*She stops sewing and listens to the wind.*] Ah, Abigail, I'm afraid! [*She sobs.*] Let me tell mother. Mother!

ABIGAIL:

Tell her what?

BETTY:

About Tituba.

ABIGAIL:

Hush, Betty Parris! Don't you dare, or your father will thrash us all. Besides it's too late now—the cake is baked today.

BETTY:

We shall be sent to Hell.

ABIGAIL:

Then, we cannot help it, and I'll pray only for its finest room. But maybe not. Yet I must know if there be witches preying here and if so who they be. The cake will prove it. Tituba has promised—the witches' cake—to feed it to the dog.

BETTY:

Oh, I'm afraid, afraid, afraid. Dear mother!

ABIGAIL:

I'll kill her if she bothers us! [*She puts her hand over her little cousin's mouth.*] But I *will* know the truth—you can't stop me. I'll say you are bewitched.

BETTY:

Oh no, no, no, no . . .

ABIGAIL:

Then be quiet. [*ecstatically*] The pretty truth! The Devil's truth! [*She sings a song.*]

The pretty truth,
the Devil's truth,
plays upside down
with the whole world.

[*Toward the end of the song, Sarah Good, a disreputable old hag, with a pipe in her mouth, has walked in. She applauds the singing with her toothless laughter.*]

SARAH GOOD:

Ah, my fine ladies!

[*Little Betty screams and drops her sewing.*]

ABIGAIL:

Sarah Good! How did you get in?

SARAH GOOD:

Through the door. The chimney, did you think? The door.
And I'd not be the first to do it unannounced.

ABIGAIL:

Do what?

SARAH GOOD:

To walk in without knocking. Isn't this the gossips' center?
The latchstring's always out for scandal here. Sarah Good
has eyes as well as another.

ABIGAIL:

What do you see?

SARAH GOOD:

Speak more civil to your elders, you little hussy. It's the
world! What world there is in this paltry place. They're
all running here. All the little waggle-tongues. And not
they alone but them that should have better sense. What's
the news?

ABIGAIL:

News of what?

SARAH GOOD:

Ah, little sly Miss Innocence. The witches! Do you think I
have no ears?

[Abigail pinches Betty, who screams.]

SARAH GOOD:

The witches! The witches, that you're all feeding your
slithy tongues on! Away with you, you brat. Where's
your mammy? Come the very words from me mouth and
there she stands.

*[Mrs. Parris, an unoffending woman, has come into the
room with cloak and bonnet in her hand, preparing to go
out.]*

MRS. PARRIS:

Children! What's all this noise? [*seeing Sarah*] Oh!

SARAH GOOD:

Don't be afraid, Goody Parris. It's only poor, harmless Sarah Good . . . looking for work to keep body and soul together for the Judgement Day—when, whatever else we get, we'll all find rest. When this snip of a girl—that I'd like to take over my knee for her impudence . . .

ABIGAIL:

Get out, you witch!

MRS. PARRIS:

Abigail! Betty, come here to your mother!

ABIGAIL:

Don't you go.

BETTY [*to her mother*]:

Go away from me—I'll throw this book at you!

MRS. PARRIS:

Betty! Not that! Are you in truth bewitched? Go now, Sarah Good. I have no time for you.

SARAH GOOD:

You have no time for me. All I said was, what's the news? . . . What news? said she . . . News of the witches, said I . . . The witches? says she . . . So you have no work for me? Not even so much as would buy a bit of baccy for me pipe? So I'm not good enough for you? You have a black woman to do your cleaning. Ha! And these small snow-flakes can sit warming their seats the winter through and to no better end than to gabble of their betters until such tongues grow in their little heads, through idleness, that they could lick the backs of their necks with them like any scrawny crow. So you have no time for me? And your reverend husband brooding in his study—do ye call it—writing his Sunday sermons of the damned while his poor

wife with her long white hands does nothing—or holds them up to pray and twists and ties them into knots. While these [*pointing to Abigail*] run wild! I see enough.

ABIGAIL:

Agh, get her out, I say. She is a witch.

[*Betty cowers against her mother's skirts.*]

SARAH GOOD:

And every slinky, man-sick, smooth-faced fancy Nancy—a man would cure her . . . running here to have her palm read—and worse, by a black slave.

ABIGAIL [*barking like a dog*]:

Bow wow wow wow!

SARAH GOOD:

What's this? Give an old woman a few pence then for some baccy and I'll not bother ye more.

MRS. PARRIS [*taking some money from her pocket*]:

Here then, and go—before my husband finds you with his whip.

SARAH GOOD [*to Abigail*]:

And the Devil spend you, young miss. You're a pert one. We'll meet again, ye little bitch. You're the ringleader. [*to Mrs. Parris*] Be careful that she don't make trouble for us all before she's done. [*She spits.*] That's for the lot of you. And let her clean that up. Ha, ha, ha, ha!

[*Sarah Good goes out, mumbling to herself. Abigail, who has been running around the room, crawling under chairs and barking, stops short as soon as Sarah Good is gone and brushes off her skirts. Mrs. Parris sings.*]

MRS. PARRIS:

Poor innocent children in this
wild land—that you should be
witness to such disgrace of womanhood.

Alas, sweet lambs,
that your tender minds
should be shaken
by such horrid storms,

blasts from the regions of the lost
and damned. Alas, that
the white fabric of unready youth
be stained by oaths and lies.

[*She turns and calls.*] Tituba! Where is that lazy thing? Tituba, come here. Children, harken to what I say. Your father's blind and deaf at work in his study. I must go on an errand. Do not be frightened. Tituba will stay with you. Tituba! And Betty, my pet, reflect and pray.

[*Tituba, a drawling half-Negro, half-Carib slave, comes into the room.*]

TITUBA:

Yes, ma'm.

MRS. PARRIS:

And children, pray when harm is near! The Fiend cannot harm you when you pray. I won't be long.

[*Tituba begins to scrub the floor but soon tires and goes to stir the fire.*]

ABIGAIL [*in a mysterious voice*]:

Have you stirred the dough?

TITUBA:

What you say?

ABIGAIL:

Has the cake been baked?

TITUBA:

Maybe it's all been baked. Maybe I feed it to de dawg. Maybe the dog he have a fit and run out in the fields.

ABIGAIL:

Tituba—he didn't! I'll call them in.

TITUBA:

Come here my Betty, come here my little gold-haired baby child. Come to Tituba—Tituba loves you. What was all that noise I heard in here? Don't nobody hurt my little Betty. Or Tituba kill him dead for sure. [*She sings.*]

Don't let nobody hurt my child.

[*Meanwhile Abigail has been signalling from the window. She takes her cape and hood and finally runs out as Tituba croons Betty to sleep. Now some older girls begin to come in, one by one. They are of various ages: Mercy Lewis, a sly servant girl of 19, leading her charge, Ann Putnam, a frail, nervous child of 12, by the hand; Elizabeth Hubbard, 17 years old; and two older girls, both 20, Sarah Churchill and Mary Warren. Some of the older ones, like Abigail, are here simply for mischief, but Ann Putnam has come on a serious, even tragic errand—sent by her mother to enquire of Tituba about visions of the departed dead which have been haunting Mrs. Putnam's dreams.*]

MERCY:

Did you hear? Mary Walcott and Susanna Sheldon fell into convulsions at the Walcott house this morning.

SARAH:

Who will be next?

MERCY [*laughing*]:

I'd like to show them! [*She cries herself—half in earnest, half pretending—into a fit.*] Look, a black dog is biting me! Look on Tituba's head—a yellow bird! Oh, I am being stuck with pins. [*The others pay no attention to her.*]

ABIGAIL:

Tituba!

TITUBA:

Don't wake my baby.

ABIGAIL:

Oh, bosh! You've got to tell us. We've got to know. Who is tormenting us? [*She goes toward the oven.*]

TITUBA [*putting Betty down*]:

Get away from my oven.

MERCY:

What's in there? The witches' cake? I think I smell it.

TITUBA:

You don't smell nothin'. If your uncle catches me here with you this way, he going to whup me hard and drive me off and then you find out nothin'.

SARAH [*coaxing*]:

But you will tell us. They say in the Bahamas, where you come from, that there are witches there and sorcerers. Tituba, are they real? What can they do?

TITUBA:

Let the child rest. She's all tuckered out. Don't you mind these big girls. You just a little one . . . you gonna make her sick. [*She caresses the child.*] I wish I could take her far away in my own country—where the sun shines good all day. Away from this cold weather and these hard people. These are not my people. You all got white, hard faces. You all witches—all you. [*She makes a sweeping gesture.*]

ABIGAIL:

You blaspheme.

TITUBA:

I like to take her down to my country where I come from and cure her. She's sick.

ABIGAIL:

She's bewitched. We've got to find the one who did it. They ride in at night. I've seen them.

MERCY:

So have I. They meet and sign the book.

TITUBA:

On the green islands they no snow—and no hard ice looks like a goat's horn. Like a stone. And the blue waves come soothin' in free and easy from the big bay and they smell sweet as bees' honey through the mango trees. [*The girls listen.*] The night so deep and dark and full of big stars you get lost in it, and a big crawlin' flower hangs from the walls long as my arm, called the night bloomin' serious. A big, full flower and when it crack it shall creep down the wall like it have feet. And the richest smell like nothin' you ever smell on the earth roll out of it—and the big night come flyin' to it on wings a foot long, blue and green, come flyin' in to dip down and drink up the sky so sweet you don't dare lie down on the wall or they pull you up off you back and carry you to the hills—and you don't care what they do to you.

ABIGAIL:

Tituba, you're wasting time!

TITUBA:

You're the worst. You got the Devil in you! You don't give me no peace.

SARAH:

She said the Devil is in her. Look what you've done.

[*Abigail does not move.*]

TITUBA:

All I see here is hard people like you. And you just a child. And work, work, work. And now you want me to find the witches for you. What do I know about witches?

ABIGAIL:

You do know. You know you do. Find them! I order you.

TITUBA:

I know what I know. What do I care about you witches?

ABIGAIL:

Again, I warn you!

MERCY:

You're in league with the Devil.

TITUBA:

Let the Devil take care of his own. I'm in league with nobody. What they come for and snatch me away up here?

[For a moment no one speaks. Suddenly Betty slips from Tituba's arms and falls to the floor, where she lies writhing.]

ABIGAIL:

Look!

SERVERAL VOICES:

You bewitched her.

TITUBA *[alarmed, to Abigail]*:

You set her up to that. You're a hard one. You one of the hardest I know. I think you right—the Devil not far off. Come up close. And keep your hands off that door. You gonna spoil the whole thing. *[She opens the oven door, revealing the cake—far back in the oven. They all exclaim excitedly.]*

THE CHILDREN:

Look at that! That's a *cake*! Umpp!

TITUBA:

Keep you hands off. Just to touch it, it'll burn you to the bone. *[listening]* Who's that coming? He gonna whup me! He gonna whup me, hard! *[She puts the cake far back in*

the oven and, after listening a moment, hides herself in the dark corner of the deeply recessed fireplace.]

[Rev. Parris, Betty's father, comes into the room.]

REV. PARRIS:

Didn't I hear Tituba here? Haven't we enough of nefarious business? Where did she go?

BETTY *[after a frightening pause]*:

In the fire.

REV. PARRIS *[thinking the child is lying]*:

That is enough of lies. Your childish minds have put the whole town to shame. Even the children—are you damned? If that black woman is to blame, I'll beat her till her bones stick through her flesh. What are you here for, all of you?

ABIGAIL:

Betty's mother sent them here to keep us company while she was gone.

REV. PARRIS:

You should have found some work to do till she returns. Ah, children, if you knew what has descended on this parish. *[He sings.]*

Ah children if you knew, etc.

[after the song] Begone now all of you—and Betty come with me. You are too small. *[He goes out.]*

ABIGAIL:

Tituba! Come out!

[Tituba emerges from hiding.]

TITUBA:

I told you so. You get us all in trouble. *[She takes the cake out of the oven and exhibits it.]*

SARAH:

There's a piece out of this cake! *[They all look.]*

TITUBA:

I gave it to the dog.

ABIGAIL & SARAH:

What happened?

TITUBA:

He go mad and run off through the fields yelpin' and yellin' like the Devil.

[One of the children screams.]

SARAH:

Then it is true—we are bewitched. It is the Devil has done it.

ABIGAIL:

I knew it. I knew it.

[Ann Putnam suddenly stiffens, as in an epileptic fit. The others gather round her. Abigail barks again: Bow, wow, wow, wow, wow!]

MERCY & SARAH:

Who is it, Tituba?

TITUBA:

How I know?

ABIGAIL *[maliciously, and suddenly perfectly normal]*: I know. It's Sarah Good! I hope they hang her by the neck. I shall denounce her.

[At this point, black young demons, some wearing dog masks, begin to come out of the dark corners of the fireplace. They caper about the fire, but the girls do not see them.]

ABIGAIL:

I knew it! I knew it, I knew it, I knew it, I knew it! Oh, I hate them all.

MERCY:

And I! They beat us. They torture us because they find us young.

TITUBA:

Who dey?

ABIGAIL:

I'll teach that old woman to torment me! She shall hang for it.

[As the girls leave, after a bit of gossiping—some serious, some laughing, all excited—the small demons, masked as dogs and other grotesque-headed beasts begin to bark, hoot and whistle, dancing about in the shadows. Abigail is finally alone.]

ABIGAIL:

Bow wow wow wow!

[The demons dance about her with great glee. As the curtain descends, she joins them.]

CURTAIN

Scene 2

The set is the same as in the preceding scene, but "modernized" to conform to the requirements of a club restaurant in Washington, D.C., in 1950. It is a place frequented mainly by government officials of one sort or another, rather exclusive. The small tables that fill the stage area have been pushed back from before the fireplace to make room for the floorshow which is to follow. The Salem fireplace itself has been decorated with pumpkins and cornstalks. Toward the front, at one side and partly hidden by two

palm trees in tubs, is a single small table. The place is rather gloomy, the drapes drawn, only a few lights lit.

Several young colored waitresses, giggling and laughing among themselves, are making up the tables, placing flowers in little vases, etc.

As the curtain goes up "Mac" McDee, a State Department under-secretary, is seen sitting dejectedly at the small table. The waitresses glance at him with amusement from time to time. He has a drink before him and a full ashtray. Stella Rajaputsky, the hostess at the club, comes in. She sees Mac and goes over to him.

STELLA:

Mac, you promised me!

MAC [*a little tight*]:

Hi yuh, Stella.

STELLA:

You gotta move. We gotta clean this place up.

MAC:

What for you gotta clean this place up?

STELLA:

The show!

MAC:

What show?

STELLA:

Our annual Halloween show—for the members. Come on now. [*She tries to get him up.*] I told you all about it.

[A telephone begins to ring persistently in a small booth near the fireplace. Stella moves to answer it, but Mac stops her. He pulls her down into a chair beside him. The phone stops ringing and there is silence for a moment.]

STELLA:

Mac, why don't you go home?

MAC:

I like it here. I like you. Nobody else I can talk to, Stella. Go home to your wife. She asks too many questions. You don't ask questions.

STELLA:

Darling, you know I love you. I'd do anything for you—under ordinary circumstances. I'd even shut up if you asked me to, but . . .

MAC:

Just like that, huh?

STELLA:

Just like that. So get the hell out of here, Mac. We got work to do here—and you're too good a man to let yourself go this way. Are you really drunk, or just sorry for yourself?

MAC:

I can't go home. Not now.

[*Mac and Stella sing a duet. The waitresses have gone out.*]

STELLA:

All right then, tell Mama what it's all about.

MAC:

There's nothing to say.

STELLA:

Have they got something on you?

MAC:

Sure. Why not? And I'll hop a window some day to prove it.

STELLA:

You're worn out, my boy, and need sleep.

MAC:

Sleep! I haven't slept for a month, maybe a year. I've never slept—that's why they're out to break me. I thought I could do some good and slaved my heart out, to spread my "talents," such as they are.

All right, I've made mistakes, but you'd think, to hear them talk, I was as low as a newspaper columnist. The very vagueness of the charges makes it suicide for me to answer them.

STELLA:

Another witch hunt, huh? I know their kind. But Mac, listen to me.

You can't stay here. And I can't stay with you. And your wife needs you. How do you know what's going on there?

MAC:

Baloney. She's a perfectly healthy girl. I need you, Stella. I've got to talk to someone.

STELLA:

We're having a rehearsal and the show in another hour.

MAC:

A what?

STELLA:

A rehearsal. Right now. We're putting on a show—I've got to see it through in one hour—for the members.

MAC:

Whose show?

STELLA:

Oh, just a silly thing. Halloween and all that—about the witchcraft trials at Old Salem.

[One of the young colored waitresses comes in. She is bearing a huge Devil mask on a white pole. It is too heavy for her. She does not see the two sitting at the table but begins to clown with the mask, waving it about, bowing and scraping as if to an imaginary audience—grotesquely. The impression is weird and unexplained. The telephone begins ringing again, persistently. The girl leans the mask on its pole against the fireplace and goes to answer the phone.]

MAC:

What the hell's that?

STELLA:

An Iroquois Indian witch mask—we had it made up for us for our dance. It's supposed to drive off evil spirits.

MAC:

Try it on me.

WAITRESS [*coming from the booth*]:

That's the fifth time she call up since this morning. She say she wants her husband. Lady, I ain't got your husband. [*She goes to take up the mask.*]

[*Tony, the club's headwaiter, who also acts as master of ceremonies for its floorshows, comes in. He is corpulent and florid, and is dressed in evening clothes—white tie and tails.*]

TONY [*to the waitress*]:

Che fai tu qui? Via! Via! . . . get out! Hurry up, hurry up. You think we got all day? [*He chases the girl out with a napkin he is holding in his hand and seizes the mask on its stick. At the same moment he spies Stella and Mac at the table. He comes over to them, apologetic but insistent. He holds the mask negligently, all but dragging it upon the ground. It makes a deflated appearance.*] Scuse-a-me-a-bub! Sorry to break it up, son, but we've got a job on our hands.

STELLA:

All right, boss. Just a minute.

TONY:

O.K. It's your show.

[He shrugs his shoulders and beckons offstage. Two or three of the girls come in and move the tables about as he leaves, taking the mask with him. Stella and Mac resume their duet for a moment.]

STELLA:

Face it kid! Don't let me down.

You know they've got nothing on you, really.

MAC:

Why the hell did I ever bother?

I had ideas.

STELLA:

Stand up to them.

But we're busy as hell with things, Mac. Get going. I mean it. And come back after you've cleaned up. The show will do you good. Walk right in on us. In an hour. I'll be looking for you . . . and call up your wife.

MAC:

Hey, wait a minute.

STELLA:

A surprise—for the boys tonight. Get out of here. The Salem witchcraft trials—a lot of little girls that took the town over, and how! Get going.

MAC:

O.K. But tell me about it.

STELLA:

A lot of little columnists. Bitch-sisters—you know. See you later. Come on now. *[She hustles him out.]*

[As Mac and Stella leave, the scene is blacked out and there is a musical interval to indicate the passage of about two hours' time.]

When the music ends and the lights come up again guests have begun to arrive in the club. Some are already seated. Others come in severally and in groups. Waitresses are going back and forth. There are comparatively few tables visible but from the way the little waitresses move about a larger room is indicated. The guests are talking and laughing, ordering their drinks, etc. The space before the Salem fireplace is clear for the floorshow and there is a small orchestra at one side of the stage, which is playing when the scene opens, and occasionally during the action—fading down, or out, as required for the speaking parts. Among the guests at the tables are senators and congressmen—both Republican and Democrat—well-known lobbyists, government officials, newspaper writers, legal talent, etc.]

SENATOR GASSER:

Fine. How's yours? Any more enlightenment today from the State Department morons?

AN ASSISTANT SECRETARY:

What's that I hear you saying, you jolly old cutthroat, about *your* State Department?

SENATOR WISE:

Sit down, Charlie. I didn't see you standing there. How's the latest scandal? Moving up?

ASSISTANT SECRETARY:

Which one? Somebody lose her virtue this week in your office? I said virtue.

SENATOR WISE:

No news? Well, glad to hear you're keeping your nose clean for a change. But seriously . . . *[He whispers in the Secretary's ear.]*

ASSISTANT SECRETARY:

Yeah. [*changing the subject*] What's going on here tonight?

SENATOR PIPELINE:

How would he know? All he's got to go by is the F.B.I. There he is now, that so and so. [*beckoning*] Come on over here, Fred. Who gave you a black eye?

[*Fred, the F.B.I. Agent, covers his eye with his hand.*]

SENATOR YOKELL:

Look at him put his hand up. [*They all laugh.*]

FRED:

Anything for a joke, huh?

SENATOR GASSER [*looking around*]:

They even got the press here. Um-uh! Did you ever see such a crew?

A COLUMNIST:

You can't get the smell of it, beloved, if you don't have the dung. Right?

SENATOR GASSER:

Who's been milking you, junior? Looking for something to break tonight? Come to think of it, I haven't seen young Mac around lately. Away on a mission?

ASSISTANT SECRETARY:

No, just a short leave. His wife is having twins. I wonder if he knows about it.

SENATOR GASSER:

No kiddin'.

[*There is an awkward pause.*]

SENATOR YOKELL:

What kind of language are those colored kids talking to each other?

FRED:

Some sorority lingo of their own, I guess. "Tut," I think they call it.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Can you understand it?

FRED:

Can you understand Russian? You, I mean.

SENATOR YOKELL:

I don't like it.

[There is a burst of applause and everyone turns to the stage as the orchestra sounds a fanfare. Stella, now in evening dress, appears gaily to announce her show. As she first speaks she imitates the accent of Tony, the Master of Ceremonies.]

STELLA:

Scusate, Signori! And welcome to our city!—from the far places.

SENATOR PIPELINE:

—as if we hadn't been stuck here for the past six months twiddling our thumbs. Nothing funny about that.

SENATOR WISE:

And whose fault is it, Bosco?

STELLA *[in one breath]*:

Every year, at Halloween,
it is the extraordinary pleasure
of the staff of this club
to show to you, our generous
patrons, the deep appreciation
we feel for the many favors you
bestow upon us—by presenting
for your possible amusement
our homely homespun little homily . . .

[She gasps for a deep breath.]

SENATOR GASSER:

A collich girl, no less.

COLUMNIST:

She didn't have tuh!

SENATOR GASSER [*in a farm accent*]:

That's high praise, George.

STELLA [*continuing*]:

—this year of witches and
the time!

[*She laughs.*] Now don't think I'm going to go off into poetry, boys. It's about the witchcraft trials of Salem, Massachusetts, in 1692. Quite a time, boys, quite a time. A little skit called "The Trial of Sarah Good," written, rehearsed and acted by the staff of this club—God help us! —for your consent. So here we go—with the best of good wishes to you from us all.

[*The orchestra sounds a fanfare of chords and drums.*]

STELLA:

Il prologo!

[*Tony comes in, still in tails but with a clown's hat and costume, carelessly thrown on, only partly covering him.*]

TONY:

Ridi, Pagliaccio! Opera buffa. Molto good feeling. Poco ability. Mai . . . [*He spreads his arms in a gesture of apology.*]

SENATOR YOKELL [*under his breath*]:

Talk English—so we can understand you. What do we let them in for? Any of 'em? Grease balls.

SENATOR WISE:

Damned good American food, for one thing.

SENATOR YOKELL:

If you like it.

COLUMNIST:

Why, Senator!

TONY:

You remember your history, gentlemen.

I puritani! Very fine people—

ancestros of Mayor Curley—

Bostonesi perfetti. Scusate, no speak

very good English.

Hard-working people, but

have very bad luck.

[*He makes a motion as if being hung by a rope.*]

Twenty-two persone! Squick!

One, they push him up with big stones.

Agh! I tell you in Italiano —

all educated people talk my lingo.

[*A small antelope-headed demon in scarlet appears and becomes the Master of Ceremonies' constant companion—his "familiar."*]

SENATOR YOKELL:

What's he trying to do, kid us?

SENATOR PIPELINE:

He can talk as good English as I can.

SENATOR YOKELL:

They all can.

SENATOR GASSER:

Let's give him a Bronx cheer.

TONY:

Like this is happen! Ye old boy—

he like little girls. Yes? So he

sneak up on them and he say, "Permettemi."

[*The music comes up and a spotlight focuses on the Master of Ceremonies. The club "audience" fades into the surrounding darkness, as Tony sings a patter song of Italian musical terms.*]

TONY:

Agitato. Lento. Vivace. Largo. Molto allegro.

Lento assai. Andantino. Molto agitato.

Largo. Allegretto molto. Vivace. Presto. Lento.

Allegro. Steinway piano.

You get it?

Sostenuto. Presto con fuoco. Allegretto. Molto

allegro. Vivace. Largo. Cantabile.

Molto agitato. Moderato agitato. Moderato.

Allegro. Appassionato.

Andiamo. Get going. Come on girls.

Show 'em your stuff.

[*There is a burst of applause as he finishes his song and goes off, followed by his "familiar," the little demon.*]

SENATOR PIPELINE:

I don't get it.

SENATOR WISE:

Oh, come Iowa—he's calling Wop hogs out of the spaghetti fields.

SENATOR YOKELL [*looking under the table*]:

Who the hell was the little guy in red? I don't trust these foreigners.

SENATOR WISE:

What you want is an aria from that famous classic "The Longhorns of Poker Flat," or a yodeler from the oleo lobby. [*He yodels.*] Oleo lobby! Oleo lobby!

SENATOR PIPELINE:

I hope they never get it, just the same.

SENATOR WISE:

O.K. Butter fat, fat, fat, fat, fat!

[Meanwhile, the waitresses now dressed in Puritan costumes, their faces whitened, have come in quietly and ranged themselves, like a glee club, to sing a stylized arrangement of "The Pretty Truth, The Devil's Truth," the song from the first scene in Salem.]

CHORUS OF WAITRESSES:

The pretty truth,
the Devil's truth,
plays upside down
with the whole world.

Clouds from ocean,
sweet from salt,
the whole's the fault.

Seeks solid sense
in wantonness
and damns to bless.

And learning out of
verbiage
where clown is sage.

Sees peace in riot
and once abed
no rest instead.

Dreams whose wrath
of sainted lies
stabs us from
angelic eyes.

[As the chorus disperses after this song, Stella is picked out by the spotlight near the center of the stage. The rest of the set is cast into more or less darkness.]

STELLA [*coming forward*]:

The children, thus begun as you
have heard, innocent girls, most
of them, whipped only by the violence of the times, and much
too old for whipping, striking against restraints after
winter's heavy snows, indoors, grew
restive. Then their minds, heated—
and not their minds only—rebelled, and, incited by the half-
Indian, Tituba, grew hysterical and hearing talk of
witches began to accuse their
elders as tormentors. That is to
say, the more disreputable, but soon for very fun, the decent,
envied people of the town. It went beyond their thoughts.

A feverish success upon this fertile
ground of hellish fears and back-
biting gossip led to disaster. They were made heroines,
excited brats and trollops that they were. Overnight they
grew to oracles, wild, ungoverned
furies rather of destruction. In three
months eighteen women and four men were slaughtered.
Incredible! Though none was burned. Old decent women,
young flippant trulls, half-
crazed women, quiet women, sick
women, well women and even Mr. Burroughs, a minister of
the gospel, accused, tried and hung—seven
together one day on a limb.

[As the spotlight is removed from Stella and she disappears, a change is seen to have taken place on the stage: demons have brought in a black pulpit with a great white cross, reversed, depicted upon it. They scamper back and forth, bringing in a large red book which they place on the pulpit top with a candle beside it. The Master of Ceremonies comes in, now dressed in diabolical priest's robes, which he has difficulty in managing. The little demon prankishly gets in his way. Not used to being so accom-

panied, Tony first tries to avoid the "presence," then grows angry and attempts, unsuccessfully, to drive him off. Recovering his dignity, he indicates to the club audience that it is all beyond his comprehension. Suddenly, as Tony approaches the pulpit, the little demon comes up behind him.]

TONY [grabbing at his rear]:

He BIT me!

[While this feud between Tony and the demon has been going on—in not too emphasized a fashion—the figures of Sarah Cloyce, Sarah Good, Elizabeth and John Procter and Giles Cory have silently come on stage and taken up positions around the pulpit. When the Master of Ceremonies realizes their somewhat ghostly presence he is more than a little startled. The little demon, whom he had previously driven off, re-enters, contritely, coming to him to be forgiven like a dog who has misbehaved. Tony pats the creature's head as he ascends behind the pulpit. The demon curls up on the floor in front of it.]

TONY [uncertainly, consulting his book]:

Sarah Cloyce! Which is Sarah Cloyce?

[Sarah Cloyce steps forward. She is a large, self-confident woman with great independence of manner.]

SARAH CLOYCE:

What do you want of me?

[Throughout the rest of this scene, though the attitude of the Master of Ceremonies is timorous, humane, almost apologetic, that of the witnesses and the accused is 17th-Century—serious, wholly dignified and forthright, in their true historic character. Abigail Williams comes forward.]

ABIGAIL:

There is a black man whispering in Cloyce's ear. There is a yellow bird flying around her head. [She falls down.]

TONY:

Look! Madonna! You see how the child is afflicted. You are indeed a witch.

SARAH CLOYCE:

You are a liar. God will stop the mouths of liars.

[The demon hides behind the pulpit.]

TONY:

You are not to speak in that manner in this court.

SARAH CLOYCE:

I will speak the truth as long as I live.

TONY:

Goody Cloyce, you are a witch. Confess or you will hang.

SARAH CLOYCE:

It is a shameful thing that you should mind these folk [*She points angrily, directly at the audience of club guests.*] who are out of their wits.

[Sarah Cloyce walks out. As she does so, Sarah Good appears, a disreputable vagrant—but defiant.]

TONY:

And now you, Sarah Good, you were the first to be accused. Why have you not been to church these months?

SARAH GOOD:

Because I have no close.

TONY:

Have you made no contract with the Devil?

SARAH GOOD:

No.

TONY:

Why do you hurt these children?

SARAH GOOD:

I do not hurt them. I scorn it.

TONY:

Who do you employ then to do it?

SARAH GOOD:

No creature—but I am falsely accused. [*She steps back.*]

[*The Master of Ceremonies shrugs his shoulders, spreads his hands, and leans over the pulpit to consult with the demon—as much as to say, “What’s it all about?”*]

TONY:

Elizabeth Procter!

[*Elizabeth Procter appears. She is a gentle and intelligent young matron who is abashed but unafraid before the tragedy that has overwhelmed her.*]

ELIZABETH PROCTER:

What do you want of me?

TONY:

You know of what you are accused. Elizabeth Procter, what say you?

ELIZABETH PROCTER:

I am as innocent as the unborn babe.

[*The Master of Ceremonies is now crying and takes out his handkerchief. He gestures for Mrs. Procter to go away. Her husband appears in her place.*]

TONY:

Suo marito? [*He shakes his head.*] John Procter, are you a wizard, as they say? [*He shakes his head to tell Procter to say no.*]

JOHN PROCTER:

These girls, if left alone, will make witches of us all. The handling of these trials leaves the lives of innocent people to the pleasure and passions of those who are minded to take them away.

[It is clear that the Master of Ceremonies agrees. He shakes hands—in the air—with Procter but, under the nudging and threatening of the demon, he tearfully waves John Procter out.]

TONY *[to the demon]*:

Any more?

[Giles Cory appears. He is a hulking old man of 80 or more—dead serious, completely humble but unafraid.]

TONY:

And you, Giles Cory, you are an old man. What of you? You have accused your wife, your own wife, of witchery. How is that?

GILES CORY:

I am a poor creature and cannot help it.

TONY:

Were you afraid of her?

GILES CORY *[very slowly and distinctly]*:

I don't know that I ever spoke that word in my life.

[The Master of Ceremonies and all the characters of the scene fade out as Stella comes toward them, smiling. She sings.]

STELLA:

Time flies and witches hang,
zig zag.
Night is in the human mind
that whirls, zig zag.
It is blind
night in Pastor Parris's meadow—
the witches come
on a broom,
riding to the Devil's tribunal.

[*There is the sound of wind and shrieking.*]

Time flies.

The bat of reason goes

zig zag

to its doom, torturing us

while March winds blow

zig zag,

and Sarah Nurse gives suckle to

a darting yellow bird that flies

zig zag.

Winter's hard on little girls,

so we accuse

right, left, anybody whom we choose

zig zag—

mother, child, husband, wife,

until the very minister of the Lord

is sent

zig zag, hellbent,

with a rope around his neck

to his doom.

[*Mac enters and crosses, partly through the "spot," to a table toward the front at one side. Stella sees him and, smiling, makes a sign of recognition, then goes offstage. She makes a quick change, returning disguised as Sarah Good with a mask and pipe. The orchestra strikes up some hot music, and the "girls," (augmented as may be desired) come in demurely and begin to dance. Then suddenly they throw back their Puritan garb, revealing legs bare to the hips, and go into a wild routine—as the colored waitresses. They circle around the figure of Sarah Good, making her the butt of their mockery.*]

[*The Master of Ceremonies enters with his witch mask on its stick, banging it on the floor. The girls wrap their Puritan clothes about themselves and grow quiet as he talks.*]

TONY:

Basta! Basta! That's enough. Leave this poor old woman alone. Was a ma'? You crazy? She never done nuttin'. What about it, kid? You know what is the malocchio? Huh? You witch 'em up, huh?

[Stella now throws off her mask and disguise as Sarah Good and comes forward, smiling prettily as usual.]

STELLA:

No, of course not. I never bewitched anybody. Did I, boys? I dare you! So there it is. The show's over. That's all we've got for you. *[She waves her hand to Mac. He replies.]* I hope you liked it.

[The players bow and retire. People begin to crowd around Stella to congratulate her as others prepare to leave. She comes forward, then turns and, with her back to the audience, calls out:]

STELLA:

Just a minute, friends. I almost forgot my epilogue. What I wanted to say was—really I'm a little scared. Shall I?

SEVERAL GUESTS:

Go ahead, Stella!

STELLA:

Well, I'm nothing to you. Just Stella, the hostess at your club. You see me every day—you know. But listen, fellows, you, among you, hold the world right in your hands. Perhaps I got a hell of a nerve . . . but have a heart, boys, have a heart. You know what I mean. O.K. Thank you and goodnight!

SENATOR PIPELINE:

A hot little number, I'll say. Stella—what kind of a name is that? Polish?

MAC:

You don't pronounce it right.

COLUMNIST [*noticing Mac for the first time*]:

I'll be damned! There he is! In the flesh!

MAC:

And in the spirit too, fella, believe it or not. My wife's just had twins in the hospital! Stella, did you hear that? Two boys! The drinks are on me.

STELLA:

Mac! Am I glad to see you! Wonderful!

COLUMNIST:

What a story! While his wife's in the hospital, twins! Missing State Department official found hiding in swanky night club with blond hostess who tells senators how to run country. Will that wow 'em. Oh boy, let me out of this! [*He rushes off.*]

FRED:

That does the business! Party member in 1935—almost sure. Confidential adviser to the President at Yalta. Just the man we've been looking for. [*He goes over to Mac.*] Hello Mac, how's your wife?

MAC [*holding out his wrists*]:

Wanna put 'em on now, Fred? Or wait till tomorrow?

FRED:

Don't be that way, Mac. It's not that bad. Let's go get a drink.

MAC:

Hello, Stella. It was a good show. A lot of polish to it, sweetheart. And you were absolutely right. I went home and there it was! Hospital! Twins! Holy smokes! It'll be a little tough tomorrow—but tonight! [*He kisses his fingers to her.*] I feel like a new man.

STELLA:

How's your wife and how are the kids?

MAC:

She's O.K. They're a little premature but they'll come along.

STELLA:

Oh, Mac, you're wonderful!

[The orchestra begins to play and Mac and Stella, with the chorus falling in around them, sing some such sentimental ballad as "Sweet Adeline."]

CURTAIN

ACT II

Scene 1

The first day of the examination of the witches in the meetinghouse at Salem, March 1, 1692. The General Court has assembled. The fireplace of the first scenes is blocked out (by any simple means) and the meetinghouse pulpit pushed back against it. Otherwise there is no essential change in the setting.

"It was accordingly decided to open the meetinghouse for the purpose . . . The few necessary practical arrangements were quickly made. A bar of justice was provided by turning the minister's chair about. The pulpit was moved back to make room for a large table fetched from the ordinary, and seats were set behind it for the magistrates (John Hathorne and Jonathan Corwin) and their secretary. Ezekiel Cheever performed that office on this occasion; Corwin himself, always inclined to leave the actual prosecution to Hathorne, also took notes, extraordinarily copious notes in the case of Tituba. Parris, who wrote a neat round hand, stood by for the nonce; he was, however, itching for the assignment."

—STARKEY: *The Devil in Massachusetts*, pp. 39-40

The girls are on a bench facing the court. Back of them the general public packs the room. The hall is tense and silent, except for whispering in the crowd. Outside in the bright noonday a chill March wind wails a devil's song in the eaves.

WHISPERING VOICES:

At last we shall see the witches. This is a great day for Salem—the Devil will be beat. Who is first? Sarah Good. Goody Good.

Everyone knows it must be she.

The afflicted girls. Look at them! Will she dare face them?

They say Constable Braybook had a time, for all his strength, to fetch her here ahorseback from Ipswich this morning. She flung herself from the horse and almost gave him the slip. The Devil is in her, said he, by the strength she has. A wily crone.

[A deadly silence ensues as Sarah Good is brought in by the constables, Samuel Braybook and John Willard, one walking on either side of her with a tight grip of each arm. She holds her head high and walks with something of a swagger. Looking right and left, defiantly, she stands before her judges. Rev. Parris comes up beside the magistrates' table and opens the proceedings with a prayer.]

REV. PARRIS:

Omnipotent and ever-present God . . . On this spot, here in our own meetinghouse, the most momentous crisis in the world's history has on this day come to pass. A crime in comparison with which all other crimes sink out of notice is being notoriously and defiantly committed in our midst. The great enemy of God and man, Beelzebub, has been let loose among us. What has filled the minds and the hearts of mankind for ages, the world over, with dread apprehension has come to pass—and in this village the great battle, on whose issue the preservation of the kingdom of the Lord on the earth is suspended, has begun. Indeed no language, no imagery, no conception of ours can adequately express the feeling of awful and terrible solemnity which overwhelms us all.

Almighty God, we are Thy children. To Thee we come for guidance in our need. Bewildered by the Devil's wiles we stand here, in this court, seeking to bring his foul agents whom he has loosed among us to destruction and rid ourselves in this town of Salem from dread. Bless these children, these afflicted, and give them courage, to tell the truth courageously for to Thee alone our allegiance is given—that Satan's power may be checked and the foul fiend thrown back by their strength to fiery Hell. Amen.

HATHORNE:

Sarah Good, you understand whereof you are charged: viz, to be guilty of sundry acts of witchcraft. What say you to it? Speak the truth—and inasmuch as you are afflicted, you must speak the truth, as you will answer for it before God another day.

SARAH GOOD:

Rev. Parris has prayed for this court. Let him pray for me too.

HATHORNE:

Sarah Good, what evil spirit have you been familiar with?

SARAH GOOD:

None.

"In due time, the 'afflicted children' were brought in; and a scene ensued, such as no person in that crowd or in that generation had ever witnessed before. Immediately on being confronted with the prisoner, and meeting her eye, they fell, as if struck dead, to the floor; or screeched in agony; or went into fearful spasms or convulsive fits; or cried out that they were pricked with pins, pinched, or throttled by invisible hands. They were severally brought up to the prisoner, and, upon touching her person, instantly became calm, quiet, and fully restored to their senses. With one

voice they all declared that Sarah Good had thus tormented them, by her power as a witch in league with the Devil. The truth of this charge, in the effect produced by the malign influence proceeding from her, was thus visible to all eyes. All saw, too, how instantly upon touching her the diabolical effect ceased; the malignant fluid passing back like an electric stream, into the body of the witch. The spectacle was repeated once and again, the acting perfect, and the delusion consummated. The magistrates and all present considered the guilt of the prisoner demonstrated, and regarded her as wilfully and wickedly obstinate in not at once confessing what her eyes, as well as theirs, saw. Her refusal to confess was considered as the highest proof of her guilt. They passed judgement against her, committed her to the marshal, who hurried her to prison, bound her with cords, and loaded her with irons; for it was thought that no ordinary fastenings could hold a witch. Similar proceedings, with suitable variations, were had with Sarah Osburne and Tituba. The confession of the last-named, the immediate relief thereafter of the afflicted children, and the dreadful torments which Tituba herself experienced, on the spot, from the unseen hand of the Devil wreaking vengeance upon her, put the finishing touch to the delusion. The excitement was kept up, and spread far and wide, by the officers and magistrates riding in cavalcade, day after day, to and from the town and village; and by the constables, with their assistants, carrying their manacled prisoners from jail to jail in Ipswich, Salem and Boston."

—UPHAM: *Salem Witchcraft*, Vol. II, pp. 36-7

HATHORNE:

Why do you hurt these children?

SARAH GOOD:

I do not hurt them. I scorn it.

HATHORNE:

Who do you employ then to do it?

SARAH GOOD:

I employ nobody.

HATHORNE:

What creature do you employ then?

SARAH GOOD:

No creature—but I am falsely accused.

HATHORNE:

Have you no contract with the Devil?

SARAH GOOD:

No.

HATHORNE [*to the children*]:

The court, in all kindness, must now ask you . . . Abigail Williams . . . Betty Putnam . . . [*He names all the girls.*] . . . all of you, the afflicted, to look upon this woman and to see if she is the person that hurt you.

THE GIRLS:

Yes, yes, yes!

[*Several of the girls go into fits—to the consternation of all, including Sarah Good. Hathorne turns to the slave, John Indian, who is Tituba's husband.*]

HATHORNE:

John, does she hurt you?

JOHN INDIAN:

Yes—a great many times.

SARAH GOOD:

Oh, you are a grievous liar!

[*The children are all tormented again, acting as if they were being dragged about by an unseen force. After this has passed, the court proceeds.*]

HATHORNE:

You have seen how these children are tormented. How came it about?

SARAH GOOD:

What do I know? You bring others here and now you charge me with it.

HATHORNE:

Who was it, then, that tormented the children?

SARAH GOOD:

It was Tituba.

ABIGAIL:

There is a black man whispering in Good's ear. There is a yellow bird flying around her head.

[Jonathan Corwin, the other magistrate, takes up the interrogation.]

CORWIN:

Abigail Williams, does this woman hurt you?

ABIGAIL:

Yes, many times.

CORWIN:

Does she bring the book to you?

ABIGAIL:

Yes.

CORWIN:

What would she have you do with it?

ABIGAIL:

To write in it and I will be well.

ANN PUTNAM:

Look you! There sits Goody Good upon the beam!

[All look up in amazement at such supernaturalism. The next witness called is Sarah Good's husband—who had abandoned her some years before.]

HATHORNE:

You are Good's husband. What is the reason that you said of her that either she was a witch or would be one very quickly? Have you ever seen anything by her?

GOOD:

No, not in this nature; but it was her bad carriage to me . . . and indeed I may say, with tears, that she is an enemy to all good.

ANN PUTNAM:

It is indeed she who has tortured us, and came to us and did it.

HATHORNE [*standing*]:

Remove this woman from the court. Let her be put in chains—and see that it is well done. And take her into custody to await trial.

[Sarah struggles against the constables, amid threats and crying out. The girls are alert.]

HATHORNE:

Bring in the next prisoner.

[Now bedlam breaks out as Tituba is brought cringing in before her masters.]

“Whatever Good . . . had tried to say had been punctuated by yells and writhing on the part of the girls; still, they had not been excessively tumultuous. But when Tituba was set on the bar above them, they went into a really frightful access of demoniac possession. And indeed the devil in each of them had every reason for terror of what might come out if Tituba confined herself to the facts.

"But Tituba had had some rough handling since Parris's discovery of the episode of the witch cake. Her master had been remorselessly at her to get the truth out of her, and yet the simple truth, so far as Tituba could now piece it together, was exactly what he would not accept. He would listen to no word which reflected discredit on his child whose pitiful outcries even now rang in his ears. When Tituba fell into sullen obduracy, he thrashed her. And he continued to thrash her until the terrified slave hit on the formula that pleased him.

"When Tituba at last had painfully found the 'truth' which would appease her master, she would in no wise depart from it. Thus when the trembling black woman took her place on the terrible eminence before her masters and began to respond to the questions of the magistrates in her own idiom and her slurred, southern voice, a beautiful peace came over the courtroom. The girls, beside themselves at first, became quiet as so many sleeping babes. Not that they were asleep; on the contrary they were hanging with rapt attention on Tituba's every word; for Tituba was 'confessing.' "

—STARKEY: *The Devil in Massachusetts*, pp. 42-3

HATHORNE:

Tituba, you know whereof you are accused—that you have consorted as a witch with evil spirits. What do you answer to the charge?

TITUBA:

No, Mr. Hathorne, worshipful sir. No sir.

HATHORNE:

Tituba, what evil spirit have you been familiar with?

TITUBA:

None.

HATHORNE:

Why do you hurt these children?

TITUBA:

I do not hurt them.

[There is a wild scene. Rev. Parris then stands up and Tituba cringes before him.]

HATHORNE:

Who is it, then?

TITUBA:

The Devil—for aught I know.

HATHORNE:

Did you ever see the Devil?

TITUBA:

The Devil came to me and bid me serve him.

HATHORNE:

Who else have you seen?

TITUBA:

Four women sometimes hurt the children.

HATHORNE:

Who are they?

TITUBA:

Goody Osburne and Sarah Good, and I do not know who the others were. Sarah Good and Osburne would have me hurt the children, but I would not. *[Ann Putnam cries out.]* There was, too, a tall man from Boston that I did see.

HATHORNE:

When did you see them?

TITUBA:

Last night, at Boston.

[*There are exclamations of astonishment that she could have been in Boston and Salem at the same time.*]

HATHORNE:

What did they say to you?

TITUBA:

They said, "Hurt the children."

HATHORNE:

And did you hurt them?

TITUBA:

No. There is four women and one man—they hurt the children. And then they lay all upon me—if I will not hurt the children, they will hurt me.

HATHORNE:

But did you not hurt them?

TITUBA:

Yes—but I will hurt them no more.

[*There are sighs of astonishment and relief in the courtroom.*]

HATHORNE:

Are you not sorry that you did hurt them?

TITUBA:

Yes.

HATHORNE:

And why then do you hurt them?

TITUBA:

They say, "Hurt the children, or we will do worse to you!"

HATHORNE:

What have you seen?

TITUBA:

A man come to me, and say, "Serve me."

HATHORNE:

What service?

TITUBA:

"Hurt the children," and last night there was an appearance that said, "Kill the children," and, if I do not go to hurting the children, they would do worse to me.

HATHORNE:

What is this appearance you see?

TITUBA:

Sometimes it is like a hog, and sometimes like a great dog. I have seen it four times.

HATHORNE:

What did it say to you?

TITUBA:

The black dog said, "Serve me," but I said, "I am afraid." He said if I do not, he would do worse to me.

HATHORNE:

What did you say to it?

TITUBA:

"I will serve you no longer." [*She winces in fear.*] Then he said he would hurt me; and then he looks like a man and threatens to hurt me. He have a yellow bird that he keep with him. He say that he have more pretty things that he would give me, if I would serve him.

HATHORNE:

What are these pretty things?

TITUBA:

He did not show me them.

HATHORNE:

What else have you seen?

TITUBA:

Two cats—a red cat and a black cat.

HATHORNE:

What did they say to you?

TITUBA:

They said, "Serve me."

HATHORNE:

Did you not pinch Elizabeth Hubbard this morning?

TITUBA:

The man brought her to me and made me pinch her.

HATHORNE:

Why did you go to Thomas Putnam's last night, and hurt his child?

TITUBA:

They pull and haul me and make me go.

HATHORNE:

And what would they have you do?

TITUBA:

Kill her with a knife.

HATHORNE:

How did you go?

TITUBA:

We ride upon sticks—and are there presently.

HATHORNE:

Do you go through the trees or over them?

TITUBA:

We see nothing, but are there presently.

HATHORNE:

Why did you not tell your master?

TITUBA:

I was afraid—they said they would cut off my head if I told.

HATHORNE:

What attendants hath Sarah Good?

TITUBA:

A yellow bird, and she would have given me one.

HATHORNE:

What meat did she give it?

TITUBA:

It did suck her between the fingers.

HATHORNE:

What hath Sarah Osburne?

TITUBA:

Yesterday she had a thing with a head like a woman, with two legs and wings.

HATHORNE:

What else have you seen with Osburne?

TITUBA:

Another thing, all over hairy—all the face hairy—and a long nose, and I don't know how to tell how the face looked. It is about two or three feet high, and goeth upright like a man. And, last night it stood before the fire in Mr. Parris's hall.

HATHORNE:

Did you not see Sarah Good upon Elizabeth Hubbard last Saturday?

TITUBA:

I did see her set a wolf upon her to afflict her.

A SALEM WOMAN:

We were with her, and she did indeed complain of a wolf and at another time she did complain of a cat with Good.

HATHORNE:

What clothes doth the man go in?

TITUBA:

He goes in black clothes—a tall man, with white hair, I think.

HATHORNE:

How doth the woman go?

TITUBA:

A black silk hood, and a white silk hood under it, with top knots.

[*The children are tormented again.*]

HATHORNE:

Do you see who it is that torments these children now?

TITUBA:

Yes, it is Goody Good. She hurts them in her own shape.

HATHORNE:

Who is it that hurts them now?

TITUBA:

I am blind now—I cannot see.

[*A hubbub breaks out as the court rests and the magistrates signal to take the woman out. The scene grows dark for a moment. When the lights come up again, the crowd is gone. The magistrates and a few leading citizens are talking together seriously. Of the girls, only Abigail Williams remains, sitting somewhat apart—undisturbed. A physician is speaking.*]

PHYSICIAN:

The girls are suffering from an evil hand—there can be no doubt of that.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Let me try her. Abigail Williams, come here. [*She approaches.*] You are Mr. Parris's niece and live with him?

ABIGAIL:

He is my uncle.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Abigail Williams, I have heard you speak several times of a book that has been offered you. Tell me about this book.

ABIGAIL:

There are two books. One was a short, thick book, and the other was a long book.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Of what color is the book?

ABIGAIL:

As red as blood.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Have you seen it opened?

ABIGAIL:

Yes, I have seen it many times.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Did you see any writing there?

ABIGAIL:

Yes, there were many lines written . . . and at the end of every line there was a seal.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Who brought the book to you?

ABIGAIL:

The black man.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Who is the black man, and what would he have with you?

ABIGAIL:

It was the Devil. He would have me sign the book.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Were you not afraid to see the Devil?

ABIGAIL:

At first I was and did go from him. But now I am not afraid but talk with him as well as I talk with you.

JOSEPH HUTCHINSON:

Thank you, Abigail. You may go home.

[*Abigail goes out, indifferently.*]

PHYSICIAN:

You see, you gained no advantage over her. What else?

BENJAMIN HUTCHINSON:

I was at the ordinary, there across the road, but yesterday. She was there with Mary Walcott, those two. I talked with them. She said she saw a person like George Burroughs.

PHYSICIAN:

George Burroughs!

BENJAMIN HUTCHINSON:

The little black minister that lives in Casco Bay.

A TOWNSMAN:

Indeed he is short and powerful. And black . . . and hairy . . . and a minister.

BENJAMIN HUTCHINSON:

She told me his marvelous feats of strength and said no one could do them but a wizard. She told me that he had killed three wives.

ANOTHER TOWNSMAN:

Indeed three wives have died.

BENJAMIN HUTCHINSON:

"I see him now," she said . . . "Where?" said I . . . "There!" . . . I had an iron fork in my hand and threw it where she said Mr. Burroughs was standing. Instantly she fell into a fit. And when she came out of it, she said, "You have torn

his coat, for I heard it tear." . . . "Whereabouts?" said I . . . "On one side," said she . . . Then we came into the house of Lieutenant Ingersoll and I went into the great room and Abigail came in and said, "There he stands!" . . . "Where, where?" said I, and presently drew my rapier. [*He does so now.*] Then Abigail said, "He has gone out, but there is a gray cat." . . . "Whereabouts?" said I . . . "There! There!" . . . Then I struck with my rapier [*He demonstrates.*] and she fell into a fit.

PHYSICIAN:

A marvelous and supernatural happening.

BENJAMIN HUTCHINSON:

When it was over, she said, "You have killed her!" Sarah Good came in at the moment and carried it away.

A TOWNSMAN:

What?

BENJAMIN HUTCHINSON:

The dead cat. Abigail Williams and Mary Walcott were present. They said that Goody Hobbs of Topsfield had bit Mary Walcott by the foot. Then both fell in a fit. When they came out they cried, "There go William Hobbs and his wife, both of them, along the table!" . . . Instantly I stabbed with my rapier. [*He does so.*] . . . "The room is full of them!" Then Eleazur Putnam and another stabbed with their rapiers at random. The girls cried out that we had killed a great black woman of Stonington and an Indian who has come with her. "The floor is all covered with blood," cried they and rushing to the window described a great company of witches on a hill, saying that three of them lay dead there—the black woman, the Indian and one more they knew not!

ANOTHER TOWNSMAN:

What are we to do in the face of such manifest wonders?
It is the Devil's work.

CORWIN:

What but condemn them to be hung.

REV. PARRIS:

We have but committed them, upon sufficient ground. All have been *per mittimus* sent to the jails. Let the King's courts decide. They must be tried and then hung, all of them, by due process of the law—to rid our world of evil. The men who have sought this far-off nook and corner of the world, crossing the tempestuous and dangerous ocean and landing on the shores of a wilderness, leaving everything however dear and valuable behind, came to this country for themselves and themselves alone to serve God's holy will. Their resolve was inexorable not to suffer dissent or discord to get foothold among them. And they meant to make and keep this country after their own pattern. Let us go forward with the work.

CORWIN:

Let Stoughton be the judge. He is Deputy Governor. He will not quail.

REV. PARRIS:

We shall meet. Amen.

CURTAIN

Scene 2

Salem. The Court of Oyer and Terminer. June 29, 1692. The scene is more or less the same as the preceding except that whereas that was very simple in its appointments, this is more impressive. Room has been made for a greater array

of legal talent. The judges' seats have been raised and a platform somewhat raised above the floor for the witnesses.

"Of the seven judges originally appointed to the Court of Oyer and Terminer (the trial court), only one, Bartholomew Gedney, was from Salem. Of the others, four were from Boston, these being Samuel Sewall, John Richards, William Sergeant, and Wait Winthrop. Nathaniel Saltonstall was from Haverill, and Deputy Governor Stoughton, presiding justice, from Dorchester.

"The clerk of the court, Stephen Sewall, was not only of Salem but was intimately concerned with the witchcraft through the presence in his household of little Betty Parris. Thomas Newton, "gent," sworn in as King's Attorney, was apparently free of any such connections."

—STARKEY: *The Devil in Massachusetts*, p. 149

The scene opens in an uproar. Sara Good is struggling with the constables, who are shackling her with chains. The girls are in fits. Rev. Nicholas Noyes has been questioning Sarah Good. He is fat and plethoric.

REV. NOYES:

The court is ready to pronounce sentence. Sarah Good.

SARAH GOOD:

You lie—I am wronged.

REV. NOYES:

You are a witch and you know you are a witch.

SARAH GOOD:

You are a liar. I am no more a witch than you are a wizard. And if you take away my life, God will give you blood to drink.

[The constables finish binding her and take her out. The girls have noticed that Nathaniel Saltonstall, who has

withdrawn from the proceedings, is absent from the bench. They cry out, "Where is Nathaniel Saltonstall?" There is a stir. The presiding judges seem confused and at a loss to explain. At which the girls and their sympathizers begin to raise a protest. One of them screams and falls down. There is a general cry of: "He is a wizard! Hale him here to answer for it . . . He has abandoned the just cause. Go to his house and take him!" Deputy Governor Stoughton rises and bangs his gavel.]

STOUGHTON:

Cease this silly gabble! Nathaniel Saltonstall is no wizard. He is ill. Bring in the next prisoner.

[Finally, as old Giles Cory is brought in, the hubbub subsides. Cory "stands mute" during all that follows.]

STOUGHTON:

Giles Cory, you know whereof you have been accused. What is your plea? Guilty or not guilty?

[Cory makes no answer. A Salem townsman rises to give testimony.]

TOWNSMAN:

I saw Giles Cory at meeting in Salem on a lecture day—since he has been in prison. He or his apparition came in and sat in the midmost of the men's seats, by the post. And I saw him come out with the rest of the people.

STOUGHTON:

Answer me. Is this true what you hear? Was this your apparition?

[Cory does not reply. The girls are restless and begin to cry out.]

MARY WALCOTT:

A yellow bird is whispering into Cory's ear.

STOUGHTON:

Giles Cory, do you know the penalty if you do not answer when the court demands an answer? Three times you shall be asked to plead guilty or not guilty. If you fail to answer, you shall by force of law suffer the *peine forte et dure*—it shall be squeezed out of you. You shall be put in an apartment and on each of three days be given three morsels of worst bread and to drink of standing water. If still you refuse to plead, you shall have a board laid upon you and on that stones until you talk. Know then the penalty. For the second time, Giles Cory, do you plead guilty or not guilty?

[*Cory does not answer. Pandemonium breaks loose in the courtroom.*]

REV. NOYES [*infuriated*]:

Tie his hands. What! Is it not enough to act witchcraft [*The girls are seized with agony.*] but you must do it in the face of authority? Speak—or you shall be sorry for it.

STOUGHTON:

For the third time, Giles Cory—lest you suffer the *peine forte et dure*—do you plead guilty or not guilty? Answer me.

[*Cory does not open his mouth. Now indeed the people are wild.*]

STOUGHTON:

Take him out.

[*Music is heard—for the first time in this scene—as Cory is taken out. From offstage a man's voice sings.*]

SINGER:

Come all New England men
And harken unto me.
And I will tell you what did befalle
Upon ye gallows tree.

In Salem Village was the place,
As I did heere them saye,
And Goodwyfe Cory was her name
Upon that paynful day.

This Goody Cory was a witch
The people did believe . . .

[The delirium and absurdity of the trials have to be got into this scene—the courageous devoutness of some, the aged dignity of others, the masculine power of Procter, the mob anger, the mad children. Somehow it all has to be worked into a whole—in the manner in which only a musical fantasy can be broken up. Flashes of color, with the iron wills on both sides caught and dazzled by the “wonder” of the whole. As Rev. George Burroughs, one of the victims who was hanged, said in amazement at his own part in it, he a minister of the gospel—“I do not understand but I am overcome by the providence of it.”

The director must break the action up, getting away from rigidity. He must make it show the mass of absurdity—the lack of real evidence, the unfairness of the legal procedures. The music can help to build the picture—a great swirling congeries of themes built upon the Giles Cory ballad.]

SINGER:

There were two pious matron dames
And goodly maidens three
That cryed upon this heynous witch
As you will quickly see.

Goodwyfe Bibber she was one
And Goodwyfe Goodall two,
These were ye afflicted ones
By fyts and pynchings too.

She rent her clothes, she tore her haire,
And loudly she did crye,

"May Christ forgive mine enemies
When I am called to die!"

[Elizabeth Procter is now brought forward, along with her husband, John Procter, at her elbow. They are played by Stella and Mac—now in Puritan costume. John Procter does not shrink from the protection and defense of his wife. He stands by her, a strong, brave, and resolute guardian, trying to support her under the terrible trials of her situation—disregardful of all consequences to himself.]

STOUGHTON:

Elizabeth Procter, you understand whereof you are charged—viz, to be guilty of sundry acts of witchcraft. What say you to it? Speak the truth—and so that you are afflicted, you must speak the truth, as you will answer it before God another day. Mary Walcott, doth this woman hurt you?

MARY:

I never saw her so as to be hurt by her.

STOUGHTON:

Mercy Lewis, does she hurt you?

["Her mouth was stopped."]

Ann Putnam, does she hurt you?

["She could not speak."]

Abigail Williams, does she hurt you?

["Her hand was thrust in her own mouth."]

John Indian, does this woman hurt you?

JOHN INDIAN:

This is the woman that come in her shift and choked me.

STOUGHTON:

Did she bring the book?

JOHN INDIAN:

Yes, sir.

STOUGHTON:

What to do?

JOHN INDIAN:

To write.

STOUGHTON:

What? This woman?

JOHN INDIAN:

Yes, sir.

[*"Abigail Williams and Ann Putnam were spoken to by the court; but neither of them could make any answer, by reason of dumbness or other fits."*]

STOUGHTON:

What do you say, Goody Procter, to these things?

ELIZABETH PROCTER:

I take God in Heaven to be my witness, that I knew nothing of it, no more than the child unborn.

REV. NOYES:

Ann Putnam, does this woman hurt you?

ANN [*recovering her voice*]:

Yes, sir—many times.

REV. NOYES:

She does not bring the book to you, does she?

ANN:

Yes sir, often—and saith she hath made her maid set her hand to it.

REV. NOYES:

Abigail Williams, does this woman hurt you?

ABIGAIL:

Yes, often.

REV. NOYES:

Does she bring the book to you?

ABIGAIL:

Yes.

REV. NOYES:

What would she have you do with it?

ABIGAIL:

To write in it and I shall be well. [*turning to the accused*]
Did you not tell me that your maid had written?

"Goody Procter seems to have been utterly amazed at the conduct and charges of the girls. She knew, of course, that what they said was false; but perhaps she thought them crazy, and therefore objects of pity and compassion, and felt disposed to treat them kindly, and see whether they could not be recalled to their senses, and restored to their better nature: for Parris, in his account, says that at this point she answered the question put to her by Abigail, thus:"

—UPHAM, p. 108

ELIZABETH PROCTER:

Dear child, it is not so. There is another judgement, dear child.

"But kindness was thrown away on them—for Parris says that immediately 'Abigail and Ann had fits.' After coming out of them, 'they cried out, "Look you! There is Goody Procter upon the beam!"' Instantly, as we may well suppose, the whole audience looked where they pointed. Their manner gave assurance that they saw her 'on the beam,' among the rafters of the meeting house; but she was invisible to all other eyes."

—UPHAM, pp. 108-9

JOHN PROCTER [*breaking in*]:

This is preposterous and absurd! There is no bird there—no more than in your minds. Not a word of this is true. Elizabeth, my wife, is no witch but a good woman. Ye have lost your minds. Ye have all lost your minds—men who should know better are gone mad.

ABIGAIL & ANN:

He is a wizard! [*They go into fits of writhing.*]

JOHN PROCTER:

I know not. I am innocent.

[The simulated agonies of the afflicted girls become more severe and the proceedings are interrupted as people crowd around them. From offstage, a man's voice begins to sing the ballad of Giles Cory.]

SINGER:

Giles Cory was a wizard strong,
A stubborn wretch was he,
And fit was he to hang on high
Upon ye locust tree.

[As the singing progresses, a transformation is taking place on the bench and among the persons of the trial. Elizabeth and John Procter have become Stella and Mac. Governor Stoughton changes into Senator Pipeline, Hathorne into Senator Yokell, etc. This process continues—quite openly and in full view of the audience, the actors shedding their Puritan clothes to reveal the modern dress beneath—until we have all the principal figures of the Washington nightclub scene restored. About half of the on-stage audience, however, are still Puritans.]

SINGER:

So when before ye magistrates
For tryall he did come,
He would not true confession make
But was completely dumb.

[A new deep voice picks up the next stanza.]

"Giles Cory," said the magistrate,
"What hast thou here to plead
To those who now accuse thy soul
Of crimes and horrid deed?"

Giles Cory he sayed not a word,
No single word spoke he,
"Giles Cory," sayeth the magistrate,
"We'll press it out of thee."

[The singing stops suddenly when there is a terrible, half-muffled cry from offstage.]

VOICE OF GILES CORY:

More weight! More weight!

SENATOR YOKELL:

Mr. McDee, have you ever been a member of the Communist Party?

[Mac stands mute.]

SENATOR YOKELL:

Are you *now* a member of the Communist Party? Answer yes or no.

MAC:

I refuse to answer.

SENATOR YOKELL:

You realize, Mr. McDee, that you will be held for contempt if you do not reply to my question?

MAC:

I fully realize my position.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Would you care to consult counsel before making your decision final?

MAC:

I have no need of it.

SENATOR YOKELL:

I shall call you again in ten minutes. The court is in recess.

[Senator Yokell leaves the room. As everyone relaxes, a movement is noticeable among the spectators, who become vocal. The disturbance is general. The comments of the spectators make up a "Chorus of Opinion"—what is, in fact, the conscience of the witnesses to the scene, the realization of what is to be remembered and the disturbing consciousness of a doom that may be revealing itself—a doom to the very existence of the country in these scenes, repeated after eight generations, which had been thought to have been buried. Different voices from among the spectators speak in sequence.]

CHORUS:

Strophe

Must this terror be repeated? Is this
the horror of Giles Cory's doom
come to destroy us? The old fate which
we thought to have lived down seems
to have roused again.
We are fearful of the outcome.

Antistrophe

It is late. We thought that crime
had been expiated, that the devil days
would not come again. "Progress," we
said hopefully. But we have been
corrupt, we have fouled our own beds—
a list of our corrupt mayors and
even justices would fill a large book.

[A man's voice, offstage, takes up the next passage. Then the Chorus resumes.]

MAN'S VOICE:

But it was not to be. The rot was at our own hearts in the corruption of our state governments, but especially the governments of our great cities. Philadelphia, Chicago, New York were corrupt. Boston was down. We! We ourselves, who boasted so much of our democracy, were the very ones to blame. We cannot escape the consequences of these things. We had been successful, even generous, God knows. They called us Britain's cow . . . and not much less for others . . . through flood in Japan, earthquake in Chile, famine and plague in India, in China we were the first to bring aid. But we have been despised and hated for it. I say we are to blame. Though the hearts of our people are generous we have permitted a searing corruption to dominate us. We are corrupt through and through—and this is the result of it.

CHORUS:

Look into the minds of these judges.
Look into the minds of those
who are listening to this tragedy.
Do they believe that they
shall pay? No, they hope to escape—
they think they are privileged.

My thoughts are swept away
and I am bewildered. A mother dares not
speak at the railway station
when her son is going away with
the troops. She dares not state aloud
where the guilt lies. He too
will be ashamed.

[The spectators stop speaking as Senator Yokell returns to the bench and raps his gavel for order.]

SENATOR YOKELL:

Next witness.

THE CLERK:

Stella Rajaputsky! [*Stella stands and comes forward.*] Please take the stand.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Miss . . . uh . . .

STELLA:

Rajaputsky.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Miss Rajaputsky. Is that correct? [*Stella signifies that it is.*] What sort of name is that? Is it Russian?

STELLA:

No, sir. It's Polish. My parents are Polish.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Did you ever sign the book?

STELLA:

What do you mean, sir—sign the book?

SENATOR YOKELL:

Do you carry a card? Are you, in other words, a member of the Communist Party?

STELLA:

No, sir.

[*Senator Yokell consults with his colleagues as Stella continues to stand. The clerk motions to her that she may sit down. While the senators whisper together, voices among the spectators speak again.*]

CHORUS:

I fear, I fear the evil which we
dreaded is returning. The subtle fiend
whom we thought to exorcize. Good
men, the best of all, tho' not all,
feared that evil had been let loose
on the land and would undo us,
if his agents were not hunted out.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Miss Rajaputsky, did you ever hear that your friend John McDee, an assistant secretary in the Department of State, as you knew, was an active Communist Party member?

STELLA [*standing again*]:

I never heard it and, if I had, it would not have concerned me, sir. I am a hostess at the National Club and have known Mr. McDee only as one of the club members.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Only . . . ?

STELLA:

He was always kind to me.

[*Again the senators confer together.*]

CHORUS:

I dread what is to ensue.
Now it approaches, the
three-hundred-year-old curse
that has been the scourge of
our country. Oh I fear, I fear.
Intolerance and the whispering
of scandal.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Stella Rajaputsky, did you ever attend a meeting—in an apartment in Baltimore—with Mr. McDee?

STELLA:

No, sir. I never saw Mr. McDee except as a hostess in the National Club.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Have you ever read Karl Marx's *Das Kapital*?

STELLA:

I am a good Catholic. No, sir.

[*There is a disturbance. A man still in Puritan costume stands up and shouts: A papist! An idolator! He is suppressed and ushered out.*]

SENATOR YOKELL:

And yet you had fell designs on this woman in the hospital and hoped in your secret mind that she might die.

STELLA:

What woman? What? What!

SENATOR YOKELL:

This man's wife, while she was in the hospital—in peril of her life—her torment of mind due to her husband's absence in your presence.

STELLA:

I tormented her? You must be crazy. I tried to *help* her. This man, as you call him, was . . . Oh, that's too much.

SENATOR YOKELL:

While she was in the hospital giving birth to twins, you were consorting at the National Club with this man to whom she is married.

STELLA:

Oh, what a lie . . . Mac, tell them . . .

[*Mac rises and starts to speak, but is silenced.*]

SENATOR YOKELL:

You cannot deny that this woman suffered grievously and that you were the instrument in denying her her husband's comfort, solace and support in her extremity. He could not be found—until he turned up in your presence.

MAC:

I can explain.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Just a moment, sir. [*to Stella*] You cannot deny that at such a time a man's wife has dire need of him and that this man

could not be found. Furthermore, that as a consequence of your misdeeds his children were born dead—as you desired.

STELLA [*trying to master herself*]:

Are both dead? [*She stands, swaying, and grasps the back of a chair.*]

MAC:

This is not a court of law! I insist that you hear me. I did not know that my wife was in labor. The children were *not* born dead but died only after everything known to science was done to save them. This woman, as you call her, even offered her own blood for a transfusion . . . if you must know it.

[*Stella faints and falls with a crash. The scene becomes confused.*]

CHORUS:

Look how she faints, look how
her limbs twitch and her eyes roll.
The past repeats itself. Oh what
is here foretold! The time is late.
We thought our evil days were done.

[*Noyes, still in Puritan costume, comes forward and takes up the interrogation from Senator Yokell.*]

NOYES [*to Mac*]:

You killed your children and threatened your wife's life that you might have this woman.

[*Abigail Williams and a demon appear.*]

MAC:

That's a lie! [*He now paraphrases parts of John Procter's Salem speech.*] These reports, these newspapers, these slanted columns, these people all of them if left alone will make witches of us all. "The handling of these trials leaves

the lives of innocent people to the pleasure and the passions of those who are minded to take them away."

NOYES:

Do you persist in denying that you were with this woman while your wife was in labor?

MAC:

No, but . . . I didn't know. It was unexpected.

NOYES:

You acknowledge it, then? You were found in this woman's company.

MAC:

She was kind to me. There were other reasons.

NOYES:

What other reasons?

MAC:

I didn't want to distress my wife at such a time. There was no one I could talk to.

NOYES:

About what? Oh, McDee! Confess that you were in the pay of the Soviet Government, that you carried a card and that you obtained a passport to Moscow under false pretences.

MAC:

Even if it were true, that is not a crime. Many others have done the same to travel incognito . . . but I did not.

NOYES:

Confess, or the law must take its course. Why should you go to Russia more than to Hell, if you were honest?

MAC:

I know many Russians. They're fine people. I know one old woman—round as a barrel, with her hair pulled back into a bun on her occiput . . .

NOYES:

What's that? Is it clean?

MAC:

What?

NOYES:

Occiput. Is it a mark?

MAC [*angrily*]:

Bah! A woman who says "Shut up!" to her granddaughter and slaps her across the mouth—to make her laugh out loud . . . so hard, across the mouth it makes her laugh. That's how much it hurts. A wonderful old woman . . . [*Noyes rises to interrupt him.*]

NOYES [*angrily*]:

Would you be trivial? Do you mean to trifle in this matter of life and death . . . [*Noyes has a seizure—grasps at his head and falls headlong. Mac is the first to get to him.*]

CHORUS:

Another has died, choking
in his blood, as Sarah Good
had threatened.

"If you send me to my death,
God will choke you in your
blood."

[*After Noyes has been carried out and the disturbance has somewhat abated, order is restored and Senator Yokell takes over.*]

SENATOR YOKELL:

Mr. McDee, before we adjourn our proceedings . . . under these tragic circumstances . . . I should like to terminate this phase of them. Therefore, and since you are acting as your own counsel and have refused to testify in the essential matter that concerns us, we shall at this point permit

you to enter what plea you wish to make why you should not be held in contempt.

MAC:

May I speak freely?

SENATOR YOKELL:

As you please.

MAC:

Thank you for your consideration. I am a liberal—a thing apparently anathema to you gentlemen. If the history were known, I'd say that I am one of those who would support Hugh Peters when he preached before Parliament in our early days: "Why," said he, "cannot Christians differ, and yet be friends? All children should be fed, though they have different faces and shapes—unity not uniformity is the Christian word."

CHORUS:

Though we speak big words,
though on holidays schoolchildren
read patriotic addresses—

but none believes . . .

We are shamefaced before the
responses. Our lives are not
worthy. We say one thing but do
another, not believing
that an agony may well overtake
us in our small minds,
that it may take shapes that
we may not always succeed . . .

MAC:

Based upon liberal thought, there was a time when it looked as though democracy was about to sweep the world. Sun Yat Sen was dominant in China. Mexico had thrown off Diaz. Bryce had written his *Commonwealth of Nations*.

And Russia was beginning to awaken from her long sleep. A man's mind could stand up. I deplore, indeed, the very need to speak of a liberal as either innocent or not innocent. He is neither. There should be no such confusion among them. There never was before the Communist revolution. A liberal was simply a liberal—it was quite enough to be.

CHORUS:

My thoughts are swept away and
I go bewildered. Where shall
I turn the brain's wheel to carry me
to the truth? Blood rain is
falling.

MAC:

I am a liberal. I am no Communist, nor am I a totalitarian in any sense. But I say we cannot save ourselves by being like them in our political thinking and practices, in brutally forcing compliance from any one whom we wish to force into line. Our policy of ostracising ex-reds—if I were one—is wrong. All we do is to drive the Party underground. Ostracism helps the Communists, plays into their hands. Their duplicity should be exposed, their trickery unmasked—but democracy can win only in the open. Do not drive them underground. Expose, not suppress them.

CHORUS:

It is useless. You cannot divert
the doom which the blood of brother
and brother has brought upon us.
Some day we shall be wiser.

MAC:

I demand that there be no public accusations without proper legal evidence. And even where this evidence is presented, I call as much attention to the political motives of the accuser as of the accused. I do not make the mistake

of believing that just because the wrong people are looking for Soviet agents in the American government, that there are none. I do not deceive myself that whoever is thus named is *ipso facto* an innocent liberal.

SENATOR YOKELL:

Have you finished, sir?

MAC:

I have.

SENATOR YOKELL:

You will be indicted, Mr. McDee, for contempt and placed under arrest. This hearing is closed.

[*People begin to leave the room, picking up of documents, etc., as one of the men in Puritan costume sings the epode:*]

SINGER:

"Giles Cory," said the magistrate,
 "What hast thou here to pleade
 To those who now accuse thy soul
 Of crimes and horrid deed?"

Giles Cory he sayd not a word,
 No single word spoke he,
 "Giles Cory," sayeth the magistrate,
 "We'll press it out of thee."

They got them then a good wide board,
 They layd it on his breast,
 They loaded it with heavy stones
 And hard upon him prest.

"More weight," now says the wretched man,
 "More weight," again he cried,
 And he did not confession make
 But wretchedly he dyed.

Dame Cory lived but six days more,
But six days more lived she,
For she was hung at Gallows Hill
Upon ye locust tree.

*[The last of the assembly are leaving as the room is
being darkened.]*

CURTAIN

The First President

Libretto for an Opera (and Ballet)

CHARACTERS

GEORGE WASHINGTON

MARTHA WASHINGTON

BENEDICT ARNOLD

MRS. ARNOLD

COLONEL ALEXANDER HAMILTON

GENERAL GATES

COLONEL BROOKS

AN OFFICER

GARRY, an old man.

JONES

MOORE

GRAYSON

MEADE

HARRISON

} Young officers of the American Army.

GENERAL LEE

FITZGERALD, General Lee's aide.

A SENTRY

THE SNOW MAIDENS

THEIR QUEEN

BRITISH SOLDIERS

} Dancers in the ballet.

GREENE, a staff officer.

GENERAL HENRY KNOX, later Secretary of War.

CHANCELLOR ROBERT LIVINGSTON

LEAR, Washington's secretary.

DOLL, a Negro girl.

NELLY CUSTIS

CITIZEN GENÊT, Emissary from France.

THOMAS JEFFERSON, Secretary of State.

EDMUND RANDOLPH, Attorney General.

Officers and soldiers of the American Army. Townsmen in the inn at Englishtown. Citizens of New York and Philadelphia. Chorus.

INTRODUCTION FOR THE COMPOSER:
AN OCCASION FOR MUSIC

To project the figure of Geo. Washington across the panorama of American History so that it would galvanize us into a realization of what we are today would require a tremendous music. His is the only figure of sufficient depth of character and universality of genius which we as Americans could present for such treatment. But unless we can do that we must remain mere legless men. Upon what do we stand? Have we a history at all? Certainly we should have had a very different one had not Washington passionately defended it in his powerful imagination.

It was an imaginary republic he created and defended with a very real army, as a servant of the people. It was a country he pasted together—a good deal out of shoddy—to represent the thing we still labor to perfect. His labors and our labors are the same, granted differences and varieties in the tensions involved. Could we know, deeply, what he faced and performed we should be the better able to realize what we have still to do—and what we are.

But it is impossible to know what, precisely, Washington thought and felt. We can only create him in our own image. Yet he must not violate what we feel to have been true of him. We can't have him stomping about a stage and singing arias toward the footlights. That would be unlike him. We are sure of that.

Yet music and the imagination are the keys. They open to a common world into which both history and the present can step on an equal footing of basic agreement. There the figure of Geo. Washington can join us with advice—a realization for us of his performance and its significances.

A first difficulty is that people think the man to have been stolid—a cold rod of no subtlety of interest, certainly

no emotional appeal. He worked, he married and he died. He was indeed a voluminous writer, one of the world's most prolific writers. But his exterior was frigid. He spoke, it is commonly believed, seldom and formally. What in the world, retaining his obvious vitality, can you do with a character like that?

Music must be the answer. The character creates a music—it must have created a music for its escape. A music accompanying action. It is a music to be uncovered by action, to be discovered and translated to our world of today. It was a music which Washington must constantly have felt from the beginning to the end of his life within the secrecy of his shuttling thoughts. It is a music which must be sought, borne upon which only can he affect us. His taciturnity might come out in poetic drama but there is no poetic drama today. All attempts to lodge him there must push him back into a turgid history which dulls us, defeats its purpose. It dates him, binds him. It deals with the past. He becomes at once of the past.

But music, created out of the identity of our interests, makes him of today. He becomes a contemporary in the inventions which prove our souls, in a common setting, to be the same as his. With it we mingle with him. Without it we remain apart and considerably bored.

A grand opera which would be based on Washington's struggle toward realization of a world that is new and free might distil from his character a powerful element. It would have to be, as well, a contemporary element resting its weight fairly in the things which Washington rested in. He cannot become a real figure and remain wholly in his own day. He must be musically conceived; that is, essentially liberated from the confinements of his particular actions. He must go up and we alongside him into the imagination to which music is a natural language.

How to keep recognizable features of an historical character, his local significance, and still make of him a fit

figure for the universality which music can treat? Shakespeare did it for man and woman. But he did it in an accepted convention of his day. In this case, since the times will not permit the same wordiness, a greater stringency must be resorted to. Opera offers its effects, a convention still more remote than Elizabethan drama. For opera has a primitive side to it related to the sagas. Group singing is tribal. It must have had Greek tragedy as a child. That is the mood of grand opera as sought here. It is a convention which, if accepted, will permit the freedom of movement necessary to the play of the forces involved. It can report history exactly while draining it of its essence by substituting music for a coarser time.

Practically, reality, or the odor of it, is still further broken by laying the whole action in a world which is familiar and which yet permits liberties—the dream, the mind casting backward over things past. The world of recollection is real. The mind of Washington, which knows its own history, is seen doubling back upon itself at a moment of overwhelming importance—the moment, in later life, when Washington is going up for the presidency.

No one could call this a pageant. No one could say there was not a plot. It is the moment of fruition of the man's life. His whole life has contributed to it. He dislikes his fate, he has fought it. But against his desire for retirement, for peace, for pastoral exercises which must have released his private mind upon itself—he must go. He is compelled to it, tragically, to serve—again.

The plot cannot be a superficial playing with emotion, some stupid dawdling with this or that. The plot enforces itself beyond that. It is the destiny of a man following his fate among a distraught, conglomerate people, bent upon being themselves, whose great word, "freedom," has infected him as well.

It is definitely a function, and should be the chief burden of the music to express this. There is no other way in

which it can be expressed. A movie wouldn't express it. It would miss it. It couldn't make the tragedy apparent since the photographic reality of the scenes would be constantly in the way. The tragedy is not for the most part in what the protagonist is doing; it is over all he does, it encloses him, it trips and turns him about. It must be the music. It must be an opera. A grand opera. The music must move toward the inevitable end of all love—to rest.

Well-chosen scenes appear in sequence, revealing the man struggling against unfaithfulness, incompetency—resigning all desire for self to win for the others and with the others a liberty which, if it were possible, he might have enjoyed like a supreme savage. Washington was a primitive more than any about him in his resources of fierce energy but he kept it under heavy check his life long, subdued by an oppressive destiny.

As Gilbert Stuart said of him, much to Martha's distaste, Washington was a man of violent temper—under almost perfect control, he had to add, to appease her. And the very ones he had most tormented his life to serve harassed him most in the end—though they were in awe of him—so that his whole thought came to center about a final return to Mt. Vernon, his “vine and fig tree.”

Scene after scene might be used. But this is governed by the convention of a musical performance which should not go beyond a hundred minutes. Many scenes might serve to reveal the situation as it existed, but that would not be for opera. I should suggest that it begin with personal betrayals, stand upon the faithful namelessness of common men who worshipped Washington and end with the furies and uncertainties of office, largely frustrated, softened by a note of happy retirement.

II

There is no other way than music. With recollection taking the action immediately clear of a preconceived notion of

plodding fact—the mere historicity of events—an audience will be liberated to follow something else. It will *look for* the *meaning*, in a nonsequence, automatically. And this disembodied drama the music must enforce; it is the music. By this the plot is made, using the facts, and the externality of events will flexibly conform to the actuality, the underlying music of conviction, which was the motive force in Washington.

Nothing but music can do this with a sufficient feeling of inevitability. That should be grand opera. That should be the fullest development of opera. This is not, as in Wagner, a blending of the arts of poetry, design and music. It is music only, to which design and the words add, as it were, the catgut of the strings to the violins. The music plays on them but orders them absolutely.

In this way it doesn't much matter what particular scenes are chosen so that they serve the music. Time sequence is abolished and place sequence, as in a dream, can be put aside.

There is an inevitability of strange proportions that seems to have preordained that there be an American opera and that its first theme be this theme; the character, the subdued but terrifically effective character, of Washington could be released in no other way. And it is a force which cries to be released, insistently, as if it would brook no denial. It is very definitely an Occasion for Music. Save in the silences of the original actions of his life, only music can reveal the man liberated from the events which imprisoned him, above which he stood—and to be seen again must again be made to stand clear.

The plot is Washington's life. It is not his youth or his old age. Also it is not and cannot be some one incident judged to have been dramatic. No life as great as his had as little of the externally dramatic about it. To invent a theme, an operatic theme, of whatever sort—revenge, love, persecution, ambition or lyric fancy—on which to string the

man would be fatal. It would at once falsify the true theme which is the inner drama of his life.

It may be argued then that grand opera is not the medium by which the man should be presented—that if the form of opera is to be respected and, more important, if the finished work is to be accepted and performed, one must have some conventional and easily recognizable plot to hang it on. The only answer is that by long acceptance grand opera has become threadbare. It is precisely for that reason that they say, "If grand opera is to survive, it must look to America for its rekindling." Etc. etc. It is the falsity of the usual libretto that makes opera impossible and enforces stupidity on the music. It seeks to bind the music as music is not bound in the symphony and can never be bound if it is to reach its highest effectiveness. With music limited by the conventional libretto only triteness can result.

Here the theme of Washington is perfect to the purpose. It enforces an opera that will *not be* superficially plottable. It makes it absolutely compulsory that the libretto be treated in a more thoroughgoing and liberal way, that the libretto serve only as a very flexible rack for the music. The character of Washington itself, in this case, forms the libretto, forms the nature of the word-music relationship. A revolutionary relationship. The inner character creates the necessity for the opera being like none heretofore composed. It makes it unavoidable that an opera be produced, that it be precisely this opera, and that it be an invention, the mark of a new perception celebrated. No word-music anachronism, but that it adopt the symphonic appeal of pure music raised to a pitch which will include word and scenic effects.

Or (since the work has not yet been created) if the present operatic convention should be considered inviolable, then this particular problem must be aimed to broaden and at the same time particularize (to Washington's image) that convention. The thing that created Washington and made

him taciturn but inwardly flaming, that gave his life a fragmentary surface but a tremendous continuity and singleness of purpose, must give the thing he appears to have created, such a work as this, its actuality.

The man moves, not through the scenes as in a pageant—this is not a pageant. He himself moves the scenes, as revealed by the music, and to a fixed end, relentlessly. The genius, rather, that moves him is seen operative in every scene and always the same—power in leash, selflessly, for a common purpose of freedom.

Other scenes may be chosen, but if no better ones can be found, these hereinafter summarized hold the essentials.

Act I. Washington begins alone, in middle life, toward morning, with his wife and protector, Martha, by his side. Rather than to take a sequence of scenes having no motive force, the man, freshly wakened from a troubled sleep, feels the scenes grow more and more profound as in the receding depths of his imagination he dwells upon them, prodding his reality in that state of half sleep, half wakefulness in which play very frequently the half-formed preludes to a great event. Time and place melt together and the *thing* which he questions comes more and more forward as the music progresses.

At first it is the grosser obstructions of his life which appear to him in this susceptible and suggestive state. As he admired the headlong dash of Benedict Arnold, so he saw himself, in that character, as he would like to have lived had he not been burdened with something else more powerful, deeper in the depths. Arnold represented to him a life of courage and dashing execution such as he himself might have lived—and didn't. He loved Arnold therefore. He trusted him, gave him honors and believed in him (as he would not have believed in himself, could not have believed in himself, had he permitted himself to be like Arnold). And Arnold, unbalanced, deceived everyone. In Arnold's defeat Washington saw, bitterly, not only a trust betrayed.

He saw something he admired in the dirt. Though it strengthened him deeply in himself to witness this, yet it made him more silent. "Whom can we trust now?"

Then, at Newburgh—having refused everything for himself, even possibly a crown—with the power wholly in his own hands he sees all his trusted aides plotting, not against him—that he could grasp—but to destroy the thing, the liberty, the Congress, representing the people, the living symbol of all that he had given his life so freely to perpetuate. That was beyond him. They could feel no burden such as his. They could go free. They could seize the government, ignoring the supposedly expressed will of the people, the men, women and children, of whom Washington said feelingly one night in Connecticut, "These are the ones they will never conquer." But their leader was tied. It is the revelations which the acts of others cast inward upon himself, the liberty of action which they enjoy and he craves, bringing others to degradation—if almost justifiable degradation—in his eyes, which ripened his soul. And he must block what he sees them attempting. He rises and stops them from going on. They might have gone on, but he has deep within himself that which refuses to be liberated.

Act II. Now he rises in his wrath and crushes another who disobeys. Lee defied his orders at Monmouth, and Washington caught him neatly in the act. A devastating fury, out of all reasonable control, fell upon Lee. The incident has become legendary. Such an action as Lee had permitted himself once more passed beyond the boundaries of Washington's comprehension. And yet the fury of his own life, biting upon itself, is revealed in Washington's consuming wrath at Lee. But whether in proportion or out, the overpowering anger which caused Washington as a boy to kill a horse in attempting to break him asserted itself. Old Lord Fairfax had told him then that he must learn to control his temper if he would succeed in life. But this time

it boiled over in spite of him. The dormant fury of a volcano cannot be self-contained forever.

It is impossible to show this moment as it occurred. First of all, the men were on horseback, at a crossroads in the middle of a battle. But that aside, the emphasis would be overpowering and out of all proportion to the balance of effects desired. It would throw the whole construction out of scale. So Washington's anger is reported in a narration of the incident by a young officer.

Just preceding this, at the Englishtown Inn, where soldiers and civilians have gathered the evening of the battle, the usual draft-dodger, a specimen of the common man, an unreasoning devotion to whom has been the fatal depth of Washington's character, appears for the first time—with tardy advice. A fellow, drunk, silly, boastful—a buffalo. This would be a happy solution, too, to a fated man's compulsions. If a man could thus release himself—a fool, acting the fool according to his nature.

But this is only a corner of the picture. The common man warmly reciprocated Washington's devotion to him with a love equally as strong. During the suffering of Valley Forge Washington comes face to face with this common good in the shape of a devoted soldiery. It is typified by the outpost who suffers with his feet in his hat to keep them from freezing. And those bleeding feet are the hint for the climax of the drama.

In this suffering soldiery Washington feels himself justified. He is happy. And of this happiness (tempered with tragedy) the ballet is made. It is the imagination of one of the common soldiers for the only President who ever danced through every dance at his own inaugural—the man who once danced consecutively for three hours with the wife of General Greene. The snow falls. There is dancing—the soldier recognizes Washington dancing! This is the peak of the action. The pinnacle of the feeling.

Act III. The catastrophe begins with the inauguration of the first President. Washington is unwilling, he fears the futility of his acts. They have served only to elevate him where he has no wish to be—to a position which he detests. He sees revealed the farce of his position while realizing that he is imprisoned by a fate which drives him to action. He must still obey. And he, weak at the knees, stands and gives way. He is made President. No influence of family or friend will he permit to sway his judgments. Every pleasure of office he puritanically denies himself. He strips himself bare to be the sacrifice of his fated purpose. It is fact that from the day of his coming of age he spent, unwillingly, forty of the ensuing forty-seven years in office.

And the crowd, when he most serves them, playing for moderation, for peace with England, to save them from an emotional sacrifice to France—the crowd, wanting to back the French in their own revolution (*Liberté, Egalité, Fraternité!*) to challenge England again, parades the streets, ready to drag him from the Executive Mansion and hang him! Officed in caution, he refuses to comply with their demands. They howl their derision outside his window. They throw stones.

At the same time he defeats them, for they love him at heart. They come around to agreement with his way of thinking. They allow him lovingly to deceive them, to take away from them their government, under the nose of Jefferson, for their own good. He speaks his farewell words of peace and caution. And retires to his home, an old man.

Martha takes him to herself again for a few years. And so the cycle is completed.

III

This, powerfully, overwhelmingly, is the dramatic life of Washington, unapparent among the details of his daily trafficking. It moved under that, contrapuntally, a hidden

crashing and melody which the events of the day served only to punctuate. This is the music. This also is the drama. It is elusive. But if it were not there, how could the man have emerged from his continual failures of performance and still retain in his own person a whole synthesis of his time? He carried through between the stops of his career on his own strength. And finally those about him saw that it was he alone that linked up the stops of the time into a meaning.

His was the meaning that wrested the fragments of events into a whole. It is proof of the real drama underlying Washington's outward actions that he overcame crushing defeats, events that decimated his army, starved and froze them, with an always greater power. Men looked at him puzzled. Jefferson complained that the people followed him without thought—in the end. Mobs see like dogs in the dark. They saw the inextinguishable democracy which was the man himself, one such as they.

But within himself it was still a bitter struggle—elements of tragedy that moved relentlessly, hemming him round.

It is in the second act that the real villain of the movement is introduced, Demos, in the person of the townsman at the inn at Englishtown after Monmouth. *He* knew! In the general fatigue and satisfaction, *he* could sing.

Should Washington's romantic love, the unrelinquished, unquestionable abandonment of his affections to Sally Fairfax, the wife of his best friend and neighbor, be made the theme of the opera? Certainly not. That it was a mark of his disposition toward that "destiny which has control of our action not to be resisted by the strongest efforts of Human Nature" is undeniable. But his fixity in this love, as in all the positive movements of his career, cannot be other than an outward reflection of the deep trickling waters. It is an externality only. And in this case it is inessential. It lies there with the rest to be taken up or left to lie. It can be left to lie there because other events show the same thing

in a more amenable form. To make the love for Sally Fairfax a determining element in the unrolling of his destiny and character would be to mistake the branch for the root.

"At this period, rich as it was, the word which appears most frequently in his diary is *alone*. He would travel untiringly from one of his farms to another, from a gathering of the Burgesses to a meeting of stockholders, from a watering place to a distant plantation, moving constantly over his land of Virginia which he knew so well, and over which he went always . . . *alone*; or he would shut himself up *alone* in his study to write his interminable business letters to England or to his comrades-in-arms; or he would simply remain there *alone* to think and dream." He noted in his diary sometimes during a whole week that he remained at home *alone* although Martha was living under the same roof and in the same house.

"Washington armed himself with solitude and silence against the lures of dangerous delights and a wasting sorrow, 'the silence which so often speaks more clearly than eloquence.' The glory and joy of the 18th Century was in writing—the confessions of Voltaire, Rousseau, Franklin, Frederick the Great, etc. Washington, on the contrary, saved his life and enjoyed it only because he kept it within himself, hidden, concentrated, repressed, inexpressible."

It was a music to him.

This is the opportunity: Music, music, music—all his days. Dancing and listening, through a stolid exterior, to the inner movements of his change. It is a theme purely for music, so that between the music and its prey, nothing! No crass, misinterpretable play must be allowed to intervene. His life was made for this.

With Washington every pitched battle was lost before it was fought—except one. With an army of militia and recruits changed every three months it was impossible to struggle against the finest army of regulars in the world. Washington had no illusions on the subject and wrote about

it in his letters with a violence which sometimes bordered on frenzy. Any genius less great than his would have abandoned the struggle without waiting longer (after the New York campaign). But he was used to hoping against hope, his will never yielded, and his perfectly lucid mind showed him the reason for his defeats *but also* the elements of a possible victory.

"We shall be obliged to detach one half of the army to bring back the other." The army was Washington's own possession. It had but one leader (finally), one soul. It lived, the only permanent body among a disorganized, doubting people. And it came to be a symbol of national unity.

He wanted a peaceful existence; he wanted silence and obscurity. "But of all the problems that worried him, the one that lay the heaviest upon him and irritated him the most persistently was the question of politics. He had been forced during the Revolution to act the part of a great leader and a benevolent dictator, there was no escape. It was the only way in which he could fulfill his task as Commander-in-Chief and he accomplished this task with as much skill as loathing. He was used to living in his Virginia environment, where he talked with everybody, rich and poor, and he was very sensitive to every slight change of public opinion, as are sometimes violent and nervous people who are habitually silent." "He would not have been able to explain this himself any more than could the others with whom he talked, but the fact was that he always shared the popular feeling of the people of the region in which he was living, and he always realized what were the interests at stake. He led men, not because he had a bold and original mind, not because he had the gift of words, not because of his ideas, not because he was capable of conceiving large plans, but because he carried in himself the same real needs as those who surrounded him and translated them into action more quickly and more energetically than the others."

IV

They elected him as the first President of the United States of America. With fear and trembling he prepared to go. Before going he noted in his diary:

"April 16—About 10 o'clock I bade adieu to Mount Vernon, to private life, and to domestic felicity, and with a mind oppressed with more anxious and painful sensations than I have words to express, set out for New York in company with Mr. Thompson and Colo. Humphreys, with the best disposition to render service to my country in obedience to its calls, but with less hope of answering its expectations."

The day of his inauguration (Act III) he was ashy pale. The first time he spoke to the Senate, his hands trembled so violently he could scarcely find his spectacles. (The group who put him into power wanted a strong federal government.)

He dreamed of his country night and day. He worked for America body and soul. He all but killed himself. He had one illness after another.

In the Cabinet, with Jefferson and Hamilton quarrelling daily, one pulling toward a broader democracy, the other to a stronger federalization of power, a new factor entered. The French Revolution was in progress and Citizen Genêt—though Washington had published a proclamation of neutrality as between France and England—arrived and began to foster trouble. He wanted us to declare for France, and the people were with him. Washington wanted peace. Genêt arrived at Charleston and travelled from there to Philadelphia with great ostentation, arousing enthusiasm wherever he went—inciting the people against the English.

Nothing could have annoyed Washington more.

Jefferson was instructed to tell him (Genêt) that he had come at the wrong time. Genêt replied disdainfully. To

him Washington was an old man, eminent, no doubt, but a man who had seen his day.

In the cities there were poor, nervous immigrants recently arrived from Ireland, France, Germany and the West Indies and all the regions where there was an economic crisis and political disorder.

Genêt, in spite of his faults, had a good idea. He organized these disaffected and heterogeneous elements. Genêt the orator, rose against Washington. He spoke insolently and menacingly.

His triumph did not last long. Washington put him in his place and Genêt was intimidated. The popular societies, however, remained. The newspapers were interested in them. And Jefferson undoubtedly had some connection with them.

After the Whisky Rebellion and Jefferson's retirement a violent press campaign commenced against Washington.

The Jay Treaty roused the country to fury against him.¹ He was surprised but not shaken. The treaty was bad but it guaranteed the West to America, that was enough. But Washington by his sheer obstinate silence imposed his will on the people and signed the treaty.

He refused to accept the presidency a third time.

He returned to Mt. Vernon, March 16th, 1797, and wrote in his diary, as in former times, "At home all day alone. Wind at East and very cloudy all day."

"An old gentleman riding alone in plain, drab clothes, a broad-brimmed white hat, a hickory switch in his hand, and carrying an umbrella with a long staff which is attached to his saddle-bow."²

He had much trouble justifying to himself "Demos," whose vagaries were so annoying.

¹ See S. F. Bemis: *Jay's Treaty*, Macmillan, New York, 1924.

² George Washington Parke Custis: *Recollections*, 1860, p. 168.

Jefferson and Hamilton: Washington in a fury. Jefferson retires and Hamilton remains victorious.

Twice during Washington's term he was forced to act counter to public sentiment. The first time was when a strenuous attempt was made by the French Minister to break through the neutrality which had been proclaimed, when, according to John Adams, "ten thousand people in the streets of Philadelphia, day after day, threatened to drag Washington out of his house, and effect a revolution in the government, to compel it to declare in favor of the French Revolution and against England."³ The second time was when he signed the treaty of 1795 with Great Britain, which produced a popular outburst from one end of the country to the other. In neither case did Washington swerve one iota from what he thought right, writing, "These are unpleasant things, but they must be met with firmness." Eventually the people always came back to their leader, and Jefferson sighed over the fact that "such is the popularity of the President that the people will support him in whatever he will do or will not do, without appealing to their own reason or to anything but their feelings toward him."

Lafayette sent him the key to the Bastille; Paine, in enclosing it in a letter, said, "When he mentioned to me the present he intended you, my heart leaped for joy. It is something so truly in character, that no remarks can illustrate it, and is more happily expressive of his remembrance of his American friends than any letter can convey. That the principles of America opened the Bastille is not to be doubted, and therefore the key comes to the right place." Washington considered the key curiously, toyed with it a moment, and then put it in his pocket.

Jefferson remarked that the President, often tired and always finding it difficult to express himself, relied more and

³ See Paul Leicester Ford: *The True George Washington*, Lippincott, Philadelphia, 1898, p. 304.

more on this young colonel-lawyer-financier (Hamilton) who was so lucid and so eloquent.

v

The real theme, the music, is love right enough. It is a love music but a transference of the self-love to the mob, to the common, to the people. It is clear and definite in Washington's case, a love that rather than suffer itself to be wholly thwarted enlarged itself to spread over a great area and to a great depth.

Sally Fairfax may have been its constant object but the field of action was not in her. Had she been capable of boldly breaking through convention—either they would have become a contented Virginia couple, living nameless lives—or she might then rightfully have come to be the heroine of a great romantic drama. But this did not happen. She denied herself that right. Therefore she removed herself from being named. The action took place in general affairs, in wars and in politics, and there it belongs.

Late in life, when Sally was an impoverished widow living in London (who had kept all his letters to her, though he did not know it), she wrote to him and he answered her: "Nothing," he said, "has ever been able to eradicate from my mind the recollection of those happy moments, the happiest of my life, which I have enjoyed in your company."

Thus *only* in the music can the power of the theme be expressed; but only by knowing the intricacies of the task growing in the single power of the historical can the music be made.

The wealthiest man in the colonies, the most successful, most important and the most richly deserving, Washington had been all his life used to defeat—so that it never surprised him and out of it he built his genius.

SYNOPSIS

ACT I

- SCENE 1. *A bedroom at Mt. Vernon. Early morning, the day of Washington's departure for New York to be inaugurated as first President of the United States.*
- SCENE 2. *Before the Robinson House, Benedict Arnold's residence across the Hudson from West Point. Full summer. The Imaginary Figure of Washington appears among the trees above the usual plane of action.*
- SCENE 3. *The "New Building" at Newburgh, N. Y. A meeting of the General Staff to discuss means for bringing Congress to terms.*

ACT II

- SCENE 1. *The taproom of the inn at Englishtown, N. J. The evening of the battle of Monmouth. A town character gives his views. A young officer describes Washington's encounter with Lee.*
- SCENE 2. (Ballet) *The camp at Valley Forge. A common soldier, on sentry duty, dozes for a moment in a snowstorm.*
- SCENE 3. *The same. Later. Washington and his "family" return depressed from a tour of inspection. He speaks of resigning his commission.*

ACT III

- SCENE 1. *Inside the balcony of the Federal Building in New York, looking out over the crowd. The inaugura-*

tion of Geo. Washington as first President of the United States.

SCENE 2. *An office in the Executive Mansion, Philadelphia. Popular protest against the decisions of the Executive. The Cabinet is split between Hamilton and Jefferson. Citizen Genêt appears.*

SCENE 3. *A bedroom at Mt. Vernon—as in the first scene of Act I. Formal chorus. Farewell. Martha again takes charge.*

ACT I

Scene 1

Throughout this scene the properties are never very clear, existing rather as the state between waking and dream. As much as can be discovered is a bedroom at Mt. Vernon. There is a small lamp burning by the bed. The figure of a woman, in gown and slippers, moves carefully about. She goes to the fireplace, lights a candle with a taper, is about to leave the room, but stops first at a window, on the right, and draws the curtain to look out. It is a clear night.

Washington turns in bed and looks at the clock. He is startled, as though he had overslept. Martha puts the candle down on a small table near where she is standing.

MARTHA:

Hours till morning, you must sleep again.

[Washington gets up and half-consciously turns out the small lamp, as though it were time to be about—leaving only the candle by the window for light. At first Martha has moved impulsively toward him, but stops. He goes toward her. He walks to the window and stands near her.]

WASHINGTON:

Sleep? Sleep and let
the evil dreams of seven years
bring new doubt, new fears?

[She strokes his sleeve. He looks away. The flame of the candle lights up part of his face, leaving her vague but for her hand touching his sleeve.]

MARTHA:

I know, I know.
 Pitiful was Arnold;
 bitter, Valley Forge.
 The Army turned against you—
 all evil dreams.
 Yet—sleep . . . sleep.
 Dreams of trials overcome
 should clear away tomorrow's trials.

WASHINGTON:

Tomorrow's trials . . .
 Four days' journey northward—
 parades, ceremonies,
 the inauguration . . .
 Martha, I am deeply troubled.

MARTHA:

In you the nation is strong—
 the more reason to sleep.
 The people must not see
 a tired President!

WASHINGTON:

Tired? I tell *you*
 the confederation appears
 sometimes little more than a shadow.
 There is not justice enough
 to cultivate it. Illiberality and jealousy
 mix too much in all our councils.
 [*desperately*]
 For me
 the chair of government will bring
 feelings not unlike those of a culprit
 going to the place of execution.

[Unnoticed by him, she has quietly led him to the bed toward which, as he has been talking, he has unconsciously started to move. He sits down.]

MARTHA:

I pray you,
rest like any traveller
till morning. I pray you,
sleep.

[He lies down and she covers him. She sings—a melody he knows well. He sleeps and the words are in his dreams.]

MARTHA:

Faint and wearily the wayworn traveller
plods uncheerily, afraid to stop,
wandering drearily and sad unraveller
of the mazes toward the mountain's top.
Doubting, fearing while his course he's steering,
cottages appearing as he's nigh to drop.
Oh, how briskly the wayworn traveller
threads the mazes toward the mountain's top.

[The music of the song continues into the next scene, stopping abruptly, as with an alarm, as the action begins.]

Scene 2

While the bed and the figures of Washington and Martha remain in a spot of light, the preceding scene, otherwise, dissolves as in a dream, without the lowering of a curtain. Growing black as night, the bed and the figures about it have disappeared. Finally the set brightens. The action which follows is a monologue with pantomime. The shallow stage shows the Beverly Robinson House, in a grove of trees. This is General Arnold's residence, across the Hudson from

West Point. It is early morning in late summer—the day of the betrayal. Gentle sunlight is dimmed by the heavy trees.

Now there appears, where to the left the upper part of the scene remains darkened, the Imaginary Figure of Washington. This Figure appears above the usual plane of action, as in a dream—an imaginary witness to the events that take place below. The feet remain in darkness so that the Figure seems floating, brooding over the action.

The music mounts and becomes agitated. The Imaginary Figure assumes almost the function of a “chorus” in the older interpretation, but in a simple, direct manner—the single figure of a man. It is the personification of Washington’s recollecting, feeling spirit as he recalls this bitter moment of his life.

THE FIGURE:

Arnold, the day has come, the moment
of betrayal. Once more the scenes rise
bitterly before me. Arnold, if you
whom I so deeply loved and trusted
could betray us, whom can we trust now?

[The sounds of someone approaching are heard.]

Comes the messenger with news of André’s
capture. André will hang and England
honor him. But Arnold, you shall save
that traitor’s skin of yours. Fortune
must have loved you—as did I.

[Before the house, an adjutant has dismounted and now hurries to the door, a letter pouch in his hand. He knocks. The door is opened by a servant, behind whom appears Mrs. Arnold. She is put aside by Arnold himself, who, a napkin in his hand, takes the letter, glances at it, and goes in, followed by the others.]

THE FIGURE:

Arnold! Arnold, my old friend, I pity
you. How must that heart that never
knew a fear—beat now in fear.

He's read the letter! André has been
taken! All's lost now.

*[Arnold comes alone to the door, still clutching the
napkin. Hatless, he comes out casually but closes the door
behind him. Then he glances quickly about.]*

Fly, traitor! Fly! Your old friend
Washington is near at hand.

*[Arnold throws down his napkin and runs quickly out
to the right. He has mounted the adjutant's horse and rides
quickly away at a gallop.]*

A countryman of mine! Your country
Arnold, and my country. You
or me. Which way? It cannot follow both.

The skiff is waiting to conduct
him down the river and he's gone.

*[Meanwhile, Mrs. Arnold has come to the door.
Alarmed, she calls out, then runs off looking for her hus-
band. The fading Figure of Washington continues:]*

And this *my* Arnold—he to whom, at
Morristown, remembering Saratoga,
what he did there like a soldier and
a brave man—
admiring that headlong valor, that
tenacity, that gifted soldier's heart,
with my own hands I gave a general's
uniform. Here, I thought, is an example
for the Army! And here's the same Arnold,
sneaking away. Oh coward! Oh disgraced,

unmanned! Not even daring to pause
and say to a young wife, good-bye.

[Mrs. Arnold returns, still frantically looking about, then runs to the porch and stands before the door, as if stunned. The scene darkens. There is a musical interlude.

The Figure of Washington has disappeared. As the light returns, Mrs. Arnold is still standing in front of the door, as if protecting it. Several American officers, General Washington among them, appear from the right. The others stop as Washington advances alone. Mrs. Arnold grows hysterical, screaming at him.]

MRS. ARNOLD:

No, no, no, no! You have come
to kill us all! No, no!

WASHINGTON:

Your pardon, Madam . . .

[Beside herself with grief and anxiety, Mrs. Arnold still stands protecting the door.]

MRS. ARNOLD:

He's gone. He's run away!
Oh! Who are you? Why are you here?

WASHINGTON:

Calm yourself, my dear young lady.
I am General Washington
who was your husband's friend.

MRS. ARNOLD:

No, no! You are a thief! You
have come to steal my child.

[She weeps convulsively and sinks to the ground before her door. In the gentlest manner possible Washington tries to calm her but stays off out of consideration so as not to distress her more.]

WASHINGTON:

My dear lady, if you will listen—
I give you my assurance . . .

MRS. ARNOLD:

No, no, no, no!

[Washington retires, takes his officers aside and speaks with them. They stand watching her. Mrs. Arnold, weeping and excited, sings her aria in the accepted operatic manner.]

MRS. ARNOLD:

My baby! My baby!
Sorrow! Sorrow little child!
Weep, weep, sweet face.
There is no pity, pity for us,
alone in this wild place.

[At the close of her song, young Col. Alexander Hamilton, an aide to Gen. Washington, comes forward.]

HAMILTON:

His Excellency has asked me
to give Mrs. Arnold his respects
and to hand her this letter—

[He hands her the letter which she takes but does not open, clutching it and watching him eagerly, fearfully. He speaks slowly and formally.]

HAMILTON:

—to inform Mrs. Arnold, His Excellency
has done all that depended upon him
to arrest General Arnold . . .

[He pauses.]

but having failed—

MRS. ARNOLD:

Yes! Yes!

HAMILTON:

—His Excellency takes pleasure in informing
Mrs. Arnold of her husband's safety!

MRS. ARNOLD:

He is safe! Thank God.

CURTAIN

Scene 3

The boom of a cannon is heard. The curtain rises, at about noon, on the Assembly Hall of the "New Building" at Newburgh. It is a meeting of the general and field officers of the American Army to hear a report of a committee which had been sent to Philadelphia the year before to plead with Congress for the Army.

Gen. Gates, the ranking officer of the encampment, is in the chair. The Secretary is at the table. Col. Brooks is at the rostrum—he has been interrupted by an outburst of protest or applause. There is the sharp rap of a gavel.

GEN. GATES:

Order! Order!

[*Col. Brooks resumes his reading.*]

COL. BROOKS:

And so, gentlemen, the war ended,
the Army to be furloughed. Unpaid
for months. Your committee waited,
but Congress have been deaf to
their entreaties . . .

[*Voices break out: "Justice! Let the army be paid!"
The gavel raps.*]

COL. BROOKS:

And so, gentlemen, . . .

[Voices interrupt him again. He is unable to finish and retires. Renewed outbreak of voices. Some of the officers get up. Others form in groups, talking. One officer stands addressing the chair.]

OFFICER:

—arouse fears in Congress and
the country and so obtain
justice for ourselves—

[Cries of "Justice! Justice!" and "Neglect! Abuse! On to Philadelphia!"]

OFFICER:

Unpaid for months, we have begged
for some relief from our embarrassments.

VOICES:

Hear! Hear!

GEN. GATES *[pounding his gavel]*:
Gentlemen!

[The voices subside.]

You have heard the disposition
Congress have been pleased to make
of your affairs. I now declare
this question open for discussion.

[For a moment no one rises. Then, unexpectedly, a door at the back opens and the Commander-in-Chief enters, unattended. He walks toward the chair in an atmosphere of veiled antagonism and absolute silence. They make way for him on the platform.]

WASHINGTON:

Mr. Chairman, brother officers . . .
I beg to apologize for appearing

at this meeting. Certain writings, however, which have been circulated in the camp render it necessary. With the indulgence of my brother officers I shall take the liberty of reading to them.

[There is silence. The Chairman motions for him to proceed.]

WASHINGTON *[reading from notes]*:

Gentlemen . . . An attempt has been made to convene you together. How inconsistent with the rule of propriety, how unmilitary and how subversive of all order and discipline, let the good sense of the Army decide.

The anonymous author should have had more charity than to mark for suspicion the man who recommends moderation and longer forbearance.

[He pauses and looks around, as if trying to discover who could have written the piece in question. Then he goes on—but nothing more is heard of what he says. (Perhaps a low chorus, expressing the feelings of the assembly, moves contrapuntally to the orchestra.) In any case, nothing more of what he says can be heard distinctly. Washington is seen to be talking, gently or violently, submerged in the music which carries on, pleading or rising at times to a strong note of condemnation of the desire to throw the country into confusion for private ends. Then the music stops as Washington says, in a dramatic pause, suddenly, strongly:]

My God! What can be in your hearts?

[The orchestra, and perhaps the same subdued chorus, goes on in a lower, quiet, more intimate vein. For a moment Washington pauses. Then he continues—pleading.]

WASHINGTON:

As corroborating testimony of
the good disposition
in Congress toward the Army
let me read to you from a letter.

[He takes out the letter but fails to make it out. He looks toward the light, which seems to have grown dim. The orchestra music has subsided. Then he fumbles in his pocket for his glasses which he brings out with a handkerchief and proceeds to adjust to his eyes. It is the first time he has worn glasses in public. In a pleasant and altogether natural voice he then says:]

You see, I have grown grey
in your service.
And now I find myself
growing blind.

[The music rises. The assembly is visibly affected, some wiping their eyes, etc. The music mounts to an increasing intensity of dramatic feeling as Washington turns again to his letter. As the curtain falls he is still reading.]

CURTAIN

ACT II

Scene 1

The taproom of the village inn at Englishtown, behind the American lines. Eight o'clock the night of the battle of Monmouth. It is an excessively hot night and the windows and the street door at the back are wide open. There are divers groups of men sitting and standing about, coming and going, talking and drinking. Some are asleep—in chairs, on the floor, anywhere. Most are soldiers, among whom the drab townsmen stand out plainly and apart. At the back, by the windows, several younger officers—adjutants, aides, etc.—are trying to get a breath of fresh air. Now and then they pour a drink from a pitcher standing on the table among them. All are dirty and tired. Near the bar, where the inn-keeper and his family are busy, the usual irresponsible element of the town is gathered, mostly drunk and inclined to celebrate. An old fellow is playing a fiddle—a jig tune. Groups of soldiers may be seen, dimly, passing outside. There are sounds of drums and battle in the distance. As the curtain rises, one of the townsmen is doing a little jig.]

FIRST TOWNSMAN:

Ooray for America!

[After a moment he flops back in a chair, exhausted.]

SECOND TOWNSMAN:

Come, my lad, and have some beer.

THIRD TOWNSMAN:

A song! Come, my lad, let's have it.

Sing it for us now . . .

[The man is pushed to his feet. The old fiddler accompanies him in a mock-heroic ballad.]

SECOND TOWNSMAN:

Hermit hoar, in solemn cell,
Wearing out life's evening grey,
Strike thy bosom sage and tell
What is bliss and which the way.
Thus I spoke, and speaking, sighed,
Scarce repressed the starting tear,
When the hoary sage replied,
"Come, my lad, and have some beer."

[His friends applaud. The young officers ignore the singing entirely.]

FIRST TOWNSMAN:

Here's old Garry!

[They welcome a very serious and self-important older man of the neighborhood who enters bowing gravely to all about him.]

FIRST TOWNSMAN:

Come, my lad, and have some beer.

[They laugh and make way, mockingly, for Garry. He accepts it in good part, as of an honor due him.]

SECOND TOWNSMAN:

What's the news, Garry? News!
I hear he met General Washington
riding in the street
and the General asked him how
to whip the British—and which
way to the inn.

[The old man holds up his hand for them to be quiet. He speaks very seriously.]

GARRY:

Young gentlemen, you should not
laugh and be drunk on such
a day. I tell you . . .

FIRST TOWNSMAN:

Come, my lad, and have some beer.

GARRY:

It is true. I met the General in the town, this afternoon. But it was General Lee. He was discoursing to a group of people. And I said to him—

FIRST TOWNSMAN:

Come, my lad, and have some beer.

GARRY:

—you're right, I said. They should have avoided the risk of this battle. It is folly, I said, to make attempts against the enemy in this flat country—where he's possessed of such superiority in cavalry. I said to him . . .

FIRST TOWNSMAN:

Come, my lad, and have some beer.

[As he is repeating the last verse of the song, there is the sound of a movement of troops outside. Cries of "Halt!" and "Water! Water!" The host and several others take up buckets. A Sergeant sticks his head in at the door.]

SERGEANT:

Water! Water!

[The talk shifts to the young officers by the table and the windows.]

JONES:

We retreated when we should have took them all.

MOORE:

When Wayne begged for reinforcements
and sent up word the enemy were on the run,
Lee only sputtered: "Pho, pho! It is
impossible." He would not believe it.

GRAYSON:

—and let us fall back, without
warning, on the main like damned poltroons!

MEADE:

He said to the Marquis, that he,
a Frenchman, did not know British soldiers
and that Americans could never
stand before them.

GRAYSON:

And what did the Frenchman say to that?

MEADE:

That British soldiers have been beaten
and may be again.

HARRISON:

The awful heat must have got Lee—
he acted like a man bewildered.

JONES:

None knew
why he was retreating. I said to Mercer,
"My God, what is the cause
of this retreat?" He answered,
"If you'll proceed, you'll see the cause—
you will see several columns of foot
and horse." I replied that we came
to that field
to meet columns of foot and horse.

[*Gen. Lee's aide, Fitzgerald, comes in hurriedly. He is disheveled, hatless and has one hand bandaged. The young officers bring him among them.*]

FITZGERALD:

Has anybody seen the General's dog?
You know him. He's white and brown
and spotted and has long ears—and
good God, won't somebody give me a drink?
Here he is now.

[*Another movement at the door. They all stand as Gen. Lee, a tall, thin man in uniform, accompanied by several citizens of the town, comes in.*]

LEE:

Sit down, young men, it's too
damned hot to stand on ceremony.
Fitzgerald, have they seen my dog?
Where the devil is that dog?

[*Then he turns suddenly to those standing near him.*]

What? What do you say?
By the temerity, folly and
contempt of orders of General Wayne—
separated eight miles from
our main body—I said that it
was madness to attack!
We could not be successful
in a level country . . .

We were outnumbered—especially
the cavalry, which was at twenty
different times upon the point
of turning our flanks.
This naturally *obliged* us
to retreat.

To these maneuvers the success
of the day was wholly due.
'Twas I gave him the only
victory he ever had. Washington
had scarcely more to do in it
than strip the dead.

[He drinks the water they have been holding for him.]

Five pounds reward I offer
to the one who finds my dog.

*[He turns to go. Fitzgerald moves to follow him, but
Lee motions for him to remain.]*

Stay where you are, young man.
I'll call you presently.

*[Lee goes out. For a moment all are left aghast, looking
after him, speechless. Then Jones speaks up.]*

JONES:

What happened in the West Ravine
this morning?

GRAYSON:

They say His Excellency cursed
and swore at him. Is that true,
Fitzgerald?

[Fitzgerald shakes his head, refusing to speak.]

JONES:

You were there, Harrison. What
did he say?

HARRISON:

He was in a fury,
but I couldn't hear him.

FITZGERALD:

It was his manner more than
what he said.

GRAYSON:

But what *did* he say? Out with it.
That's not like you, Fitz—
let's hear it.

[*Fitzgerald takes another drink before he speaks.*]

FITZGERALD:

It was just across the bridge.
Lee was coming in behind
the Jersey troops
when His Excellency, who was
busy, saw us and rode up
directly in our way. He was
in a rage. I never heard him
speak like that before. "I
desire to know, sir," he said,
"what is the reason, whence
arises this disorder and
confusion?" Lee seemed to be
himself confused
by His Excellency's
angry manner and appearance.
He seemed to be like one
who has not heard aright
and stammered, "Sir, sir . . ."
Then in an impatient but
decided tone Washington
repeated, "What is all this
confusion and what is the cause
of this retreat?" Still
disconcerted by His Excellency's
manner, the General spoke
of his difficulties—
contradictory intelligences,
impudent interference with his
orders—adding at the end

that the whole plan of attack
was contrary to his advice.

HARRISON:

And what did Washington reply
to that?

FITZGERALD:

He replied, still very angry,
that he was sorry General Lee
had undertaken the command
unless he meant to fight.
Then with his arms still
raised, and in a voice of
thunder, he said,
"Go to the rear, sir!"

*[A movement of troops outside. Drums. A Sergeant
sticks his head in at the door.]*

SERGEANT:

Captain Mercer!

A TOWNSMAN:

What is it?

SERGEANT:

General orders—to advance!

[There is a commotion as the officers get ready to leave.]

CURTAIN

Scene 2: Ballet

Valley Forge. A bare, windswept field with an embankment at the back on which stands a crude shelter among hemlocks and underbrush. It is bitter cold. A poorly-clad

Sentry stands above the road. He is cold and shivering. After a moment he takes off his hat and puts his feet, which are bound in rags, in it to keep them warm. A light snow begins to fall.

It is important to note that this is intended to be a "true" ballet, a serious and essential part of the opera, representing the lot of the common American soldier and his relation to Washington. The characteristic of the ballet is that it is not, in the old sense, a mere diversion, a distraction, but an important functional part intended to delineate a situation in order to clarify and dignify it, to endow it with its full emotional power. It has three phases:

Fantasy—A Dream:

The Sentry sees the snow which has begun to descend. He holds his elbow out to catch it on his sleeve. He examines it carefully. He shakes his head to keep himself awake. He rubs his eyes. Nevertheless his head droops forward. He leans on his musket and sleeps. The snow grows thicker.

The Snow Maidens begin to come on—first one or two, timidly. They see the Sentry is asleep. They beckon to the others. They are all in white, like the snow, and dance gracefully and silently—as if not wishing to waken the sleeper.

But after a moment the Queen of them all approaches and dances before the Sentry. Suddenly she is alarmed. She goes up to him and shakes him, pointing out to the right. He starts awake and places his musket at attention as Washington and his generals appear, muffled, on a tour of inspection.

Seeing the girls, the young officers laugh and gaily run after them. The girls try to escape but are caught. Meanwhile, Washington has approached the Queen, who bows before him in homage. He takes her by the hand and stands

as if talking while the other officers and girls dance about them. They invite the two to join them.

Laughing, all back away as Washington asks the Queen to dance. She does so, briefly. Then she invites him to dance with her. He shakes his head. She begs. The others urge him. He consents and does a jig and reel with the beautiful Queen. Much laughter and applause.

Suddenly he stops, having caught sight of the Sentry. He begins again. Then again . . . he stops. Pointing to the Sentry, still at attention with his musket, Washington makes it understood that *there* is the real dancer. He takes his girl, the Queen, by the hand and offers her to the common soldier—begging him to come down.

Reality:

The Sentry, much embarrassed, refuses in his turn, indicating that he is not dressed for it, bowing to Washington, his Commander-in-Chief, indicating that he is on duty, that he has to keep his eye on the country around them for signs of the enemy. Washington brushes his objections aside, finally ordering him to put down his musket and come down.

The man is shy, conscious of being in the presence of his superior officers. He can't dance. Washington urges the Queen to encourage him. She plays with him, teasing him. Everybody laughs good naturedly. Then the man rouses. He becomes excited. Awkwardly at first, then with more and more skill, he outdoes himself before his Commander-in-Chief. He is the real dancer and does all sorts of complicated movements to show his joy and appreciation.

Washington and the others applaud him, making themselves second to him as assistants to his virtuosity. Wilder and wilder grow his antics. Then—at the height of his ecstasy—he pauses. He looks about in alarm.

Tragedy:

The Sentry has seen the British approaching and realizes that they may capture or harm Washington. He tries to warn the others, but they are too intent on the dance, too drunk with pleasure. He roughly breaks away from the Queen in the middle of the dance. She clings to him. He knocks her away. She runs crying to Washington.

The Sentry runs right and left, greatly distressed, imploring the men to leave the girls, to take up their swords and—finally, to run for their lives!

Then the British, in bright uniforms, burst upon them. Some of them seize the girls. Others draw swords and fix bayonets, rushing upon Washington surrounded by his officers. There is a *mêlée*. In a final rush the British are about to lay hands upon the Commander-in-Chief when the Sentry runs forward upon their bayonets and is transfixed. He falls dead.

At this the reinforced Americans push forward and are successful. The hero is discovered dead underfoot, having sacrificed himself for his Commander-in-Chief.

Apotheosis. Led by Washington, the others lift up the dead hero tenderly and carry him up the embankment at the back. The girls are in tears. Gathering darkness. Night.

CURTAIN

Scene 3

The same. A few hours later. This scene is to follow the ballet immediately, with as little pause as possible.

The Sentry has disappeared. Washington and his staff are standing about a small fire. Washington is sitting on a low stump; the others are standing a short distance away. All seem dejected. They are silent. He stares into the fire.

WASHINGTON:

What is the reason for this
breakdown of supplies? Everything
is lacking. The Army's in
a pitiable plight. What men
are these to bear it? I cannot
bear to witness it much longer.
But why? Almighty God! What reason?

GREENE:

Money, your Excellency. Wagons
are rotting in the woods—drawn
to the side and dumped or left
there loaded as they are—
because the carters are not paid.

WASHINGTON:

Yes, I know. But back of that,
what reason?

[All are silent. No one dares to say anything.]

GREENE:

Congress have fled. Many have
lost heart.

*[Washington has taken out a small pocketknife and is
whittling with it on a stick. A long silence.]*

AN OFFICER:

They mean to starve us, sir.

WASHINGTON:

What's that?

OFFICER:

The Board of War.
The Cabal—Gates and his cronies.

GREENE:

The Congress is too weak to
stop them. They vacillate. They
can't make up their minds.

[In spite of the others, one of the officers blurts out:]

OFFICER:

They mean to supersede you in
command, Your Excellency. There is
a plot—

[He stops, somewhat overcome by his own temerity. The General has not moved. Now he speaks, very deliberately, still without looking up.]

WASHINGTON:

I have written my resignation
and have it here—in my pocket.
If it will serve the country,
I will return them my commission
in the morning.

[General Knox steps forward.]

KNOX:

That penknife in your hand—

WASHINGTON:

And what has that to do with it?

KNOX:

You were always to obey
your superiors. You were commanded
to lead this army. No one
has commanded you to cease
leading it.

Whatever lack of courage,
whatever knavery—if it exists—
would leave us here to starve,

we have no one else to turn to.
Congress have put you here
and you have sworn obedience
to them. There is no choice.
You must obey. You have sworn it
to Congress and Congress alone
can free you from that oath!

*[Washington considers for a moment, then closes his
knife, puts it in his pocket and stands up.]*

WASHINGTON:

There is something in that—
I will think it over.

CURTAIN

ACT III

Scene 1

The balcony of Federal Hall, New York City. April 30, 1789. It is toward noon on a clear day. Sound of cannon and church bells. The people are waiting while ceremonies are taking place within.

The view is over the heads of the crowd, from inside the east corner of the balcony, which runs from left to right diagonally across the stage. Beyond, in bright sunlight, are the second-story windows and peaked gables of the stone and brick houses of the street opposite. The inside of the balcony itself is in shadow. Following is a contemporary description of the scene:

"Over the balcony hung a canopy from which there were suspended red curtains. A table stood near, covered with a cloth of crimson velvet, on the center of which was a red cushion especially placed for a large and elegant Bible.

"To this open balcony in front of the Senate Chamber looking out on Wall Street the President was formally conducted. His appearance was the occasion for the wildest applause—bands played, flags waved and the multitude gathered and shouted until exhausted.

"Acknowledging the shouts of joy and this hilarious welcome Geo. Washington advanced to the front of the balcony, laid his hand upon his heart and bowed several times.

"For a moment he seemed as if about to faint but managed to return immediately to an armchair beside the table. There was a sudden hush. It had seemed to the crowd that he had been seized by an illness."

At this moment an invisible chorus, with alarm and great feeling, sing the words:

CHORUS:

Spare him! Spare him!

[But Chancellor Robert Livingston now reads the oath of office prescribed by the Constitution. Washington, greatly moved, "so that he could scarcely stand," takes the oath in dead silence and with great solemnity.]

LIVINGSTON:

You do solemnly swear that you will faithfully execute the office of President of the United States and will, to the best of your ability, preserve, protect and defend the Constitution of the United States.

[With bowed head, Washington repeats these solemn words, adding, "So help me God." The Chancellor raises the Bible to the lips of the newly-elected President, who stoops and kisses it.]

As the others on the balcony press forward to congratulate the new President, Chancellor Livingston steps to the rail of the balcony and shouts, "Three cheers for the first President of the United States!"

At this stage a signal is given for the raising of a flag on Federal Hall. There is a tremendous discharge of artillery at the Battery, and all the bells of the city ring out their peals of joy. The multitude by this time has got their second wind. Washington waves his hand and retires. The strains of "Hail to The Chief," a contemporary song written for the occasion, are heard. There are cheers, yells and singing in a festive mood. With the happy sounds of the crowd still being heard the scene rapidly darkens, fades and changes.]

Scene 2

The noise of a crowd is still heard but now it is of a wholly different character. Angry and menacing howls rise and die

away alternately outside a tall, curtained window in the executive offices of the President in Philadelphia a few years later.

The President is sitting at his desk, his back to the window, beside which, holding back one of the curtains so as not to be seen while looking out, is Lear, the President's secretary. Washington is sitting with his eyes cast upward to the right, a paper in his hand.

The stage, where he is looking, is in partial darkness, undefined. This character of the divided stage prevails throughout the scene—which re-emphasizes the fantastic dream motive of the whole piece.

THE CROWD:

Genêt! Genêt!
War with England!
Back France against the British!
Long live the Revolution!
Liberté! Egalité! Fraternité!

[Lear speaks as if in answer to a question, describing the scene.]

LEAR:

They are cheering France
and the Revolution!
Thousands of them, Your Excellency,
shoulder to shoulder!
Clinging to fences, upon porches
and railings. Calling upon
Genêt, the French Ambassador.
Genêt! Genêt! That madman who has
incited them to insurrection.
Genêt! Genêt! Your Excellency
can hear them now.

[There are more shouts and uproar from the crowd. As Washington sits staring off to the right, gradually a light

appears at the spot where he is looking, a clearing above the stage level, as if in the air. He sees, as if in his thoughts, and while Lear continues looking out the window, a sunlit corner of the porch at Mt. Vernon.

A colored girl, Doll, is sitting at the edge of the porch knitting. Nelly Custis comes from the house and stands watching her. She is in a summer dress and swings a straw hat in her hand. She looks away, off and beyond where the President is sitting at his desk. Nelly and Doll sing.]

NELLY:

Oh the sun is a lover
Who runs to us with delight
Through grass and wild clover,
Stirring the small birds to flight.

DOLL:

Yes, Miss Nelly, I know
just how you feel.

[Lear changes his position at the window as the crowd breaks out anew.]

NELLY:

Soft clouds hovering over,
Pretty flowers in his hand,
Welcome, welcome, sweet lover,
Come again to the warm land.

DOLL:

Yes'm, and at night de dawgs
barkin' and you lay
and listen and you hear like
someone sneakin', creepin'
for you on the grass—

[A stone strikes the window, ending the idyllic scene. Lear starts back. Washington turns about and stands up.]

The vision fades. Washington goes to the window and stands in full view of the howling mob.]

LEAR:

Three days, Your Excellency—
ten thousand men turning the streets
of Philadelphia into a Bedlam.
Come away, I beg you—come away.

[Washington returns to his desk and picks up a newspaper.]

WASHINGTON:

These are unpleasant things,
but not to be avoided. The
proclamation of neutrality has been signed and
will be maintained—against all odds.

THE CROWD:

Allons enfants de la patrie!

[They begin to sing the Marseillaise (this is an historical fact) but hush suddenly.]

LEAR:

It is Your Excellency's ministers
who are arriving. Here comes
Mr. Jefferson walking among them.
They are stopping him. He is
talking with them.

[Washington sits again at his desk. As he does so, the fantastic figure of Genêt appears to the right—as did Nelly and Doll before. He is haranguing a crowd, inveighing against the President.]

GENET:

France was your friend in time
of need! England the common
enemy! Citizens! Brothers!

Lock fraternal arms in mine!
Revolution bred you! Revolution
made you strong! Revolution
calls you to the side of France.
Who is George Washington
to block the people's will?
A doddering old man, who served
you once, it is true. But a tool
of England now. Rise up, be free
again and let all tyrants die
beneath your trampling feet!

[As the members of the Cabinet begin to come in, the figure of Genêt fades and Washington gets up to welcome them. Lear arranges chairs. Some go to the window, among them Jefferson, Hamilton, Randolph and Knox. Knox has come in last, with a newspaper in his hand, open, as if he had been reading it. He does not take it seriously but shows it to Washington, bantering.]

KNOX:

Look here! Here's a verse against
Your Excellency. Some poet wants
to guillotine you. Have you seen
it? Shall I read it?

[Washington, for answer, goes to his desk where he picks up three or four newspapers and brandishes them before the faces of his ministers.]

WASHINGTON:

Gentlemen, this is the same newspaper
was handed to me in the hour.
With what malignant industry
and persevering falsehoods
I am assailed, in order
to weaken if not to destroy
the confidence of the public.

The result, as it respects myself
I care not—for I have consolation
within no earthly efforts can
deprive me of. But these publications
in Bach's and Freneau's papers
are an outrage to public decency.
In what will this abuse terminate?

[He flies into a rage.]

By God! I cannot longer stand
this personal abuse that's heaped
on me. And I defy any man on earth
to produce a single act
since I have been in the government
that was not done out of the purest
motives. I tell you I have never
repented but once having slipped
the moment of resigning office—
and that is every moment since.
By God! I'd rather be in my grave
than in this situation.
I'd rather be on my farm than
to be made emperor of the world—
and yet they charge me with wanting
to be king! That rascal Freneau
sends me three papers every day,
as if he thinks I will become
distributor of his papers. I can see
no more in it than
an impudent design to insult me—

[There is an awkward pause. Washington is embarrassed at his own violence. He goes to the window, turning away from the others toward the right of the stage, which is now in a clear light. The others remain near the window.]

JEFFERSON:

This is a disgraceful scene—
Genêt must be curbed—or his
intemperate language, insolent
pretensions and disrespect
for law and authority will play
the mischief with us.
What shall we do with him?

KNOX:

Send him out of the country.

HAMILTON:

We should renounce or suspend
the treaties with revolutionary
France.

JEFFERSON:

The treaties as a whole are not
incompatible with that fair
neutrality which should be the object
of the American policy.

HAMILTON:

Then I say that what we see
outside this window
is directly chargeable
to Mr. Jefferson.

JEFFERSON:

I deny that I have any part . . .

*[Washington has turned toward them. It is growing
toward evening and Lear has lighted several candles. The
street sounds have died away.]*

WASHINGTON:

Gentlemen, let me plead with you
for more forbearance and charity.
Differences of speculative opinion

within the Cabinet should not
be pressed when we are encompassed
on all sides by avowed enemies.

[He pauses.]

All our late accounts from Europe
hold up the expectation of
a general war. I ardently wish
we may not be forced into it
by the conduct of other nations.
If we are permitted to improve,
without interruption, the great
advantages which nature
and circumstances have placed
within our reach, many years will not
revolve before we may be ranked
among the most responsible and
happiest people of this globe.

*[All remain silent for a few moments. Then Jefferson
steps forward.]*

JEFFERSON:

I came today expressly to petition
that Your Excellency fix
a final date for my retirement—
that I may return to my family
and to my farm.

WASHINGTON:

Nothing can keep you?

JEFFERSON:

My mind is quite made up.

WASHINGTON:

Like a man going to the gallows
I am willing to put it off
as long as I can.

[The Invisible Chorus is heard singing: Observe good faith and justice to all nations! In a dreamlike transition, approaching darkness, Washington is left alone near the window. There are flares outside. Lear returns from ushering the others out. Washington does not observe him but, believing himself alone, stands at the window looking out. The light from the street is upon him. The singing of the Chorus dwindles. And now, for the first time in the opera, Washington, looking out of the window, sings to a conventional aria:]

WASHINGTON:

All dangers changed
to pleasantness,
my happiest
reward

to live to know
without alloy
the sweet
enjoyment

of good laws
among
my fellow
citizens—in all

the dearest object
of my heart
this soil
where I was born.

[As Washington sings the light fades, from below upward, until only his head and shoulders remain visible. Meanwhile, a light has begun to dawn above him, at the back, through which the Chorus appears gradually, though still somewhat veiled. Washington's voice is still heard when he has completely disappeared from the scene.]

Scene 3

Continuous with the last scene. The lower parts of the stage are in darkness. The Chorus is becoming more clearly distinguishable.

CHORUS:

Welcome wanderer home from a
tempestuous ocean to that
well-resorted tavern
of your heart's desire, the
vine and fig-tree under whose
benignant shade that heart
has longed to rest in peace.

[As they sing, the scene upon the stage takes on a more or less formalized resemblance to the first scene of the opera. The bed is there and Martha beside it. The whole remains somewhat shadowy—the Chorus being emphasized more and more. Martha and Washington sing with the Chorus.]

WASHINGTON:

I am gliding down the stream
of life, and wish, as it is natural,
that my remaining days may be
tranquil and undisturbed.

[Martha, to this, sings a formalized arrangement of her song of the first act.]

MARTHA:

Faint and wearily the wayworn traveller
plods uncheerily, afraid to stop . . .

[At the end of this, the Chorus sings alone.]

CHORUS:

Good night, good night, sweet lover!

[Washington and Martha have disappeared from the scene. Then boldly the shadowy character of the scene ends abruptly and the Chorus—in full evening dress, black and white, with a full light upon it—fills the scene. The effect is to bring the whole, with a tremendous sweep, out of the past, up to today—the uncertain fruits of Washington's labors—in a music of blended voices.]

CHORUS:

EXITUS ACTA PROBAT!

CURTAIN

The Cure

CHARACTERS

GEORGE MITCHELL, a young man in his late 20's.

CONNIE MITCHELL, George's wife. A little younger than her husband. Formerly a trained hospital nurse.

PROSPERO, a young man in his early 20's.

AN OLD MAN, Prospero's father.

ROSY, the Mitchells' next door neighbor. About 30.

MABLE, an elderly woman. Another neighbor.

LEM, an employee in the post office. In his 60's. Bald.

A STATE TROOPER, about 40.

Neighbors. Firemen. An Ambulance Driver. Ambulance Attendant.

ACT I

The scene is an old Dutch-type farmhouse on the outskirts of a village in upstate New York near the salt mines of the Genesee Valley. The action begins past midnight on a stormy May night in 1952. We see the main living room of George Mitchell, an employee of one of the salt companies, and his wife, Connie. The house is rather dilapidated but the Mitchells prefer its relative isolation—almost in the open country—to the more modern homes of the company town.

We look into the house from the back. In the middle of the center wall is the front door which opens onto the roadway outside, the house being built close to the road and on a sharp curve. There are windows on each side of the front door. In the right wall of the room are two smaller doors, one leading into a bedroom and the other into the kitchen. The floor of the room is raised about three feet on the stage and below the floor level we see the outside of the back of the house—a fieldstone foundation which supports the frame, wooden clapboard structure. This strip of foundation across the stage is a painted scrim curtain. When only the footlights are lit, we see the exterior stone only. But when, for part of the action, backlights come on below the floor level, the scrim becomes transparent and we see through to a ground-level half-cellar under the house. Entrance to this semi-basement, used in the old days for storing vegetables and fruit, is by a trapdoor cut in the left side of the floor of the room above. Wooden steps, visible when the backlighting goes on, lead down from the trapdoor. The trapdoor itself can be lifted by a pulley and rope, and leans against the left wall when it is raised.

The walls of the room are covered with a small-figured wallpaper, badly faded and showing some water stains in

spots, and there are chintz curtains on the windows. There are simple bracket-type lighting fixtures on the walls. The furnishing of the living room is sparse and extremely simple—old ill-assorted pieces left in the house by former occupants or picked up at country auctions. To the right of the door is a Victorian walnut coat stand with a seat and a mirror between the clothes pegs. Against the right wall, between the two small doors, is a tall open-shelved cabinet, with china dishes and various odds and ends stacked on the shelves. At the right side of the stage there is a round oak dining table with three curving feet extending from a central leg. It stands on a hooked rug, and there are three chairs, which do not match, around it.

The furniture of the left side of the room—an old wicker rocking chair, a chintz-covered sofa, a small table, an improvised bookcase, a brass standing lamp—is a disordered shambles because, a half hour before the play begins, there has been a freak accident. A motorcycle, coming through the fog at high speed, has skidded off the curve and crashed through the house wall to the left of the front door. The windows of the left side of the house have been shattered and there is a gaping hole through the splintered clapboarding of the wall. The rider on the motorcycle has been killed and lies pinned by the legs under the battered machine in the corner of the room. A blanket has been thrown over the head and shoulders of the body.

When the curtain rises, the front door is open, showing, against the darkness, rain falling through the glare of a spotlight mounted out of sight on the town fire engine that has come to the scene of the accident.

Before the curtain rises, the mood of excitement and confusion following the accident—neighbors have heard the crash and come to investigate—is established by the voices of the firemen and spectators shouting to each other as they probe the wreckage and examine the scene. Lines such as the following may be improvised to the extent required:

"Where's the doctor?"

"It's too late for the doctor, he's dead."

"What the hell are you doing?"

"Come on, help me get his legs free."

"The damn thing's wedged so I can't move it."

"Get the jack out of the fire engine."

"Where's George? See if he's got a crowbar."

Etcetera.

As the curtain rises the Mitchells' living room is crowded with members of the town's fire brigade (wearing firemen's slickers and hats), an ambulance driver and attendant (with raincoats over their white uniforms), a state trooper (in regulation uniform), neighbors of various ages and both sexes (wearing whatever they could pull on in a hurry) and Connie and George. Connie wears a light dressing gown and bedroom slippers. George is in undershirt and a pair of work pants but he is barefoot, having forgotten, in the excitement, to put on his shoes. There is constant movement as the scene opens, some trying to get closer to the corpse—the state trooper is trying to keep the neighbors back—others to be helpful in putting things in order or removing the motorcycle. One of the neighbors is cutting burlap sacks and tacking them over the hole in the wall to keep the rain out. Another picks up books that have been scattered over the floor from the bookshelf.

AMBULANCE DRIVER:

If we are ever to get the stiff out of here, got to move all this junk.

FIRST FIREMAN:

Junk. You said it.

SECOND FIREMAN:

You got all the evidence you need?

FIRST FIREMAN:

Sure. It's an open-and-shut case.

SECOND FIREMAN:

O.K. Let's go—if we got manpower enough.

FIRST FIREMAN [*after studying the wrecked motorcycle*]:
You can't tell the ass from the front, it's so bashed in.

[*There is a general movement among the onlookers to assist the firemen with the wrecked machine. Meanwhile a latecomer to the scene of the accident attempts to inform himself on what has been going on. He approaches one of the firemen.*]

LATECOMER:

What's been going on here?

FIRST FIREMAN:

Don't bother me. Don't you see I'm busy? Where you bin?

LATECOMER:

Just got here.

FIRST FIREMAN:

Must be a reporter or something.

LATECOMER:

That's the idea.

FIRST FIREMAN:

Ask Mable here, she knows everything. [*He goes on with what he is doing.*]

LATECOMER [*to Mable, an aged citizen from the village*]:
What happened?

MABLE:

I don't want to be quoted.

SECOND FIREMAN [*laughing*]:

You tell him, Mable.

MABLE:

All I know is what I seen. When I get to the party it was almost over. I live just down the road from here but I don't

see no need to run every time my husband takes a notion to get up in the night, even if he is a fireman. When I get here the ambulance . . .

LATECOMER:

Who was it that was killed?

MABLE:

I don't know. No one that anybody knows from around here. He must have come along in the fog, poor boy, and when he missed the curve he smashed into the corner of the house and that finished him. That's all I know.

[The men working on the motorcycle attract attention to themselves.]

FIRST FIREMAN:

That son of a bitch. It's jammed so tight I can't break it loose no matter how hard I try.

[Several men in the group, including the State Trooper, contribute their advice. A wire cable has been brought in the door from a winch on the fire engine outside and attached to the frame of the motorcycle. A jack has been set in place to lift part of the caved-in wall.]

FIRST FIREMAN:

I'll get the bitch apart yet—if it takes me till morning.

SECOND FIREMAN *[after several further maneuvers]*:

Cuss it. Now you're talking. *[The cable is tightened and the motorcycle moves slightly.]* There she comes.

FIRST FIREMAN:

I never knew what a job a busted motorcycle is to move.

SECOND FIREMAN:

Now you know.

[With a final lift from the jack and a wrench on the cable from the offstage winch, the motorcycle begins to

slide free. When it is disengaged from the wall the firemen, assisted by onlookers, right it and pull it out the door. The group of workers is given a little cheer, which they acknowledge.]

FIRST FIREMAN:

And that's that.

[The Ambulance Attendant brings in a folding stretcher and the Driver helps him set it up near the body of the victim.]

AMBULANCE DRIVER:

Now give us a hand with the stiff and we're through.

FIRST FIREMAN:

That's easy. Come on you guys, you haven't forgotten the war, have you?

[He gets plenty of volunteers.]

CONNIE:

Poor, poor boy. *[She makes a move to go forward.]* He must have broken his neck.

FIRST FIREMAN:

No, not you.

CONNIE:

I'm strong.

[The men lift the body, still hidden by the blanket, onto the stretcher.]

AMBULANCE ATTENDANT:

O.K. Good. Let's get it into the ambulance.

[With some difficulty, because the door is rather narrow, they edge the stretcher out. There is the sound of the ambulance door opening and closing and then the men return one by one into the room. It has stopped raining.]

FIRST FIREMAN:

And that about closes us up for the night. [*addressing the State Trooper*] Well boss, from here on out it's all yours.

STATE TROOPER:

O.K. I'll take it from here. I got some paper work to do, then I guess these people can go to bed. The fog's lifted and the moon's out.

SECOND FIREMAN [*from the doorway*]:

George can get a carpenter to help with this mess in the morning.

CONNIE:

I'll take care of all that.

[*The motor of the fire engine is heard turning over and then the floodlight outside goes out. The men outside call to the men still waiting to leave.*]

FIRST FIREMAN:

Well, quite a party. So long. [*He leaves to the whine of the siren.*]

[*Connie and George have begun putting the house to rights. They and a few of the still-curious stop to listen to what the State Trooper is starting to say. With his back to the audience, the Trooper is beginning to sum up the night's proceedings. He is sitting at the dining table before Connie and George as if it were an informal court.*]

STATE TROOPER [*reading from his report*]:

You were asleep in bed when you were awakened by an awful crash.

CONNIE:

We didn't hear it, but it must have been awful from the wreck we saw when we came down.

STATE TROOPER:

What time exactly was it?

CONNIE:

I looked at the clock. It was exactly seven minutes past one. I knew something terrible must have happened—it was all over by that time. There wasn't a sound anymore. The house smelled of gasoline. I thought we'd had an explosion and the house was on fire. George came downstairs right behind me.

STATE TROOPER:

I think I got it down straight the first time. No witnesses, of course. The only thing that troubles me is that it was a two-seater—as far as I can tell.

GEORGE:

Sometimes a kid will fill the back seat up with his gear—maybe it was one of those set-ups.

STATE TROOPER:

Could be.

[Connie has gone over to the Trooper and has been looking over his shoulder at the report.]

CONNIE:

What's this crack about "housewife"?

STATE TROOPER:

Any objection?

CONNIE:

Sure.

STATE TROOPER:

Just a routine description of you in my report.

CONNIE:

It happens not to be true.

STATE TROOPER:

Why not?

CONNIE:

I'm a trained nurse. A registered trained nurse. Trained and registered from the Syracuse General Hospital.

STATE TROOPER:

Do you want me to put that down?

CONNIE:

Of course I want you to put it down.

STATE TROOPER:

And I bet you'd like to be right back there this minute—tending to the hospital business.

CONNIE:

That's my own affair.

STATE TROOPER:

You don't have to get miffed over it—a good-looking woman like you is always missed around the hospital.

CONNIE:

Mind your own business.

STATE TROOPER:

What shall I put down?

CONNIE:

My professional name—Constance Laboard—l-a-b-o-a-r-d. [*She spells it out for him.*] I still use it.

STATE TROOPER:

O.K. Constance Laboard, R.N. Anything else?

CONNIE:

That's not my name now.

STATE TROOPER:

Best luck girl, and apologies. [*He assembles his papers.*] It's kind of late. Sorry to leave you with all this mess on your hands.

CONNIE:

Think nothing of it. *[She gets a broom from the kitchen and starts to sweep some of the debris into a pile.]*

STATE TROOPER:

Have you any insurance?

GEORGE:

Not for this sort of thing.

STATE TROOPER:

I advise you not to try to clean up now. Go to bed. Tomorrow is another day.

[The last spectators and the Trooper quit the scene as George takes the broom out of Connie's hands.]

CONNIE:

O.K. Time to go to bed.

[They stop work and George goes into the bedroom. Connie goes about the living room putting out the lights. The weather has changed and the moon now beams in at the window. She lingers a moment to admire the moonlight.]

CONNIE:

So quiet and peaceful after all this fuss. I love it. Isn't it beautiful!

[Connie goes into the bedroom. The sounds of a country night are heard; there is even an owl hooting sporadically. The stage is empty for a moment. Then an unusual noise begins to make itself heard. It is a half-muffled sound, between a groan and a cat's scream, that seems to come from somewhere under the house. Connie reappears at the door of the bedroom and pauses to listen.]

GEORGE *[from the bedroom]*:

Aw, come to bed.

CONNIE [*turning on a light*]:
I hear something.

GEORGE [*from the bedroom*]:
It's in your mind.

CONNIE:
George, come in here. I'm scared.

[*George, now wearing pajamas, comes in and listens.*]

GEORGE:
I don't hear anything.

CONNIE:
Wait a minute.

[*They wait as several moments pass. Then the strange sound is heard again.*]

CONNIE [*letting out a half-stifled scream*]:
It's in this room. Did you close the trap last night?

GEORGE:
I think so. I can't remember. A cat must have got in. [*He goes to the left side of the room to check the cellar trap-door in the floor.*] Yes, it's shut.

CONNIE [*joining George near the trapdoor*]:
It seemed to come from over here.

[*The sound is heard again, coming apparently from under their feet. They start back.*]

CONNIE:
That's a human voice. There's someone in the cellar!

MAN'S VOICE [*from the cellar*]:
Get me out of this!

CONNIE:
Hurry, George! Open the trap! [*shouting through the floor to the invisible man*] We're coming just as fast as we can.

[There are some indistinguishable shouts and curses from below as George tries to raise the trapdoor with the pulley rope. But something has been jammed by the accident and it will not open.]

CONNIE [*shouting*]:

I can't understand what you're saying.

MAN'S VOICE:

My leg!

CONNIE [*to George*]:

Can't you get a bar and pry the thing open?

[George runs into the kitchen and returns with tools. He kneels to pry and hammer at the trapdoor. The sounds from below have ceased.]

CONNIE:

He's probably fainted.

[George finally gets the trapdoor free and with his wife's assistance raises it against the left wall. Connie has remained perfectly calm during these maneuvers, helping her husband at every turn. They kneel and stare down into the hole.]

CONNIE:

Haven't we a light on a cord we can use?

GEORGE:

No.

CONNIE:

Then get me a flash. *[George goes into the bedroom on the run. When he comes back with a flashlight Connie has already started down the cellar stairs and is groping around in the hole. He hands the flashlight down to her.]* He's fainted again. Haven't we some whisky? Lemme have the flash. *[She flashes on the light.]* What a mess!

[As Connie flashes on her light the backlighting under the stage floor comes on and we are able to see, though not too clearly, through the scrim into the cellar. The form of a man, Prospero, can be dimly seen sprawled at the foot of the cellar stair. His body is in a contorted position with one leg twisted under the stair frame.]

GEORGE:

What's happened?

[George has found the whisky in the wall cabinet and stands holding the bottle in his hand. Connie gives him the flash and takes the liquor. She goes further down into the cellar and starts to pour from the bottle into the man's throat. He chokes and begins to cough violently. George watches from above.]

PROSPERO:

What the hell are you doing to me? *[He tries to get up but cannot free his leg and collapses with the pain.]*

CONNIE:

Take it easy, pal. You're not so bad.

PROSPERO:

You don't think so, huh.

GEORGE:

Hadn't I better hotfoot it into town and phone the police?

PROSPERO *[letting out a howl]*:

You god damn bastards! *[shouting]* If you do that to me I'll pull a knife on you.

[George jumps down into the hole and tries to draw Connie away but she pushes him back. He stands halfway down the stairs shining the light on Prospero.]

CONNIE:

Come on, big boy. Give me the knife. *[In the half-darkness of the cellar we do not see how she gets it from Prospero]*

but her hand appears above the floor level holding a switch-blade. George takes it from her.] He really had one!

GEORGE:

Wasn't that rather foolish?

Connie:

I know these people. Come on, get me a better light. [*She comes up the stairs and heads toward the kitchen.*]

GEORGE:

Where are you going?

CONNIE [*pausing in her tracks*]:

Have you taken a look at that leg?

GEORGE:

No.

CONNIE:

Then don't. Without a shot of morphine in him we won't be able to touch him. I think I must have a couple of doses of Majandi still left in my bag after Mrs. Collins died.

GEORGE:

What's Majandi?

CONNIE:

Morphine. Lemme look. [*She goes into the kitchen.*]

PROSPERO:

What's she doing now?

GEORGE:

You'll see.

PROSPERO:

For Christ's sake, don't let her touch that leg.

GEORGE:

Too damn bad about you.

[Connie returns triumphantly with her old nurse's kit. All her troubles are not by any means over—being a good surgical nurse she knows that the giving of a hypodermic dose of morphine requires a sterile needle even if the solution is sterile. She lacks the equipment she needs—even alcohol and cotton for a swab to sponge off the skin. She feels guilty about not having it but is determined to go ahead. She assembles her hypodermic needle, sending up a little prayer of thanks that the barrel is not stuck after several months of disuse. She has her morphine solution ready and decides to use whisky and a Kleenex for the swab. She talks to herself as she works.]

CONNIE:

I can't be fancy. This is an emergency. *[She has completely forgotten her husband so that when he speaks to her she is startled.]*

GEORGE:

How did you make out?

CONNIE:

You're a dear. I'm fine. I'm all ready. Going to give it now. *[She goes down the steps with the needle poised in her hand—to forestall any sudden move on the patient's part.]*

GEORGE:

Look out for yourself.

CONNIE:

Don't worry.

PROSPERO *[as Connie bends over him]*:

Keep away! Don't touch me! For Christ's sake.

[George watches over his wife, holding the light from the edge of the stair hole. When the light rests on Prospero's face we see that it is bloodstained from a head injury—which must have knocked him out for a time when the crash catapulted him into the cellar.]

CONNIE:

Come on, baby. Chin up. [*She rolls up Prospero's sleeve, swabs his arm, etc. Her professional manner appears to win his confidence and he does not protest further.*] Just going to give you a shot in the arm—to go to sleep so we can work on you. [*She gives him the shot.*] Wasn't so bad, was it? [*She takes another look at Prospero's leg and comes up out of the hole.*]

[*During the rest of this scene George keeps pretty well out of it. Connie goes into the kitchen, returning with a pitcher of water, soap, towel, etc. She goes down the cellar stairs again and proceeds with her nurse's task.*]

CONNIE:

I'm going to wash your face. [*She sets the pitcher on the stair, kneels beside Prospero and goes about the business of washing his face and neck. She is thorough about it, much to the patient's annoyance, but nothing more is spoken until she finishes and starts to clean up.*]

PROSPERO [*when she has finished*]:

I got to take a piss.

[*Connie comes out of the hole with her washing things and goes into the kitchen. She returns with an empty milk bottle which she takes down to Prospero, handing it to him with the single admonition:*]

CONNIE:

Careful.

[*After Prospero has finished with his use of the bottle he hands it back from where he is lying, and Connie takes it to the kitchen. Then she runs into the bedroom and gets an armful of pillows and a blanket.*]

CONNIE:

I'm going to set that fracture while the effect of the opiate is fresh on him.

GEORGE:

No!

CONNIE [*somewhat taken aback*]:

Why George!

GEORGE:

I'm not going to let you take any such responsibility on your own shoulders.

CONNIE:

At least you can let me straighten the leg out. It's criminal to leave it all bent under him as it is now. [*She has been standing with the pillows held to her breast; now she moves toward the cellar hole prepared to put them into use.*] It's a comparatively simple procedure. I've been through it hundreds of times and my seniors have been most generous in instructing us nurses. A pillow splint is a wonderful thing in such cases as long as there is no overriding. Let me look again.

[*Since George makes no further objection, after a certain gesture of deference to her husband, Connie proceeds with her business. She kneels beside Prospero and tries to straighten his twisted leg.*]

CONNIE:

I won't do more than I said—just straighten the leg out. [*to George*] Won't you help me?

[*George comes down without a word—though obviously he is against proceeding further.*]

CONNIE:

Darling!

[*George crawls around behind Prospero in the cellar, grasps him under the shoulders and pulls him backward so that the injured leg can be straightened out.*]

CONNIE [*a little out of breath—to Prospero*]:
Good boy! I thought you'd make it! We're almost through.

[*George helps raise the leg so Connie can work one of the pillows under it; the other pillow is placed on top and Connie then ties them together with bandages, George passing her the scissors when she needs them.*]

PROSPERO:
Thanks.

CONNIE:
Don't mention it. You were a wonderful sport. [*She arranges another pillow under Prospero's head and covers him with the blanket.*] There now—are you reasonably comfortable?

PROSPERO:
Perfect.

[*Connie and George come up out of the cellar.*]

CONNIE [*rubbing her back*]:
My back!

[*George is completely noncommunicative.*]

GEORGE:
When do I go for the police?

CONNIE [*after a pause*]:
Can't we keep him?

[*There is another pause.*]

GEORGE:
You surprise me.

CONNIE [*hanging her head*]:
I missed the operating room training when I realized I was giving it up probably forever—I was heartbroken. Do you think I'll soon have a baby? That will settle it.

GEORGE:

Well . . .

CONNIE:

I can take care of this case. It will give me something interesting to do while I'm waiting. It will be duck soup to me. I'm really a farm girl used to roughing it when I was younger.

GEORGE:

But for Heaven's sake, Connie. You don't realize the probable complications. You don't know a thing about this guy. Just off the road. He's probably wanted by the law. That's just the picture that fits him best: a crook wrecked in a motor accident . . . a rural area not far from the metropolis—Buffalo, we'll say—in the middle of the night, in an attempt to get away from some crime he and a pal have committed. And you want to take him in—without question?

CONNIE [*attempting to change the subject*]:

You don't realize—no man can—how dull it can be alone most of the day—nothing to do but my house work. Not that I'm objecting. [*A wave of excitement comes over her when she realizes what a chance she is missing if she does not take this man in.*] But you can't realize it, George—I love you, completely. I know you are right. I'd have a hell of a time with the man, if we could get away with it—first from the police. It isn't that I couldn't take good care of a broken leg—I've had wonderful orthopedic training in the wards of the old hospital. I'm standing here reviewing the whole course of the case, from how to get the man out of the cellar, alone—without any more assistance than you, George, could give—and into an improvised bed.

GEORGE:

You'll never get the chance. He'll be in jail long before that.

CONNIE:

Not unless we give him up first.

GEORGE:

Aw, nuts! I'm going to turn your boyfriend over to the law—if we haven't got in too deep already. Believe me, I'm not kiddin'. I want to help you but you don't realize how many headaches I'm protecting you from. I'm going to the Reickers' to phone. I'll be back in a jiffy. *[He goes out the front door.]*

[Connie sits down at the edge of the trapdoor opening and looks into the hole where her patient now lies asleep. She smiles and shakes her head as he snores loudly for a moment and she brushes away a tear.]

CONNIE:

Poor dear, you don't know half that's going to happen to you before we'll be through with you. Poor, poor dear.

[Connie gets up wearily from where she has been sitting and brings more blankets from the bedroom. She goes down to the cellar again and begins putting them carefully about the patient, one at a time so as not to wake him. She pauses frequently when he seems to waken, then goes ahead with her task as she is reassured. Finally she sits again on the hole's edge and sighs. She is startled, but makes no visible gesture when George re-enters.]

GEORGE:

I've changed my mind!

CONNIE:

Swell of you, George. *[Without getting up, she takes her husband's hand in her own.]*

GEORGE:

I thought you'd be pleased.

[Connie gets up and kisses her husband, thoughtfully and lovingly.]

CONNIE:

I'm scared to think of what we've taken on.

GEORGE:

First, we've got to lay low. [*Connie is intently listening to what her husband is saying.*] We may not be able to move him from this cellar for a week. Do you think you can take care of him here—if he gives us a break I mean—until after the cop has been here and we can establish our alibis?

CONNIE:

George, my darling, you're wonderful.

GEORGE:

I don't know. Maybe we won't be able to get away with it. How would you like to go to jail for being an accessory after the fact—or fined ten thousand dollars?

CONNIE:

We've got nothin'. You can't get money out of a stone.

GEORGE:

They can try.

CONNIE:

I don't believe it. Really wonderful of you, George, to give me such a break. Well . . .

GEORGE [*looking at his wristwatch*]:

Quarter past four. Time for us to get a little shuteye. But I'm not in the least sleepy. I'm wide awake.

CONNIE:

I think you, George, had better go to bed. It will hit you fast. I got things to do—and besides, being a nurse, I'm used to being up late.

GEORGE:

I'm not sleepy now. [*He goes over to examine the wall damaged by the accident. Connie is not interested.*] I'm not satisfied how the whole thing happened in the first place. No one will believe it, or that it could happen.

CONNIE:

What do you care? It happened. Don't talk so loud, you might wake him.

GEORGE:

Nuts to him. He won't wake up. [*He studies the fastening that locks the trapdoor in upright position against the wall when it is raised. As George builds up his theory of how the accident happened Connie turns her back, looking down at the patient—what is happening to him.*]

GEORGE:

Pay attention to what I'm telling you.

[*For a moment Connie does pay attention but her eyes soon wander as he goes on talking.*]

GEORGE:

When the car came around the curve—the motorcycle I mean—it must have skidded and hit the corner of the house at top speed, killing the driver outright—with a broken neck. But this guy on the back seat was catapulted over his friend's head and through the opening the motorcycle had made in the wall—saving his life—and right on through our "trap" which must have been left open last night—for some reason—and then the catch must have been jarred loose and the door slammed closed over him . . . You're not paying any attention to me.

CONNIE:

Sorry, George, I have important things to do.

GEORGE:

The motorcycle must have been travelling at terrific speed.

CONNIE:

I'm really not interested.

[*George stops explaining as Connie goes toward the wall cabinet to check her syringe. She renews the dose of*

morphine and places the syringe on the table with the whisky swab handy for use. Meanwhile George has been inspecting the damaged wall.]

GEORGE:

He made quite a job of it. We'll have to work on that.

CONNIE [*still talking about Prospero*]:

We'll be lucky if he doesn't get pneumonia. Have to be ready to repeat the dose of morphine if he goes into shock, which may happen at any moment now.

GEORGE:

Still want to go on with it?

CONNIE:

Absolutely. [*She goes over to George.*] Please go to bed, George. I have to stay up—besides I'm used to it. Get your rest or as much as you can of it. I'll need your help, plenty, tomorrow. Go on.

GEORGE:

Just a minute.

[At that moment, just as Connie has gone into the kitchen, Prospero suddenly rouses and, with a violent effort, which contorts his face in pain, struggles to the stairs and manages to get far enough up so that his head shows above the floor—a startling apparition. He makes no sound but looks around briefly, trying to adjust himself to his surroundings. Connie sees him just as he gets half his body out of the hole and then collapses on the floor. She drops a tray she has been carrying and calls out to George as she rushes to help her patient who has crumpled up before her.]

CONNIE [*to Prospero*]:

Go back, you poor fool. Go back, you'll hurt yourself. [*to George*] Help me!

[From this point to the end of the act, the scene is acted out in pantomime to save time and to keep the action vivid. George grasps the collapsed Prospero, who has slumped forward upon the edge of the hole. Connie leaves him in her husband's arms and with utmost speed gets her hypodermic syringe—which she has prepared against just such an emergency—from the table, goes to her knees before the patient, swabs off the skin of his shoulder with the whisky and plunges the needle in. As Prospero relaxes she gradually lets him down into the hole and herself along with him until, flat on her belly over the edge of the hole, still clinging to him, she is drawn after him—only her butt remains facing the audience. George rushes down the stairs, and there is a quick curtain as Connie hangs thus precariously suspended.]

CURTAIN

ACT II

The scene is the same. A week and a half later. It is early morning. The damaged wall has been repaired—after a fashion, though traces of the accident still remain. The broken windows have been replaced. The trapdoor is closed and the cellar is not visible. Prospero, in pajamas, lies asleep on the cot which has been set up in the main room for him. Here Connie has been nursing him since his release from the cellar. A couple of small tables have been placed at the sides of his bed, on one of which is displayed a garden rose and a spray of blossoms. Connie is wearing a simple green house dress. As the scene opens she is at the round table wrapping up a sandwich lunch for George to take to his job. George, in overalls, is sitting on the sofa, lacing up his heavy work shoes.

GEORGE:

I hate to leave you under the same roof with that crook.

CONNIE:

Sh!

GEORGE:

O.K. with me if he wakes up.

CONNIE:

Take it easy, George, or you'll queer the whole game.

GEORGE:

I don't like it.

CONNIE:

What can he do—lying flat on his back with a broken leg? It's my Christian duty to take care of him.

GEORGE:

Nuts. And dangerous—if you haven't already gone too far.

CONNIE:

Here's your lunch. I'll have a nice supper ready for you this evening. Take it easy. I'll be careful.

GEORGE:

Somehow I hate to leave you today.

CONNIE:

So far he's been a perfect angel. [*A car horn is heard outside.*] They're waiting for you. Be a good boy and don't fret. I'll be careful. Trust me.

[*Connie flexes her right arm, "making a muscle," and laughs. She kisses her husband, putting her arms around his neck. He goes out and the car is heard driving off. Connie goes to the coat stand and takes down a nurse's apron that is hanging there. Standing before the mirror she puts it on. It fits close up to the neck. Then she takes down her little starched nurse's cap. Holding it in her hands, she suddenly raises and kisses it, then puts it on, pinning it into place. Meanwhile Prospero has awakened and has been watching her with a smile.*]

CONNIE:

How long have you been watching me?

PROSPERO:

Long enough.

[*She appears irritated. She goes over to the cot, takes hold of the lower end of it and jerks it roughly around to a position from which Prospero cannot so easily follow her movements.*]

PROSPERO:

Hey! Take it easy. Don't forget, I got a broken leg. That hurts.

CONNIE:

Now you're going to have a bath.

PROSPERO:

Oh, no.

CONNIE:

Oh, yes!

[She brings in a basin, towels, etc. from the kitchen and prepares to get him ready for a bath—much to his disgust. While so doing, she begins laughing and talking.]

PROSPERO:

What are you laughing at?

CONNIE:

I told you that state trooper would be back. If we hadn't kept you hid—at least for a few days—he'd have walked right in on us.

PROSPERO:

He'll be back again. I know these guys.

CONNIE:

When he comes—we'll have our alibi ready. You were not here the last time he called—and that was earlier this week. We can say you were anywhere but here.

PROSPERO:

Smart gal—if you can get away with it.

CONNIE:

Too bad for you if I can't. Anyhow, it's worth a try. *[She proceeds with the bath, which goes along rapidly but uneventfully in routine hospital fashion until she comes to the last procedure. She soaps up a washcloth and hands it to the patient.]*

PROSPERO:

What's this for?

CONNIE:

A washcloth—to take care of your privates.

PROSPERO:

Must I?

CONNIE:

If you don't want me to do it for you.

PROSPERO:

Humph.

CONNIE:

Now don't get fresh. [*Connie hands him the washcloth and he takes care of himself while she turns away.*] Is the sun in your eyes? How do you want your eggs? Sit up. [*Connie takes a chair, turns it upside down and places it on the bed so that it supports his back when he leans on it. She goes into the kitchen, returning with a tray on which a few simple breakfast dishes are offered. She fixes a napkin about his neck.*] You can take care of yourself from here out.

PROSPERO:

Thank you very much. I don't want any eggs.

CONNIE:

O.K., no eggs.

[*Prospero starts eating his breakfast. After a moment Connie is busying herself about the room to keep the sun out of her patient's eyes while he is eating. The sound of an approaching car is heard. It stops and we hear someone getting out. Presently the motor resumes and the car drives off.*]

CONNIE [*looking out the window*]:

It's a local license. I don't recognize the man. I wonder who it could be.

[Prospero twists himself around on his bed so as to be able to look out the window. A man's face appears there, a bearded face.]

PROSPERO:

I'd know that face through frosted glass.

CONNIE:

Shall I let him in?

PROSPERO:

Why not?

[The man shades his eyes with his hand to look in. Connie waits for the knock, then shrugs her shoulders and opens the door, not too wide.]

CONNIE:

Who is it? *[Connie and the visitor look at each other while he tries to see beyond her into the room.]*

VISITOR:

May I come in?

[Connie looks back at Prospero, then opens the door wider. The stranger advances into the room. He comes over to Prospero, who smiles but says nothing.]

VISITOR:

So there you are—at last. Attended by a trained nurse, no less.

CONNIE:

Who are you?

VISITOR:

I'm his father. *[to Prospero]* We thought you were dead. No such luck. Your mother has had me covering the roads of three states on crazy tips from your gang trying to catch up with you. A waste of time. And now I found you. I ought to turn you over to the police, you crook.

PROSPERO:

That's a sweet way to talk to your own son, Dad.

[*Connie, hardly understanding what is going on, looks from one to the other. The conversation is interrupted by sounds of a car pulling up outside, and knocking at the front door. Connie answers it and stands back, not knowing what to expect. The State Trooper comes in.*]

STATE TROOPER:

Hello, sweetheart. [*seeing there are strangers present*] Pardon me. I see you have company. I hope I'm not intruding.

CONNIE:

No. This is a friend of my husband, from the mine.

STATE TROOPER:

Who?

CONNIE:

This one. [*indicating Prospero*] And this is his father—just met him, I don't rightly know his name.

STATE TROOPER:

Where you from?

VISITOR:

Mind your own business.

STATE TROOPER:

What about the young man?

PROSPERO:

John Keats.

STATE TROOPER:

Where you from?

PROSPERO:

A farm in Indiana.

[*The visitor goes over and sits down in one of the chairs at the round table.*]

STATE TROOPER:

What's your draft number?

PROSPERO:

Don't have it with me.

STATE TROOPER:

Why not?

CONNIE:

After all, this man is a guest in my house. He was hurt in the mine . . . his father came here to help us get him home.

STATE TROOPER:

Sorry kid, but I have to know what goes on in this neck of the woods—it's my business.

CONNIE:

There's a limit to your business, too. Come on, I've got things to do.

STATE TROOPER:

He's certainly struck it rich—coming in from nowhere to such a reception.

[Connie busies herself taking the chair down from the back of the bed and fixing her patient's pillows.]

STATE TROOPER:

Have you a telephone in the house?

CONNIE *[losing her temper]*:

You can see we haven't. Lay off. I'm not interested in your business. Can't you leave me alone?

STATE TROOPER:

I have certain duties to perform.

CONNIE:

Not here—and now.

STATE TROOPER:

He should have given me his draft number—or the unit he served with.

CONNIE:

Why must he? He'll do it when he's out of bed. I refuse to have him talk any more to you. He's my patient and is too sick to be bothered any longer.

STATE TROOPER:

It's for your own protection, Connie—I beg your pardon—Miss Laboard.

CONNIE:

That's not my name.

STATE TROOPER:

We're only here for your protection in these country districts when strangers might barge in on you and make trouble. We know who you are—that nurse's uniform, for instance—you didn't think you'd have use for it so soon. [*Connie looks down over her clothes for a moment, taken aback.*] Very good-looking. Don't worry about anything. We'll take care of you. And tell this guy [*indicating the bearded old man*] buses are better than nothing if you have to take a long trip. I'll be looking in on you again. Have your boyfriend have his card on him next time. We don't want to make any trouble for you, Connie. We just have to be careful. Good-bye.

CONNIE:

Thanks.

[*The Trooper goes out the door as Connie gives a sigh of relief. His car starts up and at once can be heard drawing away.*]

PROSPERO:

Thanks.

CONNIE:

You're welcome.

PROSPERO:

Push my bed against the wall. I'm going to take a nap.

[*Connie ignores this request and turns to the visitor.*]

CONNIE:

This is your son—you said.

VISITOR [*coming forward*]:

If I didn't acknowledge it the skunk might get away with it again. Look at him! I wouldn't bother with him to ask either aye or nay, but for his mother's sake—she's like to die in a week unless I can bring her some news of him. [*He pauses to take in the room and the meaning of Connie in it.*] It's her who has had me driving the roads of three states ever since we had the news of a man—not him—killed in an accident here two weeks ago.

[*During the conversation which follows, Prospero's attitude toward his father is one of contempt and derision—yet not entirely without a kind of affection. He appears to be much amused by the discussion about him.*]

CONNIE:

Where do you come from? And what's your name—and his?

VISITOR:

Ain't the punk even told you his name yet?

CONNIE:

No.

VISITOR:

Don't look to me to tell you it either. Call him Pete—that's all you need to know about him.

PROSPERO:

You never have been clever enough to be a good liar.

CONNIE:

That's not fair.

VISITOR:

What's not fair?

CONNIE:

I want to know more about him.

VISITOR:

That's fair. What'll I tell you—so you'll know? He ought to be in jail right now for robbing a bank . . .

CONNIE:

Really!

VISITOR:

—if he wasn't there for getting a girl pregnant and running out on her.

CONNIE:

Well.

PROSPERO:

Right you are—couldn't have been more accurately reported.

VISITOR:

Heard enough?

CONNIE:

Such things appear to be quite common nowadays. Tell me more.

VISITOR:

What do you want to know?

CONNIE:

Obviously he's been educated.

VISITOR:

Educated! His mother broke her heart over his education. That's what's wrong with him.

PROSPERO:

Give the guy credit—he did his best for his son, knowing how the cards were stacked against him.

CONNIE:

You can't have too much education.

VISITOR:

Not of the kind he got.

CONNIE:

What kind of woman is she?

VISITOR:

Who?

CONNIE:

His mother.

VISITOR:

A Wop.

PROSPERO:

Look at who's talking!

CONNIE:

I won't have you talk of any woman in that way.

VISITOR:

She's a Sicilian. I'm Irish. This is our only kid. She's never had but the one, but the way she's taken on about this one has driven us both about crazy. I can't get away from her! Now that I've found him I'll have to go back home and it'll start all over again. She had him christened Peter Prospero James and the Prospero stuck to him.

CONNIE:

I like it. It's the Sicilian influence.

VISITOR:

He's got it.

CONNIE:

Did he do well in school?

VISITOR:

Did he do well in school, she says!

CONNIE:

Well?

VISITOR:

Did he do well in college? Until he was fired—in his senior year. The Brain, they used to call him!

PROSPERO:

College! Christ, they ought to make them spend their sophomore year in a whorehouse—or go to a girl's school.

CONNIE:

The Brain!

VISITOR:

The Brain, no less. I got a better name for it, begging your pardon—and it comes from something lower down. But it made him leader of his gang, I suppose, after that. He's never been in the army.

[Connie reaches up and detaches her nurse's cap, placing it in her lap.]

VISITOR:

When he moved up into big company in a few years, I was ready to believe it. He's got it.

CONNIE:

What does he tell you?

VISITOR:

That natural-born liar, you can't believe anything he tells you. And that's not the half of it.

PROSPERO:

Don't expect him to give me away—he's too dumb!

CONNIE:

Tell me more.

VISITOR:

Why should I? I've showed him up—let him take care of himself from here out. I've done my duty by his mother, I'm through. [*He starts to get up preparatory to leaving.*]

CONNIE:

You can't go now, because obviously there's more to tell.

VISITOR [*sitting down again*]:

What do you want to know?

CONNIE:

About his mother.

PROSPERO:

Mother love!

VISITOR:

Don't make me talk about her.

PROSPERO:

The love of a man for his wife when she's most constipated.

CONNIE [*to Prospero*]:

You're disgusting. [*to the visitor*] That's just what I want to hear. [*pleading*] Please!

VISITOR:

Don't start *that*.

CONNIE:

I'm sorry. I won't do it again.

VISITOR:

See that you don't. [*There is a pause.*] That no-good son of a bitch has wrecked that woman. How would you like to have a son who's keeping out of the penitentiary, where he ought to be, because someone else is taking the rap for him—till his luck runs out.

CONNIE:

Poor boy.

VISITOR:

Do you mean *him*? You're making a mistake.

CONNIE:

I can't believe it.

VISITOR:

Wake up. [*He gets ready again to leave.*] Take my advice and don't mess any more into this business. It's over your head. He's a no-good guy. I'm his father and I know what I'm talking about. God forgive him.

CONNIE [*doing her best to control herself*]:

How did you find out he was here?

VISITOR:

A little bird told me.

CONNIE:

I see.

VISITOR:

His mother, right this minute, should be in the bughouse. If it weren't for her and because you look to be a decent enough girl, I'd see that you quit the whole business right now . . . how can you get away with it? But I want to warn you. [*He pauses.*] Can I have a glass of water?

[*Connie brings him one from the kitchen.*]

VISITOR:

I didn't come here on a bus but in my own car. I left it in the next town and got a lift over here. I don't have much more to tell you. We're from Maryland. I've got money in the bank, made it farming—a thing I could never make my good-for-nothing son take an interest in. I'm not poor. But this punk is a criminal. He and his buddies tried to rob a

bank . . . and they almost got away with it . . . it was my own bank.

[*Connie keeps silent.*]

VISITOR:

Can you imagine what his mother must be going through? And can you imagine that that good-for-nothing writes poetry? His mother has always adored him. I know everyone is a thief nowadays in business. Thievery is an honest profession to hear him talk. I'm sick of such talk. You should hear him. His mother listened. I don't know too much about it but I could see through *him*. He had her twisted about his little finger. He never worked on the farm. That was beneath his dignity, the bastard. I've had my headaches with her until I had to put her in the hospital. Now you know enough about him to protect yourself against him—if you want to. I'm going to hit the road again until I can find a place it'll be safe for me to send a wire from.

CONNIE:

Thank you for speaking so frankly to me.

VISITOR:

You're welcome—though I doubt it will do much good. You're a woman and women are this sort of man's special bait. I wish I had more influence with the good Lord to damn him to hell into eternity.

[*With a sneer aimed at his son and no further word spoken, Prospero's father lets himself out the door and can be seen through the window striding off.*]

PROSPERO [*to his father*]:

I'll be seeing you. [*to Connie*] Now you know.

CONNIE:

And now it will be up to me to decide what I'm going to do with you—give you up to the police or otherwise.

PROSPERO:

Have you any choice?

CONNIE:

I don't know. All these things, after all, have nothing to do with me. If I decide not to give you up no one can make me. It remains a purely personal matter between me and the patient under my care . . . whatever I know . . . not to be betrayed. Whatever may be my sympathies . . . no one other than me knows what I have heard.

[At this point Connie goes into the bedroom for a moment. While she is absent Prospero attempts to get out of bed—and fails.]

CONNIE *[coming back into the room]*:

Oh, get back. You know better than that. *[She straightens him out on the cot.]* Don't you ever do that again. You are my patient. And what I say to you is the law. I'm not giving you up. That's final—so relax and make the best of it. *[With that decision, a great weight seems to have dropped from her shoulders; she becomes on the instant a different person. For her, and for Prospero also, though they are not fully aware of it, the whole atmosphere has changed.]* I'm not giving you up. *[She reaches in her pocket for the nurse's cap which she had discarded and places it, cockeyed, on her hair. She goes to the mirror and laughs at what she sees there.]*

[Prospero does not at first understand what is taking place within Connie's head but he quickly begins to catch on—she is divesting herself of the pretense of reverting to being a nurse. Now she takes off her nurse's cap and, with a wry smile, tosses it onto the table. Then she removes her nurse's apron, throwing it over the back of a chair. Now she is dressed more or less as any young housewife might be. She has been withdrawn into herself, not looking at Prospero. Now she turns back to him.]

CONNIE:

May I get you some lunch?

PROSPERO:

Sure, I'm hungry.

CONNIE:

Maybe not. It's pretty early.

PROSPERO:

Suit yourself. [*There is a pause.*] I don't deny that I may be the brat's father . . .

CONNIE:

I couldn't be more indifferent.

PROSPERO:

—but they can't make me marry the girl—because I'm married already.

CONNIE [*contemplating him*]:

You're a real mixed-up man.

PROSPERO:

Self-defense.

CONNIE:

I'm sorry for you.

PROSPERO:

Have you a phonograph in the joint? Let's have some music.

CONNIE:

In a moment, I'll see. [*She goes to the window, sits down and looks out, opens, then closes the window, looks at the flowers she has gathered earlier—as if contemplating whether to throw them out—then decides to keep them, and smiles to herself. Prospero watches her.*] That was foolish of me to want to bring you your lunch so soon after you had had your breakfast.

PROSPERO:

Nervous?

CONNIE [*still looking out the window*]:

Maybe. Did you really rob a bank?

PROSPERO:

I was in on it. My pal's dead—as you know.

CONNIE [*after pausing to take it in*]:

Where did you go to college? Maryland?

PROSPERO:

Princeton.

CONNIE:

Really?

PROSPERO:

While it lasted . . .

CONNIE:

You've had quite a career, so far.

PROSPERO:

Haven't I.

CONNIE:

If you're not both lying as fast as you talk.

PROSPERO:

Nothing could be nearer the truth.

[*Connie quits looking out the window and turns toward the bed.*]

CONNIE:

Do you want to sit up?

PROSPERO:

Sure.

[*Connie goes about putting another pillow into the bed back of her patient. As he sits up she locks her arm with*

his to support him while she fluffs up his pillows. During this maneuver he makes an attempt to kiss her. She extricates herself rather roughly and stands back a step.]

CONNIE:

Don't try that again.

PROSPERO:

Why not?

CONNIE [*with a laugh*]:

You'll be surprised.

PROSPERO [*quite sincerely*]:

You mean you'll beat me up?

CONNIE:

You're a very sweet man, but you can go too far.

PROSPERO:

You've forgot the juke.

CONNIE:

Oh yes. Let's see. We have one but it's not very good.

[Connie goes into the bedroom and returns with a phonograph which is of an old vintage. It makes Prospero laugh. Nevertheless she sets it up and starts it going. The record is a song—"It was at Aunt Dinah's quilting party, I was seeing Nellie home." Prospero pays little attention to the music which, as a matter of fact, can barely be heard.]

PROSPERO:

I admire you—you don't seem afraid of anything.

CONNIE:

Quite wrong. [*There is a pause.*] I'm afraid of you.

PROSPERO:

You don't show it.

CONNIE:

You're not very observant. [*She takes up some knitting from the wall cabinet shelf but is too absorbed in the conversation to do more than hold it in her hands.*] Now really tell me about your mother. You loved her, didn't you?

PROSPERO:

That dope.

CONNIE:

That doesn't mean you didn't love her.

PROSPERO:

For Christ's sake, shut off that music.

CONNIE [*turning off the phonograph*]:

I wish I had had your bringing-up in my hands. I'd have made a man of you—it's too late now. Have you ever thought of going back to college?

PROSPERO:

She tried to make me. No go.

CONNIE:

Go on. I'm listening.

PROSPERO:

That son of a bitch. He's got money. But he kept her slaving more than half her life. No running water in the house—she had to carry it up from the well in the dead of winter.

CONNIE:

That must have been years ago. The Brain should have been able long since to find a way to help her out of that.

PROSPERO:

You're kiddin'.

CONNIE:

Isn't that what your friends call you: The Brain?

PROSPERO:

Touché. [*He smiles.*] Haven't you some good jazz discs around?

CONNIE:

What are we going to do with ourselves while we're waiting for that bone to heal?

PROSPERO:

Haven't you even a pack of cards around the place?

CONNIE:

Let's pretend!

PROSPERO:

Not what I have in mind. I got something more practical to suggest. Here we are on a desert isle—the *New Yorker* always has a cartoon on the subject, hellishly funny. In a way, at their best. What Thurber would like to say in some of his cartoons and almost suggests. Have you ever read the *Decameron*—Macy's paper edition—or Rabelais? Really hot stuff.

CONNIE:

What are you coming to?

PROSPERO:

Or a play by Tennessee Williams?

CONNIE:

Well?

PROSPERO:

You won't be shocked?

CONNIE:

Shoot it.

PROSPERO:

Take off your clothes and come here on the bed with me.

CONNIE:

Old stuff. Every student nurse has to get used to that from her male patients.

PROSPERO:

Come on.

CONNIE:

I might hurt your leg.

PROSPERO:

I'll take care of that.

CONNIE:

You must think I'm awful simple.

PROSPERO:

Just slip off your dress and lie down beside me.

CONNIE:

Nothing could be simpler.

PROSPERO:

So you refuse. Quit stalling. You know you want it as much as I do.

CONNIE:

Poor dear. I think I'd better put on my cap again to remind you—have you forgotten that I am your nurse?

PROSPERO:

You bitch.

[Connie retrieves her nurse's cap from the table. With a broad grin she places the now rather crumpled cap on her head, then facing Prospero, spreads her hands out and says, in her best college French:]

CONNIE:

Voilà, Monsieur!

PROSPERO:

You god damn bastard.

CONNIE:

Isn't it getting about time for an apology? Or shall I throw you out?

[They contemplate each other seriously for a moment—how to take each other—and then Prospero laughs.]

PROSPERO:

I apologize.

CONNIE:

See that you mean it this time—because we got at least two more weeks together in this room—if we can stand it. *[She blows him a kiss.]* I shouldn't have done that.

PROSPERO:

I'll get you yet.

CONNIE:

What would you like for lunch? We have a delicious sandwich of sardines fresh out of the tin. And stuffed olives—fine for an appetizer—with Romaine lettuce from our own garden, and anchovies while they last.

CURTAIN

ACT III

The scene is the same. Two weeks later. Connie and George are seated at the round table where George is finishing up his breakfast. It is 6 A.M.—time for him to go on the job. They talk in somewhat lowered voices. Prospero is still asleep on his cot, or pretends to be—as George well knows.

GEORGE:

When you going to get rid of your boyfriend?

CONNIE:

Pretty soon now.

GEORGE:

Because I'm thinking of taking next week off the job. We're light now and I think you may need me 'round the house.

CONNIE:

Not necessarily, but suit yourself. I looked last night. The wound is well healed. It goes fast in a young person; we're about ready to put on a dry dressing. And the putting of some weight on the foot. I've got my fingers crossed.

PROSPERO [*opening his eyes*]:

I tried it out last night. It feels swell.

CONNIE:

Just like you, ignoring my specific orders. So much the worse for you if the leg caves under you. Wise guy. How did it really feel? Well . . .

PROSPERO:

I'll take the chance.

CONNIE:

You'll take the chance? Of being chunked into the hospital so fast if I hear more of that sort of shenanigans out of you!

GEORGE:

Well . . . take care of yourself. I'll be home tonight—for the week.

CONNIE:

Fussing again? [*At the door she kisses him on the mouth and smiles confidently, as much as to say: you have nothing to worry about. She calls him back.*] We've forgotten something. We have no clothes for him.

GEORGE:

I can't keep Fred waiting. Look around the place.

CONNIE:

O.K., O.K., O.K. We'll find something later. Beat it. [*George leaves.*] I've patched up the underwear so that I think it'll hold together. There are George's old shoes—if you can wear them.

PROSPERO:

I can go barefoot.

CONNIE:

No you can't. We'll have to find a pair of pants. George is just about your size, I think. He must have an old pair of work pants hanging in the closet. [*She goes into the bedroom for a moment.*] Here we are! Try 'em on. [*He makes an impulsive move to get out of bed.*] Whoa, kid! [*She restrains him.*] Not yet. Don't try to stand up. You'll fall on your face. Put your feet into 'em first. Then dangle them.

[*Prospero tries on the clothes while still lying on his back in the bed and immediately stands up.*]

CONNIE:

Wonderful!

[*Almost at once he sinks back on the bed, his head whirling.*]

PROSPERO:

Wow!

CONNIE:

Wise guy! Thought I was kiddin' you.

[*She brings him the coffee left from her own breakfast. He sips it, lying on the bed.*]

PROSPERO:

Thank you. That's better.

CONNIE:

Take it easy now. You're not completely well yet. Sit up more gradually and I'll bring you the rest of your breakfast.

PROSPERO:

No, just the coffee. Heat it a little.

CONNIE:

Shut up. I know what I'm doing. All men are the same. Calm down. [*As he sits on the edge of the bed, she brings him fruit and cereal on a tray.*] Sorry I don't have anything better than prunes to celebrate the getting out of bed. Can't give you anything else. Hens not laying.

PROSPERO [*starting to eat*]:

Tastes swell.

CONNIE:

How's the leg feel now?

PROSPERO:

Tell you later—after I get my breath. I thought I was going to walk right off as soon as my feet hit the ground. I think I'll be all right in a little while.

CONNIE:

Lean back on the pillow while I put away the breakfast things. [*He does what she bids him do, and she puts a pillow behind his head.*]

PROSPERO:

You certainly are sweet to me.

CONNIE:

I mean to be.

PROSPERO:

Forget George.

CONNIE:

There you go again.

[*She leaves the room a moment. While she is gone Prospero gets out of bed again and this time, feeling considerably stronger, takes a few halting steps, then sits again on the edge of the bed.*]

CONNIE [*returning*]:

I see you got up again. Lemme see you use your legs.

PROSPERO:

Oh boy!

[*Trying to use them, he finds the legs much stronger. He gimps lamely about the room. More to steady himself than anything else, he catches Connie about the waist and takes a few dance steps. She enjoys it and lets herself go. In the excitement of the movement she allows him to kiss her on the mouth but springs back immediately from the embrace, hands to her mouth as he, deprived of her support, collapses across the bed out of breath.*]

PROSPERO:

Wait a minute, I'm winded. [*Connie, with the tray in her hands, is starting from the room.*] Hey, wait a minute!

[*He starts to sit up. She pauses in the middle of the room.*]
Give me another kiss!

CONNIE [*shaking her head*]:
Not now. You've had enough.

PROSPERO [*scrambling up from the bed*]:
What do you mean, enough? We're only startin' to go.

[*Prospero holds her by the arms and kisses her on the cheek as she averts her face.*]

CONNIE:
Let me put these things down. [*She turns and faces him.*]

PROSPERO:
Come on!

CONNIE:
No.

PROSPERO:
What do you mean, no?

CONNIE:
Sooner or later we got to face it. I'm not going to bed with you.

PROSPERO:
Quitter.

CONNIE:
I'm not a quitter.

PROSPERO:
Quitter.

CONNIE:
Lie down on the bed again. You need it.

PROSPERO:
I don't need it for what ails me now. Quitter.

CONNIE:

Have it your own way—but don't think you can get anywhere by these methods.

PROSPERO:

I'll rape you.

CONNIE:

Don't try it. Be a nice little boy, and let's bury the hatchet.

PROSPERO:

You bitch. I've said it before and I'll say it again. You cheap bitch! You know what you want. You know what you want to pay for it—nuthin'.

CONNIE:

Speak for yourself, my dear.

PROSPERO:

You've led me on.

[At this moment there is a loud knock at the front door. Connie goes to open it. It is Lem, the postman. Lem is somewhere in the sixties and wears gold-rimmed spectacles. He is dressed in dark, shapeless pants, a checked cotton shirt, without tie, and an ancient hunter's cap. He sees Prospero and from his manner it is plain that he prides himself on having been able to locate such a rare customer.]

CONNIE:

Why Lem, come in.

[When Lem removes his cap to take out a letter, it is revealed that he is completely bald.]

LEM:

Take a look at this. Have you any such person living at this address? A registered letter: a Mr. P. McNeil. No one has heard about anyone of that name living around here.

PROSPERO:

Must be me. *[He comes forward to examine the letter.]*

LEM:

Hot diggity. It's registered. You'll have to sign for it. [*He produces a pencil. While Prospero signs Lem goes on talking.*] Leave it to me. Leave it to the old houn' dog to smell out the business of missing letters. This one has been lying about the office without a decent address on it for more than a week. Have you signed for it? O.K. So you're Mr. P. McNeil. [*He extends his hand.*] Glad to know you. So long, all. Got to get back to the office. [*He goes out.*]

[*Prospero, after looking at the letter, shoves it in his pocket unopened and turns away. A car is heard stopping at the front door. Connie is startled and goes to the window to look.*]

CONNIE:

Why for heaven's sake—it's George!

GEORGE [*greeting his wife with a kiss*]:

Surprise! I just saw the postman leaving. Any bad news?

CONNIE:

No. Just a letter for our guest.

GEORGE:

Oh. How are we getting on since breakfast? I see you got him up. Have any trouble?

PROSPERO:

A little. How do you like the rig she made up for me out of your old clothes?

GEORGE:

Not bad.

PROSPERO:

Just about the same size.

GEORGE:

Yeah. I see you got a letter.

PROSPERO:

Haven't opened it yet.

[George turns away from Prospero, giving him a chance to concern himself with the letter. Prospero sits on the bed and opens it. George turns toward Connie, full of the good luck of his unexpected day off.]

GEORGE [to Connie]:

Hot dog! They decided to give us the rest of the week off—right at the beginning of the fishing season. Pete'll be here just as soon as he can find his fishing tackle. Give me your order so I can get it at the store on the way back. Some luck. Can you imagine such a break? Did I kiss you when I came in? Sorry. I forgot. [He kisses her again.]

CONNIE:

You kissed me when you came in just now. [She takes him by the collar and kisses him again. Prospero is reading his letter. Confidentially, to her husband:] Listen darling, don't leave me again today.

GEORGE:

What a time to pick for *that*. When I have a chance to go fishin'.

CONNIE:

Forget it.

GEORGE:

Whatever you say.

CONNIE [suddenly realizing she has given herself away]: You sweetheart! You're going fishing. I'm forgetting my job as a nurse—getting rusty. Of course you're going fishin'.

GEORGE:

I've forgot it already.

CONNIE [turning to Prospero whom she sees is listening]: Help me to make this guy go—fishin'.

GEORGE:

No.

CONNIE:

You're going fishing, I insist on it. I *insist* on it. Bring me back a good mess for supper. I got to clean up this house. Do you want me to put the fishin' kit in your hands, or can you find it yourself? You know you're burned up to go. What'll you do around here anyhow the rest of the morning? I'm going to put this guy out in the yard—to get the sun. He needs it.

GEORGE:

You're a wonder! I'll do what you want me to.

CONNIE:

You'd better.

[George goes into the bedroom to get his fishing things. Connie sees the letter on the bed where Prospero has left it to go to the window.]

CONNIE:

My I read this?

PROSPERO *[over his shoulder]*:

O.K.—it's a week old, anyhow.

[Connie sits on the bed and reads the letter carefully.]

CONNIE:

Very interesting. So your pals are coming to pick you up at any minute. That will be fine. I hope they bring you some proper clothes.

[Prospero continues looking out the window as George comes back into the room with a professional-looking outfit: rubber waders; rod, reel, and net; his creel in his hand; flies in his hatband—ready to hit the river.]

CONNIE:

Good!

GEORGE:

I think I heard Pete's car—I'll wait for him outside at the corner. Sure it's all right with you?

CONNIE [*tossing it off*]:

Have a good time.

[*George leaves.*]

PROSPERO:

It certainly looks good out there. I think I'll go out.

CONNIE:

Get yourself a chair. The sun is right for you to get the most good of it. Clear out, I've got work to do. [*She looks behind the cot.*] Here's a folding chair. Do you want me to tuck you in with a blanket?

PROSPERO:

What do you take me for, a cripple?

CONNIE:

You were, no longer ago than this morning.

PROSPERO:

Don't kid yourself.

CONNIE:

Come on. Get out.

PROSPERO [*opening the door and taking a deep breath*]:

Oh boy, does that air feel good!

[*He slowly makes his way outdoors with Connie's assistance. She assists him warily, but he is too taken up with himself to make any trouble. She carries the chair out and is gone a moment, setting it up and getting him settled. Then she comes back into the room alone and prepares to*

scrub the floor. We hear a woman talking to Prospero outside.]

CONNIE:

Uh-huh.

[Down on her knees scrubbing, Connie tries to see through the door who is there and fails. She listens again as the conversation continues. Finally a young woman bursts into the room. It is Rosy, Connie's next door neighbor. Rosy is a straight-legged, skinny girl who can't weigh much more than ninety-five pounds. She has a pretty, not to say emaciated, face which reveals her to be chronically over-excited and over-sexed. She thinks nothing of coming to her neighbor's house, even appearing before a male stranger, dressed only in the slip in which she has been doing her laundry and kitchen work. She is bare-legged but has on a pair of bedroom slippers. She is baffled from having had the sun in her eyes and also by the fact that Connie is scrubbing behind the bed where she cannot, at first, see her.]

ROSY [*greatly excited*]:

Where are yuh?

CONNIE [*calmly*]:

Right here. [*She rises to her feet.*]

ROSY:

Oh. I come to borrow a scoop of sugar. Who the hell is that glamour boy you've been hidin' under your apron from the world?

CONNIE:

Let me get you the sugar.

ROSY:

Nuts with that, who is he? I'm a son of a bitch if I ever saw such a good-looking guy running around loose in this neck of the woods—next to my husband, but he's a different type.

[*Connie gets a jar of sugar from the kitchen. Meanwhile Rosy goes to the door and yells at Prospero.*]

ROSY:

Hey, come on in here where I can see you. [*She keeps the door open.*] To hell with the flies! I want to see you. [*Prospero gimps into the room.*] You're lame, huh?

PROSPERO:

None of your business.

ROSY:

Hey, snotty. Don't be that way. What's your name? Where do you come from?

PROSPERO [*to Connie*]:

Take it away. I'm going back into the yard.

ROSY:

Don't go. I'll talk nice.

PROSPERO:

See that you do. I want to talk to you. I'll go crazy if I don't talk to someone intelligent around here once in a while. Would you by the greatest stretch of your fancy call yourself intelligent?

ROSY:

Touché. Let's go on from there.

PROSPERO:

I bet you got some French blood in your veins.

ROSY:

Right. My mother was born on 34th Street.

PROSPERO:

Where the cheap whores used to come from.

ROSY:

My mother *was* a whore in the old days.

[Connie finds herself out of her depth. She is a little shocked, in spite of her nurse's training, at the twist the conversation has taken. Prospero is grimly amused and proceeds to draw out Rosy whom he suddenly finds he likes.]

ROSY:

Come on, tell me about yourself.

PROSPERO *[to Connie]*:

May I have your permission to talk freely to this stupid bitch?

CONNIE:

I object to my guests being insulted in my house.

PROSPERO:

I beg your pardon. You're right. It won't occur again.

CONNIE *[to Rosy]*:

I think you'd better go now—your water must be getting cold.

ROSY:

No, I don't mind his talk. It's clever. Just the way they talk in the smart magazines. How long have you been married?

CONNIE:

Six months.

ROSY:

How come no kids? You got a perfectly good husband, ain't you?

CONNIE:

Give us time.

ROSY *[laughing]*:

Maybe you're pregnant now. *[She looks pointedly at Connie.]* Stand up!

[*Connie, caught off her guard at the suddenness of the command, does as she is bid, consciously flattening her belly. Both Rosy and Prospero look her over critically.*]

ROSY:

Maybe not—it's flat enough, but I remember what my French mother used to say and she was right as far as my six kids were concerned.

PROSPERO:

Do you mean to say you got six kids?

ROSY:

Yea-ah.

PROSPERO:

You don't look it. [*Rosy dismisses the subject with a deprecatory and typically French gesture.*] What did your mother use to say?

ROSY:

En ventre plat
Enfant il-y-a!

PROSPERO:

What does that mean?

ROSY:

Don't you speak French?

PROSPERO:

Not that easily.

ROSY:

I thought you were a college man.

PROSPERO:

Tell me what it says.

ROSY [*translating*]:

A flat belly in a young girl
means there's a baby inside.

PROSPERO:

What do you know!

[Connie, who has been standing, immediately sits down.]

ROSY:

What of it? Unless you have other ideas. *[with a frankly lewd gesture toward Prospero]* Maybe it'll be twins like it was with me the first two or three times. Brats. But I love 'em. They don't keep me home. My husband is an orchestra leader. He plays the alto sax. I accompany him when he practices. The neighbors give the kids their bottles if I'm too drunk to do it when I get home at dawn. It's a scream. I must be getting back to my husband—to my duties, ha ha!, as they say in the movies. *[to Prospero]* Piece me to the turn in the road. I'll show you where I live. Come on.

PROSPERO *[hesitating as he thinks of his game leg]*:

I don't know whether I can make it or not. *[Connie shakes her head at him.]* Let's try.

[They move toward the door, Rosy helping Prospero to get started.]

ROSY:

'At-a-boy! It's not far. I can't understand how I came to miss hearing about you before this.

PROSPERO *[going out the door]*:

You were too busy with your husband.

ROSY:

You said it.

[They leave, closing the door behind them. Connie watches them from the window. Then, deep in thought, she turns to make the bed, which she does as only a nurse knows how to do—rapidly and expertly. Next she dusts

about the room a bit with a cloth and gathers a miscellaneous handful of sewing and mending together, putting it on the bedside table for later disposal. She has failed to notice an infant's nightgown which she had started to embroider sometime during the past weeks. It is near the top of the heap, completely forgotten. Connie is a little surprised to hear Prospero's returning footsteps. She hurries to open the door for him.]

PROSPERO [*at once sitting down*]:
Whew!

CONNIE:
Don't you think you'd better lie down on the bed?

PROSPERO:
Uh-huh. Just give me time to catch my breath. [*As Connie picks up her sewing from the table beside his bed, he catches sight of the baby's dress.*] What's that? [*He leans over awkwardly and snatches it from her. She is startled, then reaches to have it back. He holds it up tantalizingly.*] You bitch.

CONNIE [*angrily snatching the garment away from him*]:
Mind your own business.

PROSPERO [*laughing at her*]:
You ought to have your ass spanked.

CONNIE:
You wouldn't be man enough.

PROSPERO:
I leave that to your husband. You cheapskate, you thought you could play both ends against the middle, didn't you? [*Connie does not answer him.*] From the very beginning I spotted you. No nerve. No guts. Just wanted to play like any other jerk. I really thought, after I came to and saw what had been going on, that you had something. Oh, I have to thank you for what you did for me, I acknowledge

it. But I didn't realize how far you were over your head, wallowing around in the water. All that trained-nurse bunk! What does a trained nurse know that any tart from Eighth Street or the Bronx couldn't teach her, or Vassar College couldn't teach her—with the aid of contraceptives? Or any other whorish married woman? But you didn't have the nerve. You were yellow, through and through and through. I could tell you about some married women I've known—you'd be surprised. Right around you, wherever you come from—good girls with kids in the grades, good-looking, the best. It's nothing against them—just the opposite—that they enjoy a little free screwing once in a while. Women are mostly unlike men in that respect—they get tired of it and want to go back to their knitting and contract after a while, unless they have a real hot buddy. But I thought you were wise to all that. Was I mistaken! You're a hick, a real hick. You fooled me. I was flat on my back. With a little assistance from you I could have made good. I'm no fairy, not even double-gaited. I don't blame them with women turning to be that way themselves if you know the insides of modern menages. I gave you your chance, but you ran out on me . . .

[Connie's interest has been waning as she concentrates on her own somber thoughts. Prospero notices it, and to call her attention back to himself leans forward and jerks away the baby's garment which she has been holding dejectedly between her fingers. That does the trick. Aroused out of her inattention, she springs into defense of her womanly prerogatives—to retrieve her property. He holds the garment out of the way of her infuriated grasp. Finding herself frustrated, she swings her open palm out with the full strength of her powerful body and gives him a slap in the face, enough to jar him back on his heels. Instinctively, he comes back with a straight left to her chin—knocking her unconscious. She falls to the floor at his feet and rolls

slowly over, her head going under the edge of the bed. Prospero, startled, bends over her, but attempting to move the dead weight of her unconscious body is too much for him with his half-crippled leg. He struggles a moment, exhausting himself. Then when she does not react, he starts back and looks about for assistance, but realizes there can be none. Looking down at her, drawing the edge of the quilt back to do so, he panics.]

PROSPERO:

She can't be dead!

[Prospero scrambles to his feet and stumbles out the door, leaving it open behind him. Connie comes gradually to, disentangles herself from the bedclothes and starts to get up, looking about for Prospero.]

CONNIE:

Prospero!

[She realizes he is not there and slowly gets up. As she heads toward the kitchen, George comes in at the front door.]

GEORGE:

What's with him? Where's he going?

CONNIE:

Close the door, would you?

GEORGE *[noticing Connie's sewing on the floor]*:

What's been going on here?

CONNIE:

Just straightening the room up a little. Did you catch any fish?

GEORGE:

Somehow I didn't have the heart for it with you here alone. *[after a moment]* Are you sure you're all right. What's happened to your boyfriend?

[*The sound of an auto horn draws her to the window.*]

CONNIE:

There he goes. He's getting in that car with his lame leg, poor thing. It must be his friends. [*There is the sound of a whistle from outside, the shrill whistle of a man blowing between his fingers.*] They're calling me. [*Connie opens the door and stands in the doorway.*] He's blowing me a kiss. [*after a moment*] He's going away. There he goes. Forever.

[*Connie returns, bewildered for the moment, then flings herself on the bed. In the grip of her disappointment, she breaks down and, in a violent fit of hysteria, begins pounding the bed with her fist and weeping. George is alarmed and tries to comfort her. She brushes him aside. Then she suddenly turns and clings to him, clasping him tightly about the neck.*]

CONNIE:

He hit me.

GEORGE:

The son of a bitch!

[*A car is heard approaching. It stops outside the door, following which there is a knock. Connie looks at George questioningly and puts her finger to her lips, warning him to keep silent. George opens the door to admit the State Trooper, who doesn't come all the way in but leans on the door post.*]

STATE TROOPER:

Hi, kid. Hi, Connie. [*They acknowledge his greeting tacitly.*] Sorry to bother you—but who was that just leaving in the red sports car? I've seen that car around quite a bit recently. [*Connie and George exchange glances. She is silent and he waits for her to speak.*] Friend of yours? [*He gives Connie a broad wink.*]

CONNIE:

Could be.

STATE TROOPER:

O.K. [*He nods his head understandingly.*] These hot days!

[*The Trooper leaves and we hear him get into his car and drive off. Connie looks after him, then slowly closes the door.*]

CURTAIN

Notes on William Carlos Williams as Playwright

Dr. Williams's interest in drama dates from 1903, when he played Polonius in a Mask and Wig production of *Mr. Hamlet of Denmark* at the University of Pennsylvania. In 1909 he wrote his first play, *Betty Putnam*, which was produced on the embankment of the Tennis Club in his home town of Rutherford, New Jersey. In London in 1910 Ezra Pound took him to see Ibsen's *Ghosts*. In 1912, while he was building up his medical practice and settling into marriage, he became a member of the Grantwood Group interested in poetry and playwriting, together with Alfred Kreymborg, Robert Carlton Brown, Maxwell Bodenheim, Mina Loy, William Zorach and others. At the Provincetown Playhouse on Macdougall Street in New York City's Greenwich Village, he acted in Kreymborg's *Lima Beans* with Mina Loy and Zorach, and for it he wrote his first verse play, *The Old Apple Tree*, which was lost but which Williams never forgot. Later he wrote several other verse plays, some of which were produced by amateur groups in Rutherford.

As early as 1934 Williams had been working on the libretto for an opera on George Washington. This play, developed from the germs of his *In the American Grain*, matured slowly, as he explains (1961):

"The sesquicentennial of Washington's presidency—these were great years for me. My brother was a prominent architect in New York. When it began to be talked about that an opera was to be written on the theme, I proposed to

Ed that he get busy on the Flushing Meadow site where the Fair was to be held and design me a setting—which he did and we were off.

“An opera. Tibor Serly, musician and composer, was introduced to me. I also met his father, a most interesting old man, a friend of Bartok. We began to have preliminary auditions in an apartment overlooking Riverside Drive and it seemed hardly any time before something more material toward the opera of my dreams began to be realized.

“In one of my earliest prose books, *In the American Grain*, Washington was strongly mentioned, but no more than mentioned. Now I was ready to dwell on the figure of our first President and make much of him as the primary figure of our nation. The only trouble was that Washington was a silent man; it was hard to conceive of him as a figure in an opera. Despite his stature and heroic demeanor, Hamilton despised him. That placed Hamilton. But how to give Washington the figure he must have on the stage—to be taken seriously? There was a story involving the young people of Mt. Vernon during some merrymaking they had initiated—they were in the thick of it when the figure of the great man appeared down the stairs. At once all merrymaking ended and a great silence fell upon all of those present. The gaiety was killed. Washington was upset because basically he loved the raucous if crushing humor of horseplay. But he couldn't enter into that humor.

“That could be shown on the stage but once only. So the role of Washington had to be conceived wordlessly. I accepted that, but it made for a figure that appeared mostly at intervals or in the background; the ‘operatic’ had to be mainly with the women and the lighter young men who were his aides.

“Few realize how much the growth and development to manhood of George Washington was identified with the development of the country itself. But the country knew it, and he himself knew that a failure on his part would

have meant the total collapse of the cause of the colonies themselves. When he said that if he were defeated on the general front he would have no choice but to retreat into western Pennsylvania to carry on the war as a guerilla, he meant what he said and the country knew that he would do just that. He was a grimly dedicated man. From his first devoted love for his friend's wife, pursued failingly for all of his youth, that was made clear to him. He was a tough man to beat. He could not give in without losing everything. But he had nevertheless to take a second place, even if his heart would be broken. His Sally must have disappeared in the end.

"The intimate story of his development is forecast in detail from this point to his death. We shall be forever left in a quandary by Martha's decision to destroy their correspondence to the last item, which she did. We should have known more of George Washington had she not stuck to her decision. But his letters were the best part of him."

Music for *The First President* has been composed by Theodore Harris, but there has as yet been no production. The libretto was first published in *The American Caravan* in 1936.

Around 1940 his medical interests began to coalesce with his dramatic instincts, and he wrote *Many Loves*, of which he recalls (1961):

"*Trial Horse No. 1*, or *Many Loves*, was taken on as a project for the Little Theatre of Rutherford twenty years ago as a group of three one-act plays. They were too difficult for the cast we had at our disposal to perform. At this time, Noel Coward had a group of three one-act plays which he was producing on Broadway with considerable success. I saw them and it gave me an idea. Why not take my own three plays and combine them under one title? This I got to work on at once and completed the play *Trial Horse No. 1*.

"I had been a physician all my adult life. During these

years I had encountered many cases of aberrant sex. One case in particular created for me the character of Hubert, which I wove into the play in the course of the development of the plot, making a dramatic contrast between him and the normal characters. It interested me to remember the incidents which had developed between my nurses and this flagrant deviant as he appeared among my patients in the old French Hospital on West 34th Street in New York. I had to invent a character to fill out the contours which interested me and make three acts of it. It was fun and excited me no end. I had my troubles with the actors, who did not want to impersonate the character I had depicted.

"Well, in the end, when finally the play was produced professionally at the Living Theatre, we put it over with the assistance of Judith Malina who played the lead part with distinction."

Many Loves, directed and designed by Julian Beck, opened at the Living Theatre in New York on January 13, 1959 with Judith Malina playing the Alise-Serafina-Agnes Breen-Clara role, George Miller as Hubert, Ronald Durling as Peter, Robert Berger as Doc, Eileen Fulton as Ann, William Callan as Pete, Rudd Lowry as George, and a strong cast in the supporting roles. It had many excellent notices and ran in repertory for nearly a year.

"There are also a couple of plays which float about the atmosphere, much as one imagines the bodies of Paolo and Francesca to be floating in hell—without a resting place," Williams wrote to Dorothy Norman in 1947. "What a pity, for I am sure they could not possibly be as bad as what one pays to see on the boards today." One of these plays was his *Dream of Love*, of which he writes (1961):

"Having written one play more or less successfully, I was tempted to follow it up with something which would be, at last, a major work aimed at Broadway. As usual, it came from incidents in my practice as a doctor—a middle-aged man in the suburban community where he had been

successful, on the outskirts of New York City. The wife was very much in love with her husband and he with her, but that did not prevent this surreptitious poet from indulging in affairs with his women patients. But his poems which the wife knew and on occasion read aloud to him (she was an understanding reader) caused them both misgivings. The love of the man for his wife was unquestioned, but what man can be unconscious of the world of women which surrounds him?

"At the point where the doctor dies, the character of the play suddenly shifts to tragedy, with the wife occupying the central role. It is her tragedy which has to be evolved. It ends in her victory—over herself—and the rescue of the doctor. They are reunited in a love which they, and particularly she, bring to a triumphant—but losing—conclusion. Lucky for his reputation as a poet to which she has remained true from the days of their youth—as in a dream which they have dreamed together from the first."

A Dream of Love "floated" about for two years, in and out of the hands of agents. To one agent who had delicately refused the play as not fully dramatic, Williams wrote:

"There are plays less dramatic in movement that are well capable of holding audience interest for two hours of an evening—an intelligent interest which is quite legitimate. The drama in *A Dream of Love* lies in this sector, not so much in conflict (there is very little conflict in *The Cherry Orchard*) as in revelation, development of the Doctor's situation. How far will he go and what will be the effect on some of the other characters?"

In July of 1949, in the middle of one of New York's worst heat waves, *A Dream of Love* was put on at the Hudson Guild Playhouse by an off-Broadway little theatre group called "We Present." Barbara J. Whiting was the director and Ted Dallbottom choreographer. The leading roles were played by: Gerien Kelsey (Myra), Lester Robin

(Doc), Erica Feydn (Dotty), DeWitt Drury (Cliff), Vinnette Carroll (Josephine) and Robert H. Fuller (The Milkman). (No doubt to dispense with a second set, Scene 1 of Act III was cut.) William Saroyan gave the play a rave review in the *New York Herald Tribune*, but there was no air-conditioning in the theatre and it survived for only two weeks.

Williams wrote to Norman Holmes Pearson that, "I don't really believe a 'serious' play can be produced in the U. S. in our time; there is no audience for it. I don't think our world is interested in accuracies. It hurts too much to hear discussion of 'real' situations, and people just don't go to the theatre to have themselves shown up, that is, to be caused pain." Still, he insisted, "I shall not cease trying to write an acceptable play, with one set! The problems and the rewards lead me on."

A Dream of Love has since been staged by Clinton Atkinson at Wesleyan University, and there were public readings in February, 1961, at the National Arts Club by the Mannahatta Theatre Club, directed by Fred Stewart with a cast including Evelyn Davis, Clifton James, Ron Liebman, Maggie O'Neill, E. G. Marshall, Nan Martin, Joseph Sullivan and Musa Williams.

Early in the 1950's the political situation in the United States was being roiled by various individuals and committees set up for the investigation of "un-American activities." Charges of "Red-baiting" and "witch-hunting" were hurled back and forth. Williams, from his youth a determined American liberal, was deeply disturbed by this hysteria. Had there been anything like it before in American history? His own chapter on the Salem Trials, "Cotton Mather's Wonders of the Invisible World," in *In the American Grain* suggested a parallel which accounts for the mordant note of *Tituba's Children*.

In 1953 Arthur Miller produced his play, *The Crucible*, with a similar theme. But Dr. Williams had completed

Tituba's Children in 1950. This "genial coincidence" shows that alert minds and sensitive spirits are often drawn to similar subjects. *In the American Grain* has remained one of the seminal works on American history; one is reminded of the use that Hart Crane made of this book in his poem *The Bridge*.

Researching the subject, Williams visited Salem in 1948 and studied the records in the Museum archives there. He also read and quoted from Starkey's *The Devil in Massachusetts* and Upham's *Salem Witchcraft*. An old friend of the Williamses, Mrs. William Gratwick of Linwood, New York, has filled in part of the background on the composition of *Tituba's Children* in a recent letter to James Laughlin:

"My husband and I had founded an amateur touring opera company named York Opera. We started performing Gilbert and Sullivan but we were also interested in doing a modern American work if we could find one that was up to our standard of comic opera and within the range of amateur voices. A brief search proved unrewarding, (operas were not being written in '48 as they are today), so we asked Bill Williams and Thomas Canning of the Eastman School of Music if they would collaborate on one. They were delighted and Bill set to work. We followed the development of Bill's libretto with great interest, hoping that it would fit our needs, and those of other amateur groups similar to ours. But gradually we realized that *Tituba's Children* was too difficult for our inexperienced company to produce well, so matters came to rest there. It had a savage bite that our American scene certainly deserved at that time . . . it did not have the gay kind of satire that we were after. Bill knew this too. It was too bad but perhaps not fatal now that you are going to publish it. Maybe somebody will pick it up and give it a good production . . . I hope so."

The Cure was begun in 1952 when Williams was recu-

perating (at the home of his friend the late Charles Abbott near Buffalo) from a "superficial" stroke, which paralyzed his right arm and left his eyes and brain in a damaged condition. This is how Williams (in 1961) recalls it:

When the man had his first serious stroke at about the age of seventy it was in August at the home of friends, where he and his wife had been spending their vacation. That was an embarrassing circumstance to all concerned. Let's not talk too much of that and of the weeks immediately following until he could be transported home on the "Phoebe Snow" and begin his climb toward comparative good health again.

This is the story of a play which occurred to that excited and damaged imagination while the man was lying there. It was taken down day after day in longhand by his wife. The man's right arm was paralyzed from the first and he never recovered the full use of it. But as the days progressed he had a skillful local nurse who became very important to him and to his imaginings. This woman, as he recovered from his first blindness, began more and more to make herself a part of the life that he was now living. She had in her active days been a fully trained and registered nurse; the doctor (for the patient was a doctor) began to draw up her history as he had been trained to do and in doing that the play took form. How the title of the play, *The Cure*, came he will never know, but from the first that was the title that fastened itself upon his imagination.

This was to be a contemporary three-act play—about young people, at least young enough, who lived in the upper New York State country. The plot formed around an automobile accident in which one man was killed and another was so badly injured that the young couple were forced to keep him—an opportunity for the trained nurse to care for him during the duration of the play. Thus immobilized, the characters found an opportunity to work out their story.

One of the incidents which puzzled the author was how to bring in during the third act a relief element which seemed to be necessary. It's not considered good play writing to introduce a new character during the third act. But the playwright, calling on his resources, had no choice but to force things a little and succeeded in bringing it off when the play had been stalled for over three years. Finally when James Laughlin took the play in hand in 1960 and showed a disposition to publish it, all seemed to grow clear. The playwright was inspired and got to work finishing the play, using his left hand for his typing and finishing his chore at a time when he thought the task was to be too much for him.

In the nine years which have succeeded the stroke in 1952, Dr. Williams often forgets names, titles, even happenings of the day before; but he has written some of the best poetry of his long career—poetry collected in *The Desert Music*, *Journey to Love* and *Paterson V*. The late Dr. Merrill Moore, poet and psychiatrist, who examined Williams, told Mrs. Williams: "This confirms a theory I have long held: that a superficial stroke can paralyze a man's day-by-day activity and memory, but it cannot touch the deeper spring of artistic creativity." Dr. Williams is still writing superb poetry.

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